

Contributions to Hermeneutics 6

Silvia Mazzini
Owen Glyn-Williams *Editors*

Making Communism Hermeneutical

Reading Vattimo and Zabala

 Springer

Contributions to Hermeneutics

Volume 6

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Editors

Making Communism Hermeneutical

Reading Vattimo and Zabala

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Short Bios of Volume Respondents

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Santiago Zabala is ICREA research professor of philosophy at Pompeu Fabra University in Barcelona. He is the author of *The Hermeneutic Nature of Analytic Philosophy* (2008), *The Remains of Being* (2009), *Hermeneutic Communism* (2011, coauthored with G. Vattimo), and *Why Only Art Can Save Us* (2017), among others, all published by Columbia University Press and translated into several languages. He also writes opinion articles for *The Guardian*, *The New York Times*, and *The Los Angeles Review of Books*.

Introduction to *Making Communism*

Hermeneutical: Reading Vattimo and Zabala

Some regard it as a crime, others use its name as an insult. In the Western world, communism is usually seen as an authoritarian, stale political system that fell down with the rubble of the Berlin Wall. From this point of view, what keeps on being called communism and is developing in various ways in different countries around the world is considered by most politicians and media as a kind of old-fashioned ghost. Maybe they ignore that it is exactly in this form that communism appeared a long time ago – or better said, began haunting Europe after Marx's Manifesto in 1848.

However, it has to be said that intellectuals of the caliber of Negri, Žižek, Badiou, and Rancière still proclaim communism as the only remaining hope for changing the political, economic, and social system that reigns today, a safety net to bring more equal opportunities for the majority of the population – a majority still excluded from power and wealth. Not only Hardt and Negri's renowned trilogy (*Empire*, *Multitude*, *Commonwealth*) but also the collected essays of radical left-thinkers under the title of *The Idea of Communism* (2010) are significant examples of the attention this notion still enjoys in contemporary debates. It is a happy coincidence that a very original and innovative proposal in this sense was published in 2011, at the very moment of the first manifestations of the "Occupy Wall Street" movement.

The title of this book could sound enigmatic for ears not used to the philosophical vocabulary: *Hermeneutic Communism*. What kind of communism could it be? Doubtless, the historical reversal in the subtitle is likely to generate suspicion among philosophers: *From Heidegger to Marx*. Is it possible for such an oversight to have slipped by two preeminent philosophers?

The two authors of this book have developed a quite revolutionary thesis, even among revolutionaries. Gianni Vattimo and Santiago Zabala combine their political engagement (Vattimo has twice been a member of the European parliament, and Zabala writes about politics in important international publications) with their philosophical works, in which hermeneutics has always played a key role. Vattimo, a scholar of Hans Georg Gadamer and Luigi Pareyson, is known as the founder of "weak thought," a philosophy that rejects the "strong" reasons of a metaphysical foundation. Such foundations are seen by Nietzsche and others as the violent im-

sition of ideological paradigms, values and rules of a dominant group (the “winners,” as Benjamin called them), who present them as absolute and necessary. On the contrary, weak thought opens up the space, at once theoretical and practical, for the conflict of different interpretations of reality. So hermeneutics, which has often worked as the theory of interpretation of texts, books, laws, and works of art, is for Vattimo an ontology. And also for Zabala, who studied its anarchic implications in many works, and particularly in his book *The Remains of Being* (2009) where he claims that Being is conversation, it is a weak way to conduct philosophical inquiries as well as political dialogues, after the strong times of metaphysics.

From these “weak” premises, the two authors have developed a *strong* thesis: “Communism can (and should) still work as an alternative political paradigm, if combined with the hermeneutical resistance to foundations and “necessary” measures or ends.” Vattimo and Zabala distance themselves from familiar communist regimes, which have often relied on the idea of historical necessity (the dictatorship of the proletariat, the logical development of historical sequences, etc.) – which led to the formation of “groups of experts” like intellectuals or politicians, who monopolized the decision-making process, presenting the results as “scientific” and therefore indisputable. This brought, as a logical consequence, the violent imposition of an authoritarian and disciplined order in the name of the good for future generations. By contrast, Vattimo and Zabala let politics evolve from one of the anarchic origins of hermeneutics: the end of truth. This triggers an essential question: Is politics possible without truth? According to Vattimo and Zabala, the answer is affirmative as long as there are political procedures for the continuous change and evolution of political paradigms and, hence, of truth. That is, communism should be grounded on the conflict of interpretations, which guarantees equality, respect, and consideration for minorities and different cultural, religious, and social-economic groups. In this sense, hermeneutics reflects the democratic ideal, albeit in a radicalized form, since decisions are not taken in the name of absolute truth and necessity, but rather on the basis of dynamic encounters between different interpretive frameworks.

So, for Vattimo and Zabala, communism has now become weak because it has lost the strong reasons that had sustained it in the past (historical teleology, the quasi-divine destiny of the proletariat, etc.) and has finally returned freed from metaphysics, that is, the imposition of unassailable truths. It can also be considered as weak because its political inspiration is no longer Eurocentric or ethnocentric. Rather, it is drawn from a diversity of struggles on the part of marginalized and oppressed peoples across the globe and in Latin America, in particular. At stake in their project, therefore, is not only weak thought, but *the thought of the weak*, the interpretive paradigms of those pushing back against their generalized dispossession in the global neoliberal order. One could say that communism here refers to the diverse communities of voices and practices reinterpreting the world in ways that directly rebuke the developmental “truths” imposed on them.

This also explains the subtitle: *From Heidegger to Marx*. The critics of metaphysics make this inverted order (interpreting Marx through Heidegger) productive, where metaphysics is not simply understood as a philosophical theory, but much more as what the authors call the “politics of descriptions,” a politics that sees the

world through the lens of an impositionist positivistic realism: What is possible and realistic always coincides with the interests of the most powerful segments of global order. Thus, “description,” as opposed to interpretation, here means the claim to a supposed objectivity, rooted in the “conservative nature of the so-called realism” that does not recognize any form of rationality or political project that diverges from the dominant thought – the thought of dominant groups. This is what happens in “framed democracies,” which for the two authors are only formally democratic, since they seek to systematically foreclose any genuine conflict of (different) interpretations. But is there a (paradoxical) risk that *Hermeneutic Communism* would present itself as the only good or “real” interpretation? The two editors of this book think not. And the better way to “prove” it (of course in a weak way!) is to establish a (double) conversation, in the best hermeneutic tradition. That is why we worked together on a book, which is made up of multiple and different voices: *Making Communism Hermeneutical: Reading Vattimo and Zabala*. The contributors of this essay collection explore various facets of Vattimo and Zabala’s “anarchic hermeneutics” and “weak communism” in order to explore the concepts created by them such as “framed democracies,” “armed capitalism,” or “conservative impositions.” It has to be said that the main part of these essays was written in 2011, before the death of Venezuelan president Hugo Chavez (5 March 2013). Indeed, much has happened in these last years, but nothing fundamental that would question Vattimo and Zabala’s thesis – on the contrary, quoting the Italian writer Tomasi di Lampedusa, “everything needs to change, so everything needs to stay the same.” The strong powers are still there, and the weak still cannot make their needs and voices heard.

The anarchic inflection of *Hermeneutic Communism* is meant precisely to open the space for such voices to be heard. This is among the defining features of Vattimo and Zabala’s intervention in contemporary debates seeking to breathe new life into the thought and practice of communism. One of the real virtues of *Hermeneutic Communism* is that it is animated by the refusal to dictate in advance what a properly emancipatory politics looks like, which would simply replicate the imposition of “truth” carried out by what they call the “politics of description,” or the impositionist neoliberal order. Rather, it insists on a fundamental openness to multiple and shifting logics of emancipation – diverse and irreducible interpretations – that develop and articulate themselves differentially across social, geographical, and economic contexts. If the Bolivarian Revolution is taken as exemplary, it is not proposed as *the* definitive model of social transformation and resistance to “armed capitalism.” In this way, *Hermeneutic Communism* marks a clear departure from the commitment to universality shared by many of their contemporaries, including Alain Badiou, Jacques Rancière, and Slavoj Žižek, thinkers who tend to transcendentalize and fix the trajectory of emancipatory processes. This point of divergence is a critical one and is especially important for any communist project that looks beyond Europe and the West for exemplary modes of praxis and resistance. But it is also important to the extent that the project of reviving a communist alternative to the present hinges on the ability to preserve its radical promise, while dispensing with the universalizing, teleological, and impositionist dimensions of its past. This is why Vattimo insists, in his contribution to the 2009 conference on the Idea of

Communism, that what is needed is a politics that “shares with anarchism the refusal to formulate a system, a constitution, a positive ‘realistic’ model according to traditional political methods” (*IC*, 207).

If theirs is an anarchic, weak communism, it does not avoid addressing difficult questions of state power and the role that it can play in the construction of a different world. Behind their support for the “left regimes” of Hugo Chavez and Evo Morales lies a skepticism concerning the potential of social movements that do not seek to take hold of the apparatuses of the state. In stark contrast to many of their interlocutors in contemporary theoretical and political debates, they argue that electoral politics is unavoidable and must play a central role in progressive political struggles. As Vattimo has claimed elsewhere, “Parliament and the streets... can act in tandem” (*IC* 207). In their estimation, the emergence of militarized police forces, highly organized and armed with sophisticated weaponry, along with vastly expanded powers of surveillance thanks to technological advancements and the widespread erosion of constitutional limitations on their deployment, has resulted in a world in which state and capitalist structures are considerably less vulnerable to revolutionary force. “Unlike Alain Badiou, Antonio Negri, and other contemporary Marxist theorists,” they claim, “we do not believe that the twenty-first century calls for revolution because the forces of the politics of descriptions are too powerful, violent, and oppressive to be overcome through a parallel insurrection” (*HC* 3). Whether one chooses to follow them to their conclusion or not, there is no doubt that the obstacles to the kinds of revolutionary upheaval that has animated the history of communism necessitate a thoroughgoing rethinking of the methods and aims of social and political movements. *Hermeneutic Communism* is one such “rethinking,” and in keeping with its commitment to conversation, and its anarchic resistance to the imposition of any theoretical or practical paradigm as definitive, it invites others to respond, to engage, to diverge, and to reinterpret.

Hence, the goal of *Making Communism Hermeneutical* is to develop and continue a dialogue with Vattimo and Zabala’s work – both in theory and in praxis. First, the authors of this book have questioned their main arguments, asking whether it is possible to “practice politics without truth,” “renew communism through hermeneutics,” and “if some of the politics in South America could become a model for Western democracies.” But above all, one of the essential, methodologically innovative characteristics of *Making Communism Hermeneutical* consists in its conversational, hermeneutical form. Vattimo and Zabala have responded personally to each essay of the book. Thus, hermeneutics is not only a central topic but also an epistemological, concrete application of Vattimo and Zabala’s theories. This is the case because they are not grounded in *the* truth, but in discussing and multiplying different views and positions. Last but not least, the dialogue will also continue after this book has been published: a dialogue with you, our readers. In the genuine hermeneutical tradition, we hope you can add your own interpretations and develop in theory and praxis what has been discussed here, opening new horizons and unimagined, concrete possibilities.

Part I

Hermeneutics

The End of Metaphysics, the Uses and Abuses of Philosophy, and Understanding Just a Little Better: On Gianni Vattimo and Santiago Zabala's *Hermeneutic Communism*

Eduardo Mendieta

Abstract This chapter engages Vattimo and Zabala's *Hermeneutic Communism* from the standpoint of how it relates to a venerable tradition of 'manifestos'. A typology of manifestos is offered and then the question is raised, to what extent we can fit *Hermeneutic Communism* within this tradition. The chapter also engages a questionable assumption of *Hermeneutic Communism*, namely the metaphysics of the end, which is announced as the end of metaphysics. This last point is elaborated vis-a-vis a reading of Rorty, which challenged the usefulness of philosophical manifestos for practical politics.

On Political Oratory and Rhetorical Genius

Gianni Vattimo and Santiago Zabala's *Hermeneutic Communism: From Heidegger to Marx*¹ reads very much like a "manifesto," or a at the very least like a "proclamation." Manifestos, like proclamations, have three distinct components. First, they offer a bird's eye-view of why we may find ourselves in a given historical situation. They do not offer reports but reconstructions and historical interpretations. That panoramic view, however, is neither innocent nor neutral. The way it paints the temporal horizon of our time is itself a partisan effect, an invested and interested way of constructing a story about how we got to be where we are. Second, they aim to dissect historical reality in a very specific way, aiming to locate those social agents or forces that both have been decisive in bringing to the historical cross-roads where we stand, and which have been either the primary beneficiaries or primary losers of the socio-economic system under analysis. Manifestos and proclamations

¹ Gianni Vattimo and Santiago Zabala, *Hermeneutic Communism: From Heidegger to Marx* (New York: Columbia University Press, 2001). Henceforth references to this text will be noted in the body of the essay in parentheses.

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are to political reality what scalpels are to surgery. Third, manifestos and proclamations are rhetorical exercises that, once read, make it difficult not to want to get up, march and join the movement that the manifesto proclaims. Manifestos mobilize language so as to produce a certain affective response that has efficacy. They are the adrenaline and passion of the body politic. Manifestos are thus also credos or confessions of faith and thus operate as exhortations and a call to action based on the mobilization of moral suasion and power. Let me hold back for now the answer to the question that this analysis of manifestos and proclamations immediately calls to mind, namely whether Vattimo and Zabala's *Hermeneutic Communism* shares these three components. For the moment, let me take a detour through some manifestos, in order to get a better insight into the anatomy of the genre.

The indisputable and uncircumventable point of reference for any and all manifestos is clearly Marx and Engels' 1848 *Manifesto of the Communist Party*. As Umberto Eco pointed out in a wonderful little essay, the Manifesto is probably one of the most important political documents of the last 200 years.² I would rank it up there with Luther's 95 theses that launched the Reformation, the French declaration of Human Rights, and the American Declaration of Independence.³ But, in contrast to its flanking companions, Marx and Engels' *Manifesto* is also a document of world literature.⁴ Its linguistic exuberance is simply *sui generis*. Eric Hobsbawm captured succinctly its literary novelty and power when he wrote, on the occasion of the 150 anniversary of the publication of the *Manifesto*:

The new reader can hardly fail to be swept away by the passionate conviction, the concentrated brevity, the intellectual and stylistic force of this astonishing pamphlet. It is written, as though in a single creative burst, in lapidary sentences almost naturally transforming themselves into the memorable aphorisms which have become known far beyond the world of political debate: from 'A spectre is haunting haunting Europe—the spectre of communism' to the final 'The proletarians have nothing to lose but their chains. They have the world to win.' Equally uncommon in nineteenth-century German writing, it is written in short apodictic paragraphs, mainly of one to five lines, in only five cases out of more than two hundred, of fifteen or more lines. Whatever else it is, *The Communist Manifesto* as political rhetoric has an almost biblical force. In short, it is impossible to deny its compelling power as literature.⁵

Indeed, the *Manifesto* gave us many metaphors, allegories, and turn of phrases that we use to this day, sometimes without knowing where they come from. Along with the specter that haunts Europe, all history is the history of class struggle; society is

² Umberto Eco, "On the Style of *The Communist Manifesto*" in Umberto Eco, *On Literature* (New York: A Harvest Book, 2004), 23–27.

³ But the list of manifestos is not surprisingly long. Here is a link to a wonderful website that provides an alphabetical listing of the main manifestos or proclamations: <http://www.manifestos.net/titles/>

⁴ See S. S. Prawer, *Karl Marx and World Literature* (New York: Verso, 2011 [1976]), an amazing text that traced every literary reference in Marx's corpus, from the German Ideology to *Das Kapital*. The chapter on the drafting of the Manifesto is indispensable for anyone who wants to understand its rhetorical power. "World Literature and Class Conflict."

⁵ Eric Hobsbawm, "On the Communist Manifesto" in Eric Hobsbawm, *How to Change the World: Reflections on Marx and Marxism* (New Haven and London: Yale University Press, 2011), 110.

splitting into warring camps; the bourgeoisie builds its own grave diggers; and communism can be boiled down to one catchphrase: abolish all private property. In many ways, the *Manifesto* taught us to think in a historical-materialist way, without expressly arguing that this is what it sought to do. It gave us a new vocabulary as well as new allegories and metaphors through which to grasp our new historical condition. The *Manifesto* is a great pedagogical tool precisely because its linguistic flourish aimed to give us concrete tools of social analysis. But these tools of analysis cannot be dissociated from their rhetorical embodiment. After reading *The Manifesto*, we find it almost impossible not to see history in the way Marx and Engels' have articulated it.

I am now going to quote from another major document, which I hope you will recognize immediately: "We are a product of five hundred years of struggle: first, led by insurgents against slavery during the War of Independence with Spain; then to avoid being absorbed by North American imperialism; then to proclaim our constitutions and expel the French empire from our soil; later when the people rebelled against Porfirio Diaz's dictatorship, which denied us the just application of the reform laws..."⁶ This is from the First Declaration of the Lacandon Jungle from January of 1994, which was to be followed by many more proclamations, letters, communiqués, and introductions. Here are some words from the "Opening Remarks at the First Intercontinental *Encuentro* for Humanity and against neoliberalism":

This is who we are.
The Zapatista National Liberation Army
The voice that arms itself to be heard.
The face that hides itself to be seen.
The name that hides itself to be named.
The red star who calls out to humanity and the world.
To be heard, to be seen, to be named.
The tomorrow to be harvested in the past.

Behind our black mask,
Behind our armed voice,
Behind our unnameable name,
Behind us, who you see,
Behind us, we are you.⁷

Subcomandante Marcos, who we now know was a philosophy professor at UNAM, may have learned about the power of language from Marx. Yet, it is also clear that the history, the agents, and the invocation are different. Be that as it may, we can safely anticipate that Subcomandante Marcos, and the Zapatistas in general, have already earned a distinct and a privileged place in the canon of world revolutionary writing. In fact, as Enrique Dussel has pointed out in his history of the Left in Latin America, the Zapatistas marked a new stage, a new point of departure in movements for social justice and democracy in Latin America.⁸ In fact, the turn

⁶Subcomandante Marcos, *Our Word is our Weapon: Selected Writings*, edited by Juana Ponce de León (New York: Seven Stories Press, 2001), 13.

⁷Subcomandante Marcos, *Our Word is our Weapon*, 109–110.

⁸See Enrique Dussel, *Politics of Liberation: A Critical World History*, translated by Thia Cooper (London: SCM Press, 2011), 540–548.

toward the left in Latin America we have seen in the last decade was prepared by the Zapatista insurrection. Nay, a stronger claim can be made. The Zapatistas developed a new type of revolutionary language and a new sensibility about who can be agents of political transformation that allowed Evo Morales and Hugo Chávez to develop mass movements that have demonstrated the possibilities for democratic transformation from below. We can say that the Latin American left has learned many lessons, paid for by the suffering of many workers, peasants, indigenous peoples at the hands of the U.S. lead, educated, and supplied soldiers of the National Security States of the Cold War and Neo-Imperialism. We may be more than two decades away from the January of 1994 when the Zapatista's declared their war and called upon the world to support them. I want to claim that one of distinctive accomplishments of the Zapatistas was to transform the historical and political imaginary of Latin Americans: we are still fighting the anti-colonial wars that began in the sixteenth century, but there is a distinct memory that is not simply one of injury, destruction and loss, but one of solidarity, resistance, and hope.

Fortuitously as this text was being written, Verso published the transcript of some notes Gretel Adorno kept of some conversations between Horkheimer and Adorno during the Spring of 1956.⁹ Apparently, both had embarked on the project of writing a manifesto for their time. The notes are fascinating in that they provide us with an unusual insight into how politically attentive and engaged both Adorno and Horkheimer were, and to what a large extent they may have been prevented from writing the manifesto they wanted to write by Cold War politics that polarized everything in such deforming ways. It is clear that they had to abandon their project because they felt that any reference to Marx, or to historical Marxism in general, would have been seen as an endorsement of the Soviet Union. What is revealing about these notes is that they also show us an Adorno and Horkheimer committed to the dialectical tension between theory and practice that neither surrenders nor blithely celebrates the power of reason to discern our historical ontology.

Finally, and now it can be understood why I have began by discussing manifestos and proclamations, we are living through an exciting time when our own citizens in the US, not far from here, have issued their own "declaration." I quote a short section:

As we gather together in solidarity to express a feeling of mass injustice, we must not lose sight of what brought us together. We write so that all people who feel wronged by the corporate forces of the world can know that we are your allies.

As one people, united, we acknowledge the reality: that the future of the human race requires the cooperation of its members; that our system must protect our rights, and upon corruption of that system, it is up to the individuals to protect their own rights, and those of their neighbors; that a democratic government derives its just power from the people, but corporations do not seek consent to extract wealth from the people and the Earth; and that no true democracy is attainable when the process is determined by economic power. We come to you at a time when corporations, which place profit over people, self-interest over justice, and oppression over equality, run our governments. We have peaceably assembled here, as is our right, to let these facts be known.

⁹Theodor Adorno and Max Horkheimer, *Towards a New Manifesto* (New York: Verso, 2011).

And after listing the “facts” about corporate power, they conclude:

To the people of the world,

We, the New York City General Assembly occupying Wall Street in Liberty Square, urge you to assert your power.

Exercise your right to peaceably assemble; occupy public space; create a process to address the problems we face, and generate solutions accessible to everyone.

To all communities that take action and form groups in the spirit of direct democracy, we offer support, documentation, and all of the resources at our disposal.

Join us and make your voices heard!¹⁰

What is interesting about this proclamation is not simply the list of the injustices, crimes and economic mayhem that ‘corporations’ have committed and unleashed on the States’ economy and the entire world, but the way the proclamation is really a “witnessing” to moral outrage and political empowerment. It calls on people to assert their own political agency. It is above all a witnessing to the political agency and civic genius of people’s across the world. Manifestos are, thus, also confessions of faith in the power of political agents to transform their world.

The End of Metaphysics and the Metaphysics of the End

Hermeneutic Communism is full of provocative readings that aim to provide grounds for their basic argument, namely that only weak thought, qua realization of hermeneutics, can prepare us for the advent of communism, which in turn is now conceived as a historical event. In a word, hermeneutic communism is communism purified of all metaphysics. I take it that the argument proceeds in this way. We live in the age of the end of metaphysics. All that remains after the demise of metaphysics is the imperative to interpret. Consequently, hermeneutics is all we have left, since all we have left is history, and our attempts to make sense of it, and thus the history of interpretations. What remains of being, all *ontos*, is pure interpretation. Since there are neither transcendental grounds nor ontological groundings left that can offer theoretical foundations or rational warrants for our projects, all we have is the ceaseless task of historical interpretation. Hermeneutics is all the philosophy that is left and the only that we need or could need, for in it we find both a politics and ethics. The politics is that of a weakened communism, that is, a communism without metaphysical stilts, which offers itself simply as the clamoring of the oppressed and the appellation for economic justice of the victims of capitalism. The ethics implied by this hermeneutics that is all that is left to us is an ethics of interpretation in which all interpretations have a *prima facie* claim to be heard and countenanced.

¹⁰ Available on-line: <http://nycga.cc/2011/09/30/declaration-of-the-occupation-of-new-york-city/>

If these are the key philosophical moves, and I have provided an approximate interpretation of Vattimo and Zabala's project, then I have a series of questions. First, and most importantly, how did metaphysics come to an end? Sometimes Vattimo and Zabala write as though the end of metaphysics had happened qua dispensation of being itself. So, like the God of Jewish mysticism and Schelling onto-theology, being contracts and retracts to make space for the human will, and human history. But, the end of metaphysics has not come, at least not in the sense that Vattimo and Zabala seem to imply. On the one hand, what they call framed democracy, with its handmaiden, analytical philosophy with its metaphysics of descriptions and truth as objectivity, is still tethered to a metaphysics of representation. Let me call this the metaphysics of representation, or the metaphysics of representational equivalences. Evidently, that metaphysics is still operative, even if it seems to be anachronistic. How can something come to an end, and yet still remain operative? There are then three issues buried in the proclamation of the end of metaphysics: how has it come about? Did it come to an end of its own accord, or was it something that humans did that spelled its end; how it continues to undergird framed democracy with its metaphysics of representation, and thus it has not come to an end; and finally, whether in announcing its end, metaphysics' endurance is not renewed, and given a new lease on life.

What concerns me most, however, is not whether metaphysics has come to an end, which is not unlike Nietzsche's announcing the 'death of god.' I am more concerned with how it may have come about, that is, and to use Nietzsche's allegory of theocide, how we killed god, that is, how we abolished metaphysics. I take it that one of the most consistent and enduring themes of Western philosophy is precisely the project of abolishing metaphysics. It was first announced by Gorgias of Leontin, when he famously and cryptically argued: 'there is nothing, and even if there were something we could not know it, and even if we could know it, we could not communicate it.' Gorgias' argument, if we can call it that, is that all we have is language, and our attempts to make sense of our world with each other. In fact, Gorgias' argument is very similar to Hans-Georg Gadamer's claim that "*Being that can be understood is Language*."¹¹

It is this very argument that Protagoras echoes in his equally famous and misunderstood aphorism: 'man is the measure of all that is that it is, and of all that it is not that it is not.' In a word, all we have is language, interpretation, persuasion, and all the norms for coming to an understanding can only be derived from language itself. Yet, metaphysical projects endured, whether in their Platonic, Augustinian, Aristotelian, or Kantian versions and updates. And at every turn, other philosophers have taken up Gorgias's flag: even if it could be known, it would have to be known through a language, a language that is always a natural language and a shared

¹¹ Hans-Georg Gadamer, *Truth and Method*, 2nd Revised Edition (New York: Continuum, 1988), 474; Italics in original. See also Richard Rorty, "Being that Can be Understood is Language" in Bruce Krajewski, ed., *Gadamer's Repercussions: Reconsidering Philosophical Hermeneutics* (Berkeley: University of California Press, 2003), 21–29.

language. This insight, which has now become common philosophical currency, goes by the name of “the linguistic turn.”

In our more recent philosophical calendar, this turn was instigated by three key philosophers: C. S. Peirce, Ludwig Wittgenstein, and Martin Heidegger. The philosophy of the last century has been an attempt to make sense of what these three philosophers meant when they claimed that all we have are semiology, language games qua forms of life, and language is the house of being. Here, it is not a matter of deliberately trying to be fastidious by recalling textbook examples. I am making a point. Metaphysics did not come to an end of its own accord, nor was it a gift that we have received or struggled to interpret from being, or some transmundane force. Metaphysics keeps being abolished by the work of philosophy, which is carried out by philosophers using different tools within different philosophical traditions.

We philosophers persevere in the task of abolishing metaphysics because we continue to be seduced by the metaphysics of the end. We trade prophetic messianism for an apocalyptic eschatology: either we are saved or all has come to an end or must come to an end. I am here reminded of an incisive formulation of Habermas with respect to Heidegger: “The language of *Being and Time* had suggested the decisionism of empty resoluteness; the later philosophy suggests the submissiveness of an equally empty readiness for subjugation.”¹² There are neither messiahs nor expectant awaitings, neither messianic beginnings, nor apocalyptic ends, in the conversation we are. All we have is the task of our interpretation and each interpretation is the continuation of an incomplete interpretation. All interpretation is incomplete because it is radically open to the past that is evoked towards a possible future. I agree with Vattimo and Zabala that all the philosophy that is left to us is hermeneutics, but hermeneutics teaches us at the very least to adjourn the metaphysics of the end. For every hermeneutic event is both a radical beginning that reactivates the past opening up temporal horizons that engage our communicative freedom: freedom with and towards others.

On the Uses and Abuses of Philosophy

I want now to turn to the title of my essay. In the title of the essay I am alluding to a line from a review by Richard Rorty of Cornel West’s book *The American Evasion of Philosophy*.¹³ In that review Rorty celebrates West’s audacious and provocative genealogy of Pragmatism, but chides him for claiming that pragmatism needs propheticism. In fact, he wrote “that the term ‘prophetic pragmatism’ [should] sound as odd as ‘charismatic trash disposal.’”¹⁴ Cornel West calls his distinct philosophical

¹²Jürgen Habermas, *The Philosophical Discourse of Modernity: Twelve Lectures*, Frederick Lawrence (Cambridge, MA: The MIT Press, 1987), 141.

¹³Madison: University of Wisconsin Press, 1989.

¹⁴Richard Rorty, “The Philosopher and the Prophet” in *Transition*, No. 52 (1991), 70–78. The quote comes from page 75.

position prophetic pragmatism. West argues that pragmatism, as a method, requires Christian propheticism in order to have the wherewithal to engage in critique of the status quo. 'Pragmatism without propheticism is blind, propheticism without pragmatism is powerless,' could be the motto that defines West's prophetic pragmatism. In contrast, however, Rorty argued that pragmatism needs propheticism as much as a fish needs a bicycle. Philosophy, Rorty went on to argue in other places, does not need prophets. If anything it is the other way around: prophets may need the janitorial and yard work of philosophers, who simply clear the underbrush of bad, useless, and anachronistic philosophy and metaphysical mirages.¹⁵ Still, even if pragmatism does not need propheticism, it can be utopian, but it can be so by virtue of non-philosophical tools. In his important essay "Feminism and Pragmatism," Rorty wrote:

The difference between pragmatism and positions such as Marxism, which retain the rhetoric of scienticism and realism, can be thought of as the difference between utopianism and radicalism. Radicals think that there is a basic mistake being made, a mistake deep down at the roots. They think that deep thinking is required to get down to this deep level, and that only there, when all superstructural appearances have been undercut, can things be seen as they really are. Utopians, however, do not think in terms of mistake or of depth. They abandon the contrast between superficial appearance and deep reality in favor of the contrast between a painful present and a possibly less painful, dimly seen future. Pragmatists cannot be radical, in this sense, but they can be utopians. They do not see philosophy as providing instruments for radical surgery or microscopes that make precise diagnosis possible. Philosophy's function is rather to clear the road for prophets and poets, to make intellectual life a bit simpler and safer for those who have visions of new communities.¹⁶

In fact, as Rorty got older, he became even more skeptical that philosophy had much to offer to the prophets that give us new visions, new social projects. Such was his skepticism that Rorty called for a post-philosophical culture. Indeed, he was more hopeful and expected more of literature than of philosophy. I bring up Rorty, not simply because he is surely the wittiest philosopher to have come out of the United States, as well as the most ecumenical and generous, but also because he figures prominently in *Hermeneutic Communism*.

Vattimo and Zabala quote the following wonderful phrase by Rorty as an epigram for one of the best chapters in their book: "I think that the hermeneutical or Gadamerian attitude is in the intellectual world what democracy is in the political world. The two can be viewed as alternative appropriations of the Christian message that love is the only law." (quoted p. 75). I think this is vintage Rorty, and Vattimo and Zabala do well in citing it. Yet, this quote is easily misunderstood. Given all that Rorty wrote, specifically about political philosophy (that is to say about Lyotard, Rawls, Habermas, Posner, etc.), it would be inappropriate to read this statement to mean that Rorty is endorsing that hermeneutics become the guide of democratic politics. On the contrary, Rorty held strong to the conviction that democratic politics has been done more harm than good by being submitted to the court of philosophical

¹⁵ See Richard Rorty, "Feminism and Pragmatism" in Richard Rorty, *Truth and Progress. Philosophical Papers*, Volume 3 (Cambridge: Cambridge University Press, 1998), 202–227.

¹⁶ Rorty, "Feminism and Pragmatism," 214–215.

adjudication. If we take as a guide what Rorty claimed about Rawls, democratic politics as a historical tradition based on the building of institutions has priority over philosophy –which is why I picked *Take Care of Freedom and Truth Will Take Care Of Itself* as the title for our book of interviews.¹⁷ The title, which is actually a phrase Rorty often invoked, captures the primacy he gives to politics over philosophy. For Rorty, at best, the role of philosophy is to clarify what we have accomplished as political agents; but at worst, philosophy can be an obstacle to forming ever more ecumenical communities and the development of ever more inclusive moral images of ourselves when it insists that there is something deep, grounding, or rational that provides a warrant for our being committed to those communities and moral images. What democratic politics needs is more programs, more agendas for actual political empowerment, and less discussion about philosophy, metaphysics and ontology.

In short, I am afraid that Rorty would be surprised by the way in which his type of postphilosophical pragmatism has been used to justify a political project. I think that he would have reacted to Vattimo and Zabala's *Hermeneutic Communism* in the same way he reacted to Cornel West's *The American Evasion of Philosophy*, and to Habermas's *Between Facts and Norms*: democracy and political freedom need weak thought, universal pragmatics, or propheticism as much as a fish needs a bicycle. Hermeneutic communism would have struck Rorty as odd as a "charismatic trash disposal."

Understanding Is Always Understanding a Bit Better

There are some great phrases in *Hermeneutic Communism*, and one of my favorite ones is on page 5, where Vattimo and Zabala write: "the task of philosophy is not to describe the world, but to interpret it productively." I like this phrase because it points out that the task of philosophy is not simply and perhaps even less to attempt to describe the world, but to contribute to our transformation of ourselves and our world by achieving 'better,' more 'expansive,' more ecumenical, more emancipatory, understandings. I take it that Vattimo and Zabala mean "productively" in this latter sense I just elaborated: namely understanding has a practical intent. Hermeneutics is a praxis that transforms us, others, our worlds, our forms of life. It does this by the fusion of horizons of meaning, but it does this already at the lowest register of hermeneutics: when a new interpretation is put forth. But not all interpretations are equally close to God and neither do all interpretations interpret the world productively.

I agree with Vattimo and Zabala that hermeneutics has a radical, emancipatory character, which is why some have written about 'radical hermeneutics.' Reiner Schürmann, who was my teacher at the New School, can be said to be one of the

¹⁷ Richard Rorty, *Take Care of Freedom and Truth Will Take Care of Itself: Interview with Richard Rorty* edited and introduced by Eduardo Mendieta (Stanford, CA: Stanford University Press, 2006).

main defenders of such a perspective. And I am very glad to see him quoted at key places in this *Hermeneutic Communism*. But, when Vattimo and Zabala urge us to engage in a hermeneutics that interprets the world productively, they already direct us to a major question: what counts as a more productive interpretation? This turns out to be the question of what are the criteria of evaluation of better or worse interpretations. Karl-Otto Apel, who also taught at the New School in the 70s, and who was also one of my teachers, in fact took up this question in the 50s and 60s in a debate with Gadamer. Apel's position was that Gadamer had done a great service by taking up Heidegger's insights into the world-disclosing power of language and transforming them into the art of interpretation.

Yet, for Apel, the art of interpretation entailed addressing the question of what counts as the conditions for coming to an understanding about anything. Hermeneutics, like semiotics and pragmatics, was also implicated in the game of having to provide rational criteria for its execution. It is to be noted that in early essays Apel referred to his own positions as a type of transcendental hermeneutics, or transcendental hermeneutics-pragmatics. Eventually Apel settled for 'transcendental semiotics'-but it was clear to him that hermeneutics and pragmatics were folded, or implied, in semiotics.¹⁸ In fact, when he called his two-volume work *Transformation der Philosophie* he was directing us not simply to a desiderata, but to what had already taken place through the work of Peirce, Wittgenstein, Heidegger and Gadamer. The 'transformation of philosophy' that Apel aimed to diagnose and document was one that had been brought about by a hermeneutical-pragmatic reflection on the conditions of coming to an understanding. What the conditions are that enable us to recognize that we have come to a successful and more 'productive' understanding, is a question that modern hermeneutics raised correctly, even if it has not answered it yet or for the time being satisfactorily.

For my purposes in this essay, however, I have invoked Apel and his engagement with hermeneutics, and specifically the ontological hermeneutics of both Heidegger and Gadamer, to profile the argument that hermeneutics itself has raised the issue of normative criteria, and above all, of the rationality claimed implicitly in the affirmation that to understand is to understand better, and thus, that there is no understanding that at some level does not give a justification for why it is a better understanding than any other. I would like to close by paraphrasing an expression of Robert Brandom for my own ends. When we make claims about coming to any understanding whatsoever, we are already in the grip of reason, of having to give and answer to reasons—reason is at the very least this game of having to give and evaluate reasons. Reason is a score keeping of the giving of reasons. Neither hermeneutics, nor communism, dispenses with the claim of reason, the claim to have to give reasons, reasons that have to be evaluated and scored. Hitherto, and I echo the last line of Vattimo and Zabala's book, philosophers have only 'described' the world, but the task is to interpret it in ever more productive ways that will lead to its transformation.

¹⁸ See Karl-Otto Apel, *Towards a Transcendental Semiotics: Selected Essays of Karl-Otto Apel. Volume 1* Edited and Introduced by Eduardo Mendieta with Preface by Karl-Otto Apel. (Atlantic Highlands, New Jersey: Humanities Press, 1994).

For this transformation to take place, we have to show why our interpretations are better than those of liberals, neoliberals and tea partiers.

The Manifesto of the Communism to Come

I began this essay with a reflection on the power of manifestos. I focused briefly on *The Communist Manifesto* and its rhetorical power, which even to this day continues to inspire and move people. In a not well known, but indispensable little essay titled “A Rhetorical Approach to the *Communist Manifesto*,”¹⁹ Haig A. Bosmajian offers an exacting analysis of the compositional brilliance of the manifesto. Bosmajian notes that the text offers an exordium, a narration, a peroration, but that these particular rhetorical devices are all held together by an *ethos*. The ethos of the *Communist Manifesto* is dissimulated by the very approach of the narration and the exordium. The narration and the exordium carry forth, witness, enact the ethos without this ethos having to name itself, or to argue for itself. In his essay on the manifesto, Hobsbawm wrote:

What gives the *Manifesto* its force is two things. The first is its vision, even at the outset of the triumphal march of capitalism, that this mode of production was not permanent, stable, ‘the end of history,’ but a temporary phase in the history of humanity, and, like its predecessors, one due to be superseded by another kind of society (unless – the *Manifesto*’s phrase has not been much noted – it founders ‘in the common ruin of the contending classes’). The second is its recognition of the necessary *long-term* historical tendencies of capitalist development. The revolutionary potential of the capitalist economy was already evident.²⁰

What Marx and Engels accomplished in the manifesto was to bring together historical contingency with historical tendency to pry open the horizon of history in such a way that historical agency could be both catalyzed and energized. Bosmajian put it thusly:

Marx not only attempts to arouse anger, which is always attended by a certain pleasure arising from the expectation of revenge against a particular person or persons, but he also attempts to arouse hatred which is directed not only against an individual, but also against a class. Marx obviously was interested in more than arousing his audience to anger which would induce them to wish the object of their anger to suffer; his goal was to arouse his listeners to the state in which they would wish the bourgeois eradicated.²¹

The manifesto, then, should be read as a text that through its rhetorical composition produces a certain kind of moral affect, by placing us in a certain subject position, which urges human beings to engage in a project. Manifestos are affect producing devices. They are somatological devices in so far as they call forth a moral affectivity. It is the kind of moral outrage that appears both justified and necessary that

¹⁹ Haig A. Bosmajian, “A Rhetorical Approach to the *Communist Manifesto*” *The Dalhousie Review*, Vol. 43, No. 4 (1963–1964), 457–468.

²⁰ Eric Hobsbawm, “On the Communist Manifesto” in *How to Change the World*, 111.

²¹ Haig A. Bosmajian, “A Rhetorical Approach to the *Communist Manifesto*”, 460–461.

warrants a call to arms, to action. In the *Communist Manifesto*, however, there is a balance between prophecy and messianism, that is, between describing a historically contingent state of affairs and anticipating an agent or agents that will deliver us from historical tendencies. Human agency is enabled there were the horizon of history remains open and yet to be decided.

The question for us today is what kind of narration can we link to an exordium and peroration that enables a new moral outrage as we face problems very different from those of the nineteenth century, when Marx and Engels wrote their manifesto? This narration, certainly, will include stories about the rise of the bourgeoisie, industrial capitalism, imperialism and neoimperialism, but it must also includes stories about ecological devastation, human induced famines, and growing economic and political interdependence –for instance, as does Vandana Shiva’s *Manifestos on the Future of Food & Seed*.²² This narration can no longer be focused narrowly on Europe, or even the North Atlantic, or the interaction between Europe and the Americas. Its historical horizon will have to be more expansive, if it is going to appeal to a larger “we.” Rorty argued that the debate between communitarians and liberals, Aristotelians and Kantians, Derridians and Habermasians could be phrased as an argument about whether we should “contract the circle [of our community of moral accountability] for the sake of loyalty, or expand it for the sake of justice.”²³ In Rorty’s view, however, this is a false dichotomy. For him, justice is a form of loyalty to a certain we, a large and enlarged community of moral accountability. Somewhere else Rorty wrote beautifully: “For groups build their moral strength by achieving increasing semantic authority over their members, thereby increasing the ability of those members to find their moral identities in their membership in such groups.”²⁴ Manifestos, I have argued so far, are precisely the tools through which we fashion new moral identities. Manifestos conjure and interpellate a more expansive “we.” I think that they key lesson of *Hermeneutic Communism* is that we have to interpret not simply the inheritance of communism in ever more generative and creative ways, but also that we have to fashion a more ecumenical and humane “we” through the new stories we tell about how we got where we are today and where we should be going in the near future. The communism to come that is anticipated by *Hermeneutic Communism*, is one that must also invoke a new “we.”

²² Vandana Shiva, ed., *Manifestos on the Future of Food & Seed* (Cambridge, Massachusetts: South End Press, 2007).

²³ Richard Rorty, “Justice as a larger loyalty” in *Philosophy as Cultural Politics. Philosophical Papers, Volume 4* (Cambridge, MA: Cambridge University Press, 2007), 44.

²⁴ Richard Rorty, “Feminism and Pragmatism” *Truth and Progress*, 223.

Response to Mendieta

Santiago Zabala and Gianni Vattimo

Eduardo Mendieta's claim that *Hermeneutic Communism* reads like a manifesto is not only philosophically accurate, but also touching as we never thought of the text in these terms. We knew this was going to be a book of political philosophy, but it never occurred to us it would be interpreted as a manifesto or proclamation. If Mendieta is correct, readers will continue to interpret this book in the future. And it is precisely for this future that we have written it. A future which, similarly to Heidegger's other "inception," Derrida's "democracy to come," and Richard Rorty "social hope" must still arrive. While this might sound paradoxical, as we took Latin American progressive governments as a model for our Western neoliberal democracies, the book was not written for *them*, but rather for *us*. The "hermeneutic communism" we deem is still taking place in Latin America has not ended with the passing of its charismatic leader (Hugo Chavez) or recent political changes in Argentina, Cuba, and Brazil during 2014 and 2015, but rather begun there.

What is extraordinary today for us, almost 7 years after its publication, is that this inception of radical democracy and social initiatives has reached Europe. We are not referring to the *indignados* or Occupy movements, but rather those who have been capable of transforming these movements into a political party. It should not come as a surprise that the first country in Europe where this took place is Spain with Podemos. But this did not simply occur because its leaders (Pablo Iglesias, Juan Carlos Monedero, and Íñigo Errejón) travelled, researched, and admired Latin America's Bolivarian revolution, but also because of Spain's linguistic proximity to the new continent. Together with Podemos we must also emphasize the significance of Pope Francis' election. The election of a Latin American Pope who has begun a

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progressive reformation of the Vatican belongs to an epoch where the “weak” have finally began to take part in the distribution of power.

In his insightful contribution, Mendieta does not simply and generously relate our book to other manifestos (*The Communist Manifesto*, *The First Declaration of the Lacandon Jungle*, and *The Declaration of the Occupation of New York City*), but also questions the way we present the “end of metaphysics,” whether Rorty would have approved of hermeneutics’ ability to weaken communism, and “what counts as a more productive interpretation.” Let’s start with the end of metaphysics.

According to Mendieta, we “write as though the end of metaphysics had happened qua dispensation of being itself.” But “how can something come to an end, and yet still remain operative?” “Did it come to an end of its own accord, or was it something that humans did that spelled its end,” and finally, “whether in announcing its end, metaphysics endurance is not renewed, and given a new lease on life.” We agree with Mendieta how paradoxical the end of metaphysics sounds as we condemn to “framed democracies,” and “scientific realism” ongoing contemporary impositions. But as we tried to explain in the third chapter the end of metaphysics is not a fact, but a narration which has different stages and interpretations. This is why we refer to the end of colonialism and rise of cultural anthropology, and also Nietzsche’s well known chapter from *Twilight of Idols*, “How the ‘Real World’ at Last became a Myth.” These ought to be interpreted as part of the dissolution of metaphysics whose “end” is in progress, that is, an ongoing process. If this end cannot become complete, it’s not only due to our incapacity to overcome it, but rather resistance our to falling back into another metaphysics. This is why from the start we emphasize the difference between overcoming metaphysics in the sense of “überwunden” (defeating or leaving at large) and “verwindung” (twisting or weakening). In this form, metaphysics is not “renewed,” but rather overcome productively because as Heidegger once said, “overcoming is worthy only when we think of incorporation.”

Mendieta believes Rorty would have reacted to *Hermeneutic Communism* the same way he reacted to Cornel West’s *The American Evasion of Philosophy* and Habermas’s *Between Facts and Norms*: “democracy and political freedom need weak thought, universal pragmatics, or propheticism as much as a fish needs a bicycle.” It is true Rorty did not believe philosophy ought to guide politics, but we must recall for Mendieta both hermeneutics and weak thought do not rely exclusively upon Heidegger, Gadamer, and Nietzsche, but also Rorty’s own postmetaphysical pragmatism. If he believed the “hermeneutical or Gadamerian attitude is in the political world what democracy is in the political world,” it’s because hermeneutics cannot be reduced to another “philosophical stance,” that is, metaphysical approach. For Rorty “philosophy” and “hermeneutics” are not equivalent. This is probably why he believed, as he said at Gadamer’s hundredth birthday celebration in Heidelberg, that a “Gadamerian culture would have no use of faculties called ‘reason’ or ‘imagination’ – faculties that are conceived as having some special relation to truth or reality.”¹

¹ R. Rorty, “Being that can be understood is Language,” *London Review of Books* 22, n. 6, March 16, 2000.

Mendieta's reference to our call for "productive interpretations" does not require a response, as he agrees with our characterization of hermeneutics as a radical and emancipatory thought. He is correct to point out that this is a problem Reiner Schürmann and Karl-Otto Apel have also confronted. Our preference for the former does not simply rest in his use of "anarchy" to interpret the different epoch of metaphysics, but also in his suspicion in Apel's request for "rational criteria" when preferring one interpretation over another. After all, these rational criteria are never abstract or philosophical, but always participatory in oppressing the weak. Mendieta is correct to point out that the "key lesson of *Hermeneutic Communism* is" to interpret both "the inheritance of communism in ever more generative and creative ways" and "to fashion a more ecumenical and humane 'we'" as long as this "we" refers to the weak.

Politics, Hermeneutics, and Truth

Jeff Malpas and Nick Malpas

In a time of universal deceit – telling the truth is a revolutionary act
(George Orwell)

Abstract The idea that hermeneutics has a positive political potential has not always been well-recognized. Yet if politics is understood as essentially constituted within a public space of negotiation and adjudication, then it is hard to see how politics could be anything but hermeneutical in character, nor could we avoid the conclusion that hermeneutical reflection must have a positive bearing on political discourse. Vattimo and Zabala's idea of 'hermeneutic communism' not only draws the political and the hermeneutical together, but also shows how the resources of hermeneutic thinking can be brought to bear on contemporary forms of suffering, inequality and oppression. Vattimo and Zabala's hermeneutic understanding of the political is premised, however, on the abandonment, not merely of a certain form of metaphysical thinking, but on the abandonment also of the concept of truth. Yet the rethinking of truth, and especially the critique of its metaphysical misinterpretations, has been at the heart of much of the development in hermeneutic thinking over the last century, such that it would seem that any genuinely hermeneutical rethinking of the political cannot be undertaken without recourse to truth. Indeed, it is precisely the retrieval of truth, rather than its abandonment, that must stand as the real basis for the sort of hermeneutic politics, or even the 'hermeneutic communism', that Vattimo and Zabala propose.

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Interpretation, along with language, extends into almost every area of human activity, including politics. In this respect, there is a straightforward sense in which hermeneutics is relevant to politics, but only inasmuch as hermeneutics is also relevant to almost every area of human activity. The question is whether it has any deeper relevance to politics in particular, and especially to contemporary politics. One of the virtues of Vattimo and Zabala's *Hermeneutic Communism* [] is that it takes up this question and argues that hermeneutics, at least in its current philosophical form, does indeed have a special relevance to politics and the political. Far from being politically neutral, or politically conservative or regressive, as is often assumed, Vattimo and Zabala argue that hermeneutics is directly relevant to our contemporary political situation. We would agree that in its emphasis on difference, on critical engagement, on attentiveness to particularity, hermeneutics provides what may be the only frame within which any genuine philosophical opposition to the globalised order of corporate capital seems possible.

Drawing attention to the political potential that hermeneutics offers is one of the major achievements of Vattimo and Zabala's book. The attempt to connect hermeneutics with communism is also a provocative means of achieving this end. Yet there are problems with their outlook, in particular: can a politics animated by a hermeneutic sensibility really do without truth as Vattimo and Zabala claim? Their position is based on the claim that both hermeneutics and communism share a common 'weakness' that consists in their rejection of metaphysics, including the concept of truth. One might question whether this is really true of communism as it is usually understood in its Marxist form, but Vattimo and Zabala clearly use 'communism' in a way that takes it more as a form of anti-capitalism than as consisting in a positive politics of a specific form. Although there are undoubtedly issues about Vattimo and Zabala's understanding of communism that might be pursued further here, our concerns lie elsewhere, specifically in the direction of Vattimo and Zabala's reading of hermeneutics. The claim that contemporary philosophical hermeneutics carries a strongly anti-metaphysical import is not, in our view, contentious. However, Vattimo and Zabala assume a reading of the hermeneutic critique of metaphysics as consisting essentially in a critique, and even a renunciation, of the very idea of truth, and this is something we take to be contentious indeed. Consequently, our discussion will focus on Vattimo and Zabala's attitude towards truth and their refusal to admit any role for truth in either hermeneutics or politics. Whereas Vattimo and Zabala claim that "we must leave, discard, or cancel truth: *the end of truth is the beginning of democracy*",¹ we argue that leaving, discarding or cancelling truth would also involve leaving, discarding, or canceling democracy. Without truth there can be no democracy, nor any genuine human community.

Vattimo and Zabala contrast interpretation with description – a contrast that is central to their conception of hermeneutics. They characterize contemporary capitalist liberal politics as a "politics of description." Such a politics of description is based on a conception of truth understood "as a reflection of a given objective

¹ *Hermeneutic Communism*, p. 23.

order”² and, thus, takes political decision and action as determined by a true description of reality – “These metaphysically framed political systems hold that society must direct itself according to truth (the existing paradigm).”³ On Vattimo and Zabala’s account, this descriptive rather than interpretive orientation is *unhermeneutical* or even *anti-hermeneutical*. Despite its appearance of impartiality, Vattimo and Zabala claim further that the politics of description is an instrument of political domination. The politics of description works “in favor of the strong against the weak. Only the strong determine truth, because they are the only ones that have the tools to know, practice, and impose it ... the search for universal truth became an imposition on individual differences and identities.”⁴

Vattimo and Zabala identify truth as both “a reflection of a given objective order” and also as “an imposition” (of “the existing paradigm”) by the strong on the weak. Such a conception of truth is deeply problematic no matter how commonplace such a conception of truth may be in certain “critical” modes of discourse. The reason is simple: the two aspects that Vattimo and Zabala impute to truth are contradictory. The objective is that which stands apart from both the subjective and the intersubjective, just as truth stands apart from belief (*being true* is distinct from *holding true*). Truth as it is tied to an objective order is precisely something that *cannot* be “imposed,” and although the exercise of power may be able to make someone believe something, that power alone cannot make the belief true. One might be tempted to dismiss such observations as trivial and irrelevant to what might be seen as the larger philosophical issues at stake here – issues relating, not to any matters of ‘mere’ semantics, but to the way the rhetoric of truth plays out in concrete social and political contexts, and the way regimes of truth, to use a Foucaultian turn of phrase, are also always regimes of power. Yet the operation of power is not independent of what may appear as the ‘trivial’ distinctions at stake here, and understanding how power relates to truth itself depends on a proper understanding of both power and truth.

Truth is not the only concept that has an important connection to power. Any concept that carries a degree of imperatival force (as truth does inasmuch as it *commands* belief), will always be a concept that will be connected to structures of power and that will also be drawn upon by the institutions of power. Even the concept of justice, which might be seen as implicit in the argument offered by Vattimo and Zabala on behalf of the weak against the strong, is a concept that has a similar imperatival force. Justice, like all normative political concepts – as well as the normative concepts of ethics – *commands* certain forms of action and decision. Moreover, the way power connects to notions like truth and justice indicates that power itself has to be understood, not as some external imposition onto the social and political order, but as integral to that order. Indeed, if we turn back to Foucault here, we would be reminded of the fact that power is not to be construed in purely negative terms. Instead, power is productive, and what it names, in one sense at

²*Hermeneutic Communism*, p. 18.

³*Hermeneutic Communism*, p. 12 & 13.

⁴*Hermeneutic Communism*, p. 12 & 13.

least, is the structuration that makes social and political, that is, *human* life possible. That truth is connected to power follows simply from the fact that truth is necessary for human collectivity and communication. The mere fact that truth is connected to power implies nothing about whether truth is associated with any particular form of politics, and it certainly does not imply that truth is necessarily oppressive. Rather, truth, like power, is implicated in the very structure that makes politics, and political action and decision, possible.

Of course, merely recognizing that truth and power are implicated in the structure of political, and more generally, human life, leaves open the question of exactly how truth is implicated here. To understand the latter we need to inquire more deeply into the role truth plays in relation to language, communication, and meaning. Truth is a property, in one quite straightforward sense, of assertions.⁵ Although not all forms of language are assertoric, all forms of language do depend upon their embeddedness within and their connection to assertions. This follows from the systematic character of language in terms of the systematic interconnectedness of the various modes and moods of discourse – so not only is it possible to reinterpret a command as an assertion, but any particular command also necessarily implies a range of assertions.⁶ Inasmuch as assertion is arguably *the* primary linguistic form, so all language use is inextricably bound to truth. Indeed, thinking about truth really has to begin with this understanding of truth as implicated in our most ordinary speech and activity, and not with some exotic idea of truth only as the marker of some transcendent metaphysical reality (big “T” Truth) or some instrument of hegemonic power. Hannah Arendt emphasizes this aspect of truth – its centrality to communication – as well as its related role in the possibility of human collectivity, when she writes:

Truth itself is communicative, it disappears and cannot be conceived outside communication; within the “existential” realm, truth and communication are the same. “Truth is what binds us together.” Only in communication – between contemporaries as well as between the living and the dead – does truth reveal itself.⁷

To overlook truth as it is tied to communication, that is, to the very possibility of linguistic expression and understanding, is to overlook the very character of truth,

⁵This is not to say that truth is founded in the proposition alone. Heidegger’s claim that the primary locus of truth is not the proposition is not incompatible with an understanding that also recognizes the connection of truth with assertion. Indeed, Heidegger’s distinction between truth as correctness and truth as *aletheia* can itself be seen as implying just such a recognition – the point, of course, is that the latter sense grounds the former.

⁶For a classic statement of some of the issues at stake here see Donald Davidson’s ‘Moods and Performances’, *Inquiries into Truth and Interpretation* (Oxford: Clarendon Press, 2nd edn, 2001), pp. 109–121. Davidson’s focus in this paper is on accommodating non-indicative (non-assertoric) utterances within a theory of meaning that, since it takes the form of a theory of truth, thereby also gives a certain primacy to indicatives.

⁷Hannah Arendt, *Men in Dark Times* (New York: Houghton Mifflin Harcourt, 1970), p. 86; see also the discussion of this passage in Jeff Malpas, ‘Truth, Politics and Democracy: Arendt, Orwell and Camus’, in Andrew Schaap, Danielle Celermajer, and Vrasidas Karalis (eds), *Power, Judgment and Political Evil: In Conversation with Hannah Arendt* (Farnham: Ashgate, 2010), pp. 133–145.

but also to overlook, and to misunderstand, the very character of communication, language, and community.⁸

One of the hallmarks of hermeneutic thinking has been its recognition of what Gadamer refers to as the “linguisticity of understanding” [2]. Because of hermeneutics’ foundational concern with language and communication, no less than with understanding or interpretation, hermeneutics is centrally concerned with truth in the basic and fundamental sense referred to above – a sense that is bound to its essential role in language (although this communicative sense of truth is not exhausted by any account of truth that treats it merely as a disquotational predicate attaching to individual sentences). That hermeneutics is concerned with truth is suggested by the very title of Gadamer’s magnum opus, *Truth and Method*, as well as by the way in which truth appears at the heart of Heidegger’s thinking. Even though hermeneutic philosophers stress the need to critique the narrowly ‘realist’ or metaphysical conception of truth as some form of ‘correspondence’ between sentences and world (a rethinking that is evident in the work of Davidson as well as Heidegger),⁹ still this critique does not involve an abandonment of truth or ‘farewell’ to truth (as Vattimo has it elsewhere [3]), but rather a rethinking of the very idea of truth. In hermeneutic terms, truth is understood as foundational to the possibility of meaning, and as that which, in Arendt’s terms, allows for the possibility of human communication and community. In this respect, truth not only stands in an essential relation to language, and to being (which, following Heidegger, is to be understood non-metaphysically), but also to the very possibility of politics and political critique. Critique does not involve mere opposition. It is instead founded in that which can be contested, which also thereby lies *between* people, and which is itself the proper focus for contestation. In hermeneutic terms, contestation or disagreement, as well as agreement, must always be *about* something, and, must thus be grounded in a common subject matter. This point is emphasized by Gadamer, and it is here

⁸At this point, some brief comment is needed concerning Alfred Tarski’s famous proposal for the formal definition of truth on the basis of its disquotational character (discussed by Vattimo and Zabala in *Hermeneutic Communism*, pp. 19–20). Even though Tarski characterized his proposal as consistent with a correspondence account, that proposal does not imply that truth is indeed to be understood on the basis of such an account. Davidson points out, in a way that can be seen to parallel some of Heidegger’s arguments regarding truth (see Jeff Malpas, ‘The Two-fold Character of Truth: Heidegger, Davidson, Tugendhat’, *Divinatio* 34, 2011, pp. 141–170), that Tarski’s definition actually relies on a prior grasp of truth just as it relies on our prior understanding of the embedded sentence, the sentence that is quoted or named, within a Tarskian T-sentence. Consequently, Tarski provides no account of truth at all, but only the structure for a formal definition of the truth predicate as it operates within a given language (and it does this extensionally, that is, by providing a procedure that will enable the identification of the members of that class of sentences to which the truth predicate can properly be attached). It is because it does this that Davidson thought it could function as the basis for a theory of meaning. For more on this issue, see the summary of the Davidsonian position, which includes a brief discussion of Tarski, in the *Stanford Encyclopedia of Philosophy*, Malpas, Jeff, “Donald Davidson”, *The Stanford Encyclopedia of Philosophy* (Fall 2010 Edition), Edward N. Zalta (ed.), URL = <<http://plato.stanford.edu/archives/fall2010/entries/davidson>>.

⁹See Jeff Malpas, *Donald Davidson and the Mirror of Meaning* (Cambridge: Cambridge University Press, 1992), and, more recently, ‘The Two-fold Character of Truth: Heidegger, Davidson, Tugendhat’.

that the concept of truth, as well as of objectivity (understood simply as that which pertains to the object), plays an essential role. This understanding of truth as communicative enables us to see, *contra* Vattimo and Zabala, how truth is actually opposed to violence.

Vattimo and Zabala describe the politics of description – the politics they associate with contemporary liberalism and capitalism – as also a politics of truth, and since Vattimo and Zabala take this to mean that it is a politics that operates “in favor of the strong against the weak”, so they also view it as essentially a politics of *violence*. Indeed, they claim that violence is itself the “political meaning” of truth:

Truth is not only “violent,” in that it turns away from solidarity, but it is “violence,” because it can easily become an imposition on our very existence. Being “violent” might imply that it can also be peaceful, but truth instead often implies an imposed description whose acceptance is assumed. Violence is the political meaning of truth, because truth always implies a concluding constriction.¹⁰

There is no question that, as we noted earlier, truth has an imperatival force – it commands belief. Moreover, the making of truth claims, like any linguistic act, can also have negative effects on others – sometimes harmful and sometimes coercive. But these facts do not warrant the claim that truth *as such* is violent. The power truth has over us, which is not identical with political power, is a power that derives from our own being as already given over to truth, given over to care for and about the truth. This is, moreover, not a power that we can ever escape, since it is not a power exerted over us from without – instead, the power of truth is a power generated through the way truth functions as a necessary part of the very dynamic of meaning, desire, belief and action in which we are ourselves enmeshed. To suppose that we could somehow escape the power of truth would thus be radically to misunderstand our own being. The inference from the character of truth as a “constriction” or “imposition” to the claim that violence is the political meaning of truth, involves a misunderstanding not only of truth and violence but also of the way in which truth constricts or limits.

Understood as a limit, truth is not, to paraphrase Heidegger, that at which we stop, but rather that from which we begin.¹¹ Truth enables while it also limits, and this is why truth has so often been understood, quite properly, as essentially tied to freedom. To be able to act at all, one must have largely true beliefs about oneself (for example, one’s abilities and intentions) and about that on which one acts. Truth

¹⁰ *Hermeneutic Communism*, p. 18.

¹¹ “A boundary is not that at which something stops but, as the Greeks recognized, the boundary is that from which something begins its presencing. That is why the concept is that of *horismos*, that is, the horizon, the boundary”, Martin Heidegger, ‘Building Dwelling Thinking’, in *Poetry Language Thought*, trans. Albert Hofstadter (New York: Harper & Row, 1971), p. 154. “. The ‘power’ of truth is to be understood, in this respect, as like the ‘power’ of the horizon. The positive sense of limit that is at issue here is central to hermeneutics, inasmuch as one of the key hermeneutic insights is that finitude is not that which prevents understanding, but is rather its enabling condition. For more on this theme see Jeff Malpas, *Heidegger’s Topology* (Cambridge, Mass.: The MIT Press, 2006), and also *Heidegger and the Thinking of Place* (Cambridge, Mass.: The MIT Press, 2012).

enables not only the possibility of individual action and understanding, but also, the possibility of human being together. This is a point made, in different ways, by Heidegger, Gadamer, and Arendt. Thus, rather than being “an imposition on individual differences and identities,”¹² truth refers us to a common world which goes beyond any individual’s perspective or will, and so forms a common basis for both individual differences and for relationships between people. As Arendt writes: “Facts inform opinions, and opinions, inspired by different interests and passions, can differ widely and still be legitimate as long as they respect factual truth.” [4] Moreover, as she also points out, when people lose the ability to distinguish between truth and falsity and the connection to a common reality (as is the case under totalitarian regimes, which “conjure up a lying world of consistency”), then “loneliness” pervades society. Under such circumstances, people lose a sense of their own identity as they also lose the capacity to relate authentically to others [5].

The failure to recognize the way in which both human identity and human relationality are connected with truth and the commonality of the world leads Vattimo and Zabala to make the strange claim that, in the politics of description, violence takes place through “dialogue” in which claims to truth amount to a “‘silencing’ of [the] other interlocutor.”¹³ Undoubtedly ‘dialogue’, like ‘truth’ (or like ‘justice’), can be deployed rhetorically to advance particular agendas of coercion or oppression. Yet that should not blind us to the fact that genuine dialogue (and also truth) is foundational to non-coercive modes of discourse and conduct. Indeed, the only way in which people can break out of what Foucault calls the “silence of slavery” is through dialogue, and that dialogue would be meaningless if people could not speak truly, for the most part, or were not committed to such speaking – which is why Foucault himself claims that respect for the task of speaking the truth (a task he describes as an “infinite labour”) is an obligation “that no power can afford to short-change” [6]. If politics is to be conducted in a non-coercive (and thus non-violent) fashion, then there can be no other course open other than that of commitment to dialogue and respect for truth.

In political terms, real violence – the violence that involves deliberate assault on people’s bodies, possessions, and relationships – actually stands in an antagonistic relation to truth. Untruthfulness – deceit, evasion, concealment – amounts to a form of discursive violence. It is violence against others *by means of speech*, and, since truth and truthfulness are conditions for the very meaningfulness of speech, it is also violence *against speech itself*. Untruthfulness is also wedded to violence pragmatically, since untruthfulness is one of the means by which violence can be enacted without retribution, as well as one of the means by which its effects are often intensified. Conversely, speaking the truth is at work in the uncovering of violence, in ensuring accountability for violence, and in preventing violence. It is also essential in the reconstitution of social relations in the aftermath of violence – a key idea in the theory of restorative justice. Indeed, the very possibility of non-violent relations

¹² *Hermeneutic Communism*, p. 13.

¹³ *Hermeneutic Communism*, p. 19.

depends on modes of social interaction regulated by truth and conducted through dialogue.

Of course, the antagonism that exists between truth and violence is obscured when we forget the distinction between what is true and what is merely claimed as true. Violence itself is the inevitable outcome of this forgetting, since it arises out of the inability to recognize that what one *holds to be true*, or what one *wants to be true*, need not coincide with what *is true*. The assertion of one's own belief or will despite the truth is itself a form of violence – violence against reality and one's own capacity for knowledge and rational action and, potentially, violence against others.

It is precisely because truth and violence are antagonistic that resistance to violence – and so also the resistance of the weak to the strong, the resistance to tyranny and oppression – has so often depended on the mobilization of truth. This is no less true of the resistance to the oppressive forms of contemporary corporate capitalism than it has been of the resistance to other forms of domination – be they monarchical, imperialist, fascist, or communist. It is no accident that one of the key issues underpinning the corrosion of democratic governance in the United States and other “Western” democracies is the increasing control of information and the use of deception and disinformation by government and corporate agencies. This is why the disclosure of government information by independent groups or individuals (such as Edward Snowden or Wikileaks) is of such contemporary significance – such disclosure is an attempt to call governments to account for their misdeeds at a time when the accountability of power has been eroded. The political meaning of truth is not violence, then, but precisely the refusal of violence. Moreover, we can now appreciate how the refusal of violence and the respect for truth come together in what we would argue is the core hermeneutic commitment to allow the other to speak, and, also, to allow that the other might be right. As Gadamer claimed (echoing Albert Camus' famous claim regarding the essence of democracy): “The possibility that the other might be right is the soul of hermeneutics”¹⁴ – it is also the soul of any genuine alternative to violence in the political sphere or elsewhere.

As we have already seen, the opposition between description and interpretation is central to Vattimo and Zabala's critique of contemporary politics, in particular, to their critique of it as metaphysical. Vattimo and Zabala construe hermeneutics almost purely in terms of the commitment to interpretation, which they oppose to description. Truth, in their view, stands firmly on the side of description, and is thus dissociated from and opposed to interpretation. Although this emphasis on interpretation might seem an uncontroversial way of characterizing hermeneutics, the idea of an absolute distinction between interpretation and description threatens to reinstate a mode of metaphysical thinking of exactly the sort that Vattimo and Zabala claim to reject. The opposition they posit between interpretation and description is one of the very “established polarities” with a “hierarchical order” that they decry and regard as characteristic of metaphysics.¹⁵ Recognizing the universality of the

¹⁴A claim made at the Heidelberg Colloquium, July 9, 1989, and quoted by Jean Grondin, *Introduction to Philosophical Hermeneutics*, p. 124.

¹⁵*Hermeneutic Communism*, p. 13.

hermeneutic problem means recognizing, not only the way in which any and every distinction is always subject to a degree of hermeneutic indeterminacy, but also the impossibility of absolutizing the distinctions that arise within an interpretive context. This indeterminacy affects even the distinction between interpretation and description. Indeed, interpretation and description cannot be regarded as antagonistic. Description itself always involves interpretation (in the sense of imputing meaning to something) and each interpretation always takes a certain description of its subject matter (which identifies that which is to be interpreted) as given. Thus, rather than rejecting the distinction between interpretation and description, a properly hermeneutic understanding should recognize the interplay, within particular discursive and interpretive contexts, between what can be understood as interpretive and descriptive modes. The distinction between those modes, together with the distinction between holding true and being true, will itself figure as an element in the larger dynamic of hermeneutic engagement as such.¹⁶

We would argue that, properly understood, truth is not a metaphysical concept at all, but is rather anti-metaphysical. Attending to truth means attending to the character of discourse as always oriented by and towards the truth, as always concerned for the truth (although truth is not the only concern of discourse), even while truth always remains beyond any absolute determination in terms of a single foundational statement or any finite body of statements. Truth is always the truth of this or that claim, in this or that discursive context. Attending to truth means attending to the complexity of our situatedness in the world, to the complexity of the situatedness of others, and to the complexity of the world itself. In politics, this ought to counsel against the idea that any single ideology – any single descriptive *or* interpretive frame – will provide a final answer to the demands of political action and decision. In this respect, hermeneutics should not be taken to be necessarily allied with either communism, capitalism, or any other political doctrine.

Hermeneutics does, however, have a strongly democratic tendency – not in the sense that ‘democracy’ denotes a comprehensive political outlook or any specific political arrangement, but rather as it entails a commitment to dialogue, openness of debate, transparency of process, accessibility of information, and, crucially, equality of participation as the proper basis for political decision and action. Democracy in this sense involves a commitment to *politics* as a domain of public contestation, negotiation, and participation rather than to any particular political outcomes or even procedures. Indeed, it seems that any determination of the specific outcomes that politics should achieve (such as the control of production and the distribution of social goods that has traditionally been the focus of communism) that did not arise

¹⁶ In this respect, hermeneutics should not be characterized as concerned *only* with interpretation, but also with description – with description as it is always entangled with interpretation, even as it may also be distinguished from it. What becomes problematic, then, in hermeneutic practice and elsewhere, is the disavowal of the dynamism and indeterminacy that is in play here, and it is this same refusal that surely underpins the ‘absolutizing’ mode of thinking that we term ‘metaphysical’.

from actual political debate amongst both politicians and the general public would be precisely the kind of imposed paradigm that Vattimo and Zabala reject.

Resisting the imposition of political measures (and the violence, oppression, and injustice they would entail) requires that we make public power accountable and that we facilitate wide participation in public affairs, neither of which are possible unless people have access to and respect for the truth. At times, Vattimo and Zabala seem to agree that politics should be a matter of such free public action¹⁷ and that “non-violent methods” are “the most productive alternatives” to fight capitalist oppression¹⁸ – although we would stress that non-violence should be chosen primarily for moral, rather than strategic, reasons. Rather ominously, however, Vattimo and Zabala also claim that violence and violation of democratic “rules” “ought to be defended” inasmuch as they are necessary for realizing other socially or economically beneficial aims. Thus they approvingly cite Mao’s dictum that “A revolution is not a dinner party ... A revolution is an insurrection, an act of violence by which one class overthrows another.”¹⁹ It is strange that here violence seems endorsed, whereas elsewhere the supposed violence associated with truth is taken as grounds for the refusal of truth.²⁰

Although we would agree with Vattimo and Zabala that hermeneutics does indeed provide a powerful platform from which to formulate a critique of the oppressive character of contemporary liberal and capitalist ideologies and political formations, it does so in a way that enables a similar critique of many of the ideologies and forms of communism also. Hermeneutics is founded in the normative ideas of concern for truth, respect for others, and the commitment to mutual understanding, but these ideas provide a platform from which to critique any political doctrine, action or institution, and not only those associated with capitalism. In this respect, a genuinely hermeneutic politics ought to be one that takes its bearings, not from any particular political ideology, but from the actual character and circumstances of human life; that seeks to maintain a genuinely open and transparent realm of public debate and decision-making; that allows for the open-ended and negotiatory character of politics without avoiding the necessity to judge and act; and that refuses to accept that the subordination of moral and ethical considerations to state or corporate interests (especially the supposed imperatives of economics). A genuinely hermeneutic politics would be, in short, a politics oriented to truth and to the human,²¹

¹⁷ *Hermeneutic Communism*, p. 77.

¹⁸ *Hermeneutic Communism*, p. 140.

¹⁹ *Hermeneutic Communism*, p. 136–7.

²⁰ Similarly, Vattimo and Zabala refer approvingly to methods of non-violent resistance, including those developed by Gandhi in particular, as having the potential to curb the dominion of global capital, and yet they overlook Gandhi’s own characterization of the way of non-violence as also the way of truth – *Satyagraha* – which is also the *force* of truth.

²¹ Rather than in the sense associated with the usual forms of “humanism”, our reference to “the human” should be understood in a sense best articulated within the frame of hermeneutics itself: the human is that which is always given over to the task of understanding – to the understanding of self, of other and of the world – and as such is given over to an essentially responsive and relational mode of being.

which together form the essential limit and enabling condition of politics. Only with respect to a politics such as this could one truly say that it that has ceased to operate under the sway of metaphysics.

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Response to Jeff Malpas and Nick Malpas

Gianni Vattimo and Santiago Zabala

“When it comes to political deliberation, as Richard Rorty used to say, “philosophy is a good servant but a bad master.” But how can philosophy stop being a master or guide? Isn’t this inevitable when it comes to ethical or religious deliberations? One of the great lessons of the late American thinker was that if you took care of solidarity, contingency, and freedom, “truth will take care of itself.” In sum, truth should not come first, but rather second or even last among our philosophical concerns. But as the epigraph by George Orwell in Jeff and Nick Malpas’ contribution indicates (“In a time of universal deceit – telling the truth is a revolutionary act”) truth for them is vital. It should not simply come first; it must also be a core concept without which hermeneutics cannot operate. This is why from the start they ask whether “a politics animated by a hermeneutic sensibility [can] really do without truth as Vattimo and Zabala claim?” In the limited space we have we will recall why truth must be overcome and comment on two other issues they raise: the significance of dialogue and Wikileaks revelations.

The problem of truth is not altogether discarded in *Hermeneutic Communism*. Quite the contrary. From the beginning, we clarify why it is a problem (through a number of examples from Husserl, Heidegger, Tarski, Pascal Engel and Rorty) that must be overcome not only for political reasons, since citizen’s lives are at stake, but also because of the generalized call to order (through a return to realism) to which we have been submitted since 9/11. But how can truth be overcome? As a central concept of our philosophical tradition (together with Being), truth should not be overcome in the sense of “*überwunden*” (defeating, forgetting or removing), but rather in the sense of “*verwindung*,” that is, twisting or weakening in a productive

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manner. But what does this mean? As Heidegger explained in *The Event* (1941–1942):

Here the “overcoming” does not in the least possess the pejorative sense of forcing down, beating down, the sense of removal or curtailment. It is not the triumph of better insight and greater cleverness but, instead, is an event of Being itself... The overcoming, in the realm of the history of Being, is essentially a twisting free.¹

“Twisting free” from the problem of truth allows hermeneutics, and for that matter philosophy in general, to disclose “events of unconcealment,” that is, other political realms (like communism) previously considered wrong, useless, or even obsolete. Without this, we are only left with descriptions or “true interpretations”, and those realms would be permanently dismissed. This is why we believe that the distinction between the “politics of descriptions” and “interpretation” that Malpas and Malpas reject can still be useful to recuperate or create new realms of emancipation. This difference will not result in a truer interpretation, but rather contrast the establishment and imposition of one single realm once for all. In this way, “a politics animated by a hermeneutic sensibility” must “do without truth” if it desires to remain faithful to the play, conflict, and anarchy of interpretation that distinguishes it.

After pointing out a number of logical “contradictions” and “misunderstandings” in our post-metaphysical notion of truth, which indirectly indicates how entangled Malpas and Malpas are within metaphysics, they also criticize our suspicion of “dialogue” when it comes to political matters. Although they recognize that dialogue “can be deployed rhetorically to advance particular agendas of coercion or oppression”, they also claim this should not “blind us to the fact that genuine dialogue (and also truth) is foundational to non-coercive modes of discourse and conduct.” The reference to “genuine” and “true” dialogue in their sentences is precisely the reason why we prefer the term “conversation.” Whereas in the former truth is always presupposed (as in Plato’s dialogue with the slaves in the allegory of cave or today at the United Nations security council deliberations), in the latter it is discarded from the beginning because in a conversation one never knows where it will lead. Even though we have distinguished dialogue from conversation throughout the book, it is curious that nowhere in Malpas and Malpas’ contribution is there any reference to this essential difference. Like the distinction between “truth” and the “events of unconcealment” mentioned above, this difference is vital if hermeneutics will remain faithful to Heidegger’s call to overcome metaphysics. This is probably why the German thinker also called for an overcoming that is “creative,” that is, where “in one respect the directionality of thinking is maintained, although in another respect it is thereby at the same time radically raised beyond itself.”²

Malpas and Malpas’ take Wikileaks’ government information disclosure not only as evidence of the liberating nature of truth, but also as a force against violence

¹ Heidegger, *The Event*, trans. R. Rojcewicz (Bloomington: University of Indiana Press, 2010), 40.

² M. Heidegger, *Contributions to Philosophy (Of the Event)* (1989), trans. Richard Rojcewicz and Daniela Vallega-Neu (Bloomington: Indiana University Press, 2012), 143.

insofar as it is “an attempt to call governments to account for their misdeeds at a time when the accountability of power has been eroded.” But have Wikileaks’ innumerable revelations over these years actually changed anything? The fact that Assange is still forced to remain secluded within the Embassy of Ecuador in London is not only an indication of truth’s violence, but also of its constrictions. We are not certain their reference to Wikileaks demonstrates how “the refusal of violence and the respect for truth come together in what we would argue is the core hermeneutic commitment to allow the other to speak, and, also, to allow that the other might be right.” Independently of the truth revealed by Wikileaks, the ‘others’ are not only barred from speaking, it cannot even be said that they have a right to, since truth, as we write in *Hermeneutic Communism*, “always implies a concluding constriction.”

Hermeneutic Communism: Left Heideggerianism's Last Hope?

Martin Woessner

Abstract Gianni Vattimo and Santiago Zabala's *Hermeneutic Communism: From Heidegger to Marx* represents the most recent—and perhaps the most provocative—attempt to harness a reactionary, conservative philosophy for politically progressive ends. Until now, such forced marriages have ended only in divorce. Like thinkers ranging from Herbert Marcuse to, more recently, Richard Rorty and Peter Sloterdijk, Vattimo and Zabala are forced to admit that irreconcilable differences loom on the horizon of their project. Nevertheless, their book offers a suggestive reimagining of the tradition of “Left Heideggerianism,” which makes it perhaps even more relevant than before. But will rescuing Heidegger for the Left will help to rescue us from the relentless march of global capitalism? This essay explores “Left Heideggerianism” as an intellectual tradition, and asks how, when, and why philosophy should intervene in politics.

Hermeneutic Communism is the philosophical equivalent of a Rorschach test: its meaning says more about its interpreters and interlocutors than anything else. To some, the idea of marrying hermeneutics to communism—Heidegger to Marx—will seem a paradox, to others an oxymoron. Some may even find it an aporia rich with philosophical potential. That Gianni Vattimo and Santiago Zabala see it as none of these things says a great deal, I think, about their commitment to both discourses. To borrow from their own vocabulary, theirs is a weak commitment, one that is open to continued interpretation and re-thinking. In this sense, *Hermeneutic Communism* is not a closed book but an open dialogue, between two philosophers, two theoretical traditions, and, perhaps most importantly, two competing conceptions of human reality.

Vattimo and Zabala's work is full of aporetic insight. The curious subtitle of *Hermeneutic Communism*, with its reversal of philosophical progression—not From Marx to Heidegger, as historical chronology would have it, but from Heidegger to Marx—already hints at the ways in which the book will challenge and possibly

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overturn received opinion, whether philosophical or political.¹ Yet I would like to suggest that, for all its against-the-grain novelty, the book represents but a recent, if very provocative, attempt to harness what is generally considered a conservative, even reactionary philosophy for what are undoubtedly progressive ends in the political realm. *Hermeneutic Communism* rests more of its weight on Heidegger than on Marx. Indeed, as I read it, the book's revolutionary project revolves not simply around the revival of communism, which, as everyone from Derrida to Žižek has suggested, lives on even after its real-world burials, but upon the endeavor to rescue Heideggerian philosophy from its own political impasse.² In short, *Hermeneutic Communism* represents not the last hope for communism, as Vattimo and Zabala intimate, but possibly for left Heideggerianism.

Like thinkers ranging from Herbert Marcuse and Günther Anders, to, more recently, Richard Rorty, Vattimo and Zabala are forced to admit that irreconcilable differences loom on the horizon of left, or communist Heideggerianism. How can one join the intellectual forefather of Lenin, Stalin, and Mao to the philosopher who once praised the "inner truth and greatness" of National Socialism? Why would one even want to? What tangible political and philosophical progress can come from such an amalgamation? In attempting to answer such questions, Vattimo and Zabala's book offers a suggestive reimaging of the tradition of left Heideggerianism, one that makes this peculiar philosophical genealogy perhaps more relevant than ever before. To do so they invert the usual approach to philosophico-political problems: they offer a political reading of contemporary philosophy while simultaneously outlining a philosophical interpretation of contemporary political reality. Whereas previous left Heideggerians had looked to philosophy to help them solve political problems, Vattimo and Zabala look to real-world politics to help them understand the significance of their philosophical inheritances. Marxist politics—what they call communism here—allows them to rescue Heidegger, just as Heidegger allows them to keep Marxist thinking from morphing into an inflexible scientism. If *Hermeneutic Communism* could be reduced to a motto it would be something like the following: Heideggerian philosophy but Marxist politics. Significantly, it would not—in fact could not—be the other way around.

Opening with a political reading of contemporary philosophy and closing with a philosophical reading of contemporary politics, *Hermeneutic Communism* demonstrates and performs one of its main theses—namely that in the current world-historical moment philosophy cannot be apolitical, just as politics can no longer

¹ A similar historical reversal can be found in Vattimo's essay, "Nietzsche, Heidegger's Interpreter," in *Dialogue with Nietzsche*, trans. William McCuaig (New York: Columbia UP, 2006), 181–189.

² On communism's intellectual legacy, see, for example, Jacques Derrida, *Specters of Marx: The State of Debt, The Work of Mourning, and the New International*, trans. Peggy Kamuf (New York: Routledge, 1994); Costas Douzinas and Slavoj Žižek, eds., *The Idea of Communism* (New York: Verso, 2010); Slavoj Žižek, *In Defense of Lost Causes* (New York: Verso, 2009); Alain Badiou, *The Communist Hypothesis*, trans. David Macey and Steve Corcoran (New York: Verso, 2010). On the continued debates about Heidegger's politics, see, most recently, Emmanuel Faye, *Heidegger: The Introduction of Nazism into Philosophy in Light of the Unpublished Seminars of 1933–1935*, trans. Michael B. Smith (New Haven: Yale UP, 2009).

pretend to be neutral and/or rational. The latter insight challenges dominant neoliberal ideology in both its economic and humanitarian forms. It also falls in line with a growing dissatisfaction with the current global world order, one which now spans the political spectrum.³ The former claim—that philosophy can no longer pretend to be a politically neutral, value-free activity—suggests that philosophy and politics today are fully imbricated, even and especially when they pretend otherwise. For Vattimo and Zabala “the essence” of John Searle’s famous debate with Jacques Derrida about the meaning of J.L. Austin’s theory of speech acts, for example, “was not linguistic but political.”⁴ More than a (melo)dramatic clash of philosophical titans, the debate between Searle and Derrida—stand-ins for analytic and continental discourses, respectively—represents, for Vattimo and Zabala at least, a confrontation between “scientific realists,” who are the “the servants of political power” and all those who, like Derrida, protest the “imperialistic approach” of such philosophical work.⁵ That George W. Bush later awarded a National Humanities Medal to Searle only confirms their suspicions that analytic philosophy in America is in league with the defenders of the neoliberal status quo.

If they read contemporary philosophy through the lens of global politics, Vattimo and Zabala similarly read contemporary politics through a philosophical lens. The recent emergence of “South American socialism” is hailed in *Hermeneutic Communism* because it is not “framed within a disciplinary” or “metaphysical vision of the world.”⁶ Post-metaphysical philosophy and anti-capitalist politics, in other words, go hand in hand, and they are opposed by the allied forces of scientific realism and neoliberal capitalism. Such a formula has the benefit of demarcating—boldly and succinctly, in a manner reminiscent at times of *The Communist Manifesto*—the battle lines of the current politico-philosophical struggle, but it has at least one noticeable drawback, which is that it exaggerates the cohesiveness of each camp. In extolling communism, for example, Vattimo and Zabala are forced to leave the troubling case of China aside; and in criticizing the forces of scientific realism they are forced to downplay the diversity of American analytic and social-scientific thinking, which can hardly be reduced to the work of Searle alone.⁷

³For just two examples, see David Harvey, *A Brief History of Neoliberalism* (Oxford: Oxford UP, 2005) and Samuel Moyn, *The Last Utopia: Human Rights in History* (Harvard: Harvard UP, 2010).

⁴Gianni Vattimo and Santiago Zabala, *Hermeneutic Communism: From Heidegger to Marx* (New York: Columbia UP, 2011), 33.

⁵*Ibid.*, 35. In making such claims, Vattimo and Zabala are very much in line with the claims made by John McCumber in his book, *Time in the Ditch: American Philosophy in the McCarthy Era* (Evanston, Illinois: Northwestern UP, 2001). For a critique of McCumber’s thesis, see my *Heidegger in America* (Cambridge: Cambridge UP, 2011), 193–195. See also George A. Reisch, *How the Cold War Transformed American Philosophy of Science: To the Icy Slopes of Logic* (Cambridge: Cambridge UP, 2005) and Joel Isaac, “Tangled Loops: Theory, History and the Human Sciences in Modern America,” *Modern Intellectual History* 6:2 (August 2009), 397–424.

⁶*Ibid.*, 135.

⁷Intellectual historians such as Joel Isaac and Andrew Jewett, for example, have argued that the human and social sciences in the United States have been the sight of many debates, exchanges, and transformations throughout the twentieth century, and especially in the years after the Second

Nowhere is this tendency toward generalization more noticeable than in Vattimo and Zabala's invocation of Heideggerian philosophy. Without even delving into the centrist- to right-leaning Heideggerian legacy, the one articulated and espoused by Heidegger himself both before and, importantly, after the Second World War, we can safely say that Heidegger's reception has been more diverse—and more fractious—than *Hermeneutic Communism* would have us believe.⁸ The tradition of left Heideggerianism has seen its fair share of conflict and interpretive struggle. By situating *Hermeneutic Communism* back into the this elusive and at times contradictory philosophical genealogy, to which Vattimo and Zabala's work is indebted and from which it deviates in important ways, I hope to demonstrate not only that the perils facing the marriage of Marx and Heidegger are not new, but also that they remain almost insurmountable.

From *Hermeneutic Communism* to Heideggerian Marxism

Hermeneutic Communism puts a polemical point on the Heideggerian ideas that have been percolating for many years in the work of both Vattimo and Zabala. Only recently have these ideas taken on such an explicitly political cast. According to at least one of his previous definitions of “left Heideggerianism,” Vattimo admitted that this peculiar intellectual discourse, which he was freely adapting to his own needs and purposes, represents not so much a political program as a philosophical one.⁹ In this instance at least, Vattimo was quick to point out that the leftist path was a route not taken by Heidegger himself. “The leftist reading of Heidegger,” Vattimo admitted, represents a reading of Heidegger's work that Heidegger “himself did not choose.”¹⁰ In this regard, Vattimo's (and now Zabala's) left Heideggerianism can be likened to Marx's own left Hegelianism, which was of course not chosen by Hegel, either. Despite turning Hegel on his head, Marx operated within the structures of the Hegelian conception of history. Similarly, Vattimo and Zabala operate within the Heideggerian conception of history, even as they seek to reinterpret and revalue it for their own political and philosophical ends. Vattimo's and Zabala's Heidegger, a leftist Heidegger, is not, then, the Heidegger of existential resolve, of jingoistic

World War, the high watermark of scientism as a research ideal in the American academy. See Isaac, *Working Knowledge: Making the Human Sciences from Parsons to Kuhn* (Cambridge, Massachusetts: Harvard UP, 2012) and Jewett, *Science, Democracy, and the American University: From the Civil War to the Cold War* (Cambridge: Cambridge UP, 2012).

⁸On the persistence of Heidegger's radical conservatism throughout his career, see Daniel Morat, *Von der Tat zur Gelassenheit: Konservatives Denken bei Martin Heidegger, Ernst Jünger, und Friedrich Georg Jünger, 1920–1960* (Göttingen: Wallstein, 2007) and, more recently, “No Inner Immigration: Martin Heidegger, Ernst Jünger, and the Early Federal Republic of Germany,” *Modern Intellectual History* 9:3 (November 2012): 661–679.

⁹Gianni Vattimo, *Beyond Interpretation: The Meaning of Hermeneutics for Philosophy*, trans. David Webb (Stanford: Stanford UP, 1997), 13.

¹⁰Ibid.

decisionism, of Volkisch nostalgia. It is not the Heidegger who, according to Domenico Losurdo, articulated an "ideology of war" in the years following the First World War.¹¹ In short, Vattimo's Heidegger is the post-Kehre Heidegger, the Heidegger who abandons an engaged existentialism for a more passive, poetic thinking. This is ostensibly the weaker Heidegger, the one who appears to shun politics and instead contemplates the flight of the gods and the modern forgetting of Being.

Whether pre- or post-Kehre, though, Heidegger was no friend of Marxism and Vattimo and Zabala are forced to spend a good deal of time working around this fact. They would have us believe that left Heideggerianism has its roots in Heidegger's own work. *Hermeneutic Communism* opens with a lengthy epigraph from Heidegger, one in which he suggests that the famous Marxist injunction from the "Theses on Feuerbach" to change the world is one that he took seriously.¹² It is one of the rare places in Heidegger's extensive body of work where Marx appears at all. And as we now well know, Heidegger was never intrigued by Marxist-derived communism as a political choice. Far from it, in fact. In the years following Hitler's ascent to power in 1933, Heidegger would even go so far as to posit that Soviet communism, along with American-style democratic capitalism, posed a twin danger to Germany, a nation caught "in the pincers of Russia on the one side and America on the other."¹³ Because he thought that, "seen metaphysically," both nations were the same, as they were both shaped by "the hopeless frenzy of unchained technology and of the rootless organization of the average man," Heidegger even went so far as to articulate what Theodore Kisiel has called a "philosophical geopolitics," which justified Nazism as a third-way revolution between the pincer-like perils of capitalism and communism.¹⁴ To be sure, in 1935 at least, Heidegger worried "the farthest corner of the globe" was, thanks to modern technology, in danger of being "exploited economically," but in airing such sentiments he was by no means signaling a fondness for Marx.¹⁵ In fact, as Anson Rabinbach has argued, the few brief mentions that Marx and Marxism receive in Heidegger's thinking are by and large limited to texts penned towards the end, or even after World War II, texts such as the "Letter on Humanism," which may have been motivated by ulterior, if not entirely self-serving motives, directed as they were to audiences comprised of the occupying forces in Germany as much as anybody else.¹⁶

¹¹ Domenico Losurdo, *Heidegger and the Ideology of War: Community, Death, and the West*, trans. Jon and Marella Morris (Amherst, New York: Prometheus Books, 2001).

¹² *Hermeneutic Communism*, 1.

¹³ Heidegger, *An Introduction to Metaphysics*, trans. Gregory Fried and Richard Polt (New Haven: Yale UP, 200), 40, 41.

¹⁴ Theodore Kisiel, "Heidegger's Geopolitics in the Third Reich," in Gregory Fried and Richard Polt, *A Companion to Heidegger's An Introduction to Metaphysics* (New Haven: Yale UP, 2001): 226–249.

¹⁵ Heidegger, *An Introduction to Metaphysics*, 40.

¹⁶ Anson Rabinbach, "Heidegger's 'Letter on Humanism' as Text and Event," *In the Shadow of Catastrophe: German Intellectuals between Apocalypse and Enlightenment* (Berkeley: University of California Press, 1997), 97–128. Speaking of Heidegger's postwar "Letter on Humanism,"

If Heidegger did not himself establish the necessary links between his thinking of Being and Marx's world-historical analysis of capitalism for a viable research program to emerge, some of his most talented students took up the task with enthusiasm. It is from then, and not from Heidegger directly, that we can derive a tradition of left Heideggerianism. For young, politically active students in the interwar years, students such as Günther Anders and Herbert Marcuse, Heidegger's revolutionary teaching seemed to hold not just philosophical promise, but also political promise. Like Vattimo and Zabala, they were captivated by Heidegger's commitment to—as he put in *Being and Time* — “Destroying the History of Ontology,” which would not only overturn the received philosophical tradition and all of its empty categories, but also lay bare the fundamental elements of reality, or the “facticity of existence.”

In Heidegger, Anders and Marcuse thought they had found a critique of modern society that seemed to echo that of the western Marxist tradition.¹⁷ Marcuse, who went on to become one of the guiding lights of the New Left in the sixties, is perhaps the most well known proponent of left Heideggerianism. He all but invented what Richard Wolin and John Abromeit have termed “Heideggerian Marxism”—a prototype, in many ways, of Vattimo and Zabala's hermeneutic communism.¹⁸

Marcuse wrote his Habilitation under Heidegger in 1930. It was later published as *Hegel's Ontology and the Theory of Historicity*.¹⁹ But already in 1929, in an essay titled “On Concrete Philosophy,” Marcuse had articulated the key doctrines of Heideggerian Marxism. In the immediate aftermath of the publication of *Being and Time*, he argued that the true meaning of philosophy had to be located in the idea of “the making visible of truth.”²⁰ Only via the “process of philosophy becoming concrete” could truth emerge.²¹ True philosophy, in other words, had to become praxis. It also had to become public.²² Far from resorting to abstractions or “ideal types,” concrete philosophy was to tackle real-world, historical experience and then labor

Rabinbach puts it bluntly but rightly: “The ‘Letter’ is a gesture of defiance in the clock of humility. Heidegger's complaints about the ‘peculiar dictatorship of the public sphere,’ the conflict of ‘isms,’ and his tilt toward Marxism reveal his barely disguised contempt for the occupation [of Germany]. It is also a direct answer to the call for a reckoning with the Nazi past and an opening to democracy, which Jaspers issued in *The Question of German Guilt* [...], which he and the university committee found so utterly lacking in Heidegger” (115).

¹⁷ While some scholars have seen Marcuse as being heavily indebted to Heidegger, and especially his understanding of technology—see, for example, Andrew Feenberg, *Heidegger and Marcuse: The Catastrophe and Redemption of History* (New York: Routledge, 2005)—more recent interpreters have emphasized Marcuse's deep and continuing commitment to Marxism. See, for example, John Abromeit, “Left Heideggerianism or Phenomenological Marxism? Reconsidering Herbert Marcuse's Critical Theory of Technology,” *Constellations* 17:1 (March 2010): 87–106.

¹⁸ Herbert Marcuse, *Heideggerian Marxism*, eds. Richard Wolin and John Abromeit (Lincoln, Nebraska: University of Nebraska Press, 2005).

¹⁹ Wolin, “Introduction: What is Heideggerian Marxism?” *Ibid.*, xviii.

²⁰ Marcuse, “On Concrete Philosophy,” *Ibid.*, 34.

²¹ *Ibid.*, 44.

²² *Ibid.*, 46, 47.

to change contemporary life. Using Heidegger's neologism for human existence, Dasein, Marcuse offered the following description of how the process worked:

Concrete philosophy knows that truths can never be taken in abstract form and arbitrarily grafted on to any Dasein; rather they must be grasped out of the midst of the existing Dasein and maintained in existence. For this reason, concrete philosophy incorporates into its "teaching" the entire concrete situation of contemporaneous Dasein in the complete determinateness of the social structure. Only when it knows how Dasein thus determined suffers and acts, what its real difficulties are, which modes of existing and which paths for change are prescribed to it by the situation, only then can it bring Dasein into truth, become for it an existential necessity.²³

Writing in the year of the Stock Market Crash, Marcuse made it clear that human existence "had been shaken to its foundation"—"the crisis of capitalism" was in fact, he argued, "a crisis of existence."²⁴ And if it was true that, as Marcuse maintained, "all personal values have been lost or have been put into the service of technological and rational 'objectivity'" as a result of capitalism, then only a critique of capitalism could rescue human existence from the forces of anonymous rationalization that led to the crash in the first place. With no critique forthcoming, technology and rationalization would outpace human experience in time, making human existence all but obsolete—something Günther Anders would maintain many years later in his two-volume magnum opus, *Die Antiquiertheit des Menschen: Über die Seele im Zeitalter der zweiten industriellen Revolution*.²⁵

Similar concerns could be found even earlier, in the writings of one of the founding fathers of western Marxism, Georg Lukács. Indeed, as the French philosopher Lucien Goldmann once argued, the early writings of Heidegger, including even *Being and Time*, seem to be in direct conversation with Lukács. It was Lukács's *History and Class Consciousness* (1923), after all, that introduced the idea of the "reification of consciousness," in which Goldmann heard echoes of Heidegger's discussion of objectivity, praxis, and inauthenticity (or *Vorhandenheit*, *Zuhandenheit*, *Uneigentlichkeit* in the argot of *Sein und Zeit*). In Goldmann's reading, both Lukács and Heidegger undermined the idea of scientific objectivity as something external to human engagement. As Goldmann puts it, "there is a close affinity between Heidegger and Lukács in the analysis of what Heidegger calls 'traditional ontology' and Lukács calls traditional philosophy or positivist thought." Both reject the idea that a "knowledge of objects can be had independently of the subject," or even "that there is a subject and an object." For both Lukács and Heidegger, in other words, "objectivity does not exist."²⁶ Existence and praxis are all we have, and they cannot be grasped by a detached, scientific rationality.

²³ Ibid., 45.

²⁴ Ibid., 42.

²⁵ *Die Antiquiertheit des Menschen: Über die Seele im Zeitalter der zweiten industriellen Revolution* (1956; Munich: C.H. Beck, 1961).

²⁶ Lucien Goldmann, *Lukács and Heidegger: Towards a New Philosophy*, trans. William Q. Boelhower (London: Routledge & Kegan Paul, 1977), 30.

What Lukács and Heidegger had most in common, according to Lucien Goldmann, was something already anticipated by Marx's materialism. In his "Theses on Feuerbach," Marx faulted his predecessor for failing to recognize that "the tangible world" is itself a product of "concrete human activity."²⁷ Heidegger's destruction of the history of ontology promised a return to this concrete world, to the world of praxis and existential experience. It was a promise that captivated Anders and Marcuse as students, especially because it seemed to correspond almost exactly to another of Marx's declarations in the "Theses on Feuerbach," namely that

The question whether objective truth can be attributed to human thinking is not a question of theory, but is a practical question. Man must prove the truth, that is, the reality and power, the this-sidedness of his thinking in practice. The dispute over the reality or non-reality of thinking which is isolated from practice is a purely scholastic question.²⁸

To their eventual disappointment, though, Heidegger's students discovered that Heidegger, for all his revolutionary bravado, remained trapped in the very language and categories of traditional philosophy.

Heidegger promised a concrete philosophy, but his work could never deliver such a thing. He remained, in other words, a scholastic. Marcuse eventually came to this conclusion, but it was Anders who, in an oft-cited polemic published in *Philosophy and Phenomenological Research* after the Second World War, hammered the point home.²⁹ In his words, "the province of Heidegger's concreteness begins behind hunger" yet still "ends before economy and machine."³⁰ Heidegger gestured toward the realities of daily existence, but flinched before he could fully capture them. His philosophical work claimed to be concrete, even and especially when it continued to be abstract and traditionally philosophical. No wonder, then, that Anders entitled his essay "On the Pseudo-Concreteness of Heidegger's Philosophy."

In many ways, Anders and Marcuse's critique of Heidegger's pseudo-concreteness prefigured a discourse that other western Marxists would adopt as they confronted Heidegger's legacy in the postwar period. This discourse, in many ways a discourse of disillusionment, led to books such as Adorno's *The Jargon of Authenticity*.³¹ It also led to one of the first public forays of a young Jürgen Habermas—at one time a self-described "Heidegger disciple"—who questioned Heidegger's decision to publish the lectures comprising *An Introduction to Metaphysics* without omitting or commenting on their discussion of "the inner truth and greatness" of National

²⁷ Ibid., 35.

²⁸ Karl Marx, "Theses on Feuerbach," *The Marx-Engels Reader*, Second Edition, ed., Robert C. Tucker (New York: Norton, 1978), 144.

²⁹ On Marcuse's critique of Heidegger's pseudo-concreteness, see Wolin, "Introduction," xx.

³⁰ Günther Stern (Anders), "On the Pseudo-Concreteness of Heidegger's Philosophy," *Philosophy and Phenomenological Research* 8:3 (March, 1948): 337–371, quote on 347. I discuss Anders's critique of Heidegger at greater length in my *Heidegger in America*, 66–78.

³¹ Theodor W. Adorno, *The Jargon of Authenticity*, trans. Kurt Tarnowski and Frederic Will (Evanston: Northwestern UP, 1973).

Socialism.³² As a result, the alliance between Heidegger and Marx seemed to wither even before it could set down any lasting roots. The hunger for concreteness, for a philosophy that would finally do justice to material reality, was what Heideggerian Marxism promised. All that it delivered, though, was a jargon of obfuscating pseudo-concreteness.

Far from criticizing Heidegger for his alleged pseudo-concreteness, Vattimo and Zabala argue that Heidegger successfully returned philosophical thought to the social world. They remain true believers in the project abandoned by Anders and Marcuse in this regard. The project of *Hermeneutic Communism* cannot survive without such faith. In his provocatively titled recent book, *A Farewell to Truth*, Vattimo even goes so far as to claim that “the practical transformation of the conditions of existence” is a task “taken more seriously by Heidegger than by Marx”—a claim that surely would have surprised figures such as Adorno, Anders, and Marcuse, not to mention Lukács.³³ And yet, it is a claim that is not new to Vattimo’s philosophical thought. In *The Adventure of Difference: Philosophy after Nietzsche and Heidegger*, Vattimo tackled the criticisms of Adorno and Lukács—criticisms directed primarily towards the political implications of Heidegger’s philosophy—head on. There he declared that Heidegger’s “*Introduction to Metaphysics* grasps the very root of the constitution of our civilization’s conceptual language; in this respect it represents that very ‘complement’ which has been called for to fill the lacunae of Marx’s *Capital*.”³⁴ If Marx lays bare the economic realities of the world then, according to Vattimo, Heidegger uncovers its metaphysical foundations.

In recent years, Vattimo has lauded the “concrete practice of a handful of great twentieth-century philosophers,” especially Heidegger but also including Lukács, Adorno, Horkheimer, and Benjamin, who have helped to develop “an ontology of actuality.”³⁵ Because these thinkers take seriously the historically determined and conceptually contingent nature of reality, they serve as useful guides in the ongoing attempt not to just to describe the world, but also to interpret, and, ultimately, to change it.

By transforming Heidegger from the philosopher of resoluteness and authenticity that he was in the thirties into an ontologist of actuality, Vattimo is able to articulate what Richard Rorty has described as a “commonsense Heideggerianism.”³⁶ We might also refer to it as Heidegger without the Heideggerian politics. In the past,

³² See Habermas, “Public Space and Political Public Sphere—The Biographical Roots of Two Motifs in My Thought,” in *Between Naturalism and Religion: Philosophical Essays*, trans. Ciaran Cronin (Malden, Massachusetts: Polity, 2008), 20.

³³ Gianni Vattimo, *A Farewell to Truth*, trans. William McCuaig, foreword by Robert T. Valgenti (New York: Columbia UP, 2011), xxxi.

³⁴ Vattimo, *The Adventure of Difference: Philosophy after Nietzsche and Heidegger*, trans. Cyprian Blamires with the assistance of Thomas Harrison (Baltimore: Johns Hopkins UP, 1993), 53.

³⁵ Vattimo, *Farewell to Truth*, 23, 22. Zabala also discusses the idea of “an ontology of actuality” in his *The Remains of Being: Hermeneutic Ontology After Metaphysics* (New York: Columbia UP, 2009), 10 ff.

³⁶ Rorty, “Foreword,” Gianni Vattimo, *Nihilism and Emancipation: Ethics, Politics, & Law*, ed. Santiago Zabala, trans. William McCuaig (New York: Columbia UP, 2004), ix.

Vattimo has labored to make Heidegger safe for democracy, and it could very well be that one of the most pressing goals of left Heideggerianism is precisely this.³⁷ But where earlier left Heideggerians pursued this goal through the earlier, more existentially inclined of Heidegger's writings, Vattimo and Zabala draw inspiration primarily from the later writings, which speak more of modern nihilism, of the fateful destiny of Being, and of the dissolution of metaphysics beyond the realm of human initiative. Vattimo and Zabala complicate the genealogy of left Heideggerianism in that they work backwards through the Heideggerian corpus. Viewed from this perspective, the hope for a concrete "ontology of actuality" expressed in texts such as *Being and Time* remains a guiding light rather than—as it was for Heidegger's own students, who enjoyed a rather different vantage point—a dwindling, if not to say a false star.

Hermeneutic Communism as an Ethical Project

A series of philosophical forced marriages, from Lukács down to the various New York Intellectuals who contributed to *Partisan Review* as well as, eventually, the insurgent leaders of the New Left, have populated the history of western Marxism, which has sought to put Marx in dialogue with other intellectual traditions. The lineage of Heideggerian Marxism is no exception to this genealogical pattern, to this list of odd pairings. In countries such as France and Italy, especially, Heidegger could be appropriated by former résistants—a Sartre or a Pareyson, for example—as a prophet of authenticity. Years later, Václav Havel would advocate a similar, Heidegger-inspired position in his dissident writings. More recently, postcolonial theorists have sought to combine the Marxist understanding of world-historical systems with a Heideggerian respect for the pull of local traditions and cultures. Dipesh Chakrabarty, for example, has sought to reframe world history in the era of globalization by following both Marx and Heidegger in his project of—to borrow the title of his much discussed work—"provincializing Europe."³⁸ Marx helps him to understand the logic of modernization that underwrote the imperial project, while Heidegger later gives him the tools—hermeneutic tools, Vattimo and Zabala would say—to critique and reframe this very logic from the perspective of colonial subjects, who have dwelled in a world shaped, but not wholly determined, by capitalism.

As the latest attempt to make Heideggerian Marxism—if not to say Western Marxism—work, *Hermeneutic Communism* takes up an old trope and makes it new. But the true message of the book, as I read it, can be separated out from both the Heideggerian and Marxist traditions it endorses. In other words, one need not signal

³⁷ See Vattimo, *Nihilism and Emancipation*, 87.

³⁸ See Dipesh Chakrabarty, *Provincializing Europe: Postcolonial Thought and Historical Difference* (Princeton: Princeton UP, 2000). I discuss Havel and Chakrabarty at greater length in my essay, "Provincializing Human Rights? Human Rights from Charles Malik to Dipesh Chakrabarty," in José Manuel Barreto, ed., *Human Rights from a Third-World Perspective* (Cambridge: Cambridge Scholars Press, 2013), 65–101.

any allegiance to Marx or to Heidegger to be a good hermeneutic communist. This is in keeping with the anti-fundamentalist, anti-foundational, non-dogmatic tenor of the book. Vattimo and Zabala are not seeking acolytes. After all, what is most needed today is not philosophical consensus, which is self-serving and generally unimportant anyhow, but a commitment to do good—and to do good not just for ourselves, but for those most ostracized by the current status quo: the poor, the marginalized, the excluded, and the oppressed. It is to them that we owe allegiance, if allegiance is something that is required. To be an hermeneutic communist is not to adopt the perspective of Marx or of Heidegger, it is to adopt the perspective of the weak, who are, in Vattimo's and Zabala's perspective, the "the losers of history."³⁹

In his book *The Remains of Being*, Zabala embraces these "losers of history," but only obliquely. In *Hermeneutic Communism*, the remains of Being are more explicitly named as the detritus of humanity excluded by the capitalist project. For both Vattimo and Zabala, the remains of capitalism, like the remains of Being, are the clues to the past that at the same time represent prefigurings of the future. It is only amongst these remains, amongst the leftovers of modernization and progress, that alternatives will be found. And who today would fail to see that alternatives are needed? The growing anti-capitalist sentiment across the globe, especially in the wake of the 2008 economic collapse, can longer be dismissed—like it was so long ago by one of the architects of neoliberal ideology, Ludwig von Mises—as merely the expression of "ignorant people" motivated "by the most powerful human passions of envy and hatred."⁴⁰ Given the ongoing turmoil of economic life in the postindustrial age, it is also all but laughable to maintain—as one of the editors of von Mises's work does—that economics is "scientific," because it is based on "value-free," "logically necessary," and "apodictic" conclusions.⁴¹ In fact, in the wake of the current economic crisis, it may be more accurate to describe neoliberal economics as Naomi Klein does: "a fundamentalist version of capitalism," or even—as she calls the forced imposition of Chicago School economics upon post-coup Chilean society—"a form of intellectual imperialism."⁴² The title of a recent history of American-sponsored global development after World War II says it even more succinctly: *Economists with Guns*.⁴³

For Vattimo and Zabala, hermeneutic communism remains, at its most foundational level, an ethical project. Even when they address rarefied questions of ontology, they do so, as Zabala writes in *The Remains of Being*, from the perspective of "practical, moral life."⁴⁴ They are motivated by the voices of the marginalized and

³⁹ *Hermeneutic Communism*, 65.

⁴⁰ Ludwig von Mises, *The Anti-capitalistic Mentality*, edited and with a preface by Bettina Bien Greaves (1956; Indianapolis: Liberty Fund, 2006), 26.

⁴¹ *Ibid.*, ix.

⁴² Naomi Klein, *The Shock Doctrine: The Rise of Disaster Capitalism* (New York: Picador, 2007), 7, 76.

⁴³ Bradley R. Simpson, *Economists with Guns: Authoritarian Development and U.S.-Indonesian Relations, 1960–1968* (Stanford: Stanford UP, 2008).

⁴⁴ Zabala, *The Remains of Being*, xii.

the excluded. More important than logical necessity, for them, is the attempt to foster solidarity. As Vattimo puts it in *Farewell to Truth*:

We can never claim that our point of view is the same as God's. We can only acknowledge that we see things on the basis of certain prejudices, certain interests, and if truth is possible at all, it is the result of an accord that is not necessitated by any definitive evidence, only by loving charity, solidarity, the human (all-too-human?) need to live in harmony with others.⁴⁵

This suggests that philosophy and politics can only survive if they are transformed somehow into ethics, a task recommended, as Robert T. Valgenti has pointed out, by Vattimo's own mentor Pareyson.⁴⁶ Going beyond Pareyson, though, Vattimo and Zabala suggest that it is not enough simply to do ethics, either, especially if it is seen as just another academic research area. Ethics requires practical action, and the fact that Vattimo and Zabala have produced a practical book, a hybrid book, suggests that the time for writing "pure philosophy" is over. Only a philosophy that is as comfortable quoting the latest IMF reports as it is explicating Kant can speak to the changing ontology of the present, the very reality of today. Articulating such a philosophy requires the work of a new kind of intellectual: "not a scientist, not a technician, something more like a priest or an artist—but a priest without a hierarchy, and an artist of the streets."⁴⁷ The true test of philosophy, like the true test of the emerging socialisms of Latin America, will hinge upon whether such figures are granted a fair hearing.

Before he gave up on the (objective) concept of truth, Vattimo used to speak of the importance of "dwelling in the truth." Drawing upon the later Heidegger's work, particularly the essay "Building Dwelling Thinking," Vattimo, in *Beyond Interpretation* argued that "dwelling implies," most of all, "an interpretative belonging which involves both the consensus and the possibility of critical activity."⁴⁸ In this he seems to rehearse Marcuse's early talk of making the truth visible, of making it concrete. It is not insignificant, I think, that Havel, in his struggle against Soviet totalitarianism in Czechoslovakia, resorted to exactly the same kind of terminology. In his seminal essay, "The Power of the Powerless," which was dedicated to the philosopher Jan Patočka—who had suffered a fatal heart attack in Soviet custody, and from whom Havel had learned his Heidegger—Havel suggested that a free society was one that offered the possibility of "living within the truth."⁴⁹ If the "powerless" of Havel's world, those oppressed by authoritarian communism, are the weak and the marginalized of Vattimo and Zabala's world, then we are reminded, by all three authors, that opposition to oppression and domination cannot merely be

⁴⁵ Vattimo, *A Farewell to Truth*, 36.

⁴⁶ Valgenti, "Foreword," to *Ibid.*, xiii.

⁴⁷ Vattimo, *A Farewell to Truth*, 21.

⁴⁸ Vattimo, *Beyond Interpretation*, 82.

⁴⁹ Václav Havel, "The Power of the Powerless," *Open letters: Selected Writings, 1965–1990*, selected and edited by Paul Wilson (New York: Vintage, 1992), 125–214. For more on Havel and the influence of Heideggerian philosophy on his thought and politics, see my "Provincializing Human Rights?"

articulated, it must also be lived and experienced. If philosophy can only survive by becoming ethics, then ethics can only survive by being something lived.

Conclusion: *Hermeneutic Communism* as a Politics of Liberation

As I read it, the things that resonate, that linger on after reading *Hermeneutic Communism*, have nothing to do with hermeneutics or with communism, but with such lasting notions as love, charity, solidarity, fairness, and justice. In fact, much of the book sounds rather like liberation theology, which is in some sense indigenous to the Americas, the same Americas that have produced Castro, Chávez, Lula, and Morales, to whom *Hermeneutic Communism* is dedicated. From the perspective of the world-historical provinces (at least according to Europeans such as Hegel, Marx, and Heidegger), liberation theology has explored and exposed the crumbling foundations of the current world. Indeed, as one of liberation theology's most articulate and passionate advocates, Franz J. Hinkelammert, has stated, "liberation theology leads not only to a critique of capitalism, but also to one of modernity itself. It arrives at the confirmation of a crisis of Western society itself."⁵⁰ This critique, in the words of Gustavo Gutiérrez, in his *A Theology of Liberation*, "must be verified in social praxis; it must become effective commitment, without intellectual purisms, without inordinate claims; it must be revised and concretized constantly." These are words that could serve as a useful summation of *Hermeneutic Communism's* primary thesis.⁵¹

The lasting impulse of *Hermeneutic Communism*, as I read it, is not to be found in its Marxist faith in the coming collapse of capitalism, nor in its Heideggerian narrative about the end of metaphysics. The real strength of hermeneutic communism comes not from its attacks on scientific realism, but from its insistence that, in the current moment in world history, we are compelled to listen to—and to work on behalf of—the peoples pushed to the margins. For this we do not need a comprehensive understanding of the ontological difference. Rorty, long before he softened on Heidegger's politics, intimated as much when, in an early essay comparing Heidegger to Dewey, he offered the following sketch, meant to dramatize the way forward for philosophers in the modern world:

Dewey found what he wanted in turning away from philosophy as a distinctive activity altogether, and towards the ordinary world—the problems of men, freshly seen by discarding the distinctions with the philosophical tradition had developed. Heidegger hoped that a

⁵⁰ Franz J. Hinkelammert, "Liberation Theology in the Economic and Social Context of Latin America: Economy and Theology, or the Irrationality of the Rationalized," in Batstone et al., eds., *Liberation Theologies, Postmodernity, and the Americas* (New York: Routledge, 1997), 48.

⁵¹ Gustavo Gutiérrez, *A Theology of Liberation*, 15th anniversary edition with a new introduction by the author, trans. Sister Caridad Inda and John Eagleson (Maryknoll, New York: Orbis Books, 1988), 139.

new path would open. But he thought we shall only see it open if we detach ourselves from the problems of men and are still; in that silence we may perhaps hear the word of Being.⁵²

“Heidegger’s weakness,” Rorty went on to conclude, “was that he could not escape the notion that philosophers’ difficulties are more than just philosophers’ difficulties.”⁵³ Insofar as it can avoid such a predicament—perhaps by being read, simultaneously, as both more than and less than philosophy—*Hermeneutic Communism* will remain compelling. But all this hinges, first and foremost, on the ethical impulse that animates it. Without it, hermeneutic communism will most certainly remain an immaterial specter; with it, however, solidarity, love, and justice may materialize yet before our very eyes.

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⁵² Richard Rorty, “Overcoming the Tradition: Heidegger and Dewey,” *Consequences of Pragmatism—Essays: 1972–1980* (Minneapolis: University of Minnesota Press, 1982), 53–54.

⁵³ *Ibid.*, 54.

Response to Woessner

Gianni Vattimo and Santiago Zabala

Intellectual historians have something in common with philosophers: they also aim to interpret the “big picture” instead of focusing on little details. Unfortunately, too many philosophers today are losing this virtue and becoming so called “specialists,” “experts”, or “technicians.” If Martin Woessner, who was trained as an intellectual historian, embodies this philosophical virtue to the fullest, it is probably thanks to his long-time interest in Martin Heidegger. This is not simply evident in his contribution, whose incisive intuitions we will now try to respond to, but also in his book *Heidegger in America*,¹ which we both read years ago with great interest. This reception of Heidegger in America does not simply outline the great effect his thought had in a nation he snubbed, but also suggests that the German thinker’s greatest legacy “may rest not within the pages of his *Gesamtausgabe*, but in the careers of his students, especially since so many of them went on to become the greatest of thinkers in their respective fields.”² But does this not also stand for classics (Marx), philosophical movements (hermeneutics), and political ideologies (communism) when confronted through Heidegger?

Woessner’s contribution makes a number of important claims: first, that our goal was not to rescue communism, but rather leftist Heideggerianism; secondly, that “Heideggerian Marxism” is to a certain extent “a prototype” of our “hermeneutic communism”; and thirdly, that our project, at its most foundational level, is ethical and particularly close to liberation theology. All these claims rest on the premise that we rely more on Heidegger than Marx. We agree, if “Heidegger” and “Marx” stand for “hermeneutics” and “communism.” After all, their names appear in the

¹ M. Woessner, *Heidegger in America*. Cambridge: Cambridge University Press, 2010.

² M. Woessner, *Heidegger in America*. 53.

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subtitle instead of the title. Our interpretation never pretended to be faithful to these thinkers' texts. Similarly to other hermeneutic philosophers, our goal was to interpret communism and Marxism through Heidegger's ontological stance. This does not imply that his philosophy is truer than or superior to others, but rather more radical in disclosing and overcoming their metaphysical connotations. What perhaps distinguishes our Heideggerianism from that of others is the need to apply this procedure also against Heidegger's own thought and political choices.

The recent publication of Heidegger's *Black Notebooks* (which confirm once again his anti-Semitism, among many other hatreds),³ renders the hope of rescuing a leftist interpretation of Heidegger almost impossible. As Woessner recalls, there have been several attempts in the past not only to link Marx to Heidegger (Herbert Marcuse, Günter Anders, and Richard Rorty among many others), but also to interpret signs of a leftist political stance in his own texts. This is why he is right to stress that it is from these other authors, "and not from Heidegger directly, that we can derive a tradition of left Heideggerianism." At this point one must ask why we've given so little space to Marcuse, Anders and other so-called "Heideggerian Marxists"?

The answer does not simply rest in the specific period of Heidegger's writings we dealt with (after his turn in the 1930s), or in our indifference toward saving him, but rather in the project of divesting communism of those metaphysical structures he identified in our theoretical tradition. It is important to remember that both Marcuse and Anders wrote in an epoch when communism was primarily represented by the Soviet Union fighting against the West, while we are left with its remnants, in other words, regions, nations, groups trying to defend common, environmental, and civil rights. This is why our overall strategy, as Woessner notices, is to "offer a political reading of contemporary philosophy while simultaneously outlining a philosophical interpretation of contemporary political reality." Heidegger is indispensable to overcoming a metaphysical world that has become much more framed technologically than Marcuse and Anders could have predicted. In this condition it is not enough to believe in a project of "Heideggerian Marxism" or "leftist

³David Farrell Krell has recently pointed out that one must also remember those references that did not cause any scandal in the reception of Heidegger's notebooks these past years. As the American thinker explains, far "more frequent than any reference to Judaism or the Jewish are the scathing references to Christian civilization, Christian faith, and the Christian churches — all of them. Heidegger equates what he calls *Kulturchristentum* with the apparatus of the Reich itself, since both church and state are obstacles to what he calls a thinking of *beyng*, *Seynsdenken* (95: 1–6). The critique of National Socialism is thus laced with a similar critique of the politics of the Papacy, as though the Concordat were a recent event instead of one of Hitler's first great diplomatic victories (95: 18–19). Religionists of every stamp are conspiring with National Socialism in its current form, not against it... I repeat that Heidegger's references are often obscure, the polemic so broad in scope, so all-inclusive and so irate, that it is often difficult to understand the target. Some of the references seem to be harmless, although vague." (David Farrell Krell, *Ecstasy, Catastrophe: Heidegger from Being and Time to the Black Notebooks*, New York: SUNY Press, 2015, 136). See also M. Woessner review of Peter Trawny, *Freedom to Fail: Heidegger's Anarchy* *Freedom to Fail: Heidegger's Anarchy*, in *The Los Angeles Review of Books*, August 28th, 2015.

Heideggerianism". One must return to Marx through Heidegger, to communism through hermeneutics.

Woessner's third claim, that our book is essentially an ethical project which sounds very much like liberation theology, is a remark that Rorty would also have made if he were among us. The American thinker, which Woessner also refers to, often reminded us of philosophy's futility when it came to solving practical, ethical, or political problems. Even though we "do not need," as Woessner points out, "a comprehensive understanding of the ontological difference" to solve these problems, it is necessary to put an end to the imperial "philosophical consensus" sought today in the academy. This consensus, which Rorty also avoided, is what ruins ethics and religion when studied as just another academic discipline. If our goal, as Woessner brilliantly explains, was to practice a philosophy capable of speaking to the "changing ontology of the present," it is because, similarly to liberation theology, we are also drawn by an ethical, religious, and political concern for the weak.

Love's Law? The Principle of Anarchy in a Weakened Communism

Peg Birmingham

*As the resistance of principles, conventions, and categories,
anarchy is not the end of the political project of hermeneutics
but its beginning*
(Vattimo and Zabala, Hermeneutic Communism)

Abstract My essay looks at the status of love in *Hermeneutic Communism*. At the beginning of Chapter Three, Vattimo and Zabala refer to Rorty's claim that the hermeneutical attitude is in the intellectual world what the democracy is in the political world and both can be viewed "as alternative appropriations of the Christian message that love is the only law." They return to this notion of love further on, referring to a Nietzschean-Christian style, claiming: "Now that God is dead and the absolute truth is not credible anymore, love for the other is possible and necessary" (111–112). They go on to raise the question, "Can anyone continue to doubt that love for the other can coincide with a communist politics?" (112) I will explore their argument that love ought to be a replacement to the law, asking whether a politics of love allows for an alternative politics today. Is there not a long and bloody history of political love, a history of sacrificial violence in the name of love of god or love of country? The response could be, "yes, but this is not yet love of the other." But are things any better when we love the other? First can we love the other? Secondly, does love replace the law or is the Christian imperative, "Love thy neighbor," itself a form of law? Here I will recall Freud when he points to the ambivalence of human beings—love and hate—such that we need to be commanded to love? Finally, why the turn to political affections at all? If politics, as Arendt claims and whom the authors cite, is rooted in activity in concert with a plurality of others to create a public space," then politically, would not a reflection on the kinds of political activities necessary for such a public space be more productive than for a hermeneutic communism? Taking up their reference to Arendt, my essay will conclude by finding resources within *Hermeneutic Communism* for an alternative to love, namely the notion of political action, which I claim is more productive for a communist

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politics. This last will raise the question of the status of political principles, specifically the status of the universal in this very important work.

Mid-way through *Hermeneutic Communism*, Vattimo and Zabala refer to Rorty's claim that the hermeneutical attitude is in the intellectual world what democracy is in the political world and both can be viewed "as alternative appropriations of the Christian message that love is the only law."¹ Toward the conclusion of the book, they return to this notion of love, referring to a Nietzschean-Christian style, and claiming: "Now that God is dead and the absolute truth is not credible anymore, love for the other is possible and necessary" (111–112). They go on to raise the question, "Can anyone continue to doubt that love for the other can coincide with a communist politics?" (112) At the same time, the authors eschew all appeals to a universal principle in a weak communism arguing that such appeals are inherently metaphysical, tied to a conception of an ahistorical universal truth. This conception of truth, they argue, is complicitous with political violence and domination, including the violence at the heart of what they call "framed democracies." An emancipatory politics must therefore free itself from universal principles and embrace anarchy wherein the only law is to love.

While I agree with their critique of metaphysical truth's complicity in political domination and violence, it seems to me that Vattimo and Zabala have too quickly collapsed all conceptions of the universal into the monolithic metaphysical universal. This is especially problematic insofar as their call for a 'weak communism' continues to be a call for a democracy outside of "framed democracy," yet they overlook entirely the conception of the historical universal at work in the revolutionary emergence of modern democracy. In what follows I want to explore the distinction between a metaphysical and a historical universal, arguing that the anarchy at the beginning of their political project of hermeneutics also has its universal principle. In other words, implicit in their work is a *principle* of anarchy, which, if acknowledged allows for something other than love's law, that most dangerous and most familiar of political emotions and commandments.

The Metaphysical Universal in Politics

Contrary to Hannah Arendt's well-known phrase "the banality of evil" that describes the thoughtlessness at work in political violence, *Hermeneutic Communism* reflects on the kind of thought that has also sustained and supported a politics of domination and violence. Implicitly adding to Arendt, the book claims that it is not simply thoughtlessness, but also thought—metaphysical thought or what the authors call "strong thought"—that must also be held to account for the ways in which it is

¹Vattimo and Zabala [1]. Hereafter referred to in the text with page numbers.

complicitous with violence and domination. The event framing the book is the philosopher John Searle accepting the National Humanities Medal from George W. Bush. The important question for Vattimo and Zabala is what the award represents for Searle's philosophical position and a politics of power: "What is most interesting about the awarding of this prize is not that Searle accepted it but rather what sort of philosophy is endorsed by a president who had both just invaded a country contrary to the desires of the majority of the world's population and restricted the fundamental civil rights of his own citizens" (11).

For the authors, Searle's philosophy represents the strong thought of metaphysics with its claim of a universal ahistorical truth which, they argue, has contributed to violence, war, the militarization of democracy, and "armed capitalism." Vattimo and Zabala are explicit: they are not arguing that metaphysics causes the kinds of violence that continues to be waged globally, but instead, "Metaphysics is an aspect and a consequence of domination, not its cause" (12).

The question they ask is, "how did this happen?" How did a type of thinking that from the outset understood its activity as a practice of critique of prevailing prejudices and beliefs become an aspect and consequence of domination? The book's answer to this question is rich and complex. Here I note only their reading of Plato's *Meno* wherein they make a distinction between conversation and dialogue. As is well known, *Meno* is a dialogue between Socrates and a slave-boy, a dialogue in which the slave-boy, an ascription that the authors claim must be taken literally denoting as it does the intersection of philosophy and politics, comes to see for himself the truths of geometry, truths which he has always already known but forgotten until the always helpful Socrates helps him to remember. As Vattimo and Zabala point out, the slave-boy cannot understand geometry until he submits to "Plato's interrogation." This relation between the dominant philosopher and the submissive interlocutor reaches its most violent moment in the cave allegory where prisoners are described as being "dragged by force," taken by the "scruff of the neck" out of the cave by the philosopher.

Plato's metaphysics, concerned as it is with the one/many problem in which the many must be subsumed under and ruled by the one, has consequences for politics. One has only to return to *Republic*, the most political of all Plato's dialogues, to grasp the legitimacy of Vattimo's and Zabala's claim. Here it is enough to recall that for Plato the just city emerges from a city at war with itself and its neighbors, a war brought on by the unruly multitude ruled by their unlimited desires. To end the war, the city needs in addition to its shoemakers, builders and bakers, a new class, a guardian class, the class of the philosophers, who will not only protect the city from its enemies, but, more importantly, impose order within. From the outset, philosophy emerges out of war; its task, similar to a good military officer, is to impose a rational order on the many which are incapable of ruling themselves. If there is any doubt of Plato's view of the many, one has only to turn to Book Eight of *Republic* wherein democracy is described as the frenzied rule of the multitude who are incapable of distinguishing between the good and bad, the beautiful and the ugly. The many, Plato argues, will *always* choose the worst. Democracy then is the worst regime save tyranny which democracy will certainly devolve into given enough

time. In the end the multitude have a stark choice: the blind ambition of the tyrant or the rational, orderly rule of the philosopher.

While for Plato the concern with metaphysical truth is at odds with democracy, Vattimo and Zabala disagree, arguing that a certain conception of democracy—namely liberal democracy or what they also call ‘framed democracy’—is not at all in opposition to a notion of universal truth. Framed democracy, they argue, is characterized by the self-certainty of the truth of who the “we” are; it is a conception of democracy in which order and stability are the governing values. Framed democracies—framed by the language of crisis and emergency—impose the status quo, always understood as the truth of human affairs, against any real emergency. As the authors put it, the objective of framed democracy is “to sustain an absence of emergencies, disruptions, and shocks” (62). Hence its complicity with a notion of an ahistorical universal truth that includes a concept of history as progressive insofar as it is viewed as moving forward within the horizon of a universal truth. By contrast, for those at the margins of the frame or outside of the frame altogether, the real emergency is the lack of emergency, “that is, a lack of change, alteration, or modification of the current state of affairs” (65). Those at the margins of the frame are those living in states that do not comply with the dictates of liberal capitalism or who occupy the slums of the cities of framed democracies, “that is, they occupy those places where history continues, where events are unpredicted, and where the population is discontinuous” (65). I will return to this in the last section of the essay.

So far the account given above describes the ways in which metaphysics is complicitous with and supports political domination and control. But how is metaphysics a *consequence* of political domination as the author claim? The answer to this question gives us the first glimmer of the shortcoming of Vattimo’s and Zabala’s monolithic account of the universal as an ahistorical, sovereign universal that imposes its rational truth upon the world. Paradoxically their account of the metaphysical ahistorical universal is itself ahistorical; it does not take into account the historical conditions for this metaphysical conception of the universal which lies in the political world of Greek democracy. Entirely lacking in their analysis of the metaphysical universal is a genealogical account which as Balibar puts it, “different institutions, ages, and discourses are framed and analyzed in the light of the present.”² Balibar’s conception of genealogy is entirely consistent with Vattimo’s and Zabala’s hermeneutics which they argue is not relativistic precisely because it takes account of history: “Although a given interpretation could be preferable to others, this preference will not depend on anything external and capable of guaranteeing its objectivity but only on a positive recollection of its premises, that is, the history that produced it” (106).

A genealogical or hermeneutical account that takes seriously the “history that produced it” reveals that Greek democracy, equating as it does freedom and equality, understands freedom in terms of status. In other words, Greek citizenship was not universal; it did not belong to the many, but only to the few who share equally in status and privilege. The paradox of the metaphysical universal is that on the one

²Balibar and Balibar [2], p. 135).

hand it claims a universal timeless truth accessible to all rational beings, while on the other, it continues its complicity with a political conception of citizenship belonging only to a particular class. As we have seen, Plato's account follows philosophically what is already at work in the political realm of his day; just as the equality and freedom of citizenship is reserved only for the few with status, so too only a few, not the many, are able to grasp the timeless, sovereign truth of the rational order. The point here is that the metaphysical universal is a historical universal, the *consequence* of a particular notion of citizenship, equality, political representation, and sovereignty. This is not to reduce the universal entirely to its historical, social and political conditions. A condition is not a determinate cause. As Balibar points out, "Aristotle and Cicero already had said that the principle of the *politeia* or *civitas* referred to an *ius communis populi* that was essentially democratic." The *universal* principle of freedom and equality, the *ius communis populi*, embraced by Aristotle and Cicero both transcends its conditions even as it is bound to them. Again, when analyzed genealogically the metaphysical universal is revealed to be a historical universal. This has ramifications for rethinking the principle of anarchy at work in Vattimo's and Zabala's weakened communism.

A Weakened Communism and the Historical Universal

Before turning to what I argue is an unacknowledged "historical universal" in Vattimo's and Zabala's work, I want to first take up their understanding of a "weak communism." In their introduction, the authors cite approvingly Eric Hobsbawm's definition of communism in the twenty-first century: "...critique of capitalism, critique of an unjust society that is developing its own contradictions; the ideal of a society with more equality, freedom, and fraternity; the passion of political action, the recognition of the necessity for common actions; the defense of the causes of the poorest and oppressed...Communism as a motivation, not as a program" (5–6). Significantly, the social ideal that motivates communism in the twenty-first century is "more equality, freedom, and fraternity" as well as the increased capacity for political agency and exercising that agency in common concert for the defense of the poor and oppressed. Moreover, they claim the *emancipatory ideal* that motivates communism in the twenty-first century is historical: "If Being is history...we would say that only what is history is Being. This would leave out everything that pretends to avoid history. This is not very different from saying that emancipation means openness, transformation, and projected interpretation instead of what already is; this, after all, is probably why Rorty used to say, "If you take care of freedom, truth will take care of itself" (94). And further on, they define emancipation in terms of a certain interpretation of history: "In sum, weak thought becomes a (strong) theory of weakening as an interpretive sense of history, a sense that reveals itself as emancipative because of the enemies it has attracted. Weak thought can only be the thought of the weak, certainly not the dominating classes." The emancipatory ideal motivating communism is given a date, 1848. Here they cite

Derrida: “It is a link of affinity with suffering, and hope, a still discrete, almost secret link, as it was around 1848, but more and more visible...” (120). The emancipatory ideal of 1848 must be increased, “open to the multiplicities of identities,” which nevertheless, “unite all the proletarians of the world.”

Striking in their understanding of the emancipatory ideal motivating communism in the twenty-first century is its proximity to the revolutionary ideals of 1789 and 1848, the latter explicitly named. Again, the emancipatory ideal motivating communism is phrased explicitly as “more equality, freedom, and fraternity.” Unacknowledged by Vattimo and Zabala is the universal at work in this emancipatory ideal. This is not the metaphysical universal concerned as it is with ahistorical truth claims; it is rather a universal declared through political praxis, a praxis tied to specific political and social conditions. It is in other words, a historical universal. As Balibar points out, the 1789 Declaration is revolutionary because it announces a new *universal* conception of the citizen, one no longer rooted in differences of status and hierarchy such as the free person versus the slave, or the sovereign and its subjects; instead, it declares the universal right of political agency and participation for all human beings: “What is distinctly characteristic of modern citizenship, at least by right or in principle, is the universalization of the status of the citizen. In other words, this status ceases to be a privilege and instead comes to be conceived in terms of universal access, or a universal right to politics: a right not only to political rights (a ‘right to have rights,’ as Arendt said), but also to effective political participation.”³ In other words, as Balibar points out, it is not the democratic principle as such that marks the revolutionary nature of the declaration of rights—after all, this principle was at work in Ancient Greece—but rather the declaration “*universalizes* the principle of equality, extending the right to political participation to our common humanity or what Marx calls our “species-being.”⁴ This universality, he argues, “excludes exclusion, forbids the denial of citizenship in the name of determinations of condition, status, or nature.”⁵

At the same time and in close proximity to Vattimo’s and Zabala’s understanding of the emancipatory ideal motivating a weakened communism, the 1789 Declaration not only declares universal equal access to politics, it also declares the universal right to resist oppression, specifying that “there is oppression against the social body when a single one of its members is oppressed: there is oppression against each member when the social body is oppressed.” The Declaration ends by stating, “When the government violates the rights of the people, insurrection is for the people and for each portion of the people the most sacred of rights and the most indispensable of duties.” The foundation of all liberty, equality, and security is the right to insurrection against oppression.

The right to insurrection against the state therefore does not produce citizens of a new state of right, but instead, produces political subjects whose agency is shaped in response to specific historical, political, and economic oppression. It does not

³ Balibar and Balibar [3], p. 312).

⁴ Ibid.

⁵ Ibid., p. 312.

specify the form this revolution will take. The universal right to resist oppression is not done in the name of the suffering of the other, but in the recognition of the oppression and wrong done to political subjects who have a right and a duty to insurrection. In other words, the Declaration declares the need for justice, not pity, and in so doing produces political agency where it did not exist before. Vattimo and Zabala are aware of this, particularly in defining their hermeneutic politics as very close to Arendt's: "If politics, as Hannah Arendt explained, is not exclusively conflicting assertions of truth, claims to recognition, and power relations but rather the action necessary to create a public realm in which individuals coexist freely while protecting the private space required for their personal development, then hermeneutics is also political" (77). They agree with Arendt that power does not precede action but is its result; they recognize that power is a quality of collective agency which changes according to historical conditions thereby allowing for new solidarities and new collectivities which continue to act as Balibar puts it, "to reconstitute the community's universal by making a "'part of those who have no part' or by giving an unconditional right to the discourse of equality whose bearers they are historically." ⁶

Certainly Arendt would agree that this conception of political agency, declaring as it does the universal right of equal access to politics and the universal freedom to "reconstitute the community's universal" (to cite Balibar again) is an anarchic politics. As the 1789 Declaration explicitly notes, the right to resist oppression—the fundamental universal right of all who find themselves oppressed, the right on which all the other rights stand—cannot be written into the constitution. This is a right that citizen exercise outside the law as they challenge and reshape the law. The anarchic resistance of political agency is unpredictable, unexpected, exploding the status quo. As Vattimo and Zabala put it, the collective exercise of political agency to resist oppression creates the "real emergency" that breaks the democratic *frame* of armed capitalism with its false language of crises and threatened catastrophes.

The authors might respond that I have been carefully avoiding the language of "human rights" in my discussion of 1789 and the historical universal. They might respond by arguing that the notion of the "historical universal" that I find at work in the Declaration is nothing other than another form of the metaphysical universal: the declaration of universal, ahistorical truth of the human being which once again imposes itself on every and all particular political spaces, insisting on shaping them a particular way, this time a universal republicanism that allows liberal capitalism to do its work. They might respond by asking, "Isn't it precisely in the language of universal human rights that liberal, armed capitalism is able to frame democracy in order to prevent the real emergency? As the authors put it, the objective of framed democracy is "to sustain an absence of emergencies, disruptions, and shocks." And they might continue to ask is it not in the language of human rights that once again an appeal is made an ahistorical universal truth tied as it is to a notion of history as progressive and hence static? Is not the language used to relegate the oppressed to the margins of the frame or outside the frame altogether, "[those who] occupy both

⁶Etienne Balibar, *Ibid.* p. 314.

those states (such as Iraq, Afghanistan, or Iran) that do not comply with liberal measures and the slums of the cities of the framed democracies; that is, they occupy those places where history continues, where events are unpredicted, and where the population is discontinuous" (65). In other words, is there nothing more at odds with a notion of weakened anarchic communism than invoking the declaration of human rights? In their own response to these questions, they might simply refer to Marx, "On the Jewish Question."

While it is beyond the scope of these remarks to engage in a full discussion of the Declaration and the various ways in which framed democracy has transformed human rights into humanitarian rights, thereby allowing their militarization and arming capitalism in just the ways that the author suggest, I point out that the authors explicitly cite 1848. This date reminds us that Marx's view of the Declaration is complex and that he is responding to Bruno Bauer in his essay, "On the Jewish Question." Still further, he is arguing against Bauer's claim that the Jews must give up their particularity rooted as it is in their religion and take up universal republicanism. Still further, we must recall that Marx advocated for the Jews to gain particular human rights. In his essay, "On the Jewish Question," Marx explains the apparent contradiction: "The actual individual man must take the abstract citizen back into himself and, as an individual man in his empirical life, in his individual work and individual relationships become a species-being; man must recognize his own forces as social forces, organize them, and thus no longer separate social forces from himself in the form of political forces. Only when this has been achieved will human emancipation be complete."⁷ In this passage, Marx does not deny the universality of the emancipatory ideal of human rights; instead he insists on the inseparability of social citizenship and social rights from political citizenship and political rights. In other words, it is not the case that Marx is rejecting out of hand the 1789 Declaration, nor does he deny that a notion of the universal is at work in his emancipatory ideal; rather he insists that the 1789 declaration of human rights be understood as involving the individual as *species-being*, a *collective* being rather than the egoistic, bourgeois individual of capital. Still further, he insists on the inseparability of the universal emancipatory ideal with the particular social forces and conditions that must be reorganized. As cited above, Marx's emancipatory ideal, at work in 1848, is the universal ideal articulated in 1789: the universal access to politics inseparable from the universal right to resist oppression; the forms and shapes of resistance are historical, local, and caught up in concrete social forces.

The Principle of Anarchy: Law's Love or Anarchic Solidarity?

In conclusion, having argued for an unacknowledged historical universal at work in Vattimo's and Zabala's anarchic communism, I want to take up their claim that love is the only law of a weak communism, arguing instead that their anarchic weakened

⁷Marx (p. 65).

communism contains a principle of anarchy. Here I am following Reiner Schürmann, one of the three foundational thinkers for the authors' weakened communism, who claims that anarchy also contains its principle. The principle of anarchy that I find at work in the authors' conception of a weakened communism is not love, but solidarity. While it may seem that love and solidarity are indistinguishable and that I am quibbling therefore over nothing, my argument is that the two terms are vastly different and, further, that love in politics is inherently violent and this because it is inherently apolitical.

Following from the last point, and I will pose this as a question: is not the very real danger of love in politics the history of sacrificial violence that accompanies it? Is there not a long and bloody history of political love carried out in the name of love of god or love of country, the country taking on the status of an "immortal god"? Moreover, is not love always a partial sentiment and in need of the supplement, either the presence of the divine to make it truly universal, or, remaining on earth, justice as Hume so aptly argued in his *Treatise*? It seems to me this is why Schmitt turns to a kind of love when he analyzes the political sentiment that underwrites the friend/enemy distinction. The intensity that forms the collective, that makes one willing to sacrifice oneself and even one's children at the "alter" of the nation is the inherently partiality of love: I love partially and therefore it is a good emotion for Schmitt's conception of the political and its distinction between friends and enemies. Unlike Hume who insists that the move from the moral to the political is the move from love to justice, Schmitt celebrates the partiality of love as it is that which forms the collective bond strong enough for blood to be sacrificed in its name.

The response of the authors could be, "yes, but this is not yet love of the other and this is the love animating our weakened communism." But are things any better when we invoke the love of the other? First can we love the other? Are we not again caught in the abstract universal so soundly (and rightly) critiqued by Marx, an abstract other who is unencumbered with social and political forces and conditions? This seems essentially the case if the authors seem to be appealing to an understanding of love as *caritas*, that is, the universal love of one's fellow human beings. But is not *caritas* a love not more in keeping with a metaphysical universal and a timeless, ahistorical truth? Secondly, and following from this, does 'love of the other' not return us to a theological politics out of place with Vattimo's and Zabala's claim that a weak communism has its ontological roots in a conception of being as thoroughly historical? Does not a thoroughly historical politics always involve those who are obliged by history to live together in political sites that are not free from hostilities and conflicts? These are sites where political actors are not necessarily friends, much less, lovers, and yet acting in concert for the sake of the universal emancipatory ideal of equality and freedom is not out of the question. Indeed, it is the political obligation inherent to a weakened communism. Finally, is it the case as the authors claim that the Christian notion of love replaces the law? Is it instead the case, as Freud points out, that love does not replace the law in Christianity? And this because the imperative, "Love thy neighbor," must take the

form of a commandment or law precisely because human beings are ambivalent creatures who equally love and hate?

It seems to me that the principle of anarchy, a principle that is hauntingly present throughout *Hermeneutic Communism*, is solidarity. And solidarity is not love. If love can be said in the singular, solidarity cannot. I can love the other in his or her singularity, but I am in solidarity with others, always said in the plural and politics by definition must be said in the plural. It is the move from the 'I-Thou' to the "We," however troubling and problematic the constitution of the 'we'. As Rousseau understood, an aggregate made up of individuals (and is this not the state of liberal capitalism?) is not yet political. The political requires the constitution of the "we" which is again the most difficult issue of the political. The principle of solidarity moves us from an aggregate to an association and this because solidarity denotes acting in concert with others for the sake of some common purpose or common aspect. It is significant that one of the first uses of solidarity occurs in 1848 in the context of the "people's press" and "collective responsibility." Significantly, Vattimo and Zabala displace Rousseau's abstract and sovereign general will with the principle of anarchy, the principle of solidarity. The principle of their weakened communism is solidarity insofar as they insist on the collective aspiration of increasing freedom and equality through the increase of political agency empowered to resist the oppression and domination of framed democracies. Again, it is an anarchic principle insofar as it creates a real emergency that disrupts the security order of the status quo. At the same time it is anarchic because they insist that there is no truth of the "we." The principle of solidarity is inherently open to a space of heterogeneity and plurality. Vattimo and Zabala are clear that the heterogeneity and plurality at work in the principle of solidarity necessarily includes the most foreign, the most exterior, the most marginalized. This principle of anarchy, I submit, is the universal principle of 1789 and 1848 which, to cite Balibar again, "excludes exclusion, forbids the denial of citizenship in the name of determinations of condition, status, or nature." To their immense credit, Vattimo's and Zabala's weakened communism of the twenty-first century insists on enlarging this universal principle of praxis to include for the first time a truly international solidarity tied to particular political and social sites, committed to the reorganization of social forces that are presently excluded, oppressed, and shot through with violence.

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Response to Birmingham

Gianni Vattimo and Santiago Zabala

If truth is a consequence of interpretation, rather than its cause, hermeneutic philosophers must not only be capable of accepting others' interpretations, but also inconsistencies or paradoxes in their own work when pointed out. However, this acceptance does not imply the recognition of an error, but rather functions as a reminder that theory does not stand on firm ground. This is probably why hermeneutic thinkers like to take risks. Heidegger took a political risk. Rorty took a philosophical risk. If Slavoj Žižek called for the "defense of lost causes", it is probably because too many of us have stopped taking these sorts of risks.

Contrary to what many think, abstaining from taking risks has greater intellectual consequences than taking them, as it is the realm where the possibilities of change and emancipation rest. This is why we have also taken a number of risks in *Hermeneutic Communism*. Our endorsement of Chávez is the most evident one, but there are others, such as calling for the return of communism in the twenty-first century, or stressing analytic philosophy's imperial ambitions when John Searle accepted an award from G.W. Bush. Even though Peg Birmingham is generally sympathetic to these risks, her contribution points out three issues which are philosophically more significant.

According to the American thinker we have "too quickly collapsed all conceptions of the universal into the monolithic metaphysical universal," and entirely overlook "the conception of the historical universal at work in the revolutionary emergence of modern democracy." Most importantly, we exchange "solidarity" for "love" when discussing the principle of anarchy. Birmingham's argument rests on a distinction between a "metaphysical" and a "historical universal", and the belief that the anarchy at the beginning of our political project also has "its universal principle."

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These observations, which rest on a profound knowledge of Plato, Arendt, and Balibar's political philosophy, are a clear indication of the central role universal values still play today, and the impossibility of overcoming them once for all.

Birmingham is correct to recall that the "metaphysical universal is a historical universal," that is, "the *consequence* of a particular notion of citizenship, equality, political representation, and sovereignty," but this does not justify its practical use in politics today. After all, when universals are imposed they are not justified through their historical genealogy, but rather on metaphysical grounds. We do not want to debate the usefulness or validity of historical genealogies of universals, but rather insist on their violence, as it is an ethical rather than a theoretical issue at stake. Independently of all the differences there are between universals declared "through political praxis" or "with ahistorical truth claims," the problem lies in their inevitable imposition. After all, even such emancipatory and revolutionary ideals as those of 1789 and 1848 (which Birmingham sees close to the ideal motivating our weakened communism) have been imposed violently, as we've seen in recent wars. While the distinction between a "metaphysical" and a "historical universal" seems secondary as far as violence is concerned, the difference between "love" and "solidarity" is central.

We are completely in agreement with Birmingham when she states that the "principle of anarchy... in the authors' conception of a weakened communism is not love, but solidarity." Whereas "love" refers to the remains of Christianity after Nietzsche and Heidegger dismantled its metaphysical essence, "solidarity" belongs to Rorty's post-metaphysical pragmatism, which we endorse throughout the book. We should have remained faithful to Rorty's preference for the term "solidarity." After all, Nietzsche probably also thought of love in a weaker form, that is, as plural solidarity for others instead of a singular love in the name of God. But the greatest problem with "love" in politics, as Birmingham points out, is that it is "inherently violent and this because it is inherently apolitical." It is interesting to notice that "dialogue," which we distinguish from "conversation," has also become the paradigm for apolitical governance now.

In sum, if we have eschewed all appeals to universal principles (independently whether declared "through political praxis" or "with ahistorical truth claims") in favor of a weakened communism where love (now "solidarity") is the only law, it is because it is a non-objective, non-foundational, and weakened principle. Schürmann was right: anarchy also contains its principle, but it is a principle which calls for the absence of the single rule. In the same spirit, we also call for a principle where singular love and dialogue are replaced by plural solidarity and conversations. In this form the shaky ground of theory we mention above will invite everyone to take political as well as philosophical risks.

The Political Becoming of Hermeneutics

Jeffrey W. Robbins

Abstract In his book, *The Reckless Minds: Intellectuals in Politics*, Mark Lilla rehearses the familiar condemnation of Martin Heidegger for his association with the Nazi Party. For Lilla, Heidegger is just one of many contemporary intellectuals who has no business commenting on, or involving oneself in, politics: Better to avoid the political sphere altogether than run the risk of the philosophical love of wisdom degenerating into what Lilla terms a philotyranny. In contrast to Lilla, Gianni Vattimo and Santiago Zabala accomplish the nearly unthinkable task, not only taking on the mantle of Heidegger for their entirely original and sorely needed articulation of the meaning of the politics of hermeneutics, but convincingly demonstrate that a truly Heideggerian politics would be communistic, not fascist. In so doing, Vattimo and Zabala not only reinvigorate the politics of the left, but even more, they redefine and redirect philosophical hermeneutics. As such, it can be argued that *Hermeneutic Communism* is the first salvo in the political becoming of hermeneutics.

In his book, *The Reckless Minds: Intellectuals in Politics*, Mark Lilla rehearses the familiar condemnation of Martin Heidegger for his association with the Nazi Party. For Lilla, Heidegger is just one of many contemporary intellectuals who has no business commenting on, or involving oneself in, politics: Better to avoid the political sphere altogether than run the risk of the philosophical love of wisdom degenerating into what Lilla terms a philotyranny. And not just Heidegger, for Lilla modern European history is replete with other examples of philosophers betraying the ideals of freedom and intellectual inquiry, in league with totalitarian regimes, and so utterly deluded that they fail philosophy's first and most enduring test—to tame the passions. The lesson of the twentieth century especially is how the temptation of the philotyrannical mind operates by an internal force that, in the words of Lilla, blinds by “the allure of an idea.”¹ This sordid recent history is posed in contrast to the

¹ Lilla, p. 216.

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philosophical ideal as held by Socrates and Plato wherein it is doubtful whether the demands of politics and philosophy can ever be made to coincide.

In contrast to Lilla, Gianni Vattimo and Santiago Zabala accomplish the nearly unthinkable task, not only taking on the mantle of Heidegger for their entirely original and sorely needed articulation of the meaning of the politics of hermeneutics, but convincingly demonstrating that a truly Heideggerian politics would be communist, not fascist. In so doing, Vattimo and Zabala not only reinvigorate the politics of the left, but even more, redefine and redirect philosophical hermeneutics. As such, *Hermeneutic Communism* is the first salvo in the political becoming of hermeneutics. Interpretation is a political act. And by philosophically reflecting on the nature of interpretation, a particular, if not certain, politics is bequeathed: a reinvigorated communism severed from its metaphysical foundations, an antifoundationalist and postmetaphysical politics that eschews violence, a weak Marxism that by its “South American alternative” aims to dissolve the Euro-American death grip on geopolitics.

My interest in this bold project is threefold: First, along with other recent works in critical philosophy, Vattimo and Zabala have paved the way for a renewed appreciation for Heidegger. They have accomplished what the philosopher Catherine Malabou has termed a “Heidegger change,” even going so far as suggesting a changed perspective on the prevailing view regarding Heidegger’s cruel, opportunistic and inept politics. Theirs is not so much a demythologization of Heidegger that reads Heidegger against himself in order to salvage what is good and enduring from the shame of his Nazi involvement, but an actual invocation of Heidegger’s hermeneutical philosophy as a potential political model, an actual claim—however counterintuitive it might seem—that a properly Heideggerian politics would be a communistic one. For this first point, I will read Vattimo and Zabala’s invocation of Heidegger in conjunction with Malabou’s equally ambitious study wherein she reappropriates Heidegger as a thinker of ontological mutation, and thus, as a viable ethical guide. In both cases, whether with Vattimo and Zabala or with Malabou there is a fresh new critical engagement with the work of Heidegger that does not dismiss or shy away from his political past. Theirs is admittedly a dangerous undertaking. It is much easier and safer to stand with the likes of Lilla with a blanket condemnation of Heidegger. But in so doing, the connection between thinking and politics would still be left severed—our thinking bereft of any ethical and/or political direction, and our politics left to its own devices as nothing more nor less than the game of power we already know it to be.

Second, by making their contemporary political reference point what they term the “South American alternative,” it is worth exploring the degree to which this endeavor towards a hermeneutic communism can be seen as a decolonial project. For this, I will take Walter Mignolo as my guide who has been at the forefront in taking pains to define and distinguish decoloniality from both post-colonial theory and Marxist-oriented leftist politics. While there is considerable overlap and compatibility between these three projects, they are nevertheless irreducible to one another. In the words of Mignolo, they “walk in the same direction, following

different paths.”² Most notably, the chief difference is that they have different points of origination. For both post-colonial theory and the politics of the Left, they are and remain essentially Western projects, with Western intellectuals grappling with their own troubling legacies, their own cultural biases, and their own complicity in networks of power and control. Decoloniality, on the other hand, is more than, and different from, “Third world thoughts ... processed in European intellectual factories.”³ It is a radical shift in the point of origination and reference. Or better, it is the radical subversion of the very idea of the point of origin and reference. That is to say, decoloniality is defined by its embrace of a genuinely polycentric world, a dispelling of the myth of universality. So if post-colonial theory and the politics of the Left confront capitalism and colonialism from within the West itself, decoloniality stages a like confrontation but from the perspective of the ex-colonies and the once colonized. In so doing, at least Mignolo’s variant of the decolonial option takes its distance from communism. For Mignolo, both communism and capitalism belong within the horizon of modern Western civilization, and thus, are unfit for a proper decolonial form of thinking and politics. This will be important to consider when evaluating the viability of Vattimo and Zabala’s reenvisioned hermeneutic communism.

Third, I will pursue the connection between hermeneutics and politics—or better, the politics of hermeneutics as envisioned by Vattimo and Zabala. While it seems clear that their project is intended as an effort to revitalize the radical politics of the Left for the expressed purpose of changing the world, it simultaneously a work in critical philosophy. In making the case for the political becoming of hermeneutics, it is not just staking its claim within the history of hermeneutical philosophy, but it is also providing its very own critique and corrective to that history. Their claim is not simply that hermeneutics might be applied to politics, but a much stronger one: hermeneutics properly understood eventuates in a particular form of politics, specifically a communism of and for the twenty-first century. This is a departure from the way their post-metaphysical hermeneutics of weak thought have typically been portrayed, and I regard it to be the single most significant aspect of their project. But it is a high bar they must hurdle, which is, specifically whether a post-metaphysical philosophy can produce a positive politics at all, or whether postmetaphysics always and necessarily must remain only in a deconstructive mode.

I. Heidegger as Secret Agent

The case against Heidegger is well established. The argument from Karl Löwith that Heidegger’s Nazism “was not born of a regrettable miscue” but is consistent with—indeed, a necessary outgrowth of—his existentialism, has set the agenda. It was in a 1936 conversation with Löwith, after all, that Heidegger agreed “without

²Mignolo, p. 55.

³Ibid., p. 57.

reservation” that “his partisanship for National Socialism lay in the essence of his philosophy.”⁴ So in the words of Richard Wolin, “We know that Heidegger’s alliance with Nazism, far from being a temporary marriage of convenience, was grandiose and profound: at least for a short period of time, Heidegger labored under the delusion that he could play the role of ‘philosopher-king’ to Hitler’s *Führersstaat* . . . so that the ‘National Revolution’ might fulfill its appointed metaphysical destiny.”⁵

Nevertheless, this justifiable condemnation of Heidegger still only speaks to his person, of how he himself fell into the grip of his own self-importance, or of how his own political decision was a legitimate interpretation at least within his own mind, as well as for many of those who knew him and his work the best (not only Löwith, but Karl Jaspers as well). What this does not determine or settle, however, is whether and to what extent alternative interpretations and applications of Heidegger might be made. For instance, John Caputo has effectively “demythologized” Heidegger, reading Heidegger *against* Heidegger through an injection of what is essentially a Levinasian ethic. For Caputo, Heidegger’s philosophy poses the reader with a choice “between dangerous myths and salutary myths; between privileging, elitist, and hierarchizing myths and myths that promote justice and multiplicity; between exclusionary and oppressive myths and liberating, empowering myths.”⁶ It is clear that Heidegger made the wrong choice, that he failed to heed the dangers of the path of thinking and action that he was on, but if indeed if his philosophy presents us with a genuine choice then his failure need not translate into a wholesale repudiation of his thought. Perhaps regardless of how he himself saw it, his politics were *extrinsic* to his thought, and that Heidegger least of all should not be the one we allow to operate as authoritative guide for how his thinking ought to be interpreted and applied. By his delusions of grandeur, by his political opportunism, and by his callousness and cruelty to those he once regarded as friends, teachers, and mentors (think Husserl), Heidegger has forfeited the right of being his own privileged interpreter. It is at this point that the recent commentaries by Malabou and Vattimo and Zabala fit in with regard to the invocation of Heidegger as a potential political model. More than a demythologization, theirs is an actual reclamation of Heidegger. And not a Heidegger purged of his politics, but more ambitiously, a critical argument about what a properly Heideggerian politics would actually be.

First, from Malabou, in her book *The Heidegger Change* she continues in the same vein as her earlier work on *The Future of Hegel*. In both she employs her signature concept of plasticity to demonstrate how these philosophical castoffs might be reappropriated—or better, she warns against too quick of a dismissal of Hegel and Heidegger by reading them in light of plasticity, a concept whose time has only now come to fruition and which we are only now in a position to appreciate. What this means is that the caricatures that have been made out of Hegel and Heidegger by their critics say less about Hegel and Heidegger than they do about the outdated nature of the critiques. Malabou’s reappropriation of Hegel turns on the question of

⁴Quoted in Wolin, p. 4.

⁵Wolin, p. 2.

⁶Caputo, *Demythologizing Heidegger*, p. 3.

the future—both whether there is a future *for* Hegel when it seems that the scholarship on Hegel has retread such familiar ground for so long that it has exhausted all possibilities for new and different interpretations, and more significantly whether there is a future *in* Hegel's own dialectic, or as originally charged by Heidegger, Hegel is unwilling and incapable of thinking the future.

Likewise with her book on Heidegger, there too her analysis turns on a question. In this case, the question regards the concept of change, and again her pattern of questioning remains the same: whether there is the possibility for a change in how Heidegger can be interpreted and whether and to what extent the concept of change is operative within Heidegger's own philosophy. But to inquire about change *in* Heidegger, one cannot merely talk about change, but rather what Malabou terms the "triad of change" comprised of the notions of *Wandel* (change), *Wandlung* (transformation), and *Verwandlung* (metamorphosis), or simply W, W, & V for short. Malabou argues that by reading this triad of change within Heidegger, it is not only "what confers on Heidegger's thought its power and vigor," but it also is "a device whereby Heidegger is changed."⁷ That is to say, it is about Heidegger's understanding of change and about how an appreciation of that distinct and overlooked understanding might effect a change in how Heidegger is understood.

Or put otherwise, Malabou is able to put to rest entirely the debate over the so-called Heideggerian turn over how he himself changed after his Nazi involvement by showing a consistency within Heidegger's thinking from beginning to end that conceives as being *qua* change. It is for this reason that Malabou calls this triad of change the "secret agent" of Heidegger's philosophy. By attending to W, W, & V within Heidegger's corpus, it makes manifest the ontological difference, but not in terms of the history of the forgetfulness of being but in terms of the "originary mutability of being," and of being as "nothing but its mutability." As Malabou puts it, it is an exchange of difference for change, a shift from the epoch of writing and its consequent philosophies of language to that of plasticity. By letting ourselves be "put under the spell of the leitmotif of W, W, & V" we are on the way to reach "another Heidegger." More than an ontological revolution, this is a moral-political revolution as well, one wherein—irony of ironies—Heidegger is deployed as the engine of resistance against capitalism.

By Malabou's telling, Heidegger is the defender of the precariousness of life. He is not a messianic thinker in the ilk of Derrida. His promise of change does not rest on transcendence as in the case of Lévinas. Yet nevertheless, he does accomplish a disarming of the metaphysics of presence, but not by contrasting presence with absence, or identity with difference. Instead, it is the originary nature of exchangeability that allows him to affirm a metamorphosis *without rest*, a change without beginning or end, a change that is imminent to time—indeed, constitutive of it. By this telling, the caricature of Heidegger standing passive letting being be, or waiting for a god to save us, is replaced by a non-revolutionary concept of change. Change has always already happened. We are changed in advance. And the world never stops the change. The world never stops being changed. "The genius of Heidegger,"

⁷Malabou, pp. 2–3.

Malabou writes, consists “in having inscribed the possibility of revolution not in a future event to come but in fact (so modest, slight, and tiny) of *being-there, of still being there after the accomplishment that was never accomplished*.”⁸

There is enormous political power and vigor by this thought because it schematizes human freedom and establishes the ontological conditions for political resistance. But resistance to what? Malabou gives a name to the site and target of resistance—capitalism. The culture of late capitalism establishes the biopolitical norm of flexibility wherein the human is merely acted upon, wherein the worker is made to change at the whims of market forces, but cannot—is utterly incapable to—make change. When being is conceived of as change, however, *dasein* is known as a change agent. Malabou is careful and consistent in distinguishing the flexibility demanded and valorized by free market capitalism with the adaptability associated with plasticity. Change, exchange, and metamorphosis happen, but that need not translate into pure malleability. The human is not a passive subject who is merely acted upon. No matter how much management might wish it otherwise and no matter how much working conditions mitigate against it, our time, our bodies, our intellectual property are ours alone. This permanent potential for resistance manifests our freedom. It is this plastic form that remains, no matter how often it is transformed, or even deformed. In Malabou’s turn of phrase, it is “up to us to contend.”⁹ Our fates are in our hands—not written in stone as if being had some eternal essence, nor left entirely blank as if the future was merely a play of differences. The plasticity of being teaches us that being qua change has the potential both to *receive* form and to *give* form. It is by that knowledge that we know that if it is always up to us to contend, then real change is possible. There is nothing that cannot change. More, there is nothing that is that is not change, that is not always already changed and changing. This is the strongest repudiation of the very ideology of capitalism that renders capitalism as completely natural and inevitable, and thus, irresistible. Our fates are never written in stone, but in plastic.

Like Malabou, Vattimo and Zabala invoke Heidegger as a source for political resistance against the machinery of capitalism and the way by which capitalism divvies out of the winners and losers in the global economy. The logic of capitalism sets the powerful against the weak, whether on the scale of the neoliberal geopolitical order in terms of nation-states or for individuals. Whether we recognize it or not, this is a state of emergency, but it is left to the weak and dispossessed to sound the alarm when entrenched power is invested in preserving the status quo. In this way, the weak, postmetaphysical thought of hermeneutics “becomes the thought of the weak in search of alternatives.” It is a weak form of thought that does not claim universality and “does not believe that politics can be founded on scientific and rational grounds, but only on interpretation, history, and event.”¹⁰

When compared with Malabou, this invocation of Heidegger by Vattimo and Zabala is a more traditional one, one which stresses Heidegger’s project at

⁸ Ibid. Italics hers.

⁹ Malabou, p.286.

¹⁰ Vattimo and Zabala, pp. 2–3.

overcoming metaphysics, but with a twist. By *reading Heidegger into Marx* and thereby posing the possibility of a hermeneutic communism, they correct Marxist philosophies of their own excesses—or more precisely, purge Marxism of its metaphysical bearings. The fault with Marxism is not its revolutionary charge to change the world but that it framed this demand for change “within the metaphysical tradition.”¹¹ Vattimo and Zabala set aside the general call for revolution in lieu of a more basic defense of the weak. They admit that this strategy of reading backwards—“from Heidegger to Marx”—goes “further than Marx or Heidegger intended.”¹² Nevertheless, by so doing, they articulate a conception of a “communism of the twenty-first century,” or a “weakened communism.” This would be a humbled communism that takes its distance from both the historical Soviet and contemporary Chinese models. It is humbled by the hermeneutical attitude that must always contend with the conflict of interpretations and thus which places a premium on respect for differences. And as a hermeneutic communism, it is also necessarily a democratic communism, but not the reigning democracy that has made the fateful mistake of conflating freedom with free markets and which has felt justified in spreading democracy by the barrel of a gun. Though humbled, this hermeneutic communism still presents itself if not the last, then at least the best, hope for those they identify as the “discharge of capitalism.”

The audacity in this work is how it cites Heidegger as an ally. After all, it is well known how Heidegger repudiated communism. But Vattimo and Zabala argue that this repudiation was not an outgrowth of his early Nazi sympathies, “but rather because of his need to overcome metaphysics.”¹³ As evidence of this, they site his simultaneous repudiation of Western style democracy and free-market capitalism. By their reading, Heidegger was trying to think politics otherwise. The problem with the existing forms of communism, capitalism, and democracy is that they all strived to complete a “metaphysical organization of beings,” and in so doing, failed the thought of Being, and failed to acknowledge “philosophy’s groundless realm.”¹⁴ As a post-metaphysical thinker of Being, one whose philosophical project was defined by the quest to overcome metaphysics, this is the key to thinking Heidegger’s politics otherwise; this is the “other” Heidegger who can be claimed as a political ally in the articulation of a hermeneutic communism in spite of his protestations to the contrary.

Vattimo and Zabala have conceived of Heidegger’s post-metaphysical politics in complete sympathy with that of his contemporary Carl Schmitt. With philosophy’s groundless realm, or in the remains of Being, the concept of the political becomes nothing else besides the prerogative to decide. This political decisionism fills in for the abyss left vacant by Being’s departure. For both, they saw in modern liberalism an onslaught of a technocratic order, a tragically ironic process wherein not only was the human subject eclipsed but modern politics was rendered a-political. When politics is essentially managed as a bureaucratic state—or as the science of a technocratic

¹¹ Vattimo and Zabala, p. 1.

¹² Vattimo and Zabala, p. 4.

¹³ Vattimo and Zabala, p.4.

¹⁴ Ibid., p. 5.

bureaucracy—then it is desperately in need of either a political ontology or what might very well amount to the same thing, a renewed political theology. But in both cases, the actual political projects are set up in opposition to democracy. For Schmitt, as I have argued extensively elsewhere, he saw political theology and democracy as mutually exclusive, and defined the essence of the political in terms of the friend-enemy distinction that directly goes against the democratic ideal of inclusion.¹⁵

For Heidegger, the case was not so simple, and it is at this point that the differences between Malabou on the one hand and Vattimo and Zabala on the other are most significant. It is simply not the case that Heidegger never developed the political dimensions of his thought, as Vattimo and Zabala assert.¹⁶ Even if it was only for a brief time, there is no question that Heidegger's Nazi period involved his own political translation and application of his thought. He decisively and unapologetically involved himself in an explicitly political project—an explicitly fascist one at that. The argument, then, is not whether Heidegger was or was not a political thinker, and certainly not whether he deserves the prerogative as his own privileged interpreter, but instead whether and how his thinking can be a resource for rethinking and reorienting our politics today.

We see precisely this being done by both Malabou and Vattimo and Zabala. In the terms of Lilla, Heidegger was no doubt a “reckless mind.” We can add to that that he was also egotistical, opportunistic and cruel. But someone no less than Emmanuel Lévinas still acknowledges that all thinkers in his wake still owe him a debt of gratitude—albeit, a regrettable one. Just as Lévinas turned Heidegger's anthropology of *dasein* as a being-with-others into the moral imperative that was the basis of his revisioning of metaphysics as ethics, Heidegger is being reclaimed for today's political challenges. Reckless, but not irredeemable, and the redemption in mind here has nothing to do with spirituality, with Heidegger's soul or his person. It is instead a more ancient or archaic understanding of redemption by which we regain possession of something we have lost. A debt is cleared, specifically the debt we owe not to Heidegger the man, but to the thought—the thought that was hijacked and distorted by Heidegger himself, the thought that we ourselves have been scared away from by the cautionary tale that is Heidegger.

By reading change in Heidegger, we release the “secret agent” of Heidegger's thought for today. *Dasein* is exemplary by its plasticity—not only *subject to* change by being impressed upon by all sides in an immanent order of interpersonal relations structured by care, but also a *maker of* change, and thus, always already a revolutionary. And by the hermeneutical strategy of reading backwards—from Heidegger to Marx—not only a new politics, but a potentially new concept of the political, emerge. The politics is new communism for the twenty-first century, one that is weakened, if not cured, of its metaphysical foundations wherein communism might once again—even if for the very first time—defend the interests, and stand in solidarity with, the weakest citizens.

¹⁵ See Jeffrey W. Robbins, *Radical Democracy and Political Theology* (New York: Columbia University Press, 2011).

¹⁶ See Vattimo and Zabala, pp. 76–77.

II. Communism and the Decolonial Option

The question must nevertheless be asked: why Heidegger at all? And not only why Heidegger, but why communism? Are they so necessary to the political project that they are worth the baggage they carry? Is there not some other option for imagining a global future that escapes the Euro-American stranglehold on geopolitics, an option that does not so much depend on the internal confrontation of the West with itself as it does on exploring alternative genealogies of thought and practice? This would not so much be a Eurocentered critique of modernity which still traffics in systems of knowledge and institutional practices that Walter Mignolo refers to as the “Western code” as much as it seeks a horizon of thinking outside the West but that nevertheless—or perhaps precisely thereby—recognizes the “darker side of Western modernity”?

This alternative has been called the “decolonial option.” Like Vattimo and Zabala, this decolonial option as articulated by Mignolo also stages a confrontation amongst the winners and losers of the current global order. But with Mignolo it is not simply the strong against the weak but an entire colonial matrix of power that includes the obvious features of racism, patriarchy, environmental degradation, and resource depletion as well as the not so obvious epistemological and ontological features. After all, what counts as knowledge, Mignolo contends, is still based in modern scientific rationality. And personhood is still framed by the supposedly universal code of human rights. “Decoloniality shall dispel the myth of universality grounded in theo- and ego-politics of knowledge,” Mignolo writes, leaving open the questions: “what kind of knowledge, by whom, what for?”¹⁷

It is a struggle to find the right words to describe the significance this decolonial option has, especially in the brief space allocated to it here. It is perhaps for this reason that Mignolo so often resorts to sloganeering. No doubt there are times when his arguments and analyses amount to little besides pronouncements, albeit richly evocative ones. There are other times when the slogans bespeak an urgently needed visualization—a visualization not so much of a different world, as an obscured and neglected one, wherein the blindness and hubris of the West rehearsing its own past sins and promises might be shattered once and for all. This is a visualization of a genuine *penetration* of the elaborately constructed defenses of the current global order, defenses that have been nearly impenetrable precisely because they are virtually invisible. That is to say, the colonial matrix of power has been so strong and has endured for so long because it has managed to contain within it not only its staunchest defenders, but also its critics, able to absorb or eliminate any and all resistance into itself as a functioning totality.

The point, which is not original to decolonial thinking but certainly takes on a different salience thanks to its emphasis on the point that colonialism was constitutive of modernity, is that globalization functions as a kind of hyper-modernism, and thus as an extension of colonialism. The world is interconnected by a single,

¹⁷ Mignolo, p. xvi.

interconnected global economy. The colonial matrix of power is nearly complete. Yet while economically interconnected, there remains a diversity of political theories, practices and institutions. Capital functions as a trans- or supra-national sovereign power, with almost no one or nothing capable of keeping it in check. So while various individuals and movements rise to voice their dissent, even while this might be the noblest and most serious and scrutinizing forms of self-critique, this too can and has been used to shield the West from the rest of the world. This ongoing dialectic has at times been vicious with the very world hanging in the balance. At the same time, while this has essentially been a protracted civil war—a war of the West with itself, a contest for supremacy that designates entire swaths of the world to third world status—its collateral damage has been largely externalized. And just as the Western world's damage has been largely externalized, so too might its most penetrating critique come from outside. Which is why Mignolo begins his book *The Darker Side of Modernity* by distinguishing decoloniality with other types of critiques of modernity—whether those critiques come from psychoanalysis, Marxism, poststructuralism, or even postcolonialism—precisely by virtue of its externality.

Thus to penetrate through the global defenses requires changing both *who* partakes in the conversation and also the very *terms* of the conversation. It is in this way that the decolonial option provides an epistemological and ontological alternative. And alternative is the operative word here, more so than revolution, because it is extrinsic to the normative code. “I am where I think” is the slogan Mignolo gives to this alternative epistemology and ontology, a repudiation of the presumed universality of the modern Cartesian subject.¹⁸ This is an epistemology of dwelling that does not simply make reference to local habitats and cultures, but is fully immersed. The accompanying political ontology acknowledges and provides for overlapping and conflicting spheres of sovereignty, and different possibilities for conceiving of what counts as a person and what or whom is deserving of rights as determined by bonds of mutual obligation and care. To make place central to epistemology and ontology is to put a lie to the universal code proffered by the West. Place matters. And when place matters, it is not just one single place, but different places, different peoples—*from the universal to the pluriversal*.

It is in this context that Mignolo takes distance from communism in an important disclaimer: “In a nutshell, the difference is this: the Marxist Left confronts capitalism first within Europe itself. . . . The decolonial confronts all of Western civilization, which includes liberal capitalism and Marxism. And it does it from the perspective of the colonies and the ex-colonies rather than from the perspective internal to Western civilization itself.”¹⁹ This disclaimer must be kept in mind when considering what Vattimo and Zabala identify as the “South American alternative,” by which they mean specifically Hugo Chavez’s “Bolivarian Revolution.” As Vattimo and Zabala tell it, the South American alternative “differs substantially” from previously existing forms of communism because it follows “democratic electoral procedures

¹⁸ Ibid., p. xvi.

¹⁹ Ibid., p. xviii.

and also manage[s] to decentralize the state bureaucratic system.”²⁰ The initiatives put into place by Chavez in Venezuela and Morales in Bolivia have effectively spurred economic growth, contributed to the alleviation of extreme poverty, and greatly increased literacy and access to health care. Quoting Mark Weisbrot, this success is proof of the viability of weak communism for the twenty-first century because of the way these leftist governments of Bolivia and Venezuela have “delivered on their promises to share the income . . . with the people.”²¹

Another important feature for Vattimo and Zabala is how these South American governments are militant, but not an armed, form of communism. International partnerships must necessarily be forged in order to withstand the mounting and unrelenting pressure from American interests and the neoliberal economic policies it both prescribes and imposes. Vattimo and Zabala are right to expose the concerted, if not coordinated, effort to delegitimize Chavez, and to a lesser extent, Morales. For them, intellectuals and media figures in the West are “obsessed” with South America “because its governments represent a political alternative to global capitalism and framed democracies.” That any alternative exists at all makes questionable the entire presumed *raison d’être* of globalization—namely, we have reached the end of the history of ideological conflict wherein global capital has finally achieved its own inner purpose of expanding its reach to the entire globe. Like we saw with Mignolo, South America’s ideological opposition to the rules of global capitalism puts a lie to the fatal logic that there is no outside to capitalism. Just as these South American regimes are being singled out for their responsiveness and solidarity to the poorest and most needy—those who are the “discharge of capitalism”—the regimes themselves, to the extent that they are deliberately established as external to and independent from the neoliberal global order, are also capitalism’s discharges, and as such, the world’s, or at least the region’s, best hope.

And finally, consider what Vattimo and Zabala say about the conditions of possibility for hermeneutics: hermeneutics is a distinctively post-metaphysical philosophy. As we examined prior, it is what corrects Marxism of its own excesses by purging it of its own metaphysical bearings. But what is so interesting and important about the particular genealogy of hermeneutics that Vattimo and Zabala provide in this work is that it is more than a development within the history of (Western) philosophy. Indeed, “hermeneutics would not have been possible,” Vattimo and Zabala tell us, “without the end of Eurocentrism.” Put otherwise, the conditions of possibility for hermeneutics requires an externality, one that “confirmed the disarray of the Eurocentric convictions” and the “dissolution of metaphysics.” By penetrating the defenses of the West’s own self-obsession, the very possibility of hermeneutics is revealed as a political becoming announcing the end to the “pretense to universal ‘Western’ rationality.”²²

As Vattimo and Zabala see it, this recognition of the conditions of possibility for hermeneutics that lays the groundwork for the political becoming of hermeneutics

²⁰ Vattimo and Zabala, p. 122.

²¹ Ibid., p. 129.

²² Ibid., pp. 110, 111.

provides “a chance for the return of communism.”²³ But along with Mignolo, could we press this even further? As he narrates the origins of decolonial thinking, he points to the Non-Aligned Movement [NAM] during the Cold War as the beginning of the political project of decolonization. In this way, from its inception decolonization has not pinned its hopes on either communism or capitalism. On the contrary, decolonization opened up “a new horizon . . . beyond capitalism and communism.”²⁴ Over time that essentially political project mutated from decolonization to decoloniality, the comprehensive theory that lays out the systematic critique of how the colonial matrix of power is constitutive of modernity and charts not only an alternative political alignment, but an alternative epistemology and ontology as well. It is not a question of a return, or a reproduction, or even a renewal. Instead, for once over the long history of Western modernity, there is the possibility of an embrace of a genuinely polycentric world. Vattimo and Zabala’s articulation of the South American alternative is an important gesture towards that end—and in that way, there hermeneutic communism should be seen as having a “complementary trajectory” to that of decolonial thinking. At the same time, we must be cautious that it not simply be yet another instance of “Third world thoughts . . . processed in European intellectual factories.” Vattimo and Zabala have successfully linked the end of Eurocentrism with the dissolution of metaphysics and thus the political becoming of hermeneutics. But is their weak communism weak enough, sufficiently dissolved of all remnants of its modern Eurocentric convictions? If so, it might be worth asking whether we are then better off calling communism by some other name entirely.²⁵

III. Hermeneutics and/as Politics

Regardless of its name, I remain deeply interested in and committed to what I consider to be the even more fundamental and enduring aspect of Vattimo and Zabala’s project in *Hermeneutic Communism*. In broad terms, this has to do with the connection they have established between hermeneutics and politics. More specifically, it addresses the question of whether a post-metaphysical philosophy can produce a positive politics at all, or whether postmetaphysics always and necessarily must remain only in a deconstructive mode.

Perhaps the most comprehensive and damning critiques of postmodernism comes from the famed British left-wing literary critic Terry Eagleton in his book

²³ Ibid., p. 111.

²⁴ Mignolo, p. xxxi.

²⁵ It is worth noting here how Zabala himself has acknowledged that the term “communism” is not native to the South American political movements and figures that he and Vattimo have together cited. For instance, in an interview with Silvia Mazzini he has admitted that it is true that Chavez does not call himself a communist, but instead, uses the term “socialism for the twenty-first century.” See “Chavez is Still a Model for Obama: Interview with Santiago Zabala,” *Al Jazeera* (November 11, 2012): <http://www.aljazeera.com/indepth/opinion/2012/11/2012118121638309403.html>.

from 1996, *The Illusions of Postmodernism*. Like Žižek after him (with whom he has been frequently compared),²⁶ Eagleton has criticized postmodernism from a political perspective, noting how its presumed radical ideas of negativity and undecidability is in actuality an announcement of political defeat by the left—a form of micropolitics and political subjectivity perfectly in concert with, and thus completely unable to resist, the cultural logic of late capitalism. After all, as Eagleton points out, “Capitalism is the most pluralistic order history has ever known.” Thus by relativizing capitalism as just one other form of totality among others, by refusing to organize itself in an explicitly anti-capitalist fashion, postmodernism has effectively pulled out the rug from beneath itself. For instance, in a characteristic passage, Eagleton writes:

For in a period when no far-reaching political action seems really feasible, when so-called micropolitics seems the order of the day, it is relieving to convert this necessity into a virtue—to persuade oneself that one’s political limits have, as it were, a solid ontological grounding, the fact that social totality is in any case a chimera. It doesn’t matter if there is no political agent on hand to transform the whole, since there is in fact no whole to be transformed. It is as though, having mislaid the breadknife, one declares the loaf to be already sliced.²⁷

More bluntly, and more directly to the point of Vattimo and Zabala’s hermeneutic theory, Eagleton questions the political value and viability of an epistemology wherein everything is subject to interpretation. “Everything would become an interpretation,” Eagleton writes as he narrates the philosophical genealogy of postmodernism, “including that claim itself, in which case the idea of interpretation would cancel all the way through and leave everything exactly as it was. A radical epistemology would issue, conveniently enough, in a conservative politics.”²⁸ It is with this in mind that Eagleton announces his overall assessment of postmodernism. He writes variously that “it is the upshot of a political failure” or “the backwash of a political debacle,” that has left the so-called left in a state of “political illiteracy and historical oblivion” and the power of capital never “so sublimely omnipotent and omnipresent.”²⁹

Put schematically, the problem with postmodernism, especially the post-metaphysical postmodernism which Vattimo and Zabala subscribe, is a political problem. It is a political problem because its actual politics is in fact a form of post-politics, a politics of evasion that has sidestepped the most vital and intractable political problem of our time—namely, the presumed naturalism of capitalism, and concomitantly, its nearly total, and totally unresisted, spread. While much of post-modern discourse has effectively historicized normative values and operative ideologies, Eagleton is correct to point out that historicizing in and of itself is not necessarily a radical act, and most definitely does not belong to the left alone.

²⁶ For instance, see Ola Sigurdson, *Theology and Marxism in Eagleton and Žižek: A Conspiracy of Hope* (New York: Palgrave Macmillan, 2012).

²⁷ Terry Eagleton, *The Illusions of Postmodernism* (London: Blackwell, 1996), p. 9.

²⁸ *Ibid.*, p. 14.

²⁹ *Ibid.*, pp. 21–23.

Postmodernism might very well be oppositional, but it is a framed opposition allowing for a nearly infinite multiplicity, but with no sustained and targeted critique of the lone governing logic that keep those multiplicities in a perpetual and almost purposeful state of play—"politically oppositional but economically complicit" is how Eagleton concludes his critique.³⁰

Eagleton's critique is a potent, but generalized, one. Kenneth Surin provides a much more fine-grained analysis of what we might term postmodern politics in his article, "The Ontological Script of Liberation."³¹ He begins with an acknowledgement of how the transnational flow of capital operates as a sovereign power, and how the modern model of the secular nation state is powerless to control or hold accountable the new regimes of capitalist accumulation. In the era of globalization our economy has become global but our political institutions have not. This has weakened or neutralized state power and contributed to a postpolitical citizenry. Citing his colleague Fredric Jameson, Surin argues that this apparent triumph of global capital is so dire, or so complete, that "it's easier for us nowadays to contemplate the total destruction of the earth through some ecological catastrophe than it is to believe that capitalism will come to an end."³²

In the wake of this, Surin outlines four contemporary political options for the left: The first option is the politics of identity, which Surin promptly dismisses for how smoothly it dovetails into actually existing capitalism. The second, which he associates with the ethico-political deconstructive work of Derrida and Lévinas, is the politics of subjectivity. For Surin, the politics of subjectivity becomes an unwitting politics of decision. Further, "it has no way of inserting the subject into the domain of the actually political," and as a consequence, "provides no way of imagining resistance at the level of a politics of collective action." The third option is labeled as the politics of the Event, associated with Alain Badiou and Žižek. This option is the most fervently anticapitalist contemporary mode of political resistance, but it also might be guilty of a kind of political romanticism. Further, because it is predicated on the notion of a truth-event as a radical rupture, it is incapable of providing any norms whatsoever. The state of exception which Badiou and Žižek might seize upon in order to mobilize anticapitalist resistance might just as easily and more frequently be mobilized by the right as a justification for a seizure of state power that violates constitutional norms and limitations as was seen in the aftermath of 9/11. This leaves the fourth and final option for Surin, which is the politics of the multitude, identified with Deleuze and Guattari, as well as Michael Hardt and Antonio Negri. The virtue of multitude theory, as described by Surin, is how it conceives of political power as autogenerating. In Surin's words, "the multitude directs itself according to its own powers and its own history." It is a decentralized form of

³⁰ Ibid., p. 132.

³¹ Kenneth Surin, "Rewriting the Ontological Script of Liberation: On the Question of Finding a New Kind of Political Subject," in *Theology and the Political: The New Debate*, edited by Creston Davis, John Milbank, and Slavoj Žižek (Durham: Duke University Press, 2005), pp. 240–266.

³² Ibid., pp. 252–253.

political power befitting a polycentric world. At the same time, it recognizes the logic of the global flow of capital as a transnational sovereignty.

By now, it should be abundantly clear how on nearly every count Vattimo and Zabala have risen to this sweeping challenged issue by Eagleton, and in so doing, provide a fifth option for organizing the contemporary politics of the left to the four as outlined by Surin.³³ Vattimo and Zabala have taken the hermeneutical theory of interpretation and given it a fully fleshed political body. Theirs is no politics of evasion. It is oppositional, without being economically complicit. On the contrary, its chief theoretical opposition comes by virtue of its concept of a “framed democracy.” That is, a democracy in name only, a democracy held hostage by a neoliberal economic policy that continues to divide the world between haves and have-nots divvying out the winners and losers of globalization. As Derrida has told us, there are no actually existing democracies. Democracy instead is a promise, one that so long as it is framed by economic interests as opposed to people’s power will keep its stranglehold on power and its death-grip on geopolitics.

Eagleton has accused postmodernism of only a framed opposition, by which he means the single most vital political question is left entirely out of the equation. This would not only be a politics of evasion, but also rightly a politics of defeat. Vattimo and Zabala have put the picture back in the frame; they have accomplished a political becoming of hermeneutics, and in so doing, have provided the single most important innovation in hermeneutics since the time of Heidegger’s grandiose partisanship for Nazism as the political actualization of the essence of his philosophy. But what we now can see, maybe now for the very first time, is that the reckless mistake on the part of Heidegger was not that he injected politics into his hermeneutics, but his was the wrong politics. If Vattimo and Zabala are correct, what our politics need, is not less hermeneutics, but more—and the more hermeneutical our politics, the more even communism itself can deliver on its own democratic and decolonial promises.

³³ See Kenneth Surin, “Rewriting the Ontological Script of Liberation: On the Question of Finding a New Kind of Political Subject,” pp. 254–257.

Response to Robbins

Gianni Vattimo and Santiago Zabala

Commenting on our political use of Heidegger, Jeffrey W. Robbins makes a very interesting point at the beginning his contribution, which we believe can also be applied to the book in general. He believes that by considering Heidegger “an ally” we have not simply taken a risk, but “admittedly a dangerous undertaking.” But where does this danger lie? In our support for communism and Chavez? Many others (as Jodi Dean, Domenico Losurdo, and Enrique Dussel) have also taken a clear stance in favor of unpopular ideologies like “communism” that many believe have run their course, as well as radical politicians like “Chavez” who continue to be demonized even after their death. Independently of how unpopular endorsing these ideologies and politicians may seem, they are the consequence rather than the cause of our “dangerous undertaking.” This underlying danger rests in “the political becoming of hermeneutics”, which is also the title of Robbins’ contribution.

In order to examine “the political becoming of hermeneutics” “dangerous undertaking”, Robbins confronts some of our theses with four thinkers: Catherine Malabou’s interpretation of Heidegger, Walter Mignolo’s decolonial project, and Terry Eagleton and Kenneth Surin’s take on postmodernity’s political contribution for the left. The fact that besides Eagleton the other thinkers are not mentioned in *Hermeneutic Communism* is one of the many limits of our text that this book allows us in part to amend.

Robbins is right to consider our interpretation of Heidegger’s hermeneutics as a potential political model for communism within Malabou’s “Heidegger change” paradigm, that is, those reappropriations of “Heidegger as a thinker of ontological mutation, and thus, as a viable ethical guide.” This is only possible for those who, instead of dismissing or ignoring Heidegger’s political errors, reclaim them against

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the way he “hijacked and distorted” it. In doing so Heidegger has hidden a “secret agent” within his philosophy for Heideggerians to explore. What is most interesting about this agent is not its truth, but rather its ability to create, as Robbins brilliantly put it, “a moral-political revolution as well, one wherein—irony of ironies—Heidegger is deployed as the engine of resistance against capitalism.” This is why Malabou’s theoretical operation is not very different from ours. After all the concept of “change” and “plasticity,” central in her thought, are not opposed to our notions of “remnants” and “weakness.” All four disclose how *Dasein* is “not only *subject to* change by being impressed upon by all sides in an immanent order of interpersonal relations structured by care, but also a *maker of* change, and thus, always already a revolutionary.”

This “revolutionary” trait of *Dasein* is probably at the origin of Mignolo and Eagleton’s mistrust of post-metaphysical philosophy’s contribution to decolonial investigations and in the political struggle of the left. This mistrust, as Robbins points out, is conditioned by communism’s European origins as well as a prejudice against any form of postmodern post-politics. As valuable and productive as these positions are, one must ask whether the horizon decolonization opens up beyond capitalism and communism for Mignolo, and the “evasive political” trait of post-modern stances in Eagleton’s view are not issues we have taken into consideration by linking the end of Eurocentrism with the dissolution of metaphysics and the highlighting of the political nature of hermeneutics.

This is why Robbins believes *Hermeneutic Communism* should not only “be seen as having a ‘complementary trajectory’ to that of decolonial thinking,” but also “provide a fifth option for organizing the contemporary politics of the left to the four as outlined by Surin.” After politics of “identity,” “subjectivity,” “event,” and “multitude,” the time has come for a “politics of interpretation.” As Robbins explains, ours is not a “politics of evasion. It is oppositional, without being economically complicit.” Independently of the difficult position the “political becoming of hermeneutics” will find itself in, it must continue this “dangerous undertaking” as other revolutionary stances have done in the past.

Part II

Weakening

Hermeneutic Communism as (Weak) Political Phenomenology

Michael Marder

Abstract According to Vattimo and Zabala, phenomenology fits in with the other manifestations of classical metaphysics, bent on preserving the transcendental privilege of immutable truth. In my contribution I will argue that such placement may not do justice to phenomenology, which, in its most critical manifestations, is an ally of hermeneutic communism. As a matter of fact, phenomenology holds the potential for mediating between the various opposed camps—description and *interpretation*, realism and anti-realism, the strong and the weak, metaphysics and post-metaphysics—that Vattimo and Zabala keep apart. Phenomenology oversteps its metaphysical confines, inasmuch as it is interested in the problem of givenness, in all its finitude; it's crucial question is how the world appears to an embodied, emplaced, mortal and fallible subject. The philosophy of Husserl offers a non-positivist version of *description*, compatible with interpretation; reduces or brackets extraneous impositions on experience; operates with a pre-prepositional notion of truth; and interferes with the scientific justification of political metaphysical domination. In conclusion, phenomenology stands in a somewhat unexpected proximity to hermeneutic communism.

Critique of phenomenology amounts to a tiny piece of the puzzle that is Gianni Vattimo and Santiago Zabala's thought-provoking *Hermeneutic Communism: From Heidegger to Marx*.¹ According to the spot allocated to it, phenomenology fits in with the other manifestations of classical metaphysics, bent on preserving the transcendental privilege of immutable truth. In what follows, I will argue that such placement may not do justice to phenomenology, which, in its most critical

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¹Gianni Vattimo and Santiago Zabala, *Hermeneutic Communism: From Heidegger to Marx* (New York: Columbia University Press, 2011). Hereafter cited as 'HC' within the text.

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manifestations, is an ally of hermeneutic communism. This particular piece of the puzzle belongs on the other side of the intellectual and historical barricades, and, more importantly, holds the potential for mediating between the various opposed camps—description and interpretation, realism and anti-realism, the strong and the weak, metaphysics and postmetaphysics—that Vattimo and Zabala keep apart.

To appreciate the unique position of phenomenology, let us take one of the original terms, with which *Hermeneutic Communism* operates, namely “framed democracy.”² An ingenious turn of phrase, “framed democracy” has a double sense. First, it means “democracy *enframed*,” restricted within a set of limiting parameters of parliamentary liberalism and militant capitalism wherein its procedures largely devoid of substance are allowed to unfold. Presented as the only legitimate political regime in existence today, it is a paradigm that claims for itself the universality of law and order, while viewing everything that falls outside its confines as chaotic, anarchic, and fraught with violence. Second, “framed democracy” implies the *fram- ing* of those who subscribe to its logic, a situation where the oppressed are duped into believing that its system works in circuitous ways also to their advantage. It reveals a thoroughly ideological construction of the paradigm that highjacks the place of political universality. The beauty of the expression is that the two meanings are actually inseparable one from the other: the parameters of contemporary liberal democracies are set up in such as way as to frame their subjects.

Throughout their book, Vattimo and Zabala insist on the rigidity of the frame that separates not only different accounts of truth but also opposing sets of interests, histories, and classes. Clearly, they redraw these active front lines, so as to demonstrate the limitations of framed democracy that, in its most delusional moments, has pictured itself as wholly unframed, trans-historical, objective, and universally applicable. “It should not be a surprise,” they write, “that democracy and science have become indissoluble. And it is this indissolubility that situates framed democracy outside history, where its ideal of objectivity can finally be fulfilled” (HC 39). Still, even in their account, the frame acts more as a membrane; it is porous, and, thanks to this porousness, it is able to draw on what lies outside it, just as it can expel what was previously captured within its confines. If, for instance, “the weak are the discharge of capitalism” (HC 7), then there must be a way for them to be ejected outside the system of framed democracy and, whenever necessary, to be reincorporated and exploited from within this system once again. Echoing the “industrial reserve army” in Karl Marx’s *Capital*,³ these discharges provide the much-needed flexibility to the political economic system during the alternating periods of growth and contraction that depend on the periodic crises of capital.

On the epistemological plane, too, the paradigmatic frame is more of a porous membrane, creating the lines of communication between the two sides it separates. As Jacques Derrida convincingly showed in *The Truth in Painting*, frames, in their materiality, are not one-dimensional, inasmuch as they have a width and thickness

²Cf. Part I of *Hermeneutic Communism*.

³Karl Marx, *Capital: A Critique of Political Economy*, Volume 1, trans. by Ben Fowkes (London & New York: Penguin, 1992), pp. 781ff.

of their own, outer and inner edges, elaborate or austere parergonal elements, and so forth.⁴ Following Vattimo and Zabala's account, framed democracies thrive on the imposed descriptions of what they consider to be true and relegate flexible interpretations to the hither side of the frame. But what if, instead of scrutinizing the inside and the outside—the staple categories of metaphysics *proper*—we focused on the frame itself? What does it consist of? What is interjected between presumably objective descriptions and free interpretations?

I submit that this place in-between is occupied by the *appearing* (not the *appearance*) prior to its transformation into materials for either description or interpretation. Phenomenology is concerned, precisely, with the appearing in the *how* of its appearance, that is to say, with the modes of givenness of phenomena. It thus deals with the infrastructure common to descriptions and interpretations, which is why it could influence both John Searl and Martin Heidegger or Hans-Georg Gadamer. Phenomenology oversteps its metaphysical confines, inasmuch as it is interested in the problem of givenness, in all its finitude; its crucial question is how the world appears to an embodied, emplaced, mortal and fallible subject. Already in the thought of Edmund Husserl, phenomenological investigations of givenness are intensely perspectival. His term for perspectivism is “givenness through adumbrations,” or being faced with a seemingly inexhaustible array of physical dimensions of the appearing object. Least of all does phenomenology impose a prefabricated mold of objectivity onto ontology. Far from it, phenomenological practice liberates our not yet formalized life-world from the projections of the scientific and natural attitude (“common sense”) that suffocate the very thing they are meant to express.

Let us take up the distinguishing features of phenomenology, which finds itself under siege in *Hermeneutic Communism*, one by one, paying close attention to the way they, in fact, shore up Vattimo and Zabala's project. Having slotted this piece of the puzzle into its proper place, we will observe how a certain critical spirit of phenomenology resonates with the spectrality of communism, on the one hand, and with the weakness of hermeneutics, on the other. It is my hope that the effects of their multiple resonances would enrich hermeneutic communism, create new alliances with its supposed adversaries, and, especially, defend it against the charges of a dualist or dichotomous world-view reminiscent of classical metaphysics.

Quite rightly, the authors accuse the self-proclaimed objectivity of metaphysical and scientific descriptions of serving as support mechanisms for the worst excesses of the political status quo: “A politics of descriptions does not impose power in order to dominate as a philosophy; rather, it is functional for the continued existence of a society of dominion, which pursues truth in the form of imposition (violence), conservation (realism), and triumph (history)” (HC 12). Although the word *description* is embraced by phenomenological philosophy, it has nothing whatsoever to do with the violent, realist, and triumphalist pretense of objectivity, associated with its scientific-metaphysical form. Phenomenological descriptions are the positive results of a meticulous work of reduction, which is tasked with stripping away layer after

⁴Jacques Derrida, *The Truth in Painting*, trans. by Geoffrey Bennington & Ian McLeod (Chicago: The University of Chicago Press, 1987). Cf., especially, the section on the “parergon.”

layer of unexamined presuppositions projected onto what is. In other words, they are not imposed but derived from the ever-shifting relation between the subject and the object of knowledge. Nor are they realist (Husserl has always insisted that his thought was suspended between realism and idealism), in that they are the description of givenness in its infinite manifestations, not of reality itself. And they are not triumphalist, since the work of reduction must recommence every time anew, preventing rigorous descriptions from ossifying into new metaphysical dogmas and commonsensical propositions.

We might say that the political case-in-point of phenomenological description is E.P. Thompson's 1963 book *The Making of the English Working Class*. A courageous "history from below," it is an attempt to rescue from the oblivion of the winners' history "the poor stockinger, the Luddite cropper, the 'obsolete' hand-loom weaver, the 'utopian' artisan, and even the deluded follower of Joanna Southcott."⁵ In describing these characters' life-worlds, Thompson sets aside the general methodological assumptions of traditional historiography and hence, like Husserl, produces descriptions that are avowedly interpretative and that educe their legitimacy from the fabric of existence, not from an alien ideality.

The role of reduction in phenomenology should not go unremarked, especially because it is allergic to the impositions of truth and to the effects of framing Vattimo and Zabala likewise resist. The goal of reduction is to unhinge the frames that surround the given in its givenness, to reject all sorts of "bonuses" (idealizations, immediate associations, preconceived images) surreptitiously superadded to the given, and to receive what is given within the limits of its givenness. In doing so, phenomenological reduction estranges what seemed to be intimately familiar and sheds light on the being-frame of the frame, its structuring determination of our cognition and perception as well as of the strata that accrete over and suffocate our cognitive-perceptual capacities.

The ideology critique, inherent in Vattimo and Zabala's interpretation of liberalism, is analogous to the workings of reduction. Hermeneutic communism is to the frames of the liberal state what reduction is to the frames of metaphysical and natural attitudes. Both streams of theoretical practice expose the dead and deadening character of what they reduce. The natural attitude presents the world to us in such a way that the presentation blocks from view what appears in the minutiae of its appearing. Liberal democracy occludes the viability of local alternatives to its impositions, so that "the presence of this democratic frame means not only the imposition of our systems but also the exclusion of the invaded state's cultural and political systems" (HC 57). While all framing inevitably reveals the enframed at the price of concealing something else, liberal and metaphysical violence inflicted on the given denies the most vital (existential) possibilities, relegated to the realm outside its frame.

The interplay of revealing and concealing in the movement of disclosure will be readily recognized as the hallmark of Heidegger's truth as *aletheia*. Vattimo and Zabala acknowledge their debt to the German philosopher when it comes to this

⁵E. P. Thompson, *The Making of the English Working Class* (New York: Vintage, 1966), 12.

notion of truth (HC 22), as well as to his idea of being-framed, *Ge-Stell* (HC 145). At the same time, they deem Husserl's definition to truth one of the "most successful... within contemporary analytic and continental philosophy" (HC 19). Success, of course, is the effect of the winner's history and way of thinking, to which Husserlian phenomenology is said to adhere. The authors of *Hermeneutic Communism* contend that Husserl advances a metaphysical definition of truth, which

depends on the difference between the mere 'intention' of the phenomenological Being and the matter 'itself'—in other words, between the manner in which something appears and the manner in which it is 'itself'...[T]hat is, a proposition would be true only if it 'refers' to things in a way that permits them to be seen as they are in themselves (HC 20).

Unlike Kantian transcendental philosophy, Husserl's phenomenology, however, does not postulate the existence of things-in-themselves, somehow distinct from phenomenal appearances. The methodological slogan "Back to the things themselves!" merely signals the aim of phenomenological reduction and description to re-experience the life-world without the impositions of the metaphysical and natural attitudes. Husserl was preoccupied, above all, not with truth claims, condensed in formal propositions, but with the truth of experience, the necessarily imperfect fit between the emptily intended (or the signified) object and the fulfillment of intentionality in intuition. This meant examining every discrete experience on its own terms, with its own specificities, modes of givenness, and ways of appearing. It required, moreover, going back both to the experiencing subject and to the experienced as it was experienced. After the reduction of what was transcendent vis-à-vis pure consciousness in *Ideas I*, no "matter 'itself'" remained⁶; rather, it was bracketed and set aside, along with everything that fell outside this newly discovered field for phenomenological operations. The idea of a disembodied, objective, God-like point of view is, actually, the first to be submitted to the knife of reduction, which recognizes in it a groundless imposition on experience.

Looking up to Descartes, Husserl resorts to the *Ur*-gesture of radical philosophizing, which consists in brushing away all unexamined presuppositions and truth claims and winning a new ground for thinking. Now, this ground is not won once and for all; reduction is an infinite task that must recommence as soon as experience gets buried under the sediments of concepts, theories, assumptions, and representations that grow over it. That is why Husserl is so skeptical with regard to the scientific method and rationality, which, as Vattimo and Zabala concede, he "declared to be in crisis" (HC 13). Given his critique of the European sciences, Husserl refuses either to strengthen their stranglehold on existence or to contribute to their justification of political domination. His project of liberating the life-world from the yoke of scientific rationality is of one piece with the hermeneutic communist demand to let multiple and dispersed existences interpret themselves, revitalizing the active sense of existence as interpretation (HC 87ff). A return to the life-world opens the same

⁶Edmund Husserl, *Ideas Pertaining to a Pure Phenomenology and to a Phenomenological Philosophy*, First Book, trans. by F. Kersten (Dordrecht, Boston & London: Kluwer Academic Publishers, 1983), esp. §33: "Preliminary Indication of 'Pure' or 'Transcendental' Consciousness as the Phenomenological Residuum," pp. 63–6.

“horizon of emancipation” as hermeneutic communism (HC 93), delving beneath the death masks of facts to the facticity of existence in its infinite variations that do not fit on the Procrustean bed of the sciences.

To sum up, phenomenology offers a non-positivist version of description, compatible with interpretation; reduces or brackets extraneous impositions on experience; operates with a pre-prepositional notion of truth; and interferes with the scientific justification of political metaphysical domination. But exactly what is political phenomenology? And what can it contribute to the endeavors of hermeneutic communism?

A history of the political “applications” of phenomenology runs parallel to that of the political “applications” of hermeneutics: despite their critical, emancipatory, and anarchic potential, both have been used to promote conservative programs and worldviews. What I refer to under the title *political phenomenology* has to do with (1) the givenness of political phenomena, (2) the modes of appearance of political actors on the institutional and the informal stages, and (3) the re-activation of political energy, suffocated by the empty proceduralism of the established systems of domination. All three characteristics mentioned above are also crucial to hermeneutic communism, which advances a critique of how political possibilities are precluded, withheld, and decidedly not-given by the status quo (framed democracy); envisions, through the example of the South American Left, the appearance of previously excluded, marginalized, or “discharged” weak actors on the national, regional, and international scenes; and calls for the exercise of active interpretation, coextensive with existential dispersion, as a way to re-energize an equally dispersed, anarchic politics. Having said that, in the title of the present analysis, I qualify hermeneutic communism as a *weak* political phenomenology. A few words are, therefore, in order on the sense of this weakness or of this weakening.

The minimal and chronologically first meaning of weak thought denotes, according to Vattimo and Zabala, “the abandonment of pretensions to absolutes that had characterized the metaphysical traditions” (HC 96). Proceeding along the path of the reductions, Husserlian phenomenology, too, did not spare the idols of absoluteness, including reality “in itself,” scientific rationality, and God. But it did insist on describing the being of pure consciousness, which remained after the operations of reduction were complete, as absolute. Henceforth, in Husserl’s vernacular, *absolute* will acquire a very specific signification of *absolutely irreducible*. While it may be argued that, with this notion, the old chimeras of metaphysics re-enter thinking through the backdoor, there are also traces of such irreducibility in other postmetaphysical philosophies, influenced by the founder of phenomenology. For Heidegger, absolute irreducibility will have stood for the temporality of *Dasein*. Emmanuel Levinas considers the alterity of the other irreducible. And, in Derrida’s corpus this idea assumes the shape of the un-deconstructable. In any event, the negative version of absoluteness is consistent with the tenets of weak thought that absorbs into itself the *remains* of the absolute (in Zabala’s terms, “the remains of Being”⁷) and that,

⁷Santiago Zabala, *The Remains of Being: Hermeneutic Ontology After Metaphysics* (New York: Columbia University Press, 2009).

subsequently, produces a positive interpretation of the weakening inherent in the metaphysical tradition itself.

In Husserl's phenomenological universe, absolute consciousness has a constituting function: it is the ground, on which experience as such and the world will be reconstructed in the aftermath of reduction. The political equivalent of this function is sovereignty, or the right to decide upon and constitute the political sphere, to give it a determinate shape. This is where we must insist on the weakening of political phenomenology (as much as of political metaphysics), in keeping with the argumentative thrust of *Hermeneutic Communism*. Although Vattimo and Zabala do not openly engage with the concept of sovereignty, they gesture toward its breaking-up into sovereignties (in the plural) that invalidate the assumption of a unitary and preponderant will of the sovereign. Consistent with the current theories of popular self-determination, this multiplication is possible thanks to the grounding of hermeneutic communism in existence, which cannot be gathered into a totality without losing its existential character. If the right to interpretation is coeval with the right to existence, then the active exercise of both rights by all those who have been dispossessed due to the global system of domination is tantamount to the egalitarian distribution of sovereignty that shatters its unified core. "Politics without truth" as much as "anarchic interpretation" (HC 98-9) are the corollaries to a politics without sovereignty, though not without sovereignties.

As the book's subtitle indicates, *Hermeneutic Communism* is entrusted with an ambitious task of charting backwards an intellectual itinerary that leads from Heidegger to Marx, that is to say, from existence to justice. "*If Marx emphasized the significance of keeping our feet anchored to the earth,*" Vattimo and Zabala write, "*it is Heidegger who indicated through the thought of Being how such earth is constantly moving and changing, constantly in conflict*" (HC 5). Husserl's phenomenology combines these divergent relations to the earth, much in the same way hermeneutic communism wishes to do. Phenomenology appeals to the concreteness of the earth as the ground from which our abstractions are born and to which they are bound to return if they are to retain their meaningfulness. But it also recasts the grounds of experience through reduction, by depriving us of the conceptual ground we thought secure and by rooting thinking itself in the life-world, in existence, and, ultimately, in something self-grounded, ungrounded, and groundless, i.e., Being itself. Hence, the hypothesis of my brief intervention: the road leading from Heidegger back to Marx must traverse the philosophy of Husserl, which stands in a somewhat unexpected proximity to hermeneutic communism.

Response to Marder

Gianni Vattimo and Santiago Zabala

Michael Marder is a continental philosopher specializing in phenomenology. He is the author of several books on Derrida, Schmitt, and together with Jeffrey T. Nealon, works at the frontline of so called “plant studies.” A few years ago we wrote a foreword for his first book on plants as it entered within the field of research of weak thought. “Weak thought”¹ has now marked its 35th anniversary since the publication of Gianni and Pier Aldo Rovatti’s edited collection *Weak Thought*² (with contributions from Umberto Eco, Gianni Carchia, among others), and it has been almost 40 years since Gianni first used the concept in his essay “Towards an Ontology of Decline.”³ During all these decades, weak thought has not only confronted other philosophical stances, such as as neo-pragmatism and deconstruction, but also help the weak emerge as in the case of plants studies.

If weak thought has always been attentive to everything which is weak, from oppressed groups, to animals and plants, it is not simply because they are discharged at the margins of framed democracies, but also because they belong to the weak.

¹A historical introduction to Weak Thought is available in “Introduction” in *Weakening Philosophy*, ed. S. Zabala (Montreal: McGill-Queen’s University Press, 2006). A updated account of “Weak Thought” can be found in the Special Issue of *Philosophy Today* (Volume 60, Issue 3, 2016) edited by Robert T. Valgenti and in the Dossier on *The Los Angeles Review of Books*, November 10th 2016, edited by S. Zabala with contributions from W. Egginton, K. Kolozova, R. T. Valgenti, and N. Vahanian. <https://lareviewofbooks.org/feature/weakening-philosophy-forum-gianni-vattimo/>

²Gianni Vattimo and Pier Aldo Rovatti (eds), *Weak Thought*, 1983. trans. Peter Carravetta (New York: SUNY, 2013).

³G. Vattimo, “Toward an Ontology of Decline Recoding Metaphysics.” 1979. Trans. B. Spackman. In *Recoding Metaphysics: The New Italian Philosophy*. Edited by G. Borradori. Evanston: Northwestern University Press 1988.

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Weak thought, as we said, is the “thought of the weak.” The weak are always striving for interpretation, that is, they are always striving to resist Being’s annihilation. This resistance is particularly evident in plants, which seem to be almost invisible, even to many environmentalists. Although contemporary societies are finally becoming ecologically aware and conscious of the vital significance of plants, it is important to continue to study them not only scientifically, but also politically and philosophically. After all, in *Hermeneutic Communism* we praise Correa’s Ecuador for being one of the first countries in the world to reform their constitution in order to make space for nature and earth rights. While Marder praises our political stance, he is uncertain hermeneutics is the right philosophy to sustain its goals. This is probably why his contribution focuses on defending phenomenology, given its Heideggerian rejection in our book.

According to Marder, our treatment of phenomenology does not do justice to Husserl’s method of phenomenological reduction, which “sheds light on the being-frame of the frame, its structuring determination of our cognition and perception as well as of the strata that accrete over and suffocate our cognitive-perceptual capacities.” Along with other Heideggerian philosophers, we are said to have underestimated phenomenology’s “non-positivist version of description” and its political significance. But what does “political phenomenology” refer to?

If “*Hermeneutic Communism*” is a “‘weak’ political phenomenology” for Marder, it’s because they both aim “to re-experience the life-world without the impositions of the metaphysical and natural attitudes.” As much as we agree with the similarities between phenomenology and hermeneutics that he points out in his excellent contribution, we still believe the former is not sufficiently politically oriented to engender political change. This cannot simply be attributed to a socio-political condition of the phenomenologist, as many of them were politically persecuted and therefore active, but rather to their insistence on a return to “the things themselves.” Hermeneutics, on the contrary, departs from “things in themselves” towards interpretations, that is, different horizons. Marder in part recognizes this when he points out how Husserlian phenomenology always insisted “on describing the being of pure consciousness, which remained after the operations of reduction were complete, as absolute.”

This absolute does not allow us to project philosophically a different future or political realm in the way that Heidegger’s “Dasein” or Santiago’s “remains” does. These concepts do not involve absolutes, as Marder claims, but rather historical Beings which have always to decide how they want to or can be. The possibility these hermeneutic ideas disclose involves philosophy at an existential level, where descriptions are substituted for interpretations. While we agree the “road leading from Heidegger back to Marx must traverse the philosophy of Husserl,” it should not be interpreted as a bridge, but rather as a violent and metaphysical bump on the road.

Tools for Subversion: Illich and Žižek on Changing the World

Babette Babich

Abstract Reviewing the work of Ivan Illich, Robert Kurz and Stanley Aronowitz together with Heidegger's technically economic articulation of standing reserve correspondent to challenging forth (the world, ourselves, animals, plants, whatever), this essay takes up "the thought of the weak in search of alternatives" as Gianni Vattimo and Santiago Zabala argue for the possibility of interpretive transformation. In addition to Slavoj Žižek's analysis of the resistance to revolution that functions as corollary to the existential stress of the dislocated mind, this reflection includes a discussion of media and illusion in the digital realm of Baudrillard's 'integral reality.

To take the part of the weaker party in any community, society, exchange presupposes a hermeneutic. This hermeneutic is an interpretation of the world as those without power have access (or, more accurately said, do not have access) to the world: an interpretation of the vulnerable, of weakness, other than as defined from the position of those in power. But as Machiavelli as well as Hegel and Nietzsche remind us, those in power, from media to the arts to industry and government, any privilege at all, are constitutionally incapable of seeing anything apart from their own interests or perspectives—what Nietzsche called convictions and Gadamer called prejudices.

One can only stand up on behalf of others if one does more than merely *advocate* on their behalf. Advocacy, solidarity, organized intervention, all turn out to permit the continuation of exploitation, i.e., business as usual. For and like advocacy, intervention is its own reward—as Ivan Illich, the Vienna-born priest and scholar, spent a lifetime reminding us,¹ this marvelously profitable truth of enterprise is that to

¹ See for a discussion of this phenomenon and Illich's battle against it, Chase Madar's retrospective account of Ivan Illich's attempts in 1968, speaking to the Conference on Interamerican Student Projects, to dissuade the deprecations of the colonialism of good intentions, Chase Madar's article: "The People's Priest," *The American Conservative*, February 1 (2010). Idealist imperialism lacks nuance and every one of Illich's diatribes assume a complex array of such nuances from his *Deschooling Society* (London: Marion Boyars Publishers Ltd., 2000) to his *H20 and the Waters of*

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which humanitarian institutions owe their very corporate existence. One earns a respectable living by means of a career dedicated to rendering such “services,” as Illich observed on site in the course of his life. Thus Illich’s blunter point corresponds to a meditation on what is needed beyond speaking up for or even intervening on the part of others. When the gospel tells us that a righteous life is encapsulated in an impossible conjunction for the rich—sell all you have and come follow me—this is way too much, and this is how Illich lived his life.

Advocacy, a life dedicated to public service, public philosophizing, the life of the humanitarian, corresponds to what Martin Heidegger criticized in his *Being and Time* as ‘leaping in for’ the other.² In spite of professional philosophy’s dedication to the common conviction that Heidegger had neither an ethics nor a political theory but just a reprobate politics, a claim compounded via his association with Nietzsche’s “nihilism”—and almost everyone, even the otherwise perceptive Stanley Aronowitz argues this—it is Heidegger who reminds us of the ethical virtue of allowing—permitting—supporting the other’s realization of his or her ownmost potentiality, by way of a freeing for such possibilities (only this liberation is letting be). Heidegger’s comprehension of this solicitude is a Schopenhauerian radicalization of Kant’s practical philosophy beyond the *neminem laede* [cause or make no one to suffer] that Schopenhauer is famous for. This exigence is the complicated compound that makes a maxim moral: “*imo omnes, quantum potes, juva*” [much rather help everyone as much as you can].³ Thus, attention and forethought and consequentiality is presupposed for the sake of the other: one “does not so much leap in for the other as *leap ahead* of him.”⁴ By way of an essentially *reticent* regard for the other (in all the ways Illich likewise if differently emphasizes), such solicitude frees “the Other in his freedom for himself.”⁵ This same untimely tone echoes in Nietzsche’s own reflections on *Schopenhauer as Educator* corresponding to Heidegger’s reflections on what is required to come to know oneself [*Sichkennenlernen*].

Coming to oneself in this way for the sake of one’s own freedom and freeing others for their own liberty are the traditional goals of education. And the juxtaposition of the interpretive project with praxis is the reason Karl Marx’s dictum “*Die Philosophen haben die Welt nur verschieden interpretiert, es kommt aber darauf an, sie zu verändern*” would, in 1953, be inscribed on the walls of the Humboldt University in Berlin during the era of the DDR.

Forgetfulness: Reflections on the Historicity of Stuff (Dallas: Dallas Institute of Humanities & Culture, 1985).

² Here Heidegger’s contention is that such leaping in tends to “take way care from the Other and put itself in his position.” Martin Heidegger, *Being and Time*, trans John Macquarrie and Edward Robinson (New York: Harper & Row, 1962), 1.4, §26, p. 158 [SZ 122].

³ Arthur Schopenhauer, *On the Basis of Morality*, trans. E. F. J. Payne (Providence: Berghahn Books, 1995), p. 144. I discuss Schopenhauer together with Illich in Babich, “Education and Exemplars: Learning to Doubt the Overman,” in: Paul Fairfield, ed., *Education, Dialogue and Hermeneutics* (London: Continuum, 2011), pp. 125–149.

⁴ Heidegger, *Being and Time*, pp. 158–159.

⁵ Ibid., p. 159, [SZ 122]. See, for a discussion, Babich, “Solicitude: Heideggerian Care and Assistance” in: Paul Fairfield, ed., *Relational Hermeneutics: Essays in Comparative Philosophy* (London: Bloomsbury, 2018), forthcoming.

That it was not removed in 1991 is fortuitous—it might well have been—and Gianni Vattimo and Santiago Zabala use this formula to frame their book, *Hermeneutic Communism*.⁶ For Marx, beyond “interpreting the world,” what is essential is to change the world. The hermeneutic key remains just where Marx emphasizes in the second not-as-famous sentence as Vattimo and Zabala include this in their epigraph: “changing the world in the manner intended requires beforehand that thinking be changed...”⁷

Here with respect to Vattimo’s signal contribution to hermeneutics—namely ‘weak thought,’ *il pensiero debole*, “the full ‘*debolezza*,’ weakness” that “straight” thinking compels us to admit⁸—we read that the “weak thought of hermeneutics becomes the thought of the weak in search of alternatives.”⁹ If Vattimo and Zabala offer a sober analysis of who counts as the “weak” in the first half of their book, “Framed Democracy,” pointing in particular to the “urban poor,” it is in this connection that Illich remains exemplary.¹⁰ Like Dorothy Day—and professional idealists (i.e., humanitarians) are always embarrassed by such examples—Illich himself lived his life to the letter (and to the spirit of what Illich called “conspiracy”—*con-spiratio*) well beyond anything most clerics and certainly most academics preach.¹¹ Yet the hermeneutic difficulty with Illich is the challenge of reading him. If reading Nietzsche, reading Marx, or Heidegger, includes the differently various challenges of grasping the range of their thinking, reading Illich includes an interpretive contextualization of his lived life-practice, not only serving the poor but challenging scholarship and public conceptions of education and health care ordered as both are ordered to the benefit of industry, and thus to the tradition of the heart. For Illich, this tradition was not a matter of interiority alone but works: ‘to change the world’ as Marx put it and for Illich (and for Marx) that means a life lived for others. In this way, in his way, Illich challenged sacred cows. And it is precisely for the sake of such challenges that we need hermeneutics: contra the dictates of analytic philosophy which only inscribes what it calls realist thinking (or what it calls ‘critical thinking’) as this corresponds to the received theory of whatever ruling class there happens to be, whether in society or the academy, which always reduces to the terms of conventionally institutionalized science. This will be by fiat, as the late Tzvetan Todorov has

⁶ Gianni Vattimo and Santiago Zabala, *Hermeneutic Communism: From Heidegger to Marx* (New York: Columbia University Press, 2012).

⁷ Karl Marx, epigraph to the Introduction to Vattimo and Zabala, *Hermeneutic Communism*, p. 1.

⁸ Charles Taylor, “Modern Moral Rationalism,” in Zabala, ed., *Weakening Philosophy* (Montreal: McGill University Press, 2007), p. 75; cited here from Vattimo and Zabala, *Hermeneutic Communism*, p. 97.

⁹ Vattimo and Zabala, *Hermeneutic Communism*, p. 2.

¹⁰ This ‘*exemplum vitae*,’ as Herwig Wolfram wrote as encomium to Illich’s own teacher, as Illich praised Gerhardt Ladner for his own part, is key. See: Wolfram, “Gerhart B. Ladner (3 December 1905–21 September 1993),” *Proceedings of the American Philosophical Society*, Vol. 139, No. 4 (Dec., 1995): 440–442.

¹¹ See for a discussion of some of the complex issues that have led to this neglect, Babich, “Spirit and Grace, Letters and Voice or Performance Practice and Alchemy in Alan Rickman and Nietzsche,” *Journal of the Philosophy of Education*, Vol 3, 2018, Forthcoming.

observed, of the totalizing scientism of what is said to be modern rationality, that is: all the ‘truth’ you need. Zabala and Vattimo read the same compact in the other direction, as they analyse the uncanny political collusion inscribed into analytic philosophy between George Bush and John Searle, as a “winner’s history” that also happens to haunt the infamous denunciation of Jacques Derrida—and every related kind of continental philosophy—on the part of Barry Smith and friends whose prejudices led them to condemn the lifework of a colleague in order to judge and so to dismiss Derrida’s writing as “either trivial or false.”¹² The “winner’s history” in philosophy is analytic philosophy which seeks, as Vattimo and Zabala argue that Searle seeks, to dissolve “philosophy into the sciences,” discarding “everything that does not submit to the Western rationalistic tradition, including different philosophies.”¹³ This includes philosophies expressed in other languages and as Vattimo and Zabala quote Derrida, the “imperialistic approach” of analytic philosophy ensures—and this success is now almost utterly complete in Europe as it has been in Anglophone countries for decades—that “no literary work, no philosophical work can receive worldwide legitimation without crossing the [United] States, without first being legitimized in the states.”¹⁴ It is not tradition that gives the US this power in the academy but the “winner’s history,” a glamour maintained in spite of its ongoing bankruptcy.

Like Vattimo and Zabala, Illich challenges our faith in what we call democracy. In addition, and like his hermeneutic critique of the realist rationalism characterizing, mainstream or institutional philosophy, Illich also challenges our faith not in the churches, as if we believed in these, but where our faith is found today: in science and modern medicine but and *especially* in times of economic stress, our faith in education.¹⁵ Arguably, Illich’s most subversive claim would be his argument that education instructs its subjects in the rules of acquisitiveness and the value of the objects of the same.

Although Illich’s critics protest, it is not as if anyone really disagrees. To the contrary: we take just this successful acquisition to be culture and our students ask only how they might obtain such an *efficacious* education. It is only the failure of education to deliver such acquisitive efficacy that concerns us.

More and more, students the world over look upon the university as a means to an end, to getting a job and students believe this all the more as they advance along the academic ladder. Universities are themselves complicit and undergraduate education is ‘marketed’ not as a ‘liberal’ pursuit (*pace* Michael Oakeshott and Cardinal Newman and, before the medieval institution of the university, *pace* Plato and Aristotle) but, just as Illich argued, access to a ‘job,’ which access in turn yields the very same material goods of a material culture that for Illich is increasingly inscribed as the real subtext of school. In a different voice, with all the sobriety of a social

¹² Vattimo and Zabala, *Hermeneutic Communism*, p. 36.

¹³ *Ibid.*, p. 37.

¹⁴ *Ibid.*, pp. 35–36.

¹⁵ I refer here to Illich’s *De-Schooling Society*, not (as it was misunderstood) as a brief against learning but against the institution and to the extent that most schooling is a sham and pretended education, as both Nietzsche and Kant (albeit in the good Lutheran service of Caesar), in his *An Answer to the Question, What is Enlightenment?* have observed.

scientist, albeit without reference to *either* hermeneutics *or* Illich, Stanley Aronowitz points to similar issues concerning the profit-motives of university education and its proliferation of increasingly meaningless certificates not just in terms of relevance for a job, even at the university, but also now in practice, with all the contradictions capitalism ensures.¹⁶ “Hope,” as Aronowitz writes,

has become an entailment of ‘career,’ an invitation for some to make it, even in the midst of the joblessness that is now a chronic feature of a system no longer able to accommodate even its best and brightest, let alone the millions suffering drastic economic decline.¹⁷

In our day, the professionalization—that always means the cooption—of the scholar regarding what Max Weber once innocently called a vocation in his own polemic against the careerism that is the constant soul-disease among scholars—it is a disease that has been with us, so Plato tells us, so Marcus Aurelius tells us, for the lifetime of the written word—could not be more consummate.

And who today seeks a PhD for its own sake and not also and much more for the job prospects it is thought to afford (and increasingly argued to afford) by right?

If Illich can remind us that the university was once a place dedicated not to the care of the self, as Foucault has made it popular to speak of the self, but and rather of the soul in his study of study, *In the Vineyard of the Text*,¹⁸ it is also the case that the university has not been such for a long time as Nietzsche also reflected writing on Schopenhauer and in his earlier, rarely read, and very complicated dialogue *On the Future of Our Educational Institutions*. In our times, and apart from Illich, only Jacques Ellul and Günther Anders have been as consistent in their criticisms of this perniciously vapid circle.

The academy remains a business in service of capitalism.

And this is true in practice, with bells on and with an eager vengeance (digital humanities anyone, asks the young scholar who thereby insists upon a diligent uprooting of the old—who needs books?—and the installation of him- or herself in the place of the old guard). That the parenthetical point has always been the story of things is neither important nor particularly accurate. Let us hear Marx again: “Philosophers have only interpreted the world in various ways, what matters, however, is to change it.”

The importance of hermeneutics via Illich and Heidegger (and Nietzsche and thence to Kant and Schopenhauer) and here by way of Vattimo and Zabala, is its practical dimension, this is what can be world changing about it, that is, once articulated on behalf of the weaker portion of society, namely for those without power and hence without the influence to assert their own perspective contra the imposition of the views and the rule and because this is the only reason for rule, the domination

¹⁶ For one of the most timely—and insightful discussions available today—analyzing political economics in the global context but with specific sociological and historical reference to the US, see Stanley Aronowitz, both sociologically and historically, “The Winter of Our Discontent,” *Situations: Project of the Radical Imagination*, Vol. IV, No. II (2012): 37–76.

¹⁷ Aronowitz, “The Winter of Our Discontent,” pp. 67–68.

¹⁸ See Ivan Illich, *In the Vineyard of the Text* (Chicago: University of Chicago Press, 1993) for a range of references to (and in the very constellation of the footnotes which are the real reason for this text, as a commentary upon) a number of different editions of the *Didascalicon*.

(or oppression or exploitation) of others. This is the intriguingly clear inception for and point of Vattimo's and Zabala's *Hermeneutic Communism*. Here it matters to the letter that the hermeneutic approach is not the dominant approach—it is the heart of the kind of 'continental' philosophy that is refused by mainstream or analytic philosophy—nor does it have recourse to that same authority in the university.¹⁹

What hermeneutic philosophy does is to take the part of the other, making it one's own part all the while without forgetting the otherness of the other. Thus Gadamer argues that understanding is always understanding otherwise—that is, as we can say today, 'queered against'²⁰ or contra what one had taken oneself to understand, both in the past, and because this is the way prejudice works, in advance. The point of hermeneutics is to be open to just such otherness. Understanding, to be understanding, is always an understanding otherwise than the suppositions or prejudice that one begins by taking for granted. Between Heidegger's reading of Husserl, which was more of an indoctrination, and Heidegger's reading of Nietzsche, which was a liberation (though like his own teacher Schopenhauer, it always turns out that Nietzsche is more of liberator than most of us are able to bear), Heidegger's hermeneutic questioning is a not-already-knowing reflection on our own already-knowing, our prejudices, our natural attitudes, again: what Nietzsche called our "convictions." And such a reflection, if we follow it through—without clinging to our self-subscribed bondage, i.e., to the restraints that were for Kant the "guiding yoke [*Leitbände*] of the great unthinking masses"—corresponds to what Kant called enlightenment and what Nietzsche and Marx both called liberation.

The Eternal Return of Capitalism: The History of Illusion

Robert Kurz, the late Marxist and critical theorist of the left, was fond, as a Marxist political economist ought to be fond, of the image of eternal recurrence. For as Kurz pointed out, the thing about capitalism, again and again, is that nothing seems to faze it.²¹ In other words, the contradictions of capital are confirmed constantly and capitalism fails, again and again. And yet, and this is the eternal return that intrigued

¹⁹ I discuss this in some detail in an interview with students regarding publishing and—not incidentally—intellectual capital in Babich, "An Impoverishment of Philosophy." In: Dennis Erwin and Matt Story, eds., *Purlieu: Philosophy and the University* (2011): 37–71 and more generically in terms of the continental divide here: "On the Analytic-Continental Divide in Philosophy: Nietzsche's Lying Truth, Heidegger's Speaking Language, and Philosophy," in C. G. Prado, ed., *A House Divided: Comparing Analytic and Continental Philosophy* (Amherst, NY: Humanity Books, 2003), pp. 63–103. For a recent discussion, see "The Last of the Continental Philosophers," the first installment of a four- (and ultimately eight-) part dialogue initiated by the game designer and 'outside' philosopher, Chris Bateman, published online at the end of 2016 and the beginning of 2017 on Bateman's usually gaming themed blog: *Only a Game*: http://onlyagame.typepad.com/only_a_game/2016/11/babich-and-bateman-1.html

²⁰ I discuss this complex convention, popular at the moment as it draws for its metonymic capital on queer theory in Babich, *The Hallelujah Effect: Reflections on Music, Performance Practice and Technology* (London: Routledge, 2016 [2013]).

²¹ Robert Kurz, *Vie et mort du capitalisme* (Paris: by Editions Lignes, 2011). See too Kurz, „Kapital und Geschichte“ in *Neues Deutschland* on April, 24, 2009, p. 6.

Kurz, we always prop it up—as if we cannot bear even the idea that our most beloved economic system (we call capitalism ‘democratic’ as if this could be ‘true’ or as if this were the point of capitalism which is all about gaining economic advantage via the disenfranchisement of others) might be inherently defective. To avoid this suspicion we perpetuate it even in its refutation, throwing good tax (and that means public) funds after bad private losses, which of course (as commentators observe only to be instantly ignored) amounts to a transfer of common resources, funneling public wealth, into the hands of a few. What commentators do say that is repeated in the media (as if it were or could be ‘true’) is that these few—always described, in an irony that would not have surprised Marx, as ‘job creators’—may be expected to give back to the community in spades. When the same ‘jobs’ are not forthcoming, i.e., when wage slaves are denied the opportunity to be such (this is the meaning of joblessness), commentators argue that the problem is that *insufficient* public funds were made available for the purpose whereby, as the logic of imperialistic reason holds, the *only* solution is to transfer more public funds to private fortunes. And so we do.

It is in this same spirit of eternal survivability or recurrence, that Kurz reprises his own argument on the collapse of capitalism followed by the eternal return of the same, in his study of the ‘collapse of modernity’²²:

the word collapse is a provocative cliché, and is generally used in a pejorative sense, so that the representatives of radical crisis theory can discredit someone by implying that they should not be taken seriously. Not only the capitalist elites, but also the representatives of the left, prefer to believe that capitalism is capable of eternal self-renewal.²³

Like the ‘terminator’ of popular film culture, our governments do for capitalism what Hollywood’s culture industry has always done for the generic action hero, like Arnold Schwarzenegger (and in his post-gubernatorial phase he has never needed its ministrations more). Capitalism continues to rise from its ashes, so we are persuaded, not a little because of the bewitching power of its totalizing force, in spite of every disappointment of the same such as the world economic crises of 2006–2007–2008 (oh, pick a year as these are ongoing) together with a resolute exclusion of any and all alternatives. Once again: the *only* solution is to transfer more public funds to private fortunes. This permeates every level from the system of money—the *We must save the banks!* brigade—to technology.

Kurz was also consistent in his Marxism, and this is an important insight beyond the doubtless valid critiques that emerge from conspiracy theories, as he also denied the privileged class. Analysing the subject of the modern world, Kurz discerns—rather as one learns that a sexual offender was himself the victim in his turn of

²² See, for example, Kurz’s *Der Kollaps der Modernisierung* (Leipzig: Reclam, 1994 [1991]) as well as his *Schwarzbuch Kapitalismus. Ein Abgesang auf die Marktwirtschaft* (Eichborn: Ullstein Taschenbuch, 2009 [1990]) in which he makes the simple empirical observation that the impoverishment is the effect of the market economy: „Marktwirtschaft macht arm.“ See too his *Weltordnungskrieg: Das Ende der Souveränität und die Wandlungen des Imperialismus im Zeitalter der Globalisierung* (Berlin: Horlemann, 2003).

²³ Kurz in a 2009 interview with IHU online. <http://libcom.org/library/2009-interview-ihu-online-robert-kurz>.

abuse, in a ring that is a ring in a chain of similarly ringed abuses, in the unconscious mechanism of the eternal perpetuation of the same violence, as Foucault and Lacan and Sade argue that the erotic apparently cannot do without oppression and violation—that all those so-called capitalist rulers, the “winners,” are themselves only illusions. Like the masters in Fritz Lang’s *Metropolis*, they live in a fantasy world, inside the gilded cage, a world the workers in the iron grip of the Moloch below can only dream about. Kurz’s point, Marx’s point, is that both images are correspondent, i.e., reciprocal, phantoms.²⁴

What matters is the real—and that collapses or vaporizes constantly.

Slavoj Žižek is one of the few critics to be consistently honest in the face of contemporary academic critique. Thus Žižek in November of 2012 highlighted what should be seen as a political paradox, however one regards it, from any historico-economic perspective, left or right:

The primary political effect of the economic crisis was not the rise of the radical left, but of racist populism, more wars, more poverty in the poorest Third World countries, and widening divisions between rich and poor.²⁵

The problem for critical theorists from Habermas to Honneth and nearly everyone on the so-called left, is that they seem unable to overcome the legacy of Marxist materialism—when they are not (qua academics, and see the allusion to Illich above) in complete complicity with the liberal fantasy of popular media (whereby everyone fairly well agrees with whatever theme appears on the op-ed page of the *New York Times*, as if the Times itself were not an instrument of imperialist doctrine or else one concurs with whatever a given network television broadcaster says).²⁶ But like the not-too well-known Günther Anders²⁷ and to a lesser extent, like Adorno, Žižek manages to continue to speak truth, reminding us, as Vattimo and Zabala also do with their own reference to “framed democracy,” that democracy itself is a phantasm (with all the gleam and shine of the imaginary), emphasizing what Nietzsche would have called the ultimate issue, and going so far as to reflect as Žižek does, in an unattributed echo of the late Jean Baudrillard, that it almost

²⁴ See for a discussion, Babich, „Geworfenheit und prometheische Scham im Zeitalter der transhumanen Kybernetik Technik und Machenschaft bei Martin Heidegger, Fritz Lang und Günther Anders“ in: Christoph Streckhardt, ed., *Die Neugier des Glücklichen* (Weimar: Bauhaus Universitätsverlag, 2012), pp. 63–91.

²⁵ Slavoj Žižek, “Capitalism: How the Left Lost the Argument,” *Foreign Policy*, November 2012.

²⁶ This would include Charlie Rose, if I exclude Bill Moyers because he manages to be different, and because this is a gift of the spirit not the intellect (although intellectually, Moyers is shoulders above the stature of his otherwise stylistically elegant colleague).

²⁷ Günther Anders, a student of Husserl and Heidegger and Tillich, a friend to Gershom Scholem and the first husband of Hannah Arendt, as well as being a junior colleague and erstwhile student of Theodor W. Adorno was born in 1902 and died in 1992—a decade shy of my own teacher Gadamer’s length of life, 1900–2002. What was rare about Anders was the constellation of his interests in technology and politics and philosophy and activism, where the last sets him apart from others who shared his interest.

seems “as if this crisis were staged to demonstrate that the only solution to a failure of capitalism is more capitalism.”²⁸

If the problem for critical theory in its current instaurations is its utter lack of critique, what makes Adorno continually interesting is that unlike Habermas, he managed (and it is an achievement) to remain susceptible to Nietzsche’s persistent contagions and the range of his complexities. If Adorno is not a key interlocutor for Vattimo and Zabala, openness to Nietzsche is manifest throughout their text and this is indispensable as it is a prerequisite for the openness to any critique that would be able to be counted as such today. This hermeneutic critique of a Heideggerian and Nietzschean kind is a self-critical reflection. Thus Vattimo’s and Zabala’s *Hermeneutic Communism: From Heidegger to Marx* can be set together with Žižek’s remark that “Reading Heidegger against the grain, one discovers a thinker who was, at some points, strangely close to communism.”²⁹ Of course Žižek—but this is his strength—overstates the matter. At the same time—but this is Žižek’s trademark—he understates as well. One does not need to read Heidegger against the grain: Heidegger’s reflections in his *Letter on Humanism* but also the reflections that are key to the technology lectures he gives to the Club of Bremen, that is to German business leaders in the post-war period of German re-building and development, are patently communist (without using the term as such). Hence when Heidegger defines modern technology as a ‘challenging forth,’ he defines such challenging in *economic* terms, whereby it

is always itself directed from the beginning toward furthering something else, i.e., toward driving on to *the maximum yield at the minimum expense*. The coal that has been hauled out in some mining district has not been supplied in order that it may simply be present somewhere or other. *It is stockpiled*.³⁰

Nature becomes a stock of natural resources, as does the human being. If we miss the economic, “strangely close to communism” undertone of Heidegger’s writings on technology—and most readers do—we find ourselves reading a romantic reactionary. And that is far safer, but Heidegger makes it fairly clear that the human being is increasingly ordered as part of the same “standing-reserve.” As he says (and the sentence bears analysis) “The current talk about human resources, about the supply of patients for a clinic, gives evidence of this.”³¹ The issue here concerns the hermeneutic of human resources—resources for what? The “supply of patients for a clinic”? What determines the benefit? *The patients*—shades of the current US Healthcare plan which is designed to require citizens, rather than employers, to use their own personal resources to obtain various levels of insurance—or the *clinic*?

What finds different expression in Adorno and Horkheimer’s *Dialectic of Enlightenment* is also underscored in terms of industry where Heidegger explains the difference between what looks the same to our eyes, namely today’s forester in

²⁸ Žižek, “Capitalism.”

²⁹ See on this the preface to Žižek’s *Less Than Nothing*.

³⁰ Heidegger, *The Question Concerning Technology*, p. 15. My emphasis here.

³¹ *Ibid.*, p. 18

the service of forestry and the old-fashioned or traditional woodman. The difference for Heidegger is that today's forester is

commanded by profit-making in the lumber industry, whether he knows it or not. He is made subordinate to the orderability of cellulose, which for its part is challenged forth by the need for paper, which is then delivered to newspapers and illustrated magazines. The latter, in their turn, set public opinion to swallowing what is printed, so that a set configuration of opinion becomes available on demand.³²

We need Horkheimer and Adorno, as indeed Illich and Baudrillard to begin to unpack the connections Heidegger suggests here.

If I noted above that the problem for today's critical theory is its utter lack of critique, the problem of communist and Marxist theory tends to be its commitment to historical materialism. This commitment does not derive solely from the letter of the Marxist text and certain influential accounts of the same but it is the danger of automatic, rationalistic, systems-technological thinking that includes almost all leftists and that includes Marxists of an academic and that means Hegelian stripe, a striping that included Kurz as it also included (weakened in Vattimo's sense by Nietzsche) Adorno and Anders as well as Žižek. This danger remains abandoned to the materialist expectation of the ghost of Hegel that expects that the world spirit should turn its eyes, Lyncaeus like, so very utterly inward, that and of itself, the entire fabric of civilization reverses upon itself and comes out through one or another orifice as an already accomplished Marxian conversion.

The revolution is coming and change, like the second coming, in fact exactly like the second coming, comes about of itself, given sufficient consciousness, that is: faith.

If materialism is the problem, one needs a Nietzsche to come and tease Marxism about the sense in which it, too, is still pious—and here there is the Christological secret of Hegelianism—the rest of what is at stake stands, and falls, with the contradiction this entails for practice. If the most seductive theory of the market economy is Calvinistic to this day, predestination (this code is inscribed in the financial maxim: too big to fail), the expectation that the revolution will come, when it comes, this same quietism is the curse of Marxism, of itself, by itself. But every reading that looks to *both* Nietzsche *and* Marx shatters on the ground of Hegel.

In the same fashion, the weakness of the Marxist focus on science is that it remains uncritically scientific. Thus my friend, the late Paul Thomas, the Berkeley political theorist, took only part of this point as I tried to explain it to him regarding scientism in his recent study of Engels, nicely thanking me, as he did, while nevertheless proceeding to return, virtually immediately to the standard materialist account.³³

Intriguingly, the same automatism is ascribed to capital. Thus we might remember Kurz once again: Where Nietzsche's eternal return of the same, in an infinite permutation of energies in a closed system, is over-determined, eternally so, what intrigues Kurz is the notion of repetition as it differs in the real world and in our

³² Ibid.

³³ See for this study, more timely than ever, Paul Thomas, *Marxism and Scientific Socialism: From Engels to Althusser* (London: Routledge, 2008).

prejudices or convictions regarding what can and cannot be done in the world of political economics and that means in spite of any material determination as it would seem to be formed of smoke and mirrors, such that capitalism is again and again reborn out of its own ashes to use Kurz's metaphor.³⁴ Or at least out of the ashes of whatever remains for yet another bailout.

Advancing Kurtz's analysis of collapse and persistence in late capitalism and industrial society in our real world, post the late 1980s and early 1990s, and again, post the last years of the first decade of this new century, today, here and now, the Brazilian critical theorist, Fabio Akcelrud Durão, points out that for Kurz, "the potential for change, what is other, has to be sought inside the system of exchange."³⁵ Durão argues that just where a kind of conceptually bad faith, that is: irony, an *akrasia* of critique as it were, can be said to characterize the West, things are different in Western-cum-non-Western countries like his own:

Whereas in advanced capitalist countries, those inside the market have to try to pretend they are not, in Brazil, those outside it represent perfect capitalist subjectivities. Precisely because they suffer need in a society that fully eradicated pre-capitalist structures of life, they completely believe the promises made by that which they do not have. The expensive car *really* brings beautiful women; the cigarette *really* takes one to the old West. In the closed totality of central capitalist countries, "there is no place anymore outside the machinery, from which one may name the phantasmagoria" for "only on its own incoherence should the lever be set"³⁶

It may turn out that Illich is more helpful here. Durão argues that there is a possibility of revolution precisely to the extent that such subjects are able to demand "that commodities be equal to what they communicate about themselves," and that one has thereby nothing less than a "practice of immanent critique."³⁷

To explain this circumstance, Durão invokes Kurz's convention to describe the people of Brazil, as "monetary subjects without money" and Aronowitz makes a similar point paraphrasing A.J. Liebling, in the context of his own analysis of the ideological sediment embedded (this is also hermeneutics) in descriptions of "the contemporary capitalist system in terms of the 'free' market," reflecting—here comes the paraphrase—that "the market is [only] free for those who own one."³⁸ Yet Kurz's 'monetary subject without money' happens to describe most people in the United States: not only does the same fantasy laden, subjective deficit-inscription into capital correspond to the so-called 99% but it is the very reason for credit, which, perversely, means debt. The vast majority of homeowners in the United States do not 'own' their own homes, but the bank does. Indeed nothing better illustrates Kurz's observation that the market economy "makes" one "poor" than the

³⁴ Kurz, "Die Himmelfahrt des Geldes. Strukturelle Schranken der Kapitalverwertung, Kasinokapitalismus und globale Finanzkrise," *Krisis* 16/17 (1995): 21–76.

³⁵ Kurz, "Spät Kapitalismus oder Industriegesellschaft?," p. 369, cited in Fabio Akcelrud Durão, "Adorno in Brazil," *Revista Atenea*, pp. 9–24, p. 19.

³⁶ Durão, "Adorno in Brazil," *Revista Atenea*, pp. 18–19.

³⁷ Durão, "Adorno in Brazil," p. 19.

³⁸ Aronowitz, "The Winter of Our Discontent," p. 45.

housing bubble. Kurz's insight is all the more devastatingly true to the economy of "upside-down" houses as they are called, i.e., where the 'market value' of the house is worth less than the value of the same for the bank (that would be the mortgage and that entitled debt is immune to market changes) that means—talk about *making poor*—that whatever value remains to be paid on the mortgage, a future and secured and unchanging value to the bank, must always be calculated *in addition* to the already acquired and thus already very liquid asset of the down payment already taken by the bank to secure the same mortgage. What goes up in smoke, 'making one quite literally poor,' i.e., as if one had been robbed, is not simply the language game of devalued values, here that would be devalued house prices, but real cash savings, be it from wage income, or any other labor value all nicely congealed for the capitalist in fungible cash and traded in for nothing less than the human hope for life-security: for a place to live, and hence for a mortgage to be owed on a subsequently, all-too- conveniently for the bank, *devalued* house (the array of banker's schemes to take this as a loss boggles the mind, such are the arrays of double and triple book-keeping, including insurance payments and tax write-offs—N.B., not tax-credits, that's for the little people—on top of all the government bailouts) at interest rates that and in order to have been afforded as such, at the then time, often are tied to a future scheme such that they subsequently increase just as the house value decreases. It is a capitalist wet-dream, a scenario to warm a speculator's heart and it is the only game in town, because in America and across the globe, political reforms shore up the capitalist rather than the end-consumer or citizen.

And, speaking of banks, as Žižek asks in his (and the title should now begin to seem ironic), *Less than Nothing*

But why did we have to give billions of dollars to the banks in 2008 and 2009? Because, without a functioning banking system, the entire (capitalist) economy collapses. Banks should thus also count as privatized commons: insofar as private banks control the flow of investments and thus represent, for individual companies, the universal dimension of social capital, their profit is really a rent we pay for their role as universal mediator. This is why state or other forms of social control over banks and collective capital in general (like pension funds) are crucial in taking a first step towards the social control of commons.³⁹

Žižek is able, because of the theoretical and socio-cultural position he occupies to both frame the objection to his point and its counter in a nicely compound sentence of the kind those who cannot read English are fond of using as index of obscurity:

Apropos the reproach that such control is economically inefficient, we should recall not only those cases in which such control was very effective (this was, for example, how Malaysia avoided crisis in the late 1990s), but also the obvious fact that the 2008 financial crisis was triggered precisely by the failure of the banking system.⁴⁰

I think it is crucial to repeat Žižek's last point here just because this empirical detail manages not to be noted by economists left and right: "the 2008 financial crisis was triggered precisely by the failure of the banking system."⁴¹

³⁹ Žižek, *Less Than Nothing: Hegel and the Shadow of Dialectical Materialism* (London: Verso, 2012) p. 184.

⁴⁰ Ibid.

⁴¹ Ibid.

We are talking about a collective trauma.

A separate point has to do with the real dynamic of the eternal that is the eternal recurrence of the capitalist same-old, same-old as we saw that Kurz analyses this. In the words of (the then-critical theorist) Gerry Stahl, writing in 1975:

Social reform is objectively impossible under advanced capitalist society. The contradictions of capitalism do not make reformation easier, rather, they infect any attempts at change, distorting and strangling them.⁴²

The mechanism, the consolidation of power on the part not of the weaker but on the part of those with power, is unchanged. There is bribery in congress. We call it lobbying. There are stolen elections due to outright fraud and on all levels beginning with the presidency of the United States down to every municipality, and we regard such fraud as a technical problem about which (this is the political travesty of Gore vs. Bush, Sanders vs. Clinton) there is nothing to be done (where is Beckett in our times?). To be sure, the beauty of election fraud, like banking fraud in the digital age is that there is exactly no proof because there can be none—and increasingly the same digital malleability, one way or the other, in the future but especially with respect to the history, will be true at every level.

There are ways to burn books without fire.⁴³

We fight undeclared wars and now and increasingly by means of drones, engage in combat action at a distance, which we call surgical, and we are poised to include domestic targets, any targets, anywhere. The earth is raped in more thoroughgoing ways than ever before, whole species, not just rare ones but common species: whales, wolves, lions are vanishing everywhere, not in some future, but now: in our years, at this time. We take notice of *none* of this because, and this is Žižek's point in his recurrent reference to the Chinese joke, the curse of living in interesting times: the violent gap between rich and poor means that, increasingly, life as we know it changes—and who can pay attention to anything but the immediate? Send someone through airline security and have that person dismantle their belongings for security examination via machine and have that person disrobe, and in the US, but not elsewhere, you remove your shoes, and submit to the intimate inspection of your body, either via physical groping, or virtually by means of radiation that you are told is harmless despite the fact that such an assurance, to be likely, would have required testing over the last 15 or 20 years to accumulate data on its effects on human bodies. No one can *know* this but we are told that because there is no proof of harm, it is certainly safe. Who pays attention to anything? One is thankful that it is not worse and one is grateful if one manages to remember one's personal property because as public announcement intone, passengers routinely forget their iPads, iPhones, laptops—all the high-end signifiers of consumer desire.

⁴² Gerry Stahl, *Marxian Hermeneutics and Heideggerian Social Theory: Interpreting and Transforming Our World* (Purdue, 1975. Ph.D., Diss). Stahl himself has gone on to a career at the high academic level in information theory and computer science.

⁴³ But this would have been Baudrillard's point about integral reality, virtuality, everything we call media now in order to forget the vacuity, volatility of the medium, not that we heard him then, nor do we hear him now.

Our students have no jobs—hence there was reason to note Illich’s critique of school above. At the same time what pensions we have are gutted, our own savings lost, our own houses likewise, as well as those of friends and colleagues, are ‘down-sized,’ which is a way of saying that they too have no jobs, entire nation economies collapse. And those with jobs, those who saved their houses, those whose friends are employed, shutter their perception, like airline passengers processed through security.

In the interim, the powers of collective suppression are only intensified, only increased. There is no Occupy Wall Street movement as I write, not even the peripheral tiny band that for some time early in the Fall of 2012 gathered off and on to protest Goldman Sachs on the southern corner of Central Park West, near Merchant’s Gate and just across from the Trump International Hotel and Tower, with its silver globe fetish to Trump’s original Queens and built to satisfy the anxieties of the people who paid for the towers—not Trump but Hong Kong financiers, who needed something round and something shiny to deflect *sha*, poison arrows: a feng shui “cure.” In his elegantly comprehensive, “The Winter of Our Discontent,” Aronowitz points out just how quickly things went in the ‘American Fall’ that was Occupy Wall Street:

By November a coordinated effort by 18 big city mayors from both main political parties had forced the occupiers to disband sometimes by violence, except in a few cities such as Los Angeles and Philadelphia where the local political establishment feared a blowback.⁴⁴

And in the same interim, in the spring of the following year, a similarly coordinated effort also kept news of student protests in Montreal, Canada (red square, here referring to a red patch) from university scholars in New York (that would be Buffalo as much as New York City) for—this is how the digital, this is how the media controls the real—what’s not on the news, not on the internet, does not exist.⁴⁵ There are ways to burn books without fire. Just call it fake news and have done with it.

There is no revolution, if it does not change the world. As Alasdair MacIntyre points out, as political theorist after political theorist has pointed out, all of them willy-nilly following Marx, following Rousseau, a revolution just to be a revolution has to succeed (and political ‘theorists’ are characterized as such because they argue for the distinctions, the characteristics of a successful revolution). Here, as MacIntyre saw, there is much to learn from the philosophy of science, from Paul Feyerabend to Thomas Kuhn: not only does ‘anything go’ but the existing paradigm always functions to dismantle revolutionary thinking before it begins. This is as true in philosophy—this is the meaning of analytic philosophy—as it is in the ordinary, real world.

In Žižek’s exposition, once again, what bears reflection is the practical contest between theory and practice, and now we are back to the housing bubble, the economy, the TSA:

⁴⁴ Aronowitz, “The Winter of Our Discontent,” p. 40.

⁴⁵ See the contributions to the website <http://publicuniversity.org.uk/2012/06/05/the-crisis-of-the-red-square/> entitled, *Campaign for the Public University*, owing to the efforts of Mark Carrigan, a graduate student, at the time, and then-and-still a twitter colleague in sociology at Warwick, and not less to Tracy Strong, who translated the texts from French into English.

For all that crises shatter people out of their complacency and make them question the fundamentals of their lives, the first spontaneous reaction is not revolution but panic, which leads to a return to basics: food and shelter. The core premises of the ruling ideology are not put into doubt. They are even more violently asserted.⁴⁶

Thus Žižek can title his essay “Capitalism: How the Left Lost the Argument” and we have already cited his concluding non-conspiratorial because merely empirical contention:

It is almost as if this crisis were staged to demonstrate that the only solution to a failure of capitalism is more capitalism.⁴⁷

None of this functions, nor does Žižek claim that it functions, as a refutation of Marxism. Much rather the mechanism Žižek outlines works as it does because the intrinsic working of capitalism includes, this is its logic, thank you Hegel, the mechanism of co-option which does not and never did oppose reformation but (and this is so much more effective) simply absorbs reformation.

The example of environmental or green capitalism is perhaps best on a point Žižek and Naomi Klein make (both to be sure and in different ways more dramatically than most)⁴⁸ but which is also the stock of most responsible discussions of sustainable development (hint, Maurice Strong will not be the lead to follow here). Sustainable development is always underdevelopment *by other means* and with a smokingly good conscience.⁴⁹

Thus Kurz argues that

The attempted reform is transformed under the commodity form of relations. The relation of the conscious reformers to their intended reform is obscured and takes on the apparent form of a relation of “the owners of capital” to a reform which has been altered to serve their interests. The apparent benefactors of the distorted reform need not be identifiable, they need not exist as individual people. The reform has simply been made to serve the criteria of exchange value or capital and the human agents presumed to be behind this fetish are invisible, autonomous, abstract, indefinable: the System, the Man, the They, the Power Elite.⁵⁰

Notice the distortion of reform and note too that this now and still-today institutionalized distortion took a Marcuse to theorize in the complex chaos of supposed freedom and factive unfreedom that is still the United States but increasingly encompasses the world, although the lineaments of this analysis are already to be found in Horkheimer and Adorno, and perhaps most chillingly in Anders.⁵¹ At the

⁴⁶ Ibid. Simon Winlow and Steve Hall repeat this assessment, with different fire, in their account of the 2011 summer riots in the UK. See Winlow and Hall, “A Predictably Obedient Riot: Postpolitics, Consumer Culture, and the English Riots of 2011,” *Cultural Politics*, 8/3 (2012): 465–488;

⁴⁷ Žižek, “Capitalism: How the Left Lost the Argument.”

⁴⁸ See, once again, Žižek, “Capitalism: How the Left Lost the Argument” (among other earlier variations here) and Naomi Klein, *The Shock Doctrine: The Rise of Disaster Capitalism* (New York: Picador, 2008).

⁴⁹ See on this the range of reflections in Aidan Davison, *Technology & the Contested Meaning of Sustainability* (Albany: State University of New York Press, 2001).

⁵⁰ Stahl, *Marxian Hermeneutics and Heideggerian Social Theory*, p. 95.

⁵¹ See Babich, “On Machines as the Masters of Humanity: Martin Heidegger, Günther Anders, and the Singularity of Digital Technology,” *Journal of the Hannah Arendt Center for Politics and Humanities at Bard College*, 2 (2012): 122–144.

same time this analysis also requires a hermeneutic reading, and thereby a connection with Heidegger and for its own part exemplifies Gadamer's account of the hermeneutic historicity of leading scholars' readings, and what they bind—which secured account thus preserves a 'life' in the academy—and what they loose—which is correspondingly silenced. All this is part of politics, if only the bootless (and usually gutless) politics of the academy.

One point to be added here in conclusion, from Durão and from Kurz, suggesting in an underwhelmingly globalized fashion, that (I say this quite apart from the unimaginable dimension of the race question in Brazil) that we are all Brazilians, *pace* Durão, to the extent that we are all mythic thinkers (and the colonialist conviction that 'whites' *do not* think in the same mythic fashion is part of the race problem).

We believe at a far deeper level than we consciously suppose ourselves to believe in what is advertised and we do so almost without remainder. This is the power of market priming,⁵² as this is embraced today in all fields from the arts to the academy (call it branding). Thus Robert Hullot-Kentor⁵³ has pointed to the need to distinguish between the equivocal senses of the term 'culture industry' corresponding to *the culture industry* (all around us) and Adorno's (and Horkheimer's) culture industry, which in Durão's recapitulation of this distinction is "itself part of the process that hinders the perception of the primitivization of society that the Frankfurt thinkers wanted to present."⁵⁴

But US consumers deeply believe, as Durão tells us the numerous dispossessed (or better or more accurately said never-once-possessed) Brazilian believes, in "the promises made by that which they do not have."⁵⁵ This drives the acquisition of every new smart phone (and buyer's remorse is hard on every such purchase). The difference in the more literal faith is the very possibility of subversion, as this is found in the tension engendered at once both by that promise and by its inevitable disappointment. "The expensive car *really* brings beautiful women; the cigarette *really* takes one to the old West."⁵⁶

It is commercial advertising—this is what Adorno was writing about—that engenders the magical thinking Durão restricts in his analysis to the helpless Brazilian who "really," as Durão says, believes in such promises. It is a Marlboro commercial, which we recognize even though such commercials have been banned for years in the moraline quest to discourage smoking. This vision of the West draws on the collective unconscious whether one lives in São Paulo or New York. It is a Zane Grey Western and a Karl May novel.

⁵² I discuss this in connection with Adorno in the first chapters of Babich, *The Hallelujah Effect* and see too, from a French phenomenological perspective, David Sherman's discussion of Adorno and phenomenology, *Sartre and Adorno: The Dialectics of Subjectivity* (Albany: State University of New York Press, 2007), pp. 13ff.

⁵³ Robert Hullot-Kentor, "The Exact Sense in Which the Culture Industry No Longer Exists." In Durão, ed. *The Culture Industry Today* (Cambridge Scholar's Publishing, 2010), pp. 5–22.

⁵⁴ Durão, "Report on a Frankfurt School Conference in Brazil," *Rethinking Marxism*, Vol. 20/No. 2 (April 2008): 321–331, here pp. 322–323. Here, p. 323. Durão cites precisely this point.

⁵⁵ Durão, "Adorno in Brazil," p. 19.

⁵⁶ *Ibid.*

The problem is that the subject who takes this on faith is male (and as I argue in *The Hallelujah Effect*, women share the conventions of the same subject). That subject in Beverley Hills or in Cannes or out in the Hamptons or on Martha's Vineyard knows—and knows quite empirically—that the expensive car, let's give it a name for full mythic effect, a Porsche or a Bentley, does indeed, just as really or literally, just as truly as you please, 'bring' (to use Durão's cargo cult term), beautiful women—who either share the same subjectivity as the male subject or do not count as "subjects" at all, be it for Kurz, even for Adorno, certainly not for Marcuse (author, good God, of *Eros and Civilization*) as much as they are themselves a market item like cars or cigarettes.

Contra the traditional mechanisms of repressive desublimation characteristic of technological modernity, there, in all the parts of the world where we are said to know better, is that even after eschewing the very idea of the postmodern, as Umberto Eco once observed, we nonetheless use the same knit-together patchwork of sophisticated irony to complement ourselves on that same critical sophistication.

Distracted in this way, in all the ways that we are scattered in our consciousness to ourselves and to the world around us, we are nowhere near changing the world. If Vattimo and Zabala can remind us that we can challenge the possessions of those in possession, to the extent that "hermeneutics is a way of looking at Being as an inheritance that is never considered as ultimate data,"⁵⁷ they also point out that we are up against a heritage of illusion, a history of lies:

Capitalism has always grown by considering, or forcing another to consider, as a "natural" possession what is inherited. The great dominating families are really the inheritors of the strongest pirates, thieves, and bandits, and they consider themselves entitled to command through a divine or natural law, when they are really only the result of a forgotten "violence."⁵⁸

If communism is a politics now long disfavored, a ghostly presence, it is a spectre with powers mobilized against it, powers of several wars, fought again and again, across the globe. In addition there is the theoretical ossification of communism, that is the materialism mentioned above. The promise of weakened thought, as Vattimo and Zabala explain hermeneutics, "proposes an effective conception of existence for those who do not wish to be enslaved in and by a world of total organization."⁵⁹ What this means as they rightly argue is that it is time to start making sense of the world but not in the ways that make rational, scientific, sense in the standard received fashion. Neither by way of the resources of analytic philosophy nor indeed by way of media debates on politics as these appear in the newspapers or on network(ed) news programs, it is time to begin "to interpret the world."⁶⁰

⁵⁷ Vattimo and Zabala, *Hermeneutic Communism*, p. 93.

⁵⁸ *Ibid.*, p. 93.

⁵⁹ *Ibid.*, p. 139.

⁶⁰ *Ibid.*, p. 140.

Response to Babich

Gianni Vattimo and Santiago Zabala

At first we thought Babette Babich's contribution was going to focus on our use of Nietzsche, since she is among the most important contemporary specialists of the German thinker. Instead, as a serious hermeneutic thinker often does, she surprised us by analyzing separately our "hermeneutic" and "communist" theses through a variety of authors (Ivan Illich, Stanley Aronowitz, Slavoj Žižek) and issues (education, materialism, financial crisis) in order to open new horizons and confront urgent questions. Her contribution embraces hermeneutic radicalism to the fullest. But what does this radicalism refer to?

Being a radical philosopher in the twenty-first century no longer implies explicitly believing in an ideology or being part of a political Party or Movement, but rather changing the intellectual restrictions that these ideologies and Parties contributed to. This is probably why in the title of her contribution ("Changing Convictions, Changing the World: Becoming Weak") the word "changing" appears twice. But how can we change our convictions or the world?

The American thinker indirectly responds by making two important statements: to "take the part of the weaker party in any community, society, exchange presupposes a hermeneutic", and "just where one seeks to make a change hermeneutics is again an indispensable precondition." Taking the part of the weaker group and seeking to make changes presupposes "challenges," in other words, striving for a different world than the one we are in. But why is hermeneutics the "indispensable precondition" for this task? After all, there are many other philosophical traditions, schools, and stances also concerned with this problem. If hermeneutics is the right candidate for these tasks, it is not because it is better equipped or truer than other philosophical stances, but rather always already open to the "others" and, as Babich specifies, "not

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the dominant approach.” We would go even further and affirm hermeneutics “should never become the dominant approach” if it wants to change the world.

Contrary to critical theory, which Babich reproaches for its “lack of critique” and incapacity to “overcome the legacy of Marxist materialism,” the strength of hermeneutics lies in its concern for dominant and oppressive approaches, such as those that technology promotes. This is why one should not be surprised to read Heidegger’s reflections on technology after the war as “patently communist.” Here “communist” does not stand for the ideology behind the Soviet Union, but rather for an alternative opposition and resistance to an emerging technological liberalism which is now real. “If we miss the economic, ‘strangely close to communism’ undertone of Heidegger’s writings on technology...,” Babich explains, “we find ourselves reading a romantic reactionary.” Although this “communist undertone,” which Žižek also noticed, is not common to all hermeneutic philosophers, there is a general distrust towards the technological and scientific organization of the world. It should not come as a surprise that Hans-Georg Gadamer, who studied closely with Heidegger, centered his philosophy around undermining science as the unique bearer of truth. But why must one interpret this distrust in technology as communist?

If communism, as we tried to explain throughout *Hermeneutic Communism*, has become a non-technological approach, it is because the Soviet Union lost its technological race against the United States, in other words, had to “take part of the weaker” people and society. This is why we fully agree when Babich affirms that “the problem of communist and Marxist theory tends to be its commitment to historical materialism. This commitment does not derive solely from the letter of the Marxist text and certain influential accounts of the same but it is the danger of automatic, rationalistic, systems-technological thinking that includes almost all leftists.” But what is hermeneutics committed to?

Hermeneutics is committed to resisting the existing ruling class. This can come in the form of theoretical or practical challenges. “And it is precisely for the sake of such challenges,” as Babich explains, “that we need hermeneutics: contra the dictates of analytic philosophy which only inscribes what it calls realist thinking... as this corresponds to the received theory of whatever ruling class there happens to be, be it in society... or the academy, which always reduces in the end to the terms of conventionally institutionalized modern science.” The greatest problem of these “institutions” is not only how they reduce or accept the terms of modern science, but most of all the absence of emergency they promote, which, as Heidegger explained, “is the greatest emergency.” Both society and the academy are framed today, and this means that they are incapable of “changing convictions, changing the world, and also becoming weak,” as Babich would say.

If the Weak Would Win: The Specter of Communism and the Re-birth of Democracy

Silvia Mazzini

Abstract This article develops from one of the central theses formulated by Vattimo and Zabala in *Hermeneutic Communism*. It constitutes the metaphysical idea of a unique and objective truth being the core of a totalitarian and violent political system that establishes itself as absolute by excluding any form of alternative or multiplicity. It focuses on how the ‘winners of history’ gain and maintain their political, economic, and social power, giving rise to what Vattimo and Zabala describe as today’s ‘armed capitalism’. In order to take a stand against this situation, the two authors suggest a possible way out: ‘the end of truth is the beginning of democracy’. But is it possible to practice politics without the idea of truth? And if so, how? In this respect my contribution investigates the subversive as well as creative potentialities of a ‘hermeneutic communism’, examining if and how it would be possible to witness a ‘rebirth of democracy’ thanks to the ‘victory of the weak’ - i.e. of the so-called ‘losers of history’. Through an aesthetical inquiry about the political and communicative implication of the paradigmatic and ambivalent literary figure of Hamlet, I will further attempt to explore the importance of a non-verbal communication in an hermeneutical, democratic dialogue. By doing this, I will also pose a paradoxical, quite tragic question: will the strong be isolated and marginalized, if the weak would win?

To paraphrase Shakespeare’s Hamlet, we could say that there are more things in *Hermeneutic Communism* than in many philosophy books published today. Among the significant and multiple elements of the text, I would like to take a short and apparently marginal passage as the starting point of my contribution. In the fourth and final chapter of *Hermeneutic Communism*, Vattimo and Zabala take up a classic metaphor in the Marxist literature and, quoting Derrida, argue that nowadays “communism must function as a ‘specter’.”¹ But how do spectra actually “function”? And

¹Gianni Vattimo – Santiago Zabala: *Hermeneutic Communism. From Heidegger to Marx*. New York, Columbia University Press, 2011 (from here quoted as HC), p. 121.

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more basically: how does that particular hybrid species of specter, which has been recently discovered by the authors, function: the species of the “hermeneutic-communist-specter”?

In literature and folk tales, spectra often feature as souls of dead people who intend to bring a message or a call for help to the people they want to communicate with. And in this sense a specter could certainly take on the role of Hermes, the ancient Greek god of messages and a hermeneutical character *par excellence*. On the other hand, spectra should belong to a different order of reality. So, how could a ‘hermeneutic-communist-specter’ not only communicate, but also interfere with the human historical process, if it is merely an image, a fantasy (gr. «phantasma»), the shadow of somebody (or something)?

Vattimo and Zabala *revolutionize* the meaning of the word ‘specter’, releasing its *revolutionary* potential. According to the authors, it is precisely because communism is now in a moment of extreme weakness, because it is ‘marginal’, because it seems to have died, leaving the capitalist system with an almost complete monopoly on the entire globe. Right now,

“[...] the function of the specter – which disturbs and shocks the serene routine of those who, as in the case of *Hamlet*, must reap the fruit of *violence* – is useful for shocking into awareness those who prefer not to *recognize* capitalism’s consequences.” (HC, 121)²

This marginal reference to the “case of Hamlet” is my starting point. And of course it is not my purpose here to conduct an investigation of the literary Shakespearean text in question; I hope instead that the Prince of Denmark and his story can guide me (like a ghost in his secret castle) in analyzing some of HC’s theses, collecting questions, developing hypotheses or discourses.

To Play or Not to Play? The Choice Between Different (Interpret-)Actions

In *The Birth of Tragedy*, Nietzsche compares Hamlet with the Dionysian man: “beide haben einmal einen wahren Blick in das Wesen der Dinge gethan, sie haben *erkannt*, und es ekelt sie zu handeln [...]”.³ Yet it might be interesting to juxtapose the figure of Hamlet with the Nietzschean *Übermensch*, in the sense ascribed to this figure in *Hermeneutic Communism*. Since the ghost of his father told him an ‘alternative’ (not ‘official’) version of the story of his own death, Hamlet indeed no longer has a clear and ‘strong’ *Weltanschauung*. This is also the reason why he starts to question everything, even at the risk falling into a nearly absolute skepticism. He

² *Ibidem* (my italics).

³ “[...] both have had a real sight into the essence of things: they have *realized*, and acting disgusts them [...]” M.t. from Friedrich Nietzsche: *Die Geburt der Tragödie aus dem Geiste der Musik*, in: Giorgio Colli – Mazzino Montinari (Eds.), *Nietzsche Werke. Kritische Gesamtausgabe*, 3,1, Berlin-New York 1972, pp. 52–3.

has doubts, in a quite cartesian way, about the very nature of the ghost (“[...] The spirit that I haue seene / may be the deale, and the deale hath power / T’assume a pleasing shape [...]”⁴). And with the exception of his faithful friend Horatio, all those around Hamlet assume different roles from time to time, in a maze of mirrors, power games, and different forms of manipulation and betrayal.

There are of course abyssal differences between the idea of the *Übermensch* suggested by Vattimo and Zabala,⁵ and the story of the Prince of Denmark. First, we know that Hamlet, at the end of the play, decides to use violence – which Vattimo and Zabala do not intend to propose. Furthermore the tragedy of Hamlet is focused on concerns, thoughts and actions of a single man – while I believe that the ‘subject’ of HC is essentially *plural*. It is in fact a weak subject – it is the weak or those who take the side of the weak, because they do not agree with the interpretation of the strong and their ‘monopoly’ on truth. A weak subject is in any case a subject placed on the margins of the dominant system that presents itself as the only valid one. The plural and weak subject of HC is an *oppressed* subject which has been deprived of its rights, even when the weak ‘officially’ live in a democracy yet remain partially excluded from participation in power, i.e. excluded from what they actually deserve.

In this sense, Hamlet is also an oppressed subject: we should not forget that the Danish throne would have been his and not to his uncle Claudius’, if Claudius had not married the queen, Hamlet’s mother in a hurry, two months after the death of his father. Responding to the call of the ghost of his father and revenging his death is thus for Hamlet also a way to claim his own rights and get out of his oppressed condition. A way to take back what belongs to him: the Danish throne – the power to reign.

But how and why does Hamlet decide to trust the ghost and not others? And above all, beyond this parallelism: how and why do the weak have to trust and respond to the call of Hermeneutic Communism? In posing these questions I do not aim for a kind of metaphysical, strong foundation, but for the (epistemological) conditions of a conscious *action*. And more particularly, in the case of the plural and weak subject, the search for a kind of action which can be as shared and democratic as possible.

For Vattimo and Zabala this feature is not related to a theoretical, but to a historical necessity: that is “the result of the end of metaphysics”, of the fall of the Berlin Wall and of “the end of Eurocentrism and its pretense to universal ‘Western’ rationality.”⁶ In a situation of antifoundationalism (but not of absolute relativism),⁷ the *conversation* works like a keystone for a conscious and shared action: the conversation is indeed, for Vattimo and Zabala, a procedure which has to be discussed and questioned time after time, in order to find different interpretations (and not

⁴William Shakespeare, The tragedie of Hamlet Prince of Denmarke, in Stanley Wells – Gary Taylor (Eds.): The complete Works, Oxford 1986, p. 753.

⁵“[...] that is, individuals capable of constructing [their] own alternative interpretation of the world instead of submitting to the official truth.”(HC, p. 137)

⁶HC, pp. 110–1.

⁷HC, p. 98.

absolute truths) which are able to change reality. Re-interpreting Marx's 11th thesis on Feuerbach, Vattimo and Zabala in fact affirm: "The philosophers have only described on the world in various ways; now the moment has arrived to interpret it."⁸

But *how* can this conversation between the weak take place? We know that different kinds of conversations played a central role in many protest movements of the last years. OWS, the 15-M Movement, the Arab Spring, and also the various Pirates Parties in Europe used or still use different web resources in a subversive manner: Facebook, Twitter, blogs, forums etc. have been significant tools not only to organize protests, meetings and actions, or to transmit forbidden information, but also to discuss, to make decisions together – to realize a conversation. Surely, these tools have enabled significant achievements and yielded positive results. So, do Vattimo and Zabala conceive the role and the characteristics of conversation as a tool for *Hermeneutic Communism* in this way? Or are these some of the many other possible ways of communication? In other words, if a politically relevant conversation is seen as a procedure that takes place *primarily* and essentially on a verbal level, in my opinion we would risk giving priority to central, but not unique aspects of the communicative act. As a matter of fact, the logical-argumentative, or the rhetorical-suggestive-associative thought has always played a significant role in the history of 'strong culture' in the West (and also beyond it); but it is important to listen to the *other* aspects of a conversation. Aspects that often have been considered as marginal, not because they have not been present in conversations, but perhaps because it is more difficult to systematize and interpret them in a 'clear and distinct' way. Yet precisely for this reason it seems to me that a theory focused on diversity, alternatives, and minorities should not disregard key aspects like emotion, bodily expression, performativity, and 'irrational' or instinctive parts of a speech.

Hamlet did not completely trust the logical and rational language.⁹ Perhaps for this reason, before his definitive decision to act according to the message of the spectrum – that is, before what we may call a kind of kierkegaardian 'leap of faith'¹⁰ – Hamlet chose to try another way of communication: *theater*. He asked the actors to play a story resembling the murder of his father: "[...] the play's the thing / wherein I'll catch the conscience of the King".¹¹ As a matter of fact, king Claudius felt bad and left before the performance ended. Hamlet hence used the theater as a tool that is not only related to logic and rationality, but also to the unconscious and to emotions (which in first instance require interpretation, as Vattimo and Zabala

⁸ HC, p. 5.

⁹ It is known that Hamlet expressed himself with apparently absurd and meaningless puns – also in order people to believe he got mad. Some interpreters of Shakespeare (among others, Kott), have however revealed Hamlet's ability to unhinge words, and in particular the logical-rational language, releasing at the same time, subversively, different and significant, but hidden and 'marginal' meanings.

¹⁰ Because the ghost could not offer more rational reasons than other courtiers, in order to support his thesis, I call Hamlet's decision to believe his father's 'thuth' a kierkegaardian 'leap of faith'.

¹¹ Shakespeare, p. 753.

often underline¹²). In theater, a central role is indeed played by feelings, instincts and many aspects of what is called (often in a dismissive and pejorative way) *irrationality*.¹³

In my opinion, Vattimo and Zabala also explore the less traveled lands of alternative methods of communication. For example they argue that Wittgenstein's language games have a political meaning, because they open up a political idea of society.¹⁴ Furthermore it should not be forgotten that even a pivotal book for hermeneutics, Gadamer's *Truth and Method*, focuses some of its central argumentations around the idea of the *game* (das *Spiel*). And if for Gadamer the game reveals some of its mechanisms in works of art, for Luigi Pareyson these mechanisms are applicable to all human activities, and hence also to politics.¹⁵

Understanding the theater as *one of the possible* ways to effectively have a 'weak conversation' (and a conversation between the weak), the experience of the Brazilian theater director Augusto Boal assumes an emblematic importance. As a matter of fact I think that his "Theater of the oppressed" deserves a front row seat in the discourse on the weak, and indeed on the *oppressed* weak that we are analyzing here.

An Hypothesis for a (Local) Conversation: The Theatre of the Oppressed

Giving instructions to the actors who were going to stage the murder of his father by his uncle Claudius, Hamlet claimed that the purpose of acting "was and is, to holde as twere the Mirrour vp to nature; to shew vertue her owne feature; scorne her own Image, and the very age and body of the time his forme and pressure [...]"¹⁶ The Brazilian theater director, writer, and politician Augusto Boal (1931–2009) had a different opinion. The definition of theater as "the mirror of nature", although beautiful and suggestive, did not take into account the emancipatory and political potential of this art form.¹⁷ The Theatre of the Oppressed started in the 1960s in Brazil, in a climate of workers revolts and peasants struggles, and found particularly fruitful grounds in the slums of many cities, as well as in other poor areas of the country. The various techniques of representation proposed by Boal were to be used as tools for personal change, but even more for the transformation of the social and political situation of his country.

¹² See for example HC, pp. 82–84.

¹³ But I think it is not necessary to underline the important role that also rationality and logical-argumentative-analytical language plays (or at least played) in our culture: which is very evident, for example, in Bertold Brecht's theatre and theoretical works.

¹⁴ HC, pp. 101–102.

¹⁵ See i.a. Luigi Pareyson: *Teoria della Formatività*, Torino 1954.

¹⁶ Shakespeare, p. 755.

¹⁷ Nestor Cozetti – Augusto Boal: *Entrevista: No palco, soluções para a vida real*, 05/05/2009; <http://josekuller.wordpress.com/38-entrevista-com-augusto-boal/> (date of access: 16.01.2013)

The central idea of this method was simple, but had an explosive potential: it consisted of stage representations of concrete situations of daily oppression, in order to engage the audience not only in discussions but also in real actions. The public, in short, was encouraged to go on stage, in order to search (together with the actors) for solutions and concrete strategies to solve violent conflicts that took place 'outside' the walls of the theatre building, on the 'world's stage'. Through participatory forms of expression and communication, Boal wanted to break down the boundaries of theater itself, bringing changes to the reality of everyday life.

The purpose of Boal's theater was not essentially cathartic, but political: the *public* was stimulated to be active and was considered as the center of the work. And so the public could become protagonist in the organization and formation of political life – of the *polis* or the *res publica*, (indeed, the Latin word 'publicus' means 'that which is public', 'that which belongs to all'). But *how*?

During his tenure as *vereador* (city councilor) in Rio de Janeiro from 1991 to 1996, Boal developed a particular aspect of his Theater of the Oppressed, which was called Legislative Theatre.¹⁸ Reworking, integrating, discussing different reactions, interpretations and proposals from the public, Boal made it possible that concrete legislative proposals could not only be explored, but also *made* for the district in which the theater building stood. This was Boal experimenting with possible forms of direct democracy on a local level.

This particular use of conversation, beyond the monopoly of logos and rationality, can engender fruitful political effects. First, the people have a concrete possibility to meet, so that theatre can take the role of the *agora* in ancient Greece, where people met and could discuss things that concerned the *polis*. But secondly, the people can also work together and then strengthen as a *group*: since people then begin to have something in *common* and therefore begin to build a living and organic *community*. Thirdly the *creative* (and non-conservative) role of *interpretation*, in the sense pointed out by Vattimo and Zabala, can be particularly observed in these kinds of political and creative activities: also Boal thought that the different *interpretations* of the spectators, together with their theatre activities, could lead to a possible, concrete *change* of reality – to the actual production, in fact, of a new law.

It should be noticed that if theater for Hamlet was something like 'the mirror of nature', for Boal it was rather like a democratic *conversation* (NB: any reference to Rorty or to his book *Philosophy and the Mirror of Nature* is purely implicit). So of course, without absolutizing the role of theater, I think that Boal's theories and experiments can be seen as procedures which represent a possible (methodological) alternative to the dominant system of Western rationality. In particular, I would also point out that the local dimension of the oppressed theater plays a crucial role in the development of participatory and more direct democracy. The focus on the local helps to implement a de-centralized government. This decentralization can be understood as the geographic equivalent of a political and philosophical alternative to the absolutism of the power of the 'centre': because a local focus shows a respectful attention to the different needs and identities present in a specific time and place.

¹⁸ See Augusto Boal: *Legislative Theatre: Using performance to Make Politics*, London 1998.

In other words, decentralization is resistance to the totalitarianism of laws and political systems, which are generally considered ‘neutral’ and universal, and therefore tacitly imported and imposed.

Sharing spaces in a more or less physical way, creating a direct contact between voters and political life can also help to neutralize at least a part of what Vattimo has called elsewhere the “computer-media bubble”¹⁹ of our contemporary framed democracies. That is: “[...] when political parties establish closed and self-referential bureaucracies, which come into contact with the voters only through the media.”²⁰

The problem of the relationship between how media *interpret* and *present* reality brings us to another central thesis of Vattimo and Zabala’s *Hermeneutic of Communism*. As is known, the two authors propose Chávez as a model for Obama. And according to Vattimo and Zabala, Chávez is presented in a negative way by most of the Western media not only because he has not signed the IMF, but also because the framed democracies of the West fear that his alternative model of democracy can quickly expand and ‘contaminate’ other states, bringing an earthquake into the system they prefer not to be changed. In fact they claim Chávez’s model of democracy is exemplary and has a volcanic, revolutionary flavor: the Venezuela president kicked off a large number of democratic reforms in order to improve the economical, educational and health conditions of the poor population of the country.

But why should I trust only newspapers or intellectuals with positions closer to mine (like Vattimo and Zabala’s), while excluding others? In order to interpret reality and also to have a democratic conversation, is it not necessary to listen to many different ‘voices’ – even those of the ‘strong’? Because if they would be ignored and not heard, they would paradoxically turn into the role of ‘the new weak’. At this point, I see the risk of coming back to a question I posed at the beginning of this essay: why should Hamlet listen to some voices, and not to others? Of course, like Hamlet, it may be necessary to take a Kierkegaardian ‘leap of faith’. But Hamlet, as we have seen in the interpretation I proposed, used some means of communication to reflect on the message of the ghost: so, how could this be possible in this case? Seeing and experiencing in person, beyond any kind of right- or left-wing ‘media bubble’, could be a solution to discover how things really work in Venezuela. This could be perhaps the role of a postmodern St. Thomas, that in my opinion would not represent a Cartesian position or a “fetishism of the facts”,²¹ because this solution would propose doubt as a way to create a personal and particular interpretation, and not an absolute truth. But it is known that nowadays universities, especially in Europe, do not have a lot of money, and so unfortunately I cannot afford a trip to Venezuela, at least in the coming years.

¹⁹ “[...] bolla informatico-mediatica [...]” (Gianni Vattimo: *Ecce comu*, Roma 2007, p. 46, m.t.).

²⁰ “[...] è il costituirsi dei partiti politici in burocrazie chiuse e autoreferenziali, che hanno con gli elettori il solo contatto dei mass media.” (*Ibi*, p. 44)

²¹ Paraphrasing an expression of the philosopher Ernst Bloch in his main work *Das Prinzip Hoffnung*, Frankfurt a.M. 1959, p. 256 (“Fetischist der sogenannten Tatsachen”).

But there is a more fundamental question behind this: is it really necessary to find a model of a concrete and realized utopia where the idea of Hermeneutic Communism is ‘incarnated’? Because

We are well aware that Marx, Lenin, or any other of their theoretical or practical successors never solved the problem of the complete ‘realization’ of a communist society. [...] While we cannot imagine a world where communism is completed, neither can we renounce this ideal as a regulative and inspiring principle for our concrete decisions. [...] In sum, communism is utopia or, as Benjamin would say, a project of the ‘*weak messianic power*’, a power on which the past has a claim’. After all, the messiah, as Jesus teaches in the Gospels, never allows himself to be indicated positively. The messianic power of the utopia is also a critical and indispensable limit; it is only when the revolution is considered completed (or, which is the same, Being is identified with being as a present fact) that it becomes despotic power, hegemony, and violence against any disclosure toward a different future.²²

In my opinion this statement of Vattimo and Zabala is not in contradiction with their proposal to consider Chavez as a political model. In fact, the authors do not claim that “the revolution is considered completed” in Venezuela: it is a revolution *in fieri*, essentially a resistance, and therefore it has not yet reached its final form. But I wonder if after all it is possible to export more or less completed models into other historical, economic, political and cultural contexts that are different from those in which such models have been created. In 1979, for instance, the experiment of the Theatre of the Oppressed was ‘imported’ to Hamburg, but without the desired success. According to Boal, this happened because the forms of oppression in Western society differed from those in South America – forms of violent oppression, of course, but also more subtle, ambiguous forms of oppression that were therefore not as easily recognizable. So Boal argued that in order to expose and fight these forms of violence it would have been necessary to develop another form of theatre, a new procedure, and perhaps a different method. I think Vattimo and Zabala also take this contextual specificity into account, when they affirm:

The idea that has guided us throughout this text is rigorously materialistic: the structural changes we ascertain in South America societies are inseparable from a collective culture and structure that are very different from the one that characterizes the West.²³

In my opinion the democratic model of South America could also be a success in Europe or elsewhere – but only if ‘translated’ to the concrete context of each different culture – as if it would be a ‘cultural conversation’, a conversation between systems. In other words: *interpreting a model means also changing it*. So it would not be possible for one particular system to present itself as a strong ‘truth’ (or, politically speaking, as ‘the completed revolution’). In this way, and only this way, is it possible to say that the weak (philosophically and politically) could really win.

²² HC, pp. 116–7.

²³ *Ibi*, p. 135.

The 'Invisible Power' and the Rebirth of Democracy

In the 1970s, Pier Paolo Pasolini argued that the so-called Western democracies (or what we call here 'framed democracies') were in fact ruled by a very oppressive power, one that is authoritarian and totalitarian. According to the Italian author, poet and director, the strength of this "invisible power"²⁴ had its roots in a paradoxical labyrinth of appearances, that is in the alleged tolerance, hedonism and permissiveness it pretended to create. In particular, Pasolini argued that *consumerism* was the main weapon for the ruling powers to reach an almost complete absolutism, because (too) many people begun to believe they could achieve wealth and well-being through an accumulation of goods and objects. And with this (violent, but 'subtle', indirect and therefore invisible) imposition of (*only*) *one* cultural model, all the regional distinctiveness and other differences in society had been gradually absorbed. That is, for Pasolini a cultural *homogenization* had quickly occurred even in a country like Italy, which until that moment was always characterized by a broad diversity of regional dialects and identities.

Pasolini's analyses of the cultural situation in Italy in the 1970s is not so different from the interpretation of today's society given by Vattimo and Zabala, who in fact denounce 'the increasing homologizing of the political, economic, and social structures of power.'²⁵

For Pasolini, capitalist consumerism acted as a new opium of the people.²⁶ People were getting more and more used to material wealth, goods and other services, and viewed those as necessary. Precisely because violence and exploitation was so invisible in the western world (or, in Boal's words, subtle), a revolt against it was very difficult. That is why Pasolini pinned his resistance in the Third World, which in his opinion still had the capacity and possibility to preserve precious and subversive *differences*. Perhaps for this reason the Italian director, in the last years of his life, moved the focus of his studies and observations from the sub-proletariat living in the slums of the big cities in Europe, to the populations of the so-called 'under-developed' countries. In his opinion, these cultures were still able to withstand the totalitarianism of the capitalist world and bring (paradoxically) an authentic 'development' on a global level.

One of his last films, *Notes towards an African Orestes* (1970),²⁷ is in this sense emblematic. In fact it is no coincidence that the author chose Africa (and through this metonymy, the whole Third World) as the setting for the story of Orestes. As is known, this Aeschylean trilogy is about a fundamental change in the political system of Ancient Greece and its cultural structure. It is about the end of a form of society based on the laws of blood and the intervention of the gods. This end is

²⁴ See Pier Paolo Pasolini: *Scritti Corsari*, Milan 1975 (*Corsair Writings*).

²⁵ HC, p. 2.

²⁶ See my article 'Bloch und Pasolini. Das neue Opium des Volkes' in Doris Zeilinger (ed.): *VorSchein*. 31/2010, pp. 141–150.

²⁷ It. *Appunti per un'Orestide africana*.

sanctioned by the founding of the first human court, that is to say, the ‘official’ birth of *democracy*.

In the *Oresteia* of Aeschylus, this change is brought about by the transformation of the Furies, chthonic goddesses of vengeance, into the Eumenides, goddesses of justice. This was the justice of human laws. The court of Athens was formed by men who, thanks to new procedures, could emancipate themselves from the absolute authority of the gods. ‘The End of the truth is the beginning of democracy.’²⁸ As Orestes had been judged for the first time by the agreement reached in a court of men (ie: procedure of the conversation) and not by the immutable laws of the gods (ie: absolute truth), so today democracy could experience a re-birth, if the weak would win. But if so, what other deities, besides the ‘Furies’ of the absolute and objective truth (which are supported by the framed democracies) could be transformed or, furthermore, re-interpreted? And how? What roles could the new Eumenides play, if we would live in a weak society?

Maybe it would be interesting to find out what kind of Eumenides could take the place of the Furies of consumerism. Or perhaps it could be possible to emancipate ourselves from the contemporary dictatorship of the *surplus value* of goods, replacing it with other sets of social, existential, cultural, political and/or religious values. But these are only questions and hypotheses about which I hope we can communicate – of course, in order to bring some into practice. Serving together a *phantasma*-gorical paradox – the paradox of a strong *ghost*: this and much more could happen, when the weak will win.

²⁸ HC, p. XX.

Response to Mazzini

Gianni Vattimo and Santiago Zabala

We agree with Silvia Mazzini when she points out that there are four central concepts (“specter” and “Hermes”) and figures (“Hamlet” and Nietzsche’s “*Übermensch*”) in *Hermeneutic Communism* whose common weakness imply a call for action. This common weakness is not simply interesting from a theoretical point of view, as all four strive against impositions from above, but also given their call to “act” against a common enemy. This is probably why her contribution focuses on the problem of communication among the weak, that is, how a “hermeneutic-communist-specter” interferes “with the human historical process.” This is a problem for everyone dealing with the return of communism in the twenty-first century, whether they interpret it as an idea (Alain Badiou), a horizon (Jodi Dean), or a problem (Slavoj Žižek), has to confront. Jacques Derrida, who was the first to call for a return of communism after the fall of the Soviet Union, also faced this problem when he called for a “New International.”

Mazzini, like other contributors to this volume, is right to stress the central role that the father of deconstructionism has in our book. His treatment of Marxism in *Specters of Marx* is not only significant from a historical point of view, but also for pointing out the communication or, as he called it, “link” the New International would have to promote. As Derrida explained, this had to be an “untimely link, without status, without title, and without name, barely public even if it is not clandestine, without contract, ‘out of joint,’ without coordination, without a party”: in sum, a form of “counter-conjuration, in the (theoretical and practical) critique of the state of international law, the concepts of State and nation, and so forth: in order to renew this critique, and especially to radicalize it.” Even though we still believe in the necessity of the “party,” as well as the “charismatic leader,” we have tried to

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remain faithful to the weakness or spectral nature of the link through Richard Rorty's notion of "conversation." The conflict inherent in all conversations, in which no one knows where it will end and who will be persuaded, is precisely what is missing in the ideas of state, nation, and international law the French master refers to.

In order to highlight this conflictual dimension of politics and its relation to the weak, Mazzini draws upon the plays and films of Augusto Boal and Pier Paolo Pasolini. Although the former's "theater of the oppressed" might appear at first closer to our position given its Latin American origins, the latter also has a place as his "hopes [pinned] on the resistance in the Third World" demonstrates. As Mazzini recalls, "the Italian director, in the last years of his life, moved the focus of his studies and observations from the sub-proletariat living in the slums of the big cities in Europe, to the populations of the so-called 'underdeveloped' countries." This shift was not simply caused by the level of "consumerism" and "cultural *homogenization*" of Italy in the 1970s, which today are much more alarming, but also by the "invisible power", as he put it. If this same invisibility is what ruined Boal's attempt to import his theatre of the oppressed in Europe, why would it work today when any criticism of the status quo is criticized and depicted as a violent and populist insurrection?

Although Europe has become the paradigmatic example of "framed democracies", there are signs of emancipation as the rise of Syriza in Greece or Podemos in Spain demonstrates. For example, the Latin American ideological origins of Pablo Iglesias' party should not simply be interpreted as an attempt to "import" a different model, but also as a political response to the "invisibility" or "frame" mention above. If this response has been successful until now (in less than 2 years' it has become the third political force in Spain) it's because they have managed to interfere with a population which is striving for change to a much greater degree than in Boal and Pasolini's epoch. In this epoch the simple presence of the Soviet Union and communist parties were viewed not only as the possibility of another world, but also of a simple alternative which is missing in the West now. As we can see, Mazzini has found in Boal and Pasolini's work a precedent which must be taken into account when reading *Hermeneutic Communism*. We hope our book can also become a precedent for a future political, theoretical, and also artistic alternative.

Power and Post-Metaphysics

Bradley Kaye

Abstract Hermeneutic Communism is premised on the idea that there are a multitude of metaphysical interpretations regarding the nature of reality, and human nature. However, Vattimo and Zabala often drift into postmodern refusals of metaphysical philosophy. I argue that this turn towards postmodernism tends to deter from the more powerful methods they create with Hermeneutic Communism. If in capitalism, all that is solid melts into air, then postmodern refusals towards any ontological grounding reinforce the anomic-normlessness of the alienating lack of communal social relations. Capitalism atomizes, deterring its subjects from what the Buddhists call ‘unity-mind’ which I see as the basis of communist social interactions. This metaphysical turn back to grounding relations in union with others is a point that should enable new and old metaphysical interpretations to emerge side by side. By attempting a fusion of post-metaphysical thought with the interpretive capabilities of communist criticism, Vattimo and Zabala have accomplished something unique and prescient. Hermeneutic Communism, while being a remarkable accomplishment in the field of Marxist theory, also contains several years’ worth of what one might call observations directed towards contemporary political events. At first, they offer a new approach to the hermeneutical approach to Marx’s famous line, ‘philosophers have only interpreted the world in various ways, the point is to change it’ by claiming this was not a classical refusal of the critical power to interpret. Rather, Vattimo and Zabala hold that Marx meant that the only way actually to change the world is to alter its interpretations. This does not necessarily mean ungrounding our social relations.

Hermeneutic Communism hangs on the precipice of a ground that has no ground, in that there are a multitude of metaphysical interpretations regarding the nature of reality, and human nature. However, Vattimo and Zabala often drift into postmodern refusals of metaphysical philosophy. I argue that this turn towards postmodernism tends to deter from the more powerful methods they create with HC. If in capitalism, all that is solid melts into air, then postmodern refusals towards any ontological

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grounding reinforce the anomic-normlessness of the alienating lack of communal social relations. Capitalism atomizes, deterring its subjects from what the Buddhists call 'unity-mind' which I see as the basis of communist social interactions. This metaphysical turn back to grounding relations in union with others is a point that should enable new and old metaphysical interpretations to emerge side by side. By attempting a fusion of post-metaphysical thought with the interpretive capabilities of communist criticism, Vattimo and Zabala have accomplished something unique and prescient. *Hermeneutic Communism*, while being a remarkable accomplishment in the field of Marxist theory, also contains several years' worth of what one might call observations directed towards contemporary political events. At first, they offer a new approach to the hermeneutical approach to Marx's famous line, 'philosophers have only interpreted the world in various ways, the point is to change it' by claiming this was not a classical refusal of the critical power to interpret. Rather, they hold that Marx meant that the only way actually to change the world is to alter its interpretations. This does not necessarily mean un-grounding our social relations.

Rather it means that production is always already social in nature. By extension, if the production serves as the economic base, and it is social, then it also recreates the antagonisms inherent in its mode of production writ large through the ideological superstructure of capitalism. Therefore, if unity-mind is the true representation of a communist ethos, togetherness in solidarity, then antagonism, difference, alienation, and other social grounds of capital are recreated ideologically in its metaphysics. Which is why there must be a post-metaphysical approach to these issues, which Vattimo and Zabala proposed, quite convincingly, in that these discursive differences, serve to give a hermeneutical basis to the homogenizing tendencies in the metaphysics of capitalist ideology (as Marx said; ideology is when they are doing it, but do not know they are doing it).

To give a hermeneutical approach to communism is to open up interpretations to cultural productions, to realize that some people actually know what they are doing, and then do not simply represent reality, but engage in actions that transform capitalism from below, at the level of the socio-economic base. It is not reliant on an all-knowing vanguard who leads the way, but rather a democratic process through the radicalization made possible by hermeneutic methods of praxis. In fact, this is precisely how direct action often unfolded in Occupy Wall Street. Taking its cue from various anarchist affinity groups, where impromptu coalitions are formed, and actions are put to immediate votes where all members of the group express a voice in the process, the hermeneutics of difference did not threaten to untangle the group, because each individual was respected and felt the right to disagree, and there was no clear cut vanguard above anyone else in a meta-physics of power, in the sense that power derives from the 'meta' realm 'above' the physical realm, but exactly the opposite, a horizontal approach to power that flattens relations, and each subject is a channel whereby power flows through each like circuits on an electrical power grid.

The post-metaphysics of power forms flows, breaks, channels, rather than lords and bondsmen, masters and slaves, leaders and followers, it is a vast array of subjects

who do not objectify any-*thing*, including power. It is like the Zapatistas who have no clear leader metaphysically above the rest of the commune, but a Sub-Commander who enacts the will of the people from below, from the base, a leader who actually serves. Sub-Commander Marcos is not a leader in the classical sense, often criticized by Foucault, as aura-building monarch acceding to the throne of moral-governance. The classical notion of power 'from above' is outmoded, and in the new post-metaphysics, power-lines are transversally drawn diagonally intersecting the subdivisions with which it coextensively resonates.

Agency within this nexus flows through discursive enunciations that rupture the social fabric of capital in a fashion contingent upon situational circumstances, and not a result of immutable, essential, or intransigent qualities in the being of beings in a universal or absolute sense. Yet it seems that there is a tendency among scholars whose work overlaps with hermeneutics to look at these constructions as being aporia laden. In opening up discourse to various disagreements, one must also struggle with the antinomies of aporia.

With dialectics the goal is to synthesize differences and push history forward through the resolution (and revolution) of differences. Yet, in Vattimo and Zabala, there is a tendency to restrict the dialectical aspects of Marxist philosophy to bolster a postmodern play of antinomies. In my opinion, and I can be wrong on the issue, this irresolvable play of differences can be a bit violent at times. The play can turn into relations that are un-playful. When there is a complete absence of 'unity-mind' and no discursive common ground to work in solidarity with other concerned allies on an important political issue, it does not always follow that violence occurs, but one cannot help but think that the play of difference could make antagonistic social relations the norm.

This seems to be my biggest critique when they evoke a philosopher like Friedrich Nietzsche, who I greatly admire, but who I also view as fundamentally opposed to the communist project. One cannot ignore the myriad of passages in Nietzsche where the concept of socialism is viewed as being a slave-morality tied to Christian decadence which means to turn Nietzsche into a hermeneutic communist one must take a highly selective reading of his work. One must negate the hermeneutics in the hermeneutic communism by disregarding large swaths of Nietzsche's writings.

However, in taking a hermeneutical approach to political discourse, which I take to be the overarching concern of Vattimo and Zabala's book, thinkers can begin to infuse non-Western approaches to political theory. Incorporating influences from Far Eastern, African, and Latin American thought can create new methodologies geared towards radical peace studies. If the goal is to give more information to scholars by infusing other political experiences into the communist conversation, this will hopefully bring a superior understanding of the 'other' side and lead to a decrease in political violence, and broaden our sense of the global community that we all inhabit together.

This might be viewed as a retraction into neo-classical liberalism akin to Immanuel Kant's cosmopolitan citizenry, which was outlined in his treatise entitled "On Perpetual Peace." But this distinction does arise on the basis that Vattimo and Zabala are not looking to create world peace where everyone resolves to be the

same in a dialectical synthesis of differences, but rather a place where peace occurs through the free expression of our discursive difference. Their 'unity-mind' does not ameliorate differences, but unlocks its possibility.

With the death of Modernity and Metaphysics, the ground has slid into a differential social abyss whereby skeptics of modernist utopian projects have grown weary of all progressive political projects. Utopia is by its definition a metaphysical concept in that it is 'no-where' in the physical realm. Therefore, a post-metaphysical turn in hermeneutical communism also marks the death of all utopian variations of communism in favor of broadening the interpretations and applications of the term by binding it to a radical sense of materialism.

The question that I thought about while reading *Hermeneutic Communism* was whether or not there could be this radical sense of materialism without resorting to what they called, 'scientific realism' along the lines of work perpetuated by analytical philosophers. For instance, in their scathing critique of John Searle they posit an argument that I happen to agree with which is that analytical philosophy has become hegemonic in American Philosophy departments, but beyond merely stating the obvious, they go even further to claim that American military hegemony is perpetuated by allegedly objective truth claims put forward by thinkers like Searle. This was made patently clear when President George W. Bush honored Searle at a White House Ceremony, and that this perpetuates ideas laid out by other notable conservative thinkers like Francis Fukuyama whose work claimed that neo-classical liberal capitalism is the 'end of history' and that wars must be waged to bring about a 'winners history' that perpetuates these ideas because their allegedly objective conclusions clearly show that this is the 'best' social and political system ever known.

To be honest, when I first read this I found it hard to believe that President Bush needed scientific realism to back up his colonial foreign policies. After all he was a self-proclaimed born again Evangelical Christian, who supported irrational anti-scientific policies while in office like teaching Biblical Creationism in high school science classes beside the Theory of Evolution, and put things into the National Parks like books claiming that carbon dating was not perfect science and that this meant science could not conclude that dinosaur bones were any older than six thousand years old, and that global warming was not proven beyond a reasonable doubt. These beliefs that became much more common under the Bush Administration would chip away at science to placate right wing religious and capitalist forces like the oil industry, two interests where Bush garnered most of his financial support during both of his presidential campaigns.

Upon further reflection the point put forward by Vattimo and Zabala holds up, precisely because their point is in my opinion an Althusserian one, rather than a point about political economy, it is a point made about the 'repressive apparatuses' in the military that could not exist without scientific realism. Precisely, the increased funding in military spending that occurred during the Bush Administration's errand in the wilderness of Iraq and Afghanistan would invest in scientific research only if this resulted in highly developed and sophisticated military technology like unmanned drones, which would appease the American middle class voting public which had grown weary of the war, by lowering American casualties

Yet, ironically, this double speak, which was a lynchpin of John McCain's losing campaign banked in the idea that somehow the American voters would ultimately stomach the Iraqi and Afghan casualties without questioning whether or not there were innocent lives at stake on the other side or that American drone attacks were somehow precise enough to not mistakenly kill innocent bystanders.

These are the basic ideological premises put forward by the superstructure that are necessitated by scientific realism, and this is opposed to materialism in the communist sense. The reason that materialism is different is that the communist community extends to the entire world. Communists care about the casualties in Iraq and Afghanistan because as Michael Hardt and Antonio Negri posit eloquently in their *Empire Trilogy*, nationalisms always exist to divide the working class against itself, and against classes below the workers (i.e. the lumpenproletariat) because this keeps the working class looking downward rather than pointing upwards toward those at the helm of the ideological state apparatuses. Communist materialism does not differentiate between 'us' and 'them', or friends and enemies in the sense of nationalistic communities, rather, oppression is the biggest concern of materialist communism, which is something that extends beyond provincial notions of community, into trans-national and global concerns.

Nationalism is one *modus operandi* of the metaphysics of power. It concedes that there are leaders and followers, commanders and soldiers, which is the methodology of repressive apparatuses perpetuated by fear tactics and illusory social divisions; like race and gender, which some argue are colonial constructions, not all pre-capitalist societies utilize these labels, but again scientific realism posits that these differences are biological and genetic, which somehow proves they objectively exist, beyond a reasonable doubt.

In explaining the metaphysics of power at stake in the ideological superstructure, Antonio Gramsci emphasized how hegemony works (and does not work) at a nationalistic level:

The supremacy of a social group manifests itself in two ways, as "domination" and as "intellectual and moral leadership". A social group dominates antagonistic groups, which it tends to liquidate, or to subjugate perhaps even by armed force; it leads kindred or allied groups. A social group can, and indeed must, already exercise "leadership" before winning governmental power (this indeed is one of the principle conditions for winning such power); it subsequently becomes dominant when it exercises power, but even if it holds it firmly in its grasp, it must continue to "lead" as well. ([1]: 57–8)

This quote summarizes that the hegemonic class needs to put forward its moral ideas as the norm. Who to marry (or whether to get married at all), how to act, what actions are criminal (i.e. stealing a loaf of bread because you are starving is illegal, but it is legal for corporations to steal billions from taxpayers in the form of bailouts and corporate welfare), and basically what constitutes an ethical relationship, and the bourgeoisie, if as most Marxists posit there is a confluence between the interests of collective capital and the policies of the state over the long haul, hold a monopoly on violence which stems from control of the state.

The subtle combination of consent and coercion is contingent upon the use of force. Coercion implies the use of force, typically the threat of death, and consent

implies the use of moral leadership to gain control over a subjugated population. Which means that hegemony can be obtained through a combination of physical violence and discursive conversion to a pre-set agenda. Therefore, opening up differentially discursive communities, that is, communities that stay together by presupposing that the group is posited as a heterogeneous set of antagonisms, rather than integrating its subjects into a homogeneous unity, presupposes that a hermeneutic communism can succeed. Yet, can this a-priori norm of difference all that it takes? I believe it is, precisely because the bourgeoisie, if we take the formerly discussed set of homogenizing norms laid out by any ideological superstructure is premised on establishing notions of truth that are transcendental and universal, which the proletariat can reveal to be merely powerful gimmicks of the bourgeoisie. Values that seem irrational can become the new norm, which will then be trounced by new antinomies that rise against the new rational, which was previously irrational.

This is the dance of postmodern anti-metaphysics, which is being against established social norms and hegemonic lexicons, which Vattimo and Zabala are right to point out, hegemonic discourses often present their notions as sane, rational, normal, and objectively correct in an absolute sense. Historically capitalism and fascism have been dictated by deleterious moral-intellectual leadership enabled by continuing political and economic subordination, not to mention the perpetual omni-crises, be it a foreign security threat in the case of Al Qaeda, or an internal security threat in the form of Nazi demonizing of the Jews, Gypsies, Communists, and Homosexuals, which presents a wedge-tactic preventing the working class from mounting an insurgency against the hegemonic class (the bourgeoisie) by imposing discourses that substantiate real or perceived existential threats to the entire body politic. A hermeneutic communism posits a genuinely democratic polis with the cultivation of truly organic intellectuals in step with the will of the proletariat that mirror the formal unity of the community rooted in the people's lives, rather than imposing 'policies' from above.

The Marxist Cultural Critic, E. San Juan Jr. makes this point in a little known book entitled; *Critique and Social Transformation: Lessons from Antonio Gramsci, Mikhail Bakhtin, and Raymond Williams*. The claim provided by Gramsci in this text is that every given socio-historical moment is always already heterogeneous, and it is rich in contradictions. Historical events unfold as moments that eventually acquire personalities as contrasts, struggles, peaks and valleys. Which in a somewhat dated form, San Juan Jr. claims reveals a tendency to reproduce the oppressive structures that the revolution claims to rebel against. A totally new praxis with the most communistic intentions is never completely immune to hierarchical relations of power. If communists let in anyone and everyone then this ultimately means joining in solidarity with some degenerate and backwards thinking immoralists. Revolutionaries need not only a new discursive set of relations which were to base themselves on clearing a path towards existential and ontological openness to any and all hermeneutic interpretations but a fundamentally altered set of ontological-micro-political-relations. A postmodern tendency, antithetical to long-term praxis, is to force the revolutionary subject to fly off prematurely in nucleic lines of flight

not yet fully formed. Entrenchment and retrenchment is a necessary precondition of a drawn out struggle, a permanent revolution as Trotsky claimed, but not one that loses sight of the penultimate goal which is a classless society where the metaphysics of power (power from above) is so antiquated it is thinkable as an artifact in a museum, an archaeological object thought to be nothing more than a vestige of capitalism; the archaic pre-history of communism. Marxists need not study the pre-communist modes of production (capitalism, feudalism, etc.) like the ape holding the key to man, rather than communism holding the key to placating the omni-crises in capitalism.

Reference

1. Gramsci, Antonio. 1971. *Selections from the prison notebooks*. New York: International Publishers.

Response to Kaye

Gianni Vattimo and Santiago Zabala

Kaye, together with Pepe Escobar,¹ was among the first to write a review of *Hermeneutic Communism*.² Similarly to the Brazilian investigative journalist, Kaye, from the beginning of his review (and contribution in this volume), points out how our book “contains several year’s worth of what one might call observations directed towards contemporary political events.” These “observations” are a significant part of our project which reviewers have either rejected as too journalistic or praise for its attempt to break away from the professionalism of traditional academic texts. In a way, we’re following Richard Rorty when he suggested that “philosophy books should be in the future, less pretentious, less professionalized, less priggish, less guarded, funnier, more poetic and perhaps more sexier than those of the past.”

Although our book was primarily a philosophical contribution to Marxism, that is, for an audience concerned in political philosophy, we were also interested to shake its metaphysical impositions from above. Kaye notices this when he points out that to “give a hermeneutical approach to communism is to open up interpretations to cultural productions, to realize that some people actually know what they are doing, and then do not simply represent reality, but engage in actions that transform capitalism from below, at the level of the socio-economic base.” This action is not only part of our “observations” mentioned above, but also of the “hermeneutic method of praxis” which is particularly apt to promote a “horizontal approach to power.” But where else, besides South America, has this approach taken place?

¹Pepe Escobar, “Occupy Wall Street,” in *Asia Times*, October 19, 2011. http://www.atimes.com/atimes/Global_Economy/MJ19Dj02.html

²B. Kaye, *Hermeneutic Communism*, a Review, in *Marx & Philosophy*, February 27, 2012. <http://marxandphilosophy.org.uk/reviewofbooks/reviews/2012/479>

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This “horizontal approach to power,” according to Kaye, is not only evident in South American politics, but also in the Occupy Wall Street movement, which he seems to prefer. But why has this movement not been capable obtaining any power in the US while in Spain it has found parliamentary representation through Podemos? The answer does not simply rest in the different sociopolitical customs of each nation, but also in the movements ability to transform into a Party as it occurred in Bolivia and Venezuela. Although Bernie Sanders to a certain extent incorporated this movement during the primaries in 2016, there was no doubt it could never beat Hilary Clinton in the primaries, who represented the stability, continuation, and realism of framed democracies. In order to overcome these frames, as we explained throughout *Hermeneutic Communism*, it is necessary to join the democratic representative institutions that sustains them.

Kaye is dubious of our faith in postmodernism. This is not only evident in his belief that postmodernism reinforces capitalism’s “alienating lack of communal social relations,” but also in our distrust in dialectics abilities to “synthesize difference and push history forward through the resolution (and revolution) of differences.” While we disagree that postmodernism has these counterproductive effects, dialectics is certainly incapable of promoting a revolution as the political failures of nineteenth century socialism demonstrated. This is why we have restricted, as Kaye points out, “the dialectical aspects of Marxist philosophy to bolster a postmodern play of antinomies.” This restriction was not necessary because the “irresolvable play of difference” of postmodernism and hermeneutics is “truer” than the dialectical “synthesizing of differences,” but rather fairer towards the weak. Kaye is correct when he stresses how an “irresolvable play of differences can be a bit violent at times,” but ignores how the absence of violence is much worse. This is why we often evoked Heidegger’s emergency thesis: “the greatest emergency is the absence of emergency.”

In order to understand the violence hermeneutic communists endorse, promote, and practice it is first necessary to acknowledge that it is nothing in comparison to those of metaphysical philosophers. This is why we began our book recalling John Searle and G. W. Bush’s “social political ontology” and how continental thinkers are relegated to the margins of academia. In sum, what Kaye says about revolutionaries (they not only need “a new discursive set of relations which were to base themselves on clearing a path towards existential and ontological openness to any and all hermeneutic interpretations but a fundamentally altered set of ontological-micro-political-relations”) can also be applied to metaphysical thinkers which today are returning to reaffirm the absence of emergency.

The Dangerous Divide: Between Weak Thought and Practical Politics

Lucas Ross Perkins and Michael Allen Gillespie

Abstract Gianni Vattimo and Santiago Zabala's *Hermeneutic Communism: From Heidegger to Marx* presents itself as a book offering political guidance to the world's downtrodden and as an antidote to the forms of thought and power that repress and exclude the weak. We take hermeneutic communism to be the more overtly political program corresponding to Vattimo's so-called weak thought, and argue (a) that weak thought is a potentially powerful form of thinking, whose contributions should be seen as primarily *ethical*, and (b) that the jump from the ethical (weak thought) to the political (hermeneutic communism) within the book is an awkward one at best. If we adopt a proper conception of the political as a tragic sphere perpetually demanding decisions from us on the ground, then we must hold serious doubts as to the potential contribution to politics as a form of thinking operating at such a high level of generality. Furthermore, the existing political movements and institutions praised by Vattimo and Zabala (including e.g. the regime of Hugo Chávez) seem to have little discernible connection with the basic thrust of the books' more philosophical claims. In general, we seek to cast doubt upon the potential political contributions not only of weak thought but also of all similarly-rooted forms of epochal thinking, but also to argue that those forms of thinking might be of great value to our understanding of ethics in a post-modern age.

Gianni Vattimo and Santiago Zabala's *Hermeneutic Communism: From Heidegger to Marx* presents itself as a book offering political guidance to the world's downtrodden and as an antidote to the forms of thought and power that repress and exclude the weak. It seeks to provide counsel on how to "construct true alternatives upon the ruins of Western industrial capitalism."¹ In our response to the book, we take hermeneutic communism to be the more overtly political program corresponding to Vattimo's so-called weak thought, and argue (a) that the jump from the meta-ethical (weak thought) to the political (hermeneutic communism) within the book is fraught with problems because it pays insufficient attention to the chasm that

¹ *Hermeneutic Communism*, 135.

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separates the epochal and the political, and (b) that the political developments championed in *Hermeneutic Communism* (most notably the regime of Hugo Chávez) bear little discernible relation to weak thought.

Yet while we seek to cast doubt upon the potential *political* contributions not only of weak thought but also of all similarly-rooted forms of epochal thinking, we also wish to argue that those forms of thinking might nonetheless be of great value to our understanding of our *meta-ethical situation* in a postmodern age. We also suggest alternative political exemplars for hermeneutic communism that are truer to its philosophical underpinnings.

Technology, Epochal Thinking, and the Link to Heidegger

To begin, we should make it clear that we understand weak thought as a specific variety of post-Heideggerian thinking. We are, of course, far from alone in this characterization. But we think it is important to clarify specifically what *kind* of post-Heideggerian thinking it is and to attempt to root it in particular undercurrents of that tradition. Once we do so, we will be in a better position to see weak thought as a form of *epochal* thinking.

After his so-called “turn” away from the Dasein-centric orientation of his earlier works, Heidegger sought to lay out the fundamental lineaments (*Grundzüge*) of the West in terms of the history of being (*Seinsgeschichte*), which is perhaps better understood as the history of the West’s experience of and encounter with being. This history begins with humans confronting a world that is fundamentally inimical to their projects and indifferent to their potential flourishing, a world that presents itself to humans as fundamentally alien. Over time, and via certain crucial turning points, our relationship with being changed. Within this new relationship we began learning how to assert ourselves in the world—Hans Blumenberg would later call it self-assertion (*Selbstbehauptung*)—and to use being as a tool in pursuit of our various aims: expanding production, increasing our material standard of living, prolonging our lifespan, and fortifying ourselves against those vicissitudes of fate in the hope of collectively combating them.

For Heidegger, the results of this process might *appear* from the outside to betoken a gradual but relentless linear development, or what we typically call progress. However, in Heidegger’s view, this process was not progressive but was the result of a series of qualitative leaps that have given rise to a succession of different *epochs* of being. For Heidegger, following Nietzsche, the ancient Greeks were the first to systematically “formalize” being and to posit a rational supra-sensible order subtending phenomena. For Heidegger this was not the inevitable consequence of historical development but the result of the Greek response to a new question that confronted them. The pre-philosophic Greeks lived in a world that was ruled by divine powers of all kinds. Each thing was inhabited and/or characterized by a par-

ticular divine power or attribute. Things in this sense were not beings in a materialistic sense but “personalities.” This epoch was formed by humans in response to the appearance of the question of being as the who-question.

The epoch characterized by philosophic thought began with a different question, the what-question, which asked not about the “personality” of things but about their substance or materiality. The modern age, by contrast, begins with the how-question. In this epoch, we ask not who or what something is but rather how it works. Galileo, Descartes, and Newton, to mention only the most famous, thus develop a world-picture (*Weltbild*), in which the world emerges as a mathematical representation of causal processes that detail how things come into being and pass away. Understanding how things work enables us to manipulate nature technologically, to avoid the consequences we fear and obtain the results we desire. Armed with the scientific knowledge of how things work, humans can imagine becoming the masters and possessors of nature, and thus undertaking projects ranging from modern medicine to world war. As Bacon indicated, long before Foucault, knowledge in the modern age becomes power.

This historical trajectory in Heidegger’s view culminates in an era—our own—in which *techne* thoroughly dominates human concerns. We occupy ourselves with maintaining and refining a vast machine that appears to do what we want it to but that in fact turns *us* into *its* servants and appendages. The science and technology that enable us to master nature also transform our own nature into something that can be dominated, transformed, and controlled. The machines and the attendant economic system that allow us to become the masters of things end up constraining us in a variety of ways to follow the productive pathways they open up. In this way, and with no one in particular to blame, we become both technocrats and techno-subjects living (*leben*) but not dwelling (*wohnen*) in modern techno-states.

The early Heidegger imagined that it would be possible to break free from our bondage to technology and pursue more human goals through a reassertion of practical or *phronetic* thinking that was concerned not so much with human making as with human doing and thus less with discovering the *means* of successful human striving and more with determining the *ends* for which we strive. He did not imagine that it would be possible in this way to think the world as something other than a “how.” But he did believe that it would be possible to change the mode of our how-thinking from a focus on *techne* to a focus on *phronesis* or practical wisdom, from a concern with individualism and economic productivity to a more communitarian concern with the goals of the *Volk* or the nation.² It was this project that led him to support National Socialism. In his later thought, he adopted a somewhat different approach, seeking to overcome this epoch by means of a new kind of thinking aimed at overcoming the technological nihilism of our time. According to Vattimo—and here we would agree—Heidegger does not mean overcoming in the

²For a fuller account of this Heideggerian move, see Michael Allen Gillespie, “Martin Heidegger’s Aristotelian National Socialism,” *Political Theory* 28, no. 2 (April, 2000):140–66.

sense that the technological age is discarded and superseded (as in the German *Überwindung*), but rather more accurately in the sense of *Verwindung*, a word that Vattimo rightly employs again and again. Our experience of being needs to be “worked through;” its limitations and drawbacks need to be seen for what they are. Many of us probably entertain an inkling of what may lie on the other side of that working through, but all we can know for certain is that its contours cannot be anticipated in full.

As a matter of philosophical principle, Heidegger thus never even attempts to delineate what comes after the technological age, or even *if* the “next” age would have epochal characteristics at all (Reiner Schürmann, for one, argues forcefully in his *Heidegger on Being and Acting* that what comes “after” is not just another epoch subtended by principles, but rather something far stranger and, in his words, anarchic). Vattimo is a provocative thinker on these questions because he accepts much of Heidegger’s basic story about the history of the West and its culmination in technology but seeks a kind of salvation *from* technology *within* the technological age itself. For the *Seinsgeschichte* of technology, as he sees it, culminates in the internet and globalization. Long ago we set the ball in motion to fulfill our basic needs and to rule over nature in a way commensurate with our own flourishing, and we ended up producing a deeply interconnected world in which human beings share unprecedented access to other modes of being.

Where Vattimo absolutely departs from Heidegger is in his explicit setting of the epochal drama of being against the background of Christian eschatology. For Vattimo, our era is one in which a variety of technological advancements, such as the internet, cloud computing, and the 24-h media environment,³ actually bend back upon and gnaw away at the fundamentals of the technological age. As Matthias Riedl has pointed out, Vattimo draws a direct analogy between our postmodernity and the Age of the Spirit of Joachim of Fiore. As the result of a deep personal religious experience, he concludes that his weak thought is nothing other than a transcription of the New Testament idea of God becoming man. Christ, in Vattimo’s view, came into the world and died on the cross to reveal the chasm between power and holiness and to eliminate it. Vattimo sees his thought playing a similar role, revealing the violence of metaphysical notions of truth in the service of hegemonic power and opening up a conception of interpretation that not only undermines such truth claims but offers the foundation for a multiplicitous and more perspectival understanding of existence. Such an understanding cannot help but aid the “losers of history” in loosening structures of power rooted in metaphysics.

Santiago Zabala has augmented Vattimo’s project in fundamental ways and has listened to the same “appeal of Being,” but has deepened and expanded elements of Vattimo’s project. Zabala concurs that Being is no longer with us in the way it once was. But he provides a much more nuanced picture than one can find in Vattimo of the “remains” with which we continue to grapple in philosophy. In his *Remains of*

³ *The Transparent Society* (Baltimore: Johns Hopkins University Press, 1992).

Being, Zabala grapples with a range of thinkers that share in the general thrust of the late Heidegger's thinking but differ in what they take to be its implications for us and, more importantly, in what they take to be a proper point for thinking beyond the technological age: for Derrida the trace, for Schürmann "principal anarchy," and so on. What Zabala implicitly endorses in the book is an epochal sensibility: all of the thinkers he discusses share the deep conviction that we are in the twilight of something and on the precipice of the dawn of something else.

Hermeneutic Communism seeks to provide suggestions as to what that dawn looks like today, and it is here that it begins to go astray in spite of its often sound philosophical foundations.

The Mismatch Between the Epochal and the Political

We broadly share Zabala's engaging assessment of post-Heideggerian thinking in *Remains of Being*, as well as Vattimo and Zabala's desire for a "productive post-metaphysical philosophy." We find elements of post-Heideggerian thinking—a style of thinking wary of finalized formulations of truth, being, and law but unsure of how else to proceed—compelling as high philosophy. We even share their antipathy to the idea that politics can have a purely "rational" ground seamlessly rooted in scientific realism (a view held by many political scientists), as well as their aversion to the contemporary Chinese model of governance, to Soviet communism, and other historical forces (against contemporary thinkers like Alain Badiou who often suggest otherwise). We find value in their critique of "framed democracy" as practiced by Fox News, Russia Today, and others. And we find an updated Heideggerian Marxism (or Marxist Heideggerianism if you prefer) to be a worthy intellectual project, particularly in light of how truly dated thinkers like Herbert Marcuse have become.

But when we begin to examine the attempt by Vattimo and Zabala to bridge the divide between this form of thinking and politics, we find little more than a thicket of problems and exaggerations that are quite simply *endemic* to epochal thinking. The deep mismatch between epochal thinking and politics is in fact a profound and intractable problem for the central claims of *Hermeneutic Communism* about what weak thought could or should look like in the political wild.

In what, then, does this mismatch consist? We feel that the problem is that the intended effect of epochal thinking is emphatically *not* to provide historical actors with concrete plans for action but rather to provide them with something akin to worldviews or world-orientations. So far, so good. We would never *expect* epochal thinking to provide specific plans, projects, or even goals. Neither Vattimo and Zabala nor the late Heidegger can be expected to write a *Rules for Radicals* or even a *Politics as a Vocation* and remain true to their philosophical vision.

But when they remain within the philosophical boundaries that they themselves set, thinkers like Vattimo and Zabala—not to mention Jean-Luc Nancy, Reiner Schürmann, Heidegger himself, and others—can perhaps provide historical actors with basic *signposts* for getting by in history. We might even venture to call it something like “cognitive mapping,” to use a term Fredric Jameson has made popular, at the most basic possible level. Epochal thinking is intended to lay out the basic contours of an age, to cull together the disparate strands of experience into a broader picture, to make suggestions about what the future may hold that is qualitatively different from the past and present, and to advocate a path for political resistance and action that may get us there.

For Heidegger, this meant making the humans of the twentieth century aware of just how thoroughly dominated by *techne* the world had become and just how little the dominant political “solutions” were able to cure or even address this disease. Understanding history epochally as the ever-intensifying ascendance of technology is intended to inspire a deep concern in us for the basic trajectory of the lived world as well as a longing for something fundamentally other, for a way out. Vattimo’s understanding of history is similarly epochal—and not fully antagonistic to Heidegger’s—but it has different foci and different prognostications. For Vattimo, the history of the West (which at some point became the history of the world, whether the non-West wanted it to be or not) involves the triumph of interpretation, of hermeneutics in his very specific understanding, over truth and correspondingly over being. Vattimo’s intention in producing this epochal history is to inspire us to go with the flow, so to speak, to help truth die a merciful death and to loosen its hold over our lives and our politics. As we discussed earlier, Vattimo even goes so far as to portray the weakening of truth in terms of a Joachite, tripartite conception of history, in which history is divided up into an age of the Father, of the Son, and of the Spirit. In this context post-modernism and the weakening of being amount to the Age of Spirit prophesied by Joachim of Fiore in the thirteenth century.

The aims of epochal thinking are thus *formally* identical for both Heidegger and Vattimo, even if the resulting *content*—that is, the actual story itself—diverges in deep ways. But they also share the same “formal” problem: they both have extreme if not constitutive difficulty in bridging the chasm between epochal history and the social/political realms. The *aims* of epochal history are always political in the largest sense, even if someone like the later Heidegger is famously coy about making political pronouncements. But the result of epochal thinking is always that it *ends up confusing will and fate, destiny and project*.

For Heidegger, the technological age is so totalizing that it establishes the entire staging ground for our possibilities and also everything that we must overcome in certain fundamental ways. The fate of being itself is in fact so all-engulfing that it becomes impossible for him to distinguish, for example, between the production of fertilizer and the production of corpses in a concentration camp, or more generally between different kinds of economic systems or political regimes. Viewed epochally, everything, as he puts it, is “metaphysically the same.”

For Vattimo, the postmodern Age of Spirit, in which technology and a variety of other factors have been obliterating truth, is both our destiny and also a global project. As our most important tool in fulfilling that project, Vattimo gives us hermeneutics. Vattimo was a student of Karl Löwith and Hans-Georg Gadamer (themselves both students of Heidegger). Gadamer in particular is well known as an if not the central figure in the hermeneutic school that played such an important role in continental thought in the second half of the twentieth century. His hermeneutics, which deeply depend upon tradition, have generally been considered to be quietistic or conservative, in stark contrast to the more leftist views of the Frankfurt School and Habermas in particular. Vattimo, however, argues that hermeneutics properly understood are not conservative but liberationist. Indeed he and Zabala claim that “hermeneutics is more a ‘critical theory’ than the work of the Frankfurt School, since it does not need to ground its critical function on metaphysical ideals.”

In *Hermeneutic Communism*, Vattimo and Zabala go one step further, arguing that even hermeneutics “by itself” is not enough. The realization of the world that they think is already on the way demands a fusion between hermeneutics and communism (in the very specific way in which they understand the term). “Weak thought” indeed has a political vision that corresponds to it, and in *Hermeneutic Communism* Vattimo and Zabala flesh out that politics more comprehensively than they do in any of their other works.

The Mismatch Between Epochal and Political as Manifested in *Hermeneutic Communism*

As we stated at the outset, we have very deep reservations about some of the specific political allegiances of the book. Our primary aim, though, is not to criticize those allegiances directly, but rather to point out that the *kinds* of allegiance on display in *Hermeneutic Communism* are at odds with the philosophical spirit that animates weak thought and hermeneutic communism as an ethico-political vision.

Perhaps the best way to make sense of what Vattimo and Zabala are up to is to view their project not against notions of political revolution and reform that grew up out of the Western metaphysical tradition and that have become standard features of our technological age, but rather against a different model that Vattimo explicitly evokes in his discussion of weak thought, the Christian vision of a history of salvation (*Heilsgeschichte*). Underlying such a historical approach is a vision of the future that does not develop out of a Gadamerian fusion of horizons but comes into being as the result of a radical rejection of the current world in favor of a new one. To their credit, Vattimo and Zabala recognize that there can be no simple reversal of existing arrangements without remaining dependent upon them, but they do depend on a somewhat more complicated reversal to frame the values that they believe need to shape future policy. In place of the rule of the powerful, they thus propose rule in

favor of the weak, by which they generally mean the poor. They do not aim, however, to bring the poor to power but to ultimately eliminate classes altogether. Like the early Heidegger, their goal is broadly communitarian. But in contrast to Heidegger's Platonic vision of a hierarchical, *volkisch* state of laborers, warriors, and knowledge workers, they imagine the coming into being of a world in which the meek and the weak inherit the earth.

Their vision of community is thus much more (and at times explicitly) Christian. This adoption of a Christian framework shapes their vision of the prevailing social reality. Viewed from this perspective the metaphysically constituted Western world that Vattimo and Zabala describe is analogous to the corrupt and sinful city of the pagans and is juxtaposed against a future city of God revealed to us by the proper "Biblically informed" interpretation of the social world. Instead of metaphysical and scientific modes of interpretation, which rely upon more familiar notions of efficient causation, and which Vattimo and Zabala see as the source of our current problems, they employ a hermeneutic that is at least structurally theological in that it is driven and determined by the notion of apocalyptic transformation and a new beginning. The necessity that they impute to the historical process, is thus driven by the inevitable end and everything that stands in the way of his development including almost all of modern liberal society is construed to be merely a result of the (pagan) lust for domination and concupiscence.

Ironically, the account that they develop on this foundation is little short of Manichean. The West, like Augustine's city of the pagans, is thoroughly corrupt and irredeemable. Such a totalistic rejection of this epoch, however, is fundamentally at odds with the openness and generosity of weak thought itself. In turning to politics their hermeneutics thus ceases to be multiperspectival and tentative, and becomes instead a tool of a proto-Christian dogmatism, that rests upon an existential commitment to the service to or defense of the weak and powerless. As in the case of Augustine, they thus imagine that they and those they admire are always on the side of the angels, but they can give us no explanation for why their side is angelic rather than demonic. In fact, in every instance of a political fact that seems to contradict their claims, they explain it away as an inevitable consequence of having to deal with the corrupt Western world. In this way, they overcome what is often thought to be the quietism of hermeneutics but only by plunging into an anti-metaphysical dogmatism.

Their praise of the regimes of Chávez et al and their use of them as exemplars for the future in a surprising way resembles the account that the Christian Marxist Ernst Bloch gave of the East German regime in his *Principle of Hope* (1938–47). He too presented a philosophy rooted in aspirations for a radically different future, but to make his vision believable and thus more than a utopian dream, he needed to find an actually existing regime that could plausibly serve as a concrete example that hope could attach to. He chose the East German regime which he believed or at least imagined was such a realized ideal. While it is understandable that faith seeks some

justification in the actual world, epochal thought faces great dangers when it attaches itself to existing regimes.

Bloch and Heidegger are cautionary examples of such dangers that Vattimo and Zabala and indeed all epochal thinkers need to heed lest they find themselves entangled in similar political quagmires. And yet they restrict the potential meaning of hermeneutic communism far more than they need to, asserting that “if ‘hermeneutic communism’ must be proven practically, we are convinced that it can be found in these Latin American democracies [Venezuela, Bolivia, etc.] that have constructed themselves along the lines of the Cuban resistance.” The problem here is that *Hermeneutic Communism* could have chosen, for example, a broadly participatory social movement as its example. Choosing Chávez et al as privileged signifiers strikes us as awkward at best, and completely inimical to the philosophical thrust of hermeneutic communism at worst. While it’s certainly unfair to criticize Vattimo and Zabala for releasing the book prior to events like the Occupy movement and the Arab Spring, it strikes us as beyond question that those kinds of movements—committed to equality and participation not just in their aims but also in their concrete methods—are far more in keeping with the spirit of hermeneutic communism. Such movements could even, presumably, *learn* a great deal from thinkers like Vattimo and Zabala. A style of thinking like hermeneutic communism, with its ethico-political emphasis on generosity, receptivity, openness, and caritas, might find a more-than-sympathetic audience in the Zuccotti Parks and Tahrir Squares of the world, at least among those seeking real democratic alternatives and reforms. Conversely, it is unclear what traditional state actors—be they Chávez, Morales, Obama, or anyone else—would stand to learn from hermeneutic communism in the first place.

Re-thinking the Political as Tragic

As we insisted above, our problems with the book are not primarily due to the political choices it makes or to the political developments and figures it supports. Suffice it to say that their choice of Hugo Chávez is quite troubling on its own (the choice of Evo Morales and Lula much less so). Even Noam Chomsky, who is cited frequently in *Hermeneutic Communism* and whom Chávez himself has described as a major inspiration, has offered very blunt criticisms of Chávez, calling Chávez’s concentration of executive power as “an assault on democracy” and has decried the detention of the judge Maria Lourdes Afiuni and called for her release in a public letter. For us, the deeper problem is not to be found in the championing of Chávez et al, but rather in the fact that we harbor a conception of the political that in itself does not and cannot fit nicely with the epochal narratives that undergird the book’s more philosophical and historical claims.

The conception of the political to which we adhere is essentially *tragic*. We see the political realm, especially the commanding heights of state power, as one that demands from us in-the-moment, or, if we want to think in more explicitly Heideggerian terms, *kairotic*, decision-making in an inherently pluralistic space. Following Arendt, the political space is structured by ever-shifting horizons of possibility and impossibility. The work of the political always transpires at this nexus.

When we begin seeing the political this way, then the value of weak thought's epochal thinking for politics becomes far less clear. There is nothing wrong *per se* with using epochal thinking to establish regulative ideals as Augustine does in the *City of God* and/or to attempt to illuminate what spirit or world-historical thrust or cherished idol animates the age. Indeed, the direct antipode of epochal thinking would be a form of political thinking so mired in concrete particularity that we could hardly call it "political" in any meaningful sense. But we must recognize that there is always a loss that we incur when we engage in epochal thinking. We gain generality and are able to offer basic spiritual signposts and weather vanes, but it also becomes vastly more difficult to locate concrete actors, movements, and tendencies that neatly match wavelengths with the fruits of epochal thinking.

For actors "on the ground," constantly forced to make difficult decisions between principle and expediency and between strategy and tactics, epochal thinking immediately reaches a kind of exhaustion. The tragedy of the political lies in the fact that our horizons of possibility and impossibility are never fixed or stable. In other words, there's never an Archimedean structuring point (and one doesn't have to be steeped in Derrida's "Structure, Sign, and Play" and the style of thinking it inaugurated to have a deep intuition of this structural lack at the heart of the political). In reaching any decision it is thus necessary to consider matters from multiple different perspectives. Some ways of interpreting the situation may offer us a preferable point of view in terms of our ultimate goal but this will not always be the case and will always depend a great deal on the character of the question itself. It may be true that the predominant way of thinking in the present views these decision spaces in terms of a technical/economic reasoning but this is certainly not the only form of reasoning that individuals and groups employ. Here, Vattimo's and Zabala's reliance on Heidegger's vision of the totalizing character of all epochal thinking leads them astray. It may be necessary to avoid or resist domination by technical/economic rationality, but this does not mean that we can reject all such reasoning as wrong-headed or a manifestation of the lust for domination, or that we can simply follow a thoroughly anti-technical rationality that valorizes the weak above all else—that is, those who are less able to compete in the world interpreted technically/economically. Such a stance is in fact just another form of decisionism that is uncritically committed to one goal or regime that may or may not be everything it proclaims itself to be.

The most fruitful forms of political thinking, if we adopt an appropriately tragic conception of the political, are those that persist in the space between epochal and

local thinking. We find weak thought most compelling when it restricts itself to the “local” pole of this divide, that is, when it counsels us to engage with others in a spirit of patience, mutual vulnerability, and love, and when it seeks to re-orient our entire ethical compass around a deeply hermeneutic conception of knowledge and engagement. In this spirit, it is a mystery to us why Vattimo and Zabala did not choose something like the American Civil Rights Movement as a privileged exemplar for the patient work they expect of hermeneutic communism (they do mention Gandhi’s marches, but only in passing and on the very last page). In the Civil Rights Movement, we see not only broadly shared aims and perspectives with hermeneutic communism—an insistence on radical equality, a deep concern for the weak, and lack of a metaphysical grounding—but also a powerful and indeed exemplary *practical instantiation* of something deeply akin to weak thought and weak action. The Civil Rights Movement certainly never shied away from traditional state politics, indeed it scarcely could have avoided it, but it also relied on deeply horizontal tactics and forms of organization, ranging from non-violent disobedience to conversations in kitchens, on porches, and throughout civil society.

It is in movements like this, alongside others like the World Social Forum (the “movement of movements”) and non-violent struggles against dictators in Myanmar, Egypt, and elsewhere, that we see the potential for an efficacious, participatory politics guided by weak thought. We see little such potential in top-down state action, even when top-down state action is truly in service of the weak. Furthermore, we’re not opposed to a transvaluation of the word communism in principle. Hardt’s and Negri’s attempt to do so in their sweeping *Empire*, for example, is not one that we would endorse, but it turns out to be far more compelling than that of Vattimo and Zabala because it so heavily emphasizes social movements and participatory democracy rather than state initiatives. And yet when speaking of their own brand of communism, Vattimo and Zabala don’t take us much further than presenting contemporary Venezuela as an “exemplary social and democratic model.” This surely cannot exhaust the political implications of weak thought.

Conclusions

Despite the deep difficulties that arise for weak thought when it turns to politics, it remains inspirational for postmodern considerations of the meta-ethical. That is, it takes seriously the idea that something is happening with Being, as Heidegger once said. Old certainties and anchors are indeed fading away into something that we do not yet grasp, and living in the twenty-first century demands recognizing this and tarrying with the consequences. Weak thought bears meta-ethical fruits not as a series of prognostications or even guidelines but rather as a series of thorny and yet extremely timely questions.

Weak thought is led into deep tension with itself, however, because it is a set of simultaneously ontological/theological and also historical claims. Weak thought

sees its task as a loosening and unwinding (*Verwindung*) of the often unseen chains of being, law, and truth. Its philosophic center of gravity lies in Gadamer's fulfillment of the ethico-political promise at the core of Heidegger's hermeneutical ontology. In contrast to Gadamer, however, Vattimo seeks to inspire confidence in us that our era is special, and that a great deal of the work of weakening the dominance of the Western notion of being lies behind us.

Hermeneutics is the art of continuously reminding ourselves that we are rooted in interpretation and not truth. It is the root of a potential "practice of an interested, projected, and active possibility," and a conviction that whatever truth or truths we discover, we only do so *through* interpretation. In a variety of venues, Vattimo carries through to its logical conclusion Gadamer's insistence that we are historical beings first and thinking consciousnesses second. A rootless, ahistorical consciousness might have a chance at discerning truth and law (if they are out there) and would be justified in molding the world in that image, perhaps even at all costs, but we are not such beings. As contingent, embodied, historical beings, we have neither the ability nor the right to do so. To put it as succinctly as possible, we think that weak thought is at its most powerful and poignant when it restricts itself to the meta-ethical realm, that is, when it seeks to inspire us to become a particular type of being and to interact with others in a spirit of patience and deference and to rein in our all-too-human tendencies to hold the products of our finite cognition as truth and our contingent ways of being as law. Weak thought holds that a non-violent way of being in the world—non-violent in all senses of the word—is the only one that is consistent with our weakness and finitude. To live otherwise is to arrogate to ourselves an ontological status that we do not possess.

Weak thought is thus at its most powerful when it inspires in us a kind of humility and charity, a recognition that we are not Nietzschean supermen or the masters and possessors of nature but finite and limited beings seeking our way through life in conjunction with others. When we're thinking and acting on this level, it becomes far more clear what it would mean to live in accordance with weak thought.

Yet the book founders in its attempt to operationalize weak thought as the political program of hermeneutic communism. *Hermeneutic Communism* often makes grand pronouncements about the justice and injustice of different political systems that weak thought itself are at best tentative and at worst vast exaggerations. The portrayals of both liberal regimes and the new socialist regimes in South America are deeply unconvincing and almost completely uncritical. Moreover, when the book turns to a consideration of actual politics, it actually has little to say about what kinds of political action should be undertaken, other than pointing to a few ad hoc examples. In part this is due to the fact that weak thought is very good at critiquing metaphysical forms of thought but lacks the foundation for a positive account of its own. Indeed, whenever weak thought moves from the critical to the constructive mode it ceases to be weak thought and suddenly becomes very strong indeed.

Political life is always tragic because we must always act on the basis of what we know at the moment and in the recognition that our knowledge is partial and that the "truth" that underlies it may cease to be "true" tomorrow. What we believe is neces-

sary in this situation is not an ungrounded decision for “the oppressed,” who after all are only the oppressed from one way of looking at things and who tomorrow may be the oppressors. Politics occurs in the moment and the notion that there are epochal solutions to the tragedy of the political almost invariably leads to disaster whether these solutions are rooted in strong or in weak thought. Politics, as Max Weber once said, is “the slow boring of hard boards.” Weak thought, we believe, is at its strongest when it promotes patience and generosity and at its weakest when it sides with state power. Sometimes less is indeed more, even in a postmodern world.

Response to Perkins and Gillespie

Gianni Vattimo and Santiago Zabala

“Weak thought, according to Perkins and Gillespie, indeed has a political vision that corresponds to it, and in *Hermeneutic Communism* Vattimo and Zabala flesh out that politics more comprehensively than they do in any of their other works,” as it is their “overtly political program.” While this may be the case, it is important to remember that politics and communism were first treated by Gianni in *Nihilism and Emancipation* (2003) and *Ecce Comu* (2007), which are vital phases within the development of weak thought. Although *Hermeneutic Communism* is a text which stands on its own feet, these other books must be taken into consideration when assessing weak thought’s politics.

According to the authors, the relation between “weak thought” and *Hermeneutic Communism* and our preference for Chávez over social movements are two issues we have not thought through. They seem to have found a “mismatch,” or “dangerous divide” as their title indicates, between “weak thought” and “practical politics” which drove us to underestimate social movements. Although the authors endorse the idea of weakening the metaphysical structures of our philosophical tradition, they believe our “jump from the meta-ethical (weak thought) to the political (hermeneutic communism) within the book is fraught with problems because it pays insufficient attention to the chasm that separates the epochal and the political [while] the political developments championed in *Hermeneutic Communism* (most notably the regime of Hugo Chávez) bear little discernible relation to weak thought.”

Our goal was not to ignore the separation there is between the “philosophical spirit that animates weak thought” and “hermeneutic communism as an ethico-political vision,” but rather to recall that both are on the same side of history, that is, of the weak. To a certain extent, Perkins and Gillespie recognize this when they

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affirm the manner in which our hermeneutics “rests upon an existential commitment to the service to or defense of the weak and powerless,” but then stress that we exaggerate the “openness and generosity of weak thought itself.” While weak thought is “open” and “generous”, it is also interested in defending the weak with whatever means available. In sum, the problem for Perkins and Gillespie lies in this defense and resistance, that is, in turning to practice and politics. “In turning to politics their hermeneutics thus ceases to be multiperspectival and tentative, and becomes instead a tool of a proto-Christian dogmatism, that rests upon an existential commitment to the service to or defense of the weak and powerless.” What these political scientists ignore is not only that “weak thought *is* the thought of the weak,” but also how hermeneutics has often been an anarchic position, that is, resisting descriptions, impositions, and constraints from above, as we explained in chapter three.

It is important to stress how the comparison they make between Bloch’s account of the East German regime (in his *Principle of Hope*) and our admiration of Chávez’s democratically elected government does not rest in a “radically different future,” but rather in existing historical examples. The fact that these examples today are not viable anymore, given the East German regime has disappeared and Maduro was obliged to choose a different path from his predecessor, does not mean they were errors. After all, the opponents (American capitalism, NATO, IMF) of these examples and models are not only still alive and going strong, but also continue to increase levels of social and economic inequality throughout the world.

In sum, Perkins and Gillespie believe we have restricted “the potential meaning of hermeneutic communism far more than they need to” by endorsing Latin American democracies, and that we should have instead chosen “a broadly participatory social movement as its example.” Without being fans of Negri and Hardt’s *Empire*, they do believe our project would have worked much better if we would also have endorsed these movements. But the truth is we also endorse these movements. The only difference lies in their goals: while Negri and Hardt require that they always remain at a distance from the state, we believe they should join it. As Lula’s, Morales’, and Chavez’ experiences show, in order to be effective, social movements have to transform into political parties, that is, become part of the state apparatus. As Podemos is proving in Spain now, it is not a choice between social movements and state initiatives. Rather, movements must seek to transform the latter through the demands of the former, for the sake of finally making changes.

It's Time to Change the World, So Interpret It!: On Vattimo and Zabala's Hermeneutic Communism

Liu Liangjian

*There is nothing softer and weaker than water,
And yet there is nothing better for attacking hard and strong
things.*

– Dao-de Jing

Abstract With its potential strength in superficial weakness, I maintain that weak thought functions in the way of water that Laozi, an ancient Chinese sage of Daoism, highly praises. However, we may be skeptical of the connection between the abstract wisdom of Laozi and the dialectical triumph of weak thought. Weak thought will still be literally weak if it cannot give a satisfying answer to the question as to whether interpreting is enough to engender alternatives, emergencies or events to the world. When Marx claims that “philosophers have hitherto only interpreted the world in various ways; the point is to change it”, he is calling for stepping over the gap between theory and practice, or the gap between knowing (*zhi*) and acting (*xing*), a typical expression in traditional Chinese philosophy. In spite of the impression that this challenge has been ignored in *Hermeneutic Communism*, I argue that Vattimo and Zabala realize that it cannot be easily circumvented.

Calling for Interpreting: The Strong Voice of Weak Thought?

With the doctrine of hermeneutic communism, Vattimo and Zabala declare that “philosophers until now have only described the world, now the moment has arrived to interpret it”. This manifesto-like statement is a modification of Marx’s well-known thesis that “philosophers have hitherto only interpreted the world in various ways; the point is to change it”. At first glance, it appears that Marx’s radical political demand has been modified in a moderate way. As a matter of fact, Vattimo and

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Zabala repeatedly claim to discard revolution because of its association with violence. At the very beginning of the book, we are told that hermeneutic communism “leaves aside both the ideal of development and also the general call for revolution” (Vattimo and Zabala, 3). And again, at the very end of the book, they claim “that the transformation of the world cannot be projected in the form of a violent engagement, which would only provoke increased repression,” and that this “makes much more difficult the goal of resistance and opposition and therefore communism” (Vattimo and Zabala, 139–140). Here they are telling us the truth: the dominating forces of the current world are too powerful, violent, and oppressive to be overcome through revolution. Insofar as this weak retrogression from changing the world to interpreting it, weak thought, as the thought of the weak, is literally weak.

However, Vattimo and Zabala would no doubt maintain that this interpretation has missed their eagerness for change and more seriously, the dialectics of their theory. They fiercely criticize “a current lack of emergency, that is, the increasing homologizing of the political, economic, and social structures of power” (Vattimo and Zabala, 2). A lack of emergency is a lack of alternative, event and change. As for the political practice in a democratic nation, “‘lack of emergency’ is translated into a lack of alternatives before elections and a lack of opposition after them” (Vattimo and Zabala, 54). The super-stability of the current world after the fall of the Berlin Wall has resulted in Fukuyama’s fantasy of the end of history, where democratic capitalism, with its triumph over socialism and communism, has realized itself as the ideal of human history. Fortunately, this is not the whole story today. The global economic crisis, the violent and hegemonic dimension of “liberating states”, the “sacred” fight against inhumane terrorism grounded in fundamentalism, and the decline of abstract metaphysics obsessed with absolute truth in the postmodern conditions – all of this has effectuated the disenchantment with the modern mythology of democracy, capitalism and science. Consequently, this reminds us of the implication of the term “history”, that is, changes in the passage of time, and the role of human beings in history, that of writing history through changing the world. If there is a current lack of emergency, then it is time to change the world.

But the question remains: how to change the world? The secret lies in the dialectics of the Heideggerian term *verwinden*: “Only once we recognize how metaphysics cannot be overcome in the sense of *überwunden*, defeating and leaving at large, but only in the sense of *verwindung*, that is, incorporating, twisting, or weakening, does it become possible to change the world.” (Vattimo and Zabala, 1) Similarly, political struggle “must rely on ‘weak thought,’ that is, the idea of the impossibility of overcoming metaphysics while at the same time establishing the capacity to live without legitimizations or grounding values” (Vattimo and Zabala, 97). In my opinion, *verwinden* is quite similar to the well-known Hegelian term *aufheben* (see Hegel, §96) to the extent that both of them have a revolutionary meaning of clearing away and a conservational meaning of preserving. Hence, to change the world is to incorporate (*verwinden*) it by coming terms with it rather than completely forgetting or abandoning it (See Zabala 2009, 5).

The concrete way to incorporate the world that Vattimo and Zabala suggest is interpreting. It is time to change the world in which there is a current lack of emergency, so interpret it! According to Žižek, the basic feature of an event lies in “the surprising emergence of something new which undermines every stable scheme” (Žižek, 9). Therefore, “at its most elementary, an event is not something that occurs within the world, but it is a change of the very frame through which we perceive the world and engage in it” (Žižek, 13). The logical connection between change and interpreting is exposed if we see that any stable scheme or frame cannot be undermined without interpreting, and different interpretations will lead us to envision alternatives and consequently search for change.

Through the dialectics of *verwinden*, we eventually hear the strong voice of weak thought. In his “Forward for Chinese Translation” of *The Remains of Being*, Zabala claims:

Weak thought allows philosophy to correspond to the dissolution of metaphysics (through hermeneutics) and to search for new goals and ambitions within the possibilities of the “thrown” condition of the human being: instead of an understanding of the eternal, philosophy must redirect humanity toward an interpretation of its own history. It is important to emphasize that the negative connotation of the term “weak” does not allude to a failure of thinking as such but rather to the consequences of the transformation of thought brought about by the end of metaphysics, hence, as a possibility of emancipation. Weak thought is a very strong theory of weakness, where the philosopher’s achievements do not derive from enforcing the objective world but rather from weakening its structures. ([6], 2)

With its potential strength in superficial weakness, weak thought functions in the way of water that Laozi, an ancient Chinese sage of Daoism, highly praises:

There is nothing softer and weaker than water,
And yet there is nothing better for attacking hard and strong things.
For this reason there is no substitute for it.
All the world knows that the weak overcomes the strong and
the soft overcomes the hard.
But none can practice it. – *Dao-de Jing*, Chapter 78 (Chan, 174–175)

However, we may be skeptical of the connection between the abstract wisdom of Laozi and the dialectical triumph of weak thought. Weak thought will still be literally weak if it cannot give a satisfying answer to the question as to whether interpreting is enough to engender alternatives, emergencies or events to the world. When Marx claims that “philosophers have hitherto only interpreted the world in various ways; the point is to change it”, he is calling for stepping over the gap between theory and practice, or the gap between knowing (*zhi*) and acting (*xing*), a typical expression in traditional Chinese philosophy. In spite of the impression that this challenge has been ignored in *Hermeneutic Communism*, the following sentences show that Vattimo and Zabala have realized that it cannot be easily circumvented: “Shouldn’t such a principle [that Being is ‘event’] also function for the holders of power, the defenders of the world as a stable structure that ought to be respected? We may at least recommend such an idea to them with the hope they will endorse it; nevertheless, we must remain ready to fight also in concrete ways in order to prevent the obstruction of such practice.” (Vattimo and Zabala, 94–95)

How to Incorporate Democracy?

To demonstrate that hermeneutic communism is not dead or utopian, Vattimo and Zabala appeal to Venezuela and other South American countries: economically, “Argentina’s economy grew more than 60% in six years and Venezuela’s by 95%” (Vattimo and Zabala, 129). Politically, the South American countries follow democratic electoral procedures, procedures that enabled Chavez and other communist politicians to attain power within the framework of the formal rules of democracy (See Vattimo and Zabala, 121–122). However, five years after the publication of *Hermeneutic Communism*, we have to take into serious consideration what has happened in South America, including the economic crisis in Venezuela since 2015 and the reported tyrannical domination of Chavez and his successor Maduro. Does this imply the dissolution of the myth of Chavez, or on the contrary, the terrible power of the complete dominance of capitalistic framed democracies? This is open to discussion. Nevertheless, there are still two theoretical questions. Firstly, the South American alternative, if there is one, cannot be justified on the grounds of economic growth, since weak communism must function “as a movement that embraces the programmatic cause of ‘degrowth’ as the only way to save the human species”. In other words, hermeneutic communism “can hope for a different future only if it has the courage to act as a specter by refusing to follow capitalism’s emphasis on rational development” (Vattimo and Zabala, 121). Secondly, democratic electoral procedures are not sufficient for a good political system, even if they are necessary for, and probably essential to democracy. It is questionable whether democracy is the ideal form of government in human history. The disadvantages of the “one man, one vote” principle in democratic elections have been widely discussed both in China and the West. For instance, Bei Tongdong (1970–), following Daniel A. Bell (1964–), advocates mixing democracy and meritocracy, having criticized the “one man, one vote” principle. Furthermore, a new Confucian, Tang Junyi (1909–1978), suggests introducing weighting factors in accordance with the moral qualities and political competency of electors. It is interesting to mention that Liu Cixin (1963–) in his famous science fiction *Supernova Era* (1991) also introduces weighting factors in a nationwide cyber assembly, where only children under the age of 13 survive after a cosmic catastrophe.

According to the logic of weak thought, which abandons any fantasy of absolute truth, we must admit that democracy may not be the ideal form of government in human history. Perhaps it is in this sense that Vattimo and Zabala criticize framed democracies: “Weak communism is the political alternative to the neoliberal impositions of framed democracies.” (Vattimo and Zabala, 128) Again, framed democracies shall be incorporated rather than overcome. Otherwise, we would feel confused when we are told that there will always be “government to democratize” (Vattimo and Zabala, 97; Zabala 2015, 2). Framed democracies shall be replaced by “progressive communist democracies”, which reflect the pluralism of postmodern societies at the political level.

As an alternative to framed democracy, communist democracy is characterized by conversation, which is different from dialogue. In a dialogue, the powerful interlocutor or interlocutors silence the dominated ones in the apparently peaceful and equal exchange of opinions. "It is here that dialogue becomes the best way to moralize politics, that is, to conserve framed democracy's interests, condition, and immunity." (Vattimo and Zabala, 23) Dialogue trickily legitimates the concealed violence and inequality. On the contrary, conversations are "realms of discussions and regulated conflict between positions and different interests that also move within a frame that lacks a unique dominating power" (Vattimo and Zabala, 116). Echoing the abstract dialectics of weak thought discussed above, Vattimo and Zabala describe conversation in a pastoral tone, as if it takes place at a dinner party – please keep in mind Mao's affirmation: "a revolution is not a dinner party" (Vattimo and Zabala, 136, 137). "In this politics of interpretation, conversation becomes the realm where the powerful describers of the world can listen to the requests of the weak and perhaps change their selfish priorities. But if they do not listen, today the weak can finally come together." (Vattimo and Zabala, 107) Disagreeing with the authors, I wonder if perhaps Rorty was too optimistic "when he stated that what is 'important about representative democratic government is that it gives the poor and weak a tool they can use against the rich and powerful, especially against the unconscious cruelty of the institutions the powerful have imposed upon the weak'" (Ibid.). Is there any concrete mechanism that can safeguard the willingness of the powerful to listen to the weak? Here is a paradox: in order to abandon the state of being silent and invisible, the weak has to overcome the condition of being weak.

Reinterpreting Communism and Community from a Chinese Perspective

Reading takes place in a process of conversation between the reader and the text. If the conversation is effective, the reader will appropriate (*ereignen*) the text to some extent. How can a Chinese reader, who is familiar with a certain discourse of communism, appropriate *Hermeneutic Communism*?

Vattimo and Zabala creatively coin the term "hermeneutic communism", which highlights the shared spirit of communism on the one hand and the hermeneutic tradition with Dilthey, Nietzsche, Heidegger and Gadamer as its masters on the other¹. Hence it is not astonishing that communism is reinterpreted from the perspective of hermeneutics: "Communism's promise of a society 'without classes' must be interpreted as 'without dominion,' that is, once again, without an imposed

¹In *The History of Western Hermeneutics* (Pan 2013), Pan Derong gives a detailed discussion of two types of hermeneutics in the West, that is, ontological hermeneutics represented by Heidegger, Gadamer and methodological hermeneutics represented by Emilio Betti and Paul Ricoeur. Roughly speaking, Vattimo and Santiago have consciously or unconsciously ignored the methodological approach.

unique truth and compulsory orthodoxy.” (Vattimo and Zabala, 116) This fresh interpretation is extremely shocking, opening a new horizon which was beyond imagination in the orthodox framework of the Chinese version of communism.

The power of emancipation is enlarged when these two European thinkers affirm that “hermeneutics would not have been possible without the end of Eurocentrism, which has also always been the sociopolitical correlative of Western metaphysics” (Vattimo and Zabala, 110). Since the import of Marx into China in the last century, the sinicization of Marxism has always been a great challenge, and its leading paradigm both in theory and practice has been dominated by the following question: How can Marxism achieve its sinicization by absorbing Chinese tradition? However, inspired by Vattimo and Zabala’s affirmation, we must realize that the sinicization of Marxism would not be possible without the end of Eurocentrism. This idea may be revolutionary, since it demands a paradigm shift from absorbing Chinese tradition into Marxism to absorbing Marxism into Chinese tradition. If “hermeneutic communism” is possible, can “Confucian communism”, “Daoist communism” or even “Buddhist communism” also make sense? Communism can be generally reinterpreted as a doctrine of community. Therefore, communism is shared by Marxism, Confucianism, Daoism and Buddhism, although they certainly have their distinctive understandings of community. For instance, based on Confucian tradition, we can advocate two notions, i.e., a glocal community and a Nature-man community.

Nowadays we are in a glocal age, that is, a transitional period from nation-states to a world state. With the idea of glocality, we are imagining a glocal community as a possible and desirable world order. To the construction of such a glocal community, the following four things are essential: first, a glocal perspective incorporating a national perspective; second, a glocal institution as a one-many system;² third, *zhengyi*, a Chinese version of justice as the primary glocal principle for the world order.

As far as the future political order of human beings is concerned, justice is a valuable pursuit common to us all. In this glocal age, *zhengyi*, as a Chinese version of justice based on the perspective of a Nature-human community, would benefit us considerably. Roughly speaking, *zhengyi* stresses the importance of the universality of innate moral affections and humanity (*ren*) in particular, which puts into question the pre-understood notion of the human being found in the Western concept of “justice”, namely, that a human being is a rational atomic individual; by contrast, this concept of *zhengyi* understands human beings, as well as their responsibilities and ideal existential realm, in the context of a Nature-human community.

Taking human beings as its ultimate telos, *zhengyi* does not restrict its understanding of human beings solely to the horizon of the interrelating of humans. The

²The arrangement of a world political order shall deal well with the one-many relationship on a variety of levels, including the relationship between the world government as one and local governments as many, the relationship between a universal political principle as one and the diversity of religious and metaphysical standpoints as many. The omnicentrism advocated by Brook Ziporyn in his study of China’s Tiantai Buddhism is significant for us to understand the relationship between the center and the margin, which also constitutes a dimension of one-many relations (see [7]).

essence of human beings is neither confined to rights, nor to the interrelating of humans. Emerging in the boundary between Heaven and Earth, humans shall take upon themselves as their own responsibility the task of nourishing not only the growth of the self and the growth of other human beings, but the growth of other kinds of beings as well. This is what the affective mindset comes to know about the nature and essence of human beings in its reflection. To understand humans without discarding Nature (*tian*). In the grand transformation of the cosmos, perhaps no other issue stirs our souls like the boundary of interrelation common to Nature and humans. Born as the boundary between Heaven and Earth, human beings are endowed with the highest degree of intelligence to be found in the cosmos due to possessing the capacity of transcending nature. At the same time, we do always, whether subtly or vividly, feel the impulse to return to the matrix of Heaven and Earth constituting Nature. Being existentially constitutes the *dao* of humans, but it echoes the call issuing from the *dao* of Nature. Ultimately, *zhengyi* is the pursuit of the cultivation of nature by means of nourishing the natural tendency in the Nature-human community: in the Nature-human community, everyone, by virtue of his or her own natural capacities (including rational and emotional or affective capacities) participates in the process of “each doing justice to the natural command, while maintaining the grand harmony”, an expression borrowed from *The Book of Changes*.

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Response to Liangjian

Gianni Vattimo and Santiago Zabala

The title Liu Liangjian contribution, “*It’s Time to Change the World, So Interpret It!*” sounds very much like an order, instruction or command. Even though we always try to avoid these sorts of statements, there is a great temptation to use it now. This change of heart likely has a lot to do also with Eduardo Mendieta’s contribution in this volume, in which he claims that *Hermeneutic Communism* reads like a manifesto. Perhaps, in the tradition of the manifesto, we should also have called everyone to interpret the world as clearly as Liangjian does. His contribution is not only remarkable in that it points to the similarities between “weak thought” and an ancient Chinese sage of Daoism (Laozi), but also insofar as it questions “whether interpreting is enough to bring alternatives, emergencies, or events to the world.” In order to respond to this fundamental question, Liangjian reinterprets communism from a Chinese perspective in relation to our preference for the South American alternative.

The Chinese thinker, similarly to other contributors in this volume, is also dubious of our endorsement of Chavez. The general economic and social crisis the South American country is experiencing under Maduro’s leadership certainly legitimizes the question as to whether we are witnessing “the dissolution of the myth of Chavez, or on the contrary, the terrible power of the complete dominance of capitalistic framed democracies?” We believe that Chavez as a myth, symbol, and reference for the global left still holds, not only for all the successful social, economic, and educational policies he implemented during his mandates, but also for supporting other progressive governments in the region. An interesting example is former President of Brazil Dilma Rousseff. As soon as Lula designated her as the best candidate to guide the Workers Party and Brazil into the twentyfirst century, Chavez supported

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her. Now that she has been overthrown through a coup, one must inevitably speculate on the level of involvement of “capitalistic framed democracies”, considering there has almost never been a coup in Central and South America against a leftist government without some US involvement. “And such speculation, as Mark Weisbrot recently suggested, is not unreasonable in Brazil, where Washington intervened in 2005 in support of a legislative effort aimed at undermining the Workers’ Party government.”

The massive spying on Brazil —and especially Petrobras — that Edward Snowden and Glenn Greenwald revealed in 2013, also points in this direction. It could be a coincidence that all this information about Petrobras was gathered by the U.S. government just prior to the scandals at the state-controlled oil company; or perhaps Washington shared some information with its allies in the Brazilian opposition. And there is no doubt that, like President Mauricio Macri in Argentina, the biggest players in this coup attempt — people like former presidential candidates José Serra and Aécio Neves — are U.S. government allies.¹

While we could discuss indefinitely whether Chavez is a “myth” or a “model,” as we prefer to view his legacy, is still feasible, there is no doubt that the ongoing crisis in Venezuela and other Latin American countries is caused by the “terrible power,” as Liangjian refers to the “capitalistic framed democracies.” There are two other issues related to the South American alternative which bother Liangjian: how we praise its “growth” and its “democratic electoral procedures.”

Growth for Chavez, Morales, and others Latin American politicians does not refer to a rational development of the economy as we are experiencing now in the European Union, where austerity measures are imposed regardless of their social cost, but rather the elevation of the weak out of poverty. Independently of the recent economic and political crisis the region is suffering now,² its achievements in the reduction of extreme poverty are unquestionable; after all, this is one of the few

¹ Mark Weisbrot, “Attempted Coup in Brazil Seeks to Reverse Election Results,” *The Hill*, April 4, 2016. <http://thehill.com/blogs/pundits-blog/international/275051-attempted-coup-in-brazil-seeks-to-reverse-election-results>. In a recent article in the *New York Times* Weisbrot suggested that “A U.S. Policy of Non-intervention in Venezuela Would Be a Welcome Change” considering “Washington has caused enormous damage to Venezuela in its relentless pursuit of ‘regime change’ for the last 15 years. In March, President Obama once again absurdly declared Venezuela to be an ‘unusual and extraordinary threat to the national security and foreign policy of the United States,’ and extended economic sanctions against the country. (M. Weisbrot, “A U.S. Policy of Non-intervention in Venezuela Would Be a Welcome Change” *The New York Times*, June 30th 2016: <http://www.nytimes.com/roomfordebate/2016/06/28/how-to-save-venezuela/the-us-bears-blame-for-the-crisis-in-venezuela-and-it-should-stop-intervening-there>

² It is important to understand there are different reasons behind each nation crisis. As Weisbrot reported in 2016 “Ecuador’s current recession is largely due to the collapse in the price of oil, which accounts for the majority of the government’s revenue. Venezuela has of course also been hit hard by the oil price collapse, but its recession began when oil was still at \$98 a barrel. In its case, the economy got caught in an “inflation-depreciation” spiral” which brought inflation to 180% last year, while the black market rate for the dollar rose to more than 100 times the official rate. As in Brazil, this was mainly a result of policy mistakes; most importantly in Venezuela, the unsustainable effort to maintain a fixed, overvalued exchange rate.” (M. Weisbrot, “Has the Left Run Its Course in Latin America?” *The Nation*, May 10th 2016. <https://www.thenation.com/article/has-the-left-run-its-course-in-latin-america/>

things critics of the late politician agree upon. Also, when we urge others to “embrace the programmatic cause of ‘degrowth’ as the only way to save the human species”, we are not referring to Latin American governments – remember Morales’s government passed the world’s first laws granting nature equal rights to humans – but rather to all those nations which continue to impose neoliberal rational and profit driven policies on their citizens.

The other issue that bothers Liangjian is whether “democratic electoral procedures are sufficient for a good political system.” There is no doubt that there are many disadvantages in the “one man one vote” principle (as he comments, drawing from the intuitions of Bei Tongdong, Daniel A. Bell, Tang Junyi, and Liu Cixin), but there is an important difference between their current application, as “framed” systems, and what they imply, namely the absence of truth. The absence of truth in democracies has a lot to do with the possibility of change that the electoral procedure allows. Although this change is often framed within a circumscribed number of parties or coalitions that concertedly try to avoid it, in South America this change has been able to take place, as Noam Chomsky, Greg Grandin and others have repeatedly pointed out. Whether this process is over in the region is secondary. Much more urgent is to understand that it can be repeated on other continents.

As we can see, at the center of Liangjian’s contribution lies the following question: can “hermeneutic communism” be understood from a Chinese perspective, in other words, from a country where ‘communism’ is alive, applied, and thriving economically without democratic representation? According to him our theory “is extremely shocking” to Chinese scholars, as it opens “a new horizon which was beyond imagination in the orthodox framework of the Chinese version of communism.” But if we actually managed to “open a new horizon”, it is not thanks to our sympathies for democracy and communism, but rather for hermeneutics, since the revolutionary feature of our book lies in interpretation’s progressive political nature. This is why we believe the “sinicization of Marxism” that Liangjian refers to is possible, due in part to the end of Eurocentrism, but most of all, due to the political implications of hermeneutics, which are also a consequence of the end of metaphysics. As much as we sympathize with the “glocal community” Liangjian outlines, where *zhengyi* (a “Chinese version of justice based on the perspective of a Nature-human community”) has a central role, interpretation must always be present, as it is the only thing that can bring those vital alternatives, emergencies and events we will always need.

Part III

Communism

The New Communism: Reflections at the End of Capitalism and the Need for Engaging Minor Sciences

Clayton Crockett

Abstract Along with Alain Badiou and Antonio Negri, for Vattimo and Zabala the idea of communism, after being pulverized, exorcised, and largely forgotten in the wake of the Cold War, is having a come-back. Of course at the popular level of American political discourse, the word socialism is a curse-word, and communism cannot even be invoked in any serious way. So communism remains marginalized and relegated to European and American academic Leftists, but Vattimo and Zabala raise the question anew in extraordinarily fresh, important and original theoretical terms. This chapter engages with and expands upon Vattimo and Zabala's analysis to consider the stakes of their intervention as well as reflect on the "return of the Real" in terms of an ecology that would constitute an absolute limit for capitalist growth. If capitalist growth is unsustainable in absolute terms, because it is based on indefinite increase of products, production and profits, then it can only survive in relative terms, by allocating more and more resources to fewer and fewer people and corporations and impoverishing more and more people. Put simply, capitalism has metastasized, and it will kill us if we do not develop and implement an alternative. And any alternative to capitalism would have to be broadly communistic, in Vattimo and Zabala's terms.

Hermeneutic Communism is a vital work for both philosophical and political reasons. Along with other Continental philosophers, including Jean-Luc Nancy, Slavoj Žižek, Alain Badiou and Antonio Negri, for Vattimo and Zabala the idea of communism is making a comeback. And this comeback occurs in the shadow of Derrida's important treatment in *Specters of Marx*. After being pulverized, exorcised, and largely forgotten in the wake of the Cold War, communism has returned to haunt the discontents of neo-liberalism.

At the popular level of American political discourse, however, communism is unspeakable. Even the word socialism is a curse-word, inappropriately applied to Obama's pragmatic and centrist neo-liberal agenda. In the United States communism

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cannot even be invoked in any serious way, and most European governments are still locked into neo-liberalism despite some misgivings. European debt is shredding the Eurozone from the outside in, and austerity programs are being put in place to assuage investors and shred social safety nets, which is why Vattimo and Zabala are correct to say that “reformism has come to an end” (118).

So communism remains marginalized and relegated to European and American academic Leftists, but Vattimo and Zabala raise the question anew in extraordinarily fresh, important and original theoretical terms. Communism is necessarily a ‘weak’ communism, without the power of the state behind it and the dictatorship of the party to enforce it. And it is this weak communism that is being put into practice in democratic forms primarily in South America, under the regimes of Chavez, Morales, Lula and others.

How can we conjoin and think together the political and the philosophical? Vattimo and Zabala state that the “*claims of truth are also claims of political power*” (18–19). Furthermore, they liberate what is often called postmodernism from the conservative shackles of apolitical cultural theory by re-reading Derrida. Against the idea of some sort of “turn” to political issues, they show how Derrida has consistently been engaged in political efforts, most strikingly his dispute with John Searle. Vattimo and Zabala argue that, “contrary to the majority of the interpreters of Searle’s debate with Derrida,” “we believe its essence was not linguistic but political” (33). In fact, we could view the subtitle of the book as applying to Derrida’s work itself, as a trajectory from Heidegger, where Derrida begins and whose shadow he never escapes, to Marx. So Derrida represents a transition from Heidegger, who must also be read in relation to Nietzsche, to a poststructuralist reading of Marx.

In 1848 Marx announced the specter of a communism *to come*, whereas Derrida suggests in the early 1990s that we are still desperately trying to exorcise the ghost of communism with “a worried sigh of relief: let us make sure that in the future it does not come back!”¹ According to Derrida, “the whole history of European politics at least, and at least since Marx, would be that of a ruthless war between solidary camps that are equally terrorized by the ghost, the ghost of the other, and its own ghost as the ghost of the other.”² We have no doubt about who wins, because global capitalism wins every time, but in this century we have a new war, the Global War on Terror. And this enemy is much more ephemeral and spectral than communism ever was. Capitalism can be genuinely political in Carl Schmitt’s terms so long as it can define and possess a true enemy. This time global capitalism employs the ugly dwarf of theology in its holy war on terror.

What are they so afraid of, if communism is vanquished and all enemies of capitalism are so weak? According to Vattimo and Zabala, it is precisely this weakness that gives the opponents of the global neoliberal order their greatest strength. The weakness of the weak attests to the vulnerability of capitalism itself, and if its dire state of emergency is made visible, then another possibility emerges where a new

¹ Jacques Derrida, *Specters of Marx: The State of the Debt, the Work of Mourning, and the New International*, trans. Peggy Kamuf (New York: Routledge, 1994), p. 39.

² *Ibid.*, p. 105.

form of freedom is made manifest. “*The emergency today*,” they write, “*is the completion of a condition of neutralization where ‘freedom’ is only possible within the established dialogue*” (28; emphasis in original). But a different dialogue is possible given a radicalized and broadened conception of hermeneutics that gives the weak a voice to think and write their own story, which is the story of a new communism or a new way of being in common.

It is not only the crisis of capitalism that requires a return to Marx; “the crisis of Soviet communism (parallel to the crisis of neoliberal capitalism today) requires from Marxism a hermeneutic turn” (115). The return to Marx is an interpretive turn that does not simply bypass communism but renders it weak in traditional terms of political power. Here hermeneutics is broadened and radicalized in the sense that John D. Caputo suggests in his book *Radical Hermeneutics*. Derrida is suspicious of the conservative nature of hermeneutics in Heideggerian and Gadamerian terms, but Caputo suggests that a radical hermeneutics can accommodate deconstruction. Caputo claims that despite Derrida’s critique of an “onto-hermeneutics” in Heidegger, Heideggerian hermeneutics also possesses a genuinely radical vision of uncertainty, openness to the mystery of existence, and *Gelassenheit*.³ Vattimo and Zabala do not specifically mention Caputo, but I think their understanding of hermeneutics is a radical one that is just as informed by Derrida and Nietzsche as it is by Heidegger and Gadamer.

My essay affirms as well as expands upon Vattimo and Zabala’s analysis, to consider the stakes of their intervention as well as reflect on the “return of the Real” in terms of an ecology that would constitute an absolute limit for capitalist growth and a condition for a new form of communism that manifests as a democracy in common. I agree with Žižek and Badiou that we need to retain the notion of the Lacanian Real to interpret and to intervene against neoliberalism. Vattimo and Zabala affirm the insights of Freud and Freudian psychoanalysis, and it is Lacan who makes psychoanalysis hermeneutic, in the sense that Vattimo and Zabala give this term. Furthermore, it is also the possibility of a psychoanalytic hermeneutics that Derrida poses to Gadamer in their famous interrupted encounter in Paris in 1981. Derrida asks Gadamer three short questions, the second of which explicitly concerns psychoanalysis. He says, “What to do about good will—the condition for consensus even in disagreement—if one wants to integrate a psychoanalytic hermeneutics into a general hermeneutics?”⁴ I read Vattimo and Zabala as following Derrida’s question and providing resources to envision a psychoanalytic hermeneutics that would distort and deform a more conventional understanding of hermeneutics. According to Vattimo and Zabala, “although Freud has not received enough recognition in the histories of hermeneutics, his project was really a development and radicalization of the previous psychological hermeneutics” (84). And Lacan further develops and

³See John D. Caputo, *Radical Hermeneutics: Repetition, Deconstruction, and the Hermeneutic Project* (Bloomington: Indiana University Press, 1987), p. 175, and chapters 9–10.

⁴Jacques Derrida, “Three Questions to Hans-Georg Gadamer,” trans. Diane Michelfelder and Richard Palmer, in *Dialogue and Deconstruction: The Gadamer-Derrida Encounter*, ed. Diane P. Michelfelder and Richard E. Palmer (Albany: SUNY Press, 1989), p. 53.

radicalizes Freud. So just as Vattimo and Zabala develop the political dimension of hermeneutics, Badiou and Žižek develop the political dimension of psychoanalysis.

The Real in Lacanian terms is not in any way compatible with the cynical neo-realism of corporate capitalism. Vattimo and Zabala say that “the ‘real’ still exists for hermeneutics, but only within certain paradigms, as Kuhn explained” (106). I agree with their reading and valorization of Thomas Kuhn’s notion of paradigms, but the Real is not a determinate content of a paradigm; rather, it is that which insists and pressures the symbolic order of any given paradigm.

The Real cannot be captured in any scientific determinism, because it is precisely the shift from the masculine perspective of beyond as an exception to the symbolic order to the feminine perspective of non-all at the heart of the symbolic. According to Žižek, “the Real is thus simultaneously the Thing to which direct access is not possible and the obstacle that prevents this direct access; the Thing that eludes our grasp and the distorting screen that makes us miss the Thing. More precisely, the Real is ultimately the very shift of perspective from the first standpoint to the second.”⁵ This is a radical hermeneutical insight: the Real indicates and points toward the Thing that lies beyond symbolic representation, but it is really the screen that prevents us from attaining any Thing outside our phenomenal understanding. And in terms of Žižek’s re-interpretation of Hegel through Lacan, the *Aufhebung* of the Real is actually the movement from the first to the second, from out there to in here. Later in *The Puppet and the Dwarf*, Žižek recapitulates this same argument in terms of law and love, suggesting that “the co-dependency of law and sin (in transgression) thus obeys the Lacanian ‘masculine’ logic of exception: ‘sin’ is the very exception that sustains the Law.” Love, by contrast, “is not simply beyond the Law, but articulates itself as the stance of total immersion in the Law” in the form of not all, or the internal differentiation of law from itself.⁶ The Real is not the exception to hermeneutic interpretation that lies outside of it and guarantees it in a masculine way, but instead the Real indicates the non-all or non-coincidence of interpretation with itself that keeps it from closing down.

Today we are witnessing a return of the real, in many forms. One form is British speculative realism, which can be seen alternatively as reinforcing a metaphysical scientism or as offering resources to open up science itself in a hermeneutic way.⁷ I think that there is a certain neo-realism that functions to support neo-liberal capitalism, implicitly or explicitly, in the same way that Vattimo and Zabala indict analytic philosophy “as the completion of scientific realism, [which] legitimizes not only scientific enterprises but also the American government, which in part depends on

⁵Slavoj Žižek, *The Puppet and the Dwarf: The Perverse Core of Christianity* (Cambridge, MA: The MIT Press, 2003), p. 77.

⁶Ibid., p. 116.

⁷See *The Speculative Turn: Continental Materialism and Realism*, ed. Levi Bryant, Nick Srnicek, and Graham Harman (Melbourne: re.press, 2011).

such enterprises” (35). But I think we should view the Real as fundamentally incompatible with this neo-realism.⁸

The New Communism thinks the Real precisely in its ontological and hermeneutical weakness without succumbing to the illusions of scientific managerial realism. According to Alain Badiou, the twentieth century can be characterized in terms of a “passion for the real.”⁹ And this passion for the real has consumed itself, making the century the most deadly in terms of absolute numbers of any century in history. We live on in the ashes from that fire, which is largely spent. The fire indicates the fires of communism as well as fascism, and these twin totalitarianisms consumed the world in the middle of the century before being extinguished. 1989 is the date that represents the end of actually existing communism, even though state communism combined with economic capitalism was given a new lease on life in China, beginning in 1991. And in *Specters of Marx*, as we have already seen, Derrida shows how the spirit of communism still haunts the triumph of capitalism despite the neo-Kojévian proclamation of the end of history by scribes like Francis Fukuyama.

For Vattimo and Zabala, the spectral nature of communism that haunts the triumph of corporate neoliberal capitalism is not a fault, but an advantage and an opportunity. Communism is not for the State or the Party, but rather something that takes place in practical terms for the people in their struggle against armed capitalism and framed democracies. They claim that “a revolution may only be correctly thought about outside the scientific and metaphysical horizons that still dominate classical Marxism.” However, “at the practical level such a theoretical possibility can be linked to the effective examples of a ‘new’ communism in Latin America” (133). This new communism is not a doctrinaire orthodox communism but a pragmatic means of resistance to the onslaught of neoliberalism and the groping around for new forms of life together beyond the domination of international capital enforced by the USA’s military and economic weapons. Vattimo and Zabala do not believe that a strong metaphysical Marxism or communism is either possible or desirable. A weak or hermeneutic communism “can hope for a different future only if it has the courage to act as a specter by refusing to follow capitalism’s emphasis on rational development” (121).

Although Vattimo and Zabala quibble with some of the analyses and prescriptions of Antonio Negri, Alain Badiou and Slavoj Žižek, and suggest that some of their rhetoric about communism is too strong, I think that their insights and philosophies can be mined for tools to help think and practice Vattimo and Zabala’s hermeneutic communism. For example, Negri and Michael Hardt have developed the most extensive depiction of what a communism of the multitude in common could look like over against the neoliberal Empire. Even if they push some of their analyses, such as the disappearance of the nation-state, too far, I think that the connection of communism to the common is crucial for what Vattimo and Zabala are doing

⁸See Clayton Crockett, “Postmodernism and the Crisis of Belief: Neo-Realism vs. the Real,” in *The Mourning After: Attending the Wake of Postmodernism*, ed. Neil Brooks and Josh Toth (Amsterdam: Rodopi, 2007), pp. 263–283.

⁹Alain Badiou, *The Century*, trans. Alberto Toscano (London: Polity Press, 2007).

here. We need to focus upon and valorize what we have in common, as “commons” over against what can be designated and priced as private property in material or immaterial terms.

In his book *Time for Revolution*, Negri provides a condensed theoretical sketch for his more elaborate work with Hardt. Here Negri focuses on the experience of poverty, and claims that “naked and exposed to the immeasurable, the poor shatter the postmodern aporia of production and confer meaning on the materialist teleology of the common.”¹⁰ Our experience of poverty, suffering and pain is what holds us together, exposing us in our vulnerability to the world and to each other, and it is the intensity of impoverishment that is increasing in material terms as corporate capitalism thrashes around desperately in its attempts at growth. Vattimo and Zabala cite Mike Davis’s powerful book *Planet of Slums* as a study of how neoliberal globalization involves “the reproduction of poverty” (68). Basically, as Davis explains, the “policies of agricultural deregulation and financial discipline enforced by the IMF and World Bank continued to generate an exodus of surplus rural labor to urban slums even as cities ceased to be job machines.”¹¹ We could also consider the analysis of “pauperization” by Samir Amin, who says that in the second half of the twentieth century, “*the proportion of the popular classes in a precarious position has gone from less than a quarter to more than half of the global urban population and this phenomenon of pauperization has reappeared on a significant scale in the developed centers themselves.*”¹²

Returning to Negri, he states that the experience of poverty is intrinsic to the production of being, and this is necessarily a weak power and a weak ontology. We create being together, out of our impoverishment, and this takes place in and as common, because we are not isolated individuals but necessarily social beings. According to Negri, “the common name is the event of the multitude,” and therefore “the common is the product of the multitude.”¹³ Multitude is Negri’s, and Negri and Hardt’s, name for the people in a less metaphysically strong form. A multitude is not an unruly anarchy but a “composed chaos” that occurs when people come together in common. The term ‘people’ is too organic for Negri, while an earlier term, mass, dissolves the specific singularities of the components of the group. Negri makes the multitude the subject of communism and democracy. Vattimo and Zabala do not use the term multitude, of course, and they do not really name a subject for their hermeneutic communism in this book I don’t think that multitude is an unproblematic name, but I think that Negri’s philosophy and his interpretation of Marx, specifically in *Time for Revolution*, is broadly compatible with Vattimo and Zabala.

Alain Badiou is critical of the apolitical nature of postmodernism and its weak ontology, although he is also closer to Derrida and Vattimo and Zabala than he

¹⁰ Antonio Negri, *Time for Revolution*, trans. Matteo Mandarini (New York: Continuum, 2003), p. 194.

¹¹ Mike Davis, *Planet of Slums* (London: Verso, 2006), p. 15.

¹² Samir Amin, *The Liberal Virus: Permanent War and the Americanization of the World*, trans. James H. Membrez (New York: Monthly Review Press, 2004), p. 39 (emphasis in original).

¹³ Negri, *Time for Revolution*, p. 195.

would like to admit. Badiou would like a stronger ontology and a more militant politics than Vattimo and Zabala's hermeneutic communism, but he is smart enough to recognize the difficulties of this on both sides. According to Badiou, postmodern post-Heideggerian philosophy is caught up in the linguistic turn, and claims that there are only two things in the world, bodies and languages. But Badiou claims on the contrary, "*there are only bodies and languages, except that there are truths.*"¹⁴ Truths come about by means of an event, and Badiou's entire philosophy is dedicated to setting out the ontological and logical conditions for the possibility of an event. On the one hand, the postmodern skepticism of truth is largely a caricature of figures like Derrida, Deleuze, Vattimo and Zabala. On the other hand, despite Badiou's commitment to the possibility of events, his analysis of being in terms of set theory largely makes events impossible, and so even when they do occur they are unpredictable and unforeseen. The fact that an event cannot be produced, predicted or controlled makes its ontological nature *weak*, in an important sense.

Badiou is attracted to politics in a grand style, and he has struggled to reinterpret his communism and his Maoism. He is also very critical and suspicious of the term democracy, which coincides with what Vattimo and Zabala call "framed democracy" in *Hermeneutic Communism*. Part of the problem with democracy, in addition to its corruption by representative interests in neoliberal capitalism, is that it is based on the notion of an "organic bond" that sutures democracy to politics as such. It is this organic bond that Negri tries to undo in his transition from people to multitude as the subject of democracy, and Vattimo and Zabala in their anti-metaphysical hermeneutics. In some of his most probing essays on politics, published as *Metapolitics*, Badiou considers that because democracy been stretched so far as to name politics as such, it actually constrains what is possible in political terms. "Democracy," he writes, "could thus be defined as that which authorises a placement of the particular under the law of the universality of political will," issuing from Descartes.¹⁵ But this is precisely what Vattimo and Zabala also work to liberate us from in their book, because is the metaphysical conception of politics that prescribes particular actions that issues in a framed democracy that is always controlled by the special interests of capital.

In another essay in *Metapolitics*, Badiou claims explicitly that politics is about contesting and dissolving bonds, or the absolute status of any metaphysical bond. Political activity is a work of unbinding, which means that it is anti-metaphysical in Vattimo and Zabala's terms. The work of politics takes place with a mass-movement, which is "a specific mode of the 'inconsistent consistency' of the multiple on the edge of the void, a historical event site." Here, in terms that recalls Negri's, Badiou affirms that "a multiplicity on the edge of the void is, in itself, political."¹⁶ I take Badiou's insistence that politics is a kind of unbinding as an affirmation of its necessarily interpretive nature, in Vattimo and Zabala's terms, despite the fact that

¹⁴ Alain Badiou, *Logics of Worlds: Being and Event II*, trans. Alberto Toscano (London: Continuum, 2009), p. 4 (emphasis in original).

¹⁵ Alain Badiou, *Metapolitics*, trans. Jason Barker (London: Verso, 2005), p. 92.

¹⁶ *Ibid.*, p. 72.

Badiou would resist using the term hermeneutics as too conservative and subjectivist.

Another convergence between Badiou and Vattimo and Zabala is where Badiou develops his critique of the notion of the party, which persists in Maoism, and proposes to think politics and communism beyond the confines of the party as another kind of constraining bond. This is a difficult question for Badiou, because he wants to hold onto a militancy of and for politics, but at the same time he is suspicious of the fusion that occurs by means of the party bond. Along with Jacques Rancière, he poses the question “of a politics *without party*, which in no sense means unorganized, but rather one organized through the intellectual discipline of political processes, and not according to a form correlated with that of the State.”¹⁷ Finally, in his book *The Communist Hypothesis*, Badiou claims that what ultimately characterizes communism is its refusal to live without Ideas. He says that “the dominant imperative in the world today is ‘Live without an Idea.’”¹⁸ Neoliberal capitalism substitutes money for ideas, and discounts or disqualifies any competing values. Badiou’s valorization of the Idea is probably too strong for Vattimo and Zabala, but the precarious nature of ideas in our contemporary world attests to the importance of a hermeneutic philosophy that explicitly engages ideas precisely in terms of their political implications, their possibility for thinking and living a new communism.

This new communism would be lived in common, although it would not be reductive to any pre-given or substantial commonality. It would also attend to and affirm the power of ideas, the power of our ability “to *interpret* the world” (140), as Vattimo and Zabala conclude, without succumbing to any sort of metaphysical idealism. Just as we need a new communism, we need a new materialism that is neither metaphysical, atomistic, reductive, nor consumerist in its presumptions and effects.¹⁹ In their analysis of South American socialism, Vattimo and Zabala affirm that “the idea that has guided us has been rigorously materialistic: the structural changes we ascertain in South American societies are inseparable from a collective culture and structure that are very different from the one that characterizes the West” (135). *Hermeneutic communism* is “rigorously materialistic” in its analysis of politics, philosophy and what I am calling, following Žižek and Lacan, the Real.

We need to think about the Real in ecological terms as well as philosophical and political terms. Vattimo and Zabala argue that communism must function “as a movement that embraces the programmatic cause of ‘degrowth’ as the only way to save the human species” (121). Capitalist development is predicated on growth, and only works if economic growth is possible. But the planet is reaching real ecological limits to growth in terms of natural resources. Not only oil and other fossil fuels, but arable land, rare earth elements and other critical minerals are becoming scarcer and

¹⁷ Ibid., p. 122.

¹⁸ Alain Badiou, *The Communist Hypothesis*, trans. David Macey and Steve Corcoran (London: Verso, 2010), p. 231.

¹⁹ See Clayton Crockett and Jeffrey W. Robbins, *Religion, Politics, and the Earth: The New Materialism* (New York: Palgrave Macmillan, 2012).

more expensive.²⁰ The chaotic weather patterns wreaking havoc on the planet in recent years are due to global atmospheric warming, especially of ocean temperatures. The relative stability of the planet's atmosphere is being undermined, ice is melting at the poles at an alarming rate, and water levels are slowly rising.

Capitalism has always been unequal in the sense that a relative few were enriched by most gains in production and profits. At the same time, so long as worldwide growth was increasing, this uneven and unequal growth promised to lift all boats, and there was a brief exceptional period between 1945 and 1970 which it appeared as if this were possible. For first world societies, safety nets were put in place and nearly full employment guaranteed while other nations put in place ambitious plans to industrialize. All of this was made possible due to enormous discoveries and then the exploitation of super-giant oilfields, first in North America and then in the Middle East. This energy in turn fueled the "green revolution" in agriculture as petroleum-based mechanical equipment and pesticides produced incredible yields of agricultural crops. Unfortunately, as the rate of growth slowed in the 1970s, when the United States hit peak domestic oil production, the financial economy became delinked from the real economy.

Vattimo and Zabala cite Naomi Klein's important study of disaster capitalism, *The Shock Doctrine*. Klein traces the emergence of this new and virulent form of corporate capitalism to the work of the Chicago Boys, economic and political apostles of Milton Friedman, and their activities in Latin America in the 1970s. Klein suggests that the shock of neo-liberal disaster capitalism is starting to wear off in Latin America and other parts of the world, but she neglects to analyze the crucial energy aspect of these political and economic processes. She waxes nostalgic for Keynesianism, but fails to explain that the transformation from 'normal' capitalism to 'disaster' capitalism is due to a crisis of material growth.²¹ If capitalist growth is unsustainable in absolute terms, because it is based on indefinite increase of products, production and profits, then it can only survive in relative terms, by allocating more and more resources to fewer and fewer people and corporations and impoverishing more and more people. This is the underlying factor behind the concentration of wealth over the last four decades. The only way for elite people and corporations to increase their wealth is to take more and more from the poor, and this takes place both within nations and between rich and poor nations. It's not simply that capitalism has thrown off the constraints of Keynesian liberalism in the wake of the collapse of the USSR; it's rather that capitalist growth itself is becoming critical and in its attempts to perpetuate itself has metamorphised into a more savage form. Capitalism has metastasized, and it will kill us if we do not develop and implement an alternative.

Communism in a weak or hermeneutic sense names an alternative to capitalism. Any alternative to capitalism would have to be broadly communistic, in Vattimo and

²⁰ See Michael T. Klare, *The Race for What's Left: The Global Scramble for the World's Last Resources* (New York: Metropolitan Books, 2012).

²¹ See Naomi Klein, *The Shock Doctrine: The Rise of Disaster Capitalism* (New York: Metropolitan Books, 2007), Conclusion, pp. 443–466.

Zabala's terms. They assert that "the postmodern condition that the dissolution of absolutes imposes for the survival of the human species demands that we assume communism as the horizon of any possible liberation for the human being" (111). This claim can be read as hyperbolic only if we ignore the desperate ecological state of the world that they are interpreting. We cannot save the Earth, which will continue with or without us, but we may be able to save ourselves if we can stop consuming. The problem is that as a species that's what we do; we consume and consume until we cannot consume any more. This is why Slavoj Žižek says that it's easier for us to imagine the end of the world in apocalyptic terms than to imagine an alternative to neoliberal capitalism, even as "the global capitalist system is approaching an apocalyptic zero-point."²² It's just too hard to make sense of it all, which is why Vattimo and Zabala's efforts are so important.

The new communism is necessarily sketchy and 'weak,' and it also relies on a new materialism. This materialism is not a metaphysical or a scientific determinism, but it does engage with science and philosophy in important interpretative ways. We also need to free 'science' from metaphysics and view it in more hermeneutic terms. And here is where Gilles Deleuze and Félix Guattari offer resources, especially with the notion of a "minor science" from *A Thousand Plateaus*. According to Deleuze and Guattari, there is an opposition between two kinds of science—"nomad, war machine science and royal, State science."²³ Royal science is axiomatic science that is legislative and top-down science, which serves the interests of the status quo. For example, "royal, or State, science only tolerates and appropriates stone cutting by means of *templates*...under conditions that restore the primacy of the fixed model of form, mathematical figures, and measurement."²⁴ Nomad science, on the other hand, is generally "portrayed as a prescientific or parascientific or subscientific agency."²⁵ Nomad science escapes the philosophical control of metaphysics and the political control of the State, and it is more compatible with weak communism. These nomadic or ambulant sciences may appear unscientific, or irrational and mystical from the legislative perspective of royal science, but according to Deleuze and Guattari "they only get that way when they fall into abeyance."²⁶

The opposition between nomad and royal science is similar to Thomas Kuhn's famous distinction between revolutionary and normal scientific paradigms, which Vattimo and Zabala invoke. The problem with Kuhn's perspective, from Deleuze and Guattari's perspective, is that it is too dialectical, in the sense that revolutionary science inevitably contributes to the establishment of a new normal scientific paradigm. Deleuze and Guattari want to maintain a more permanent tension between ambulant science and stable State science that I think has affinities with Vattimo and Zabala's critique of philosophical and political metaphysics, even though Deleuze

²² Slavoj Žižek, *Living in the End Times* (London: Verso, 2010), p. x.

²³ Gilles Deleuze and Félix Guattari, *A Thousand Plateaus: Capitalism and Schizophrenia*, trans. Brian Massumi (Minneapolis: University of Minnesota Press, 1987), p. 364.

²⁴ *Ibid.*, p. 365 (emphasis in original).

²⁵ *Ibid.*, p. 367.

²⁶ *Ibid.*, p. 373.

still retains the term metaphysics in his philosophy. But Deleuze and Deleuze and Guattari do affirm and celebrate not only a nomadic perspective, but also a minor philosophy and a minor literature, which is also broadly convergent with Vattimo and Vattimo and Zabala's weak philosophy.

For example, in *Difference and Repetition*, Deleuze engages with the development of differential calculus as a way of suggesting how we can think about ideas in their differentiability and their virtuality. Although royal mathematical science sees the infinitesimals of calculus as leading to and being cancelled out in finite algebraic calculus and then set theory, Deleuze intervenes into this progression and liberates a 'weak' form of mathematics so that he can develop his alternative (to Plato and Kant) conception of an Idea. Deleuze suggests that "there is a treasure buried within the old so-called barbaric or pre-scientific interpretations of the differential calculus, which must be separated from its infinitesimal matrix."²⁷ In *Difference and Repetition*, Deleuze explains that mathematics as a science is concerned with solutions, but his philosophical interest in the history of mathematics is how it poses problems. There is a sense in which dx is the Idea, because it allows Deleuze to conceive of Ideas as virtual rather than actual in quasi-mathematical terms and it allows him to conceive of Ideas as internally differentiated rather than understood in terms of identity.

According to Deleuze, set theory gives a finite solution to the problem of differential calculus, but then set theory has its own axiom of infinity. In this way, "modern mathematics leaves us in a state of antinomy, since the strict finite interpretation that it gives of the calculus nevertheless presupposes an axiom of infinity in the set theoretical foundation, even though this axiom finds no illustration in calculus." Here is where Badiou swoops in to construct his royal, axiomatic science of mathematical set theory to ground being. Badiou believes that he needs a strong science of mathematics on which to base his revolutionary conception of an event, in order to oppose it to the power of the state. But Badiou is too metaphysical at the level of mathematical ontology, from the perspective of Deleuze.²⁸

We need a minor but engaged orientation to the sciences to go along with a weak communism. And mathematics is not the only science that is crucial to engage, despite the significance of Badiou's work. In the penultimate chapter of *Difference and Repetition*, Deleuze offers resources to reconceive physics, energy and thermodynamics based on his notion of intensity. The intensity of difference the drives repetition is cancelled out in extensity, and yet "difference creates both this extensity and this quality."²⁹ There is a transcendental illusion of entropy, because we only look at the result, the extensity where intensive difference is cancelled out, rather than the energetic process itself that produces new differences and new forms

²⁷ Gilles Deleuze, *Difference and Repetition*, trans. Paul Patton (New York: Columbia University Press, 1994), p. 170.

²⁸ See Clayton Crockett, *Deleuze Beyond Badiou: Ontology, Multiplicity, and Event* (New York: Columbia University Press, 2013).

²⁹ Deleuze, *Difference and Repetition*, p. 228.

of complexity.³⁰ We struggle to reconcile the second law of thermodynamics, the necessary increase of entropy, with the processes that increase complex organization and appear neg-entropic. There is a new science of non-equilibrium thermodynamics that considers entropy not as loss of order but as gradient reduction; given a gradient of temperature or pressure, nature works to reduce this gradient as efficiently as possible.³¹ Although in most circumstances this process leads to a loss of organization, under certain conditions it contributes to the production and maintenance of organization.

Non-equilibrium thermodynamics is an example of a minor science that works according to what Deleuze calls an asymmetrical synthesis: “everything goes from high to low, and by that movement affirms the lowest: asymmetrical synthesis.”³² This movement from high to low is the reduction of gradient differentials. In addition to differential calculus and non-equilibrium thermodynamics, we can consider entanglement in quantum physics as well as epigenetics in biology as intensive minor sciences. These sciences are not settled or legislative, but show us how much there is still to understand and to interpret.³³ This is a very broad sketch, but offers resources for thinking ontology as energetics and materialism based on energy transformation. This vision of minor sciences grounded in a materialist ecology is a supplement to Vattimo and Zabala’s important work on politics and philosophy.

³⁰ Ibid., p. 229.

³¹ See Eric D. Schneider and Dorion Sagan, *Into the Cool: Energy Flow, Thermodynamics and Life* (Chicago: University of Chicago Press, 2005).

³² Deleuze, *Difference and Repetition*, p. 234.

³³ See Karen Barad, *Meeting the Universe Halfway: Quantum Physics and the Entanglement of Matter and Meaning* (Durham, NC: Duke University Press, 2007), and Eva Jablonka and Marion J. Lamb, *Evolution in Four Dimensions: Genetic, Epigenetic, Behavioral, and Symbolic Variation in the History of Life* (Cambridge, MA: The MIT Press, 2005).

Response to Crockett

Gianni Vattimo and Santiago Zabala

Crockett, together with Robbins, are the architects of a new theoretical movement called “insurrectionist theology.” This radical theology does not simply offer ways of thinking and living beyond framed democracies, but also ways to overcome its political neutrality through Martin Heidegger’s fourfold: earth and sky, gods and mortals. According to their recent manifesto,¹ the truth of political theology in the twenty-first century can no longer be imagined through liberal reforms, but only by reconsidering democracy as a form of radical religious practice and political thought. This democracy is not simply unconstrained by modern liberal capitalism, but has actually become its greatest enemy, that is, a true insurrection determined to oppose its impositions. This is probably why from the very beginning of his contribution, Crockett joins us in proclaiming the end of liberal reformism and the return of communism to fight capitalism’s unlimited growth. After all, his insurrectionist stance, similarly to our anarchic hermeneutics, is also driven by the need to overcome the absence of alternatives imposed by framed democracies: financially, culturally, and ecologically throughout the world.

Crockett’s contribution does not simply clarify our relation to a number of contemporary thinkers (Negri, Derrida, Badiou) and problems (the meaning of “new materialism,” the role of “party” and “minor sciences” today), but also present ecology as “an absolute limit for capitalist growth and a condition for a new form of communism that manifests as a democracy in common”, which we fully endorse. As

¹Ward Blanton, Clayton Crockett, Jeffrey W. Robbins, and Noëlle Vahanian. *An Insurrectionist Manifesto: Four New Gospels for a Radical Politics* (New York: Columbia University Press, 2016). See also Clayton Crockett and Jeffrey W. Robbins, *Religion, Politics, and the Earth: The New Materialism* (Palgrave: 2012).

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it is impossible for us to respond to the variety of Crockett's observations we will limit our response to two central points he makes regarding the meaning of the "Real" for communism's return and our distrust in Negri's notion of the "commons."

The return of the real, as Crockett explains, has taken very different forms in contemporary philosophy. The "new" or "speculative realism" practiced by Graham Harman and Maurizio Ferraris has little to nothing in common with the "Real" as Badiou and Žižek understand it. Whereas the former aim to reinforce metaphysical scientism to support neo-liberal capitalism, the later "retain the notion of the Lacanian Real to interpret and to intervene against neoliberalism." In order to clarify this difference, Crockett points out the "hermeneutical" nature of Žižek's ontological account of the Real. For the Slovenian philosopher the Real is not something objective or the possibility of its appearance, but rather the "screen that prevents us from attaining any Thing outside our phenomenal understanding." Contrary to the new realists, whose politics depends upon "phenomenal understanding," together with Žižek we believe this is precisely what prevents the generation of emancipatory effects. This is why Crockett argues that communism must now think "the Real precisely in its ontological and hermeneutical weakness without succumbing to the illusions of scientific managerial realism."

Our suspicions of Negri's notion of the "commons," as well as other important concepts he brought forward with Michael Hardt such as "empire" or "multitude," rests in its metaphysical connotations. As all attentive readers of the Italian philosopher know, Spinoza is not simply an author he dedicated a number of studies to,² but also at the center of his thought; Spinoza is to Negri what Heidegger is for us. But there is a substantial difference as the former ontology is one of substances and the later one of events. When Negri uses Spinoza's ontology to demand a politics of the common he inevitably falls into metaphysics, because the "commons" are interpreted as an ever lasting substance when in fact they are bound to historical circumstances, epochs, and events. This is why we are also skeptical when the Italian thinker "makes the multitude the subject of communism and democracy." The indeterminateness of these notions ("commons," "multitude," "empire") does not simply leave aside their condition ("weak," "discharged," "framed"), but also their historical reference (post-9/11 world), which is constitutive of the role they will play against the bearers of power.

Although Crockett believes "we need to retain the notion of the Lacanian Real to interpret and to intervene against neoliberalism" and that "the connection of communism to the common is crucial for" our philosophical and political project, we still consider them to be counterproductive in the long term. Whereas the former risks losing the urgent need to take action, the latter avoids outlining in detail what this action ought to look like. Crockett's simple call to think about the Real in ecological terms, as well as to link the commons to communism, shows how his insurrectionist stance embodies Žižek, Negri's, and our best ideas to change the world.

²See, A. Negri, *The Savage Anomaly: The Power of Spinoza's Metaphysics and Politics*. Trans. M. Hardt (Minnesota University Press, 2000) and A. Negri, *Spinoza for Our Time: Politics and Postmodernity*. Trans. W. McCuaig (New York: Columbia University Press, 2013).

Are the Oppressed ‘Weak’?: Emancipation and Hermeneutic Communism

Owen Glyn-Williams

Phases of a revolution are not decided in parliaments, they are only registered there. – C.L.R. James

Abstract One of the signature gestures of *Hermeneutic Communism* is to link what Gianni Vattimo has famously called ‘weak thought’ – thought deprived of its meta-physical and objectivistic vocation – to the ‘thought of the weak’, a modality of thinking suited to the emancipation of oppressed peoples around the globe. Whereas the global forces of domination marshal a fatalistic ‘politics of description’, which seeks to impose a developmental narrative that explains where history *must* go, Vattimo and Zabala argue that the historical vantage of the weak fundamentally resists the developmental ‘truths’ imposed upon them by insisting on alternatives to the ‘framed’ order of democratic capitalism. This paper problematizes the characterization of the oppressed – variously referred to as the *discharge* of capitalism and the *losers* of history – as the ‘weak’. Specifically, I argue that the emphasis on weakness results in a potentially lopsided vision of emancipation as the advent of more protective governors and representatives, who defend rather than attack the governed, an alternative to ‘framed democracy’ which, while not without promise, may not do justice to the anarchic and egalitarian force of the idea of hermeneutics that they articulate. Looking to the work of Jacques Rancière, I suggest that an account of the construction of alternative forms political subjectivity on the part of the weak *themselves* would strengthen the notion of emancipation at work in the idea of hermeneutic communism. This involves registering at the theoretical level, for example, the widespread efforts at collective self-organization and resistance taking place in the slums of Latin America in addition to the successes of figures like Hugo Chávez and Evo Morales.

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Introduction

One of the signature gestures of *Hermeneutic Communism* is to link what Gianni Vattimo has famously called ‘weak thought’ – thought deprived of its metaphysical and objectivistic vocation – to the ‘thought of the weak’, a modality of thinking suited to the emancipation of oppressed peoples around the globe. Whereas the global forces of domination marshal a fatalistic ‘politics of description’, which seeks to impose a developmental narrative that explains where history *must* go, Vattimo and Zabala argue that the historical vantage of the weak fundamentally resists the developmental ‘truths’ imposed upon them by insisting on alternatives to the ‘framed’ order of ‘democratic’ capitalism. To the extent that Latin America’s various ‘left’ governments – led by figures such as Evo Morales and the now deceased Hugo Chavez – have resisted acquiescence to the purportedly necessary trajectory of capitalist development, it is seen as a paradigmatic expression of hermeneutic communism. While I seek to affirm the emancipatory character of their account of hermeneutics, in what follows I question whether communism as *the state-led defense of the weak* makes good on what they call its ‘anarchic vein’.

In the context of the spectacular emergence of insurrectionary revolt and social movements over the past several decades across Latin America – mobilized against both global capitalism *and* the state – it seems especially important to resituate the anarchic capacities of the ‘weak’ themselves as the driving force of the region’s communist actuality. For it is precisely internal to these movements that novel, counter-hegemonic interpretations of the world are unfolding. This does not mean dismissing the progressive achievements of left regimes, but rather foregrounding the tense yet generative dynamic between popular, constituent power, and constituted state power, a dynamic that tends toward the egalitarian dissolution of this very distinction. Thus, what is at stake is not simply an assessment of the particular political conjuncture in Latin America, but the pivotal question of the relationship between political power, emancipation, and the State.

The ‘Anarchic Vein’ of Hermeneutics: Weak Thought as a Strong Theory of Interpretation

Vattimo has famously referred to his post-metaphysical philosophy as ‘weak thought’, approaching philosophy as “a process of weakening absolutes, truths, and foundations.” (*HC*, 96) Weak thought – or what is the same for Vattimo and Zabala, hermeneutics – supplants the universality of truth with the plurality of interpretations, opening the space for ways of thinking and doing that differ from those prescribed by the hegemonic global consensus. This rejection of a single ground or principle (*arché*) of truth leads them to emphasize the ‘anarchic vein of hermeneutics’, which brings the politically progressive nature of hermeneutics into view. “It

should be noted," they assert, "that there is an anarchic vein in hermeneutics that, as Reiner Schürmann explained, does not involve the absence of rules but of the universal rule. As the resistance to principles, conventions, and categories, anarchy is not the end of the political project of hermeneutics but its beginning." (*HC*, 18).

This anarchic vein is therefore not only epistemic but intrinsically political, and for two reasons. First, because the perspectival pluralization it implies opens the terrain of valid perspectives in such a way that the values, ideas, and desires of those who have been historically silenced gain a space for expression. Perspectival multiplicity is inherently counter-hegemonic, since the global order relies on the imposition of its perspective as the only valid one, presenting it as the triumph of reason. This is what Vattimo and Zabala mean when they claim: "weak thought can only be the thought of the weak, certainly not of the dominating classes, who have always worked to conserve and leave unquestioned the established order of the world." (*HC*, 96) Weak thought is by definition, then, "the thought of the weak in search of alternatives." (*HC*, 2) Second, weak thought is political precisely because it implies a *strong* theory of interpretation. Whereas objective truth merely requires cognitive apprehension – the 'mirroring' of nature – interpretation is simultaneously practical, constructive, and creative. Drawing from the expansion of the notion of interpretation in Nietzsche and Heidegger, in particular, they maintain that interpretation is a constitutive feature of practical existence, inextricably tied to our actions and projects.

The politically progressive recasting of hermeneutical weak thought as 'the thought of the weak' is perhaps best captured in what Vattimo and Zabala call "the *right of the weak to interpret*." (italics added, 79) Bearing in mind the strong notion of interpretation with which they are operating, the right to interpret the world differently necessarily entails the right to engage in projects that recast social structures and relations in new and counter-hegemonic ways. Against the 'truths' of objective thought and neoliberal restructuring, these interpretations, the *active* (re-) interpretations of the world by the oppressed, hold the potential to create another, egalitarian world. "It is just in this right to interpret differently," they claim, "that the weak emerge politically as bearers of new vitality." (*HC*, 86).

Given this account of the anarchic vein of hermeneutics and the right of the oppressed to interpret the world differently, one might be struck by the specific feature of Latin American politics that Vattimo and Zabala see as embodying this right, namely, the 'progressive' regimes of figures like Hugo Chavez and Evo Morales. Without undercutting the achievements of these regimes in areas such as poverty reduction and the rejection of neoliberal expansion, it is nonetheless noteworthy that the widespread politicization of poor and oppressed people across the continent is relegated to the background in their assessment of the promise of Latin American communism. The absence of grassroots, constituent power from their consideration of a region in which such powers have reached an extraordinary level of intensity, necessitates an examination of the relationship between popular power and the governments that Vattimo and Zabala praise. To neglect the dynamics between constituent and constituted powers risks positioning the Latin American

people as passive beneficiaries of benevolent rulers, precisely the asymmetry of capacities that *Hermeneutic Communism* seeks to move beyond through its anarchic and egalitarian theory of interpretation.

Dispersal and Dialectical Transformation

One of the reasons that Vattimo and Zabala turn to state leaders like Chavez and Morales as the locus of today's most promising emancipatory politics is their hesitation concerning the efficacy of expressions of popular power such as insurrection and militant struggle, leading them to distance themselves from other contemporary thinkers on the left. "Unlike Alain Badiou, Antonio Negri, and other contemporary Marxist theorists," they explain, "we do not believe that the twenty-first century calls for revolution because the forces of the politics of descriptions are too powerful, violent, and oppressive to be overcome through a parallel insurrection: only such a weak thought as hermeneutics can avoid violent ideological revolts and therefore defend the weak." (*HC*, 3) While it is certainly the case that new technologies of control and the militarization of civil society force us to call into question traditional notions of revolution, it should nonetheless be noted that much of the success of emancipatory politics in Latin America has come precisely from the pressure of insurrectionary force and grassroots militant mobilization.

Among recent attempts to think the relationship between popular struggle and State power in Latin America, I would like to point to two of the most prominent models for thinking this relationship. The first, represented by figures like Raul Zibechi and John Holloway, is broadly anarchist and autonomist, arguing that what social movements are effectuating is the *dispersal* of power throughout a network of non-state, 'horizontal' organizational structures. In both his *Dispersing Power: Social Movements as Anti-State Forces* and *Territories in Resistance: A Cartography of Latin American Social Movements*, Zibechi looks at the internal logics of these movements. Focusing on their immanent unfolding:

The picture that appears, one that becomes increasingly intense, is that the long-awaited new world is being born in the movements' spaces and territories, embedded in the gaps that are opening up in capitalism. It is 'the' real and possible new world, built by indigenous people, peasants, the urban poor on conquered lands, woven into the base of the new social relations between human beings, inspired by ancestral dreams, and recreated through the struggles of the past twenty years. (*TR*, 20)

He dates the beginning of the recent sequence of popular rebellion and indigenous social movements – which have been so effective at repelling international neoliberal *and* local state forces – to the 1989 uprising in Caracas, known as the 'Caracazo', and the Zapatista uprising in 1994. "The Caracazo (Caracas Insurrection) of 1989... showed that it was possible to resist and go on the offensive, from the grassroots rural communities and poor, urban neighborhoods..." (*DP*, 1) Likewise, "Zapatismo has illuminated the continent and the world since 1994 with an armed uprising that seeks not to seize power but to build a new world, and shows the importance of

building communal, municipal, and regional autonomy, from below.” (DP, 1) These events, for Zibechi, initiated ‘a new era’ defined by “the self-construction of another world, without the need to go through the seizure of the state...” (TR, 332).

Zibechi’s analyses of popular power in Latin American movements places special emphasis on their egalitarian activation of the capacities of poor and oppressed peoples to govern themselves, against the presupposition that they must rely on a robust state or a party vanguard to direct or assist them. Speaking of the ‘other world’ being built by Zapatismo in Chiapas, he attributes its novelty to the way “it has been able to build supra-community forms of power, like the councils that are regional powers comprised of several municipalities, which bring together hundreds of communities in each one. And,” he underscores, “most importantly, there are no state powers, with rotating positions, where everyone learns to govern.” (TR, 333) What is key, for Zibechi, is that the forms of political power being realized in places like Chiapas and El Alto do not constitute “a separate body above society.” (DP, 1) Instead, they break down distinctions between leaders and led, representatives and the represented, competent and incompetent, etc. If, as Vattimo and Zabala rightly show, framed democracies impose ‘truths’ about capitalist development, they *equally* impose ‘truths’ about politics and the State, such as the ‘truth’ that political power operate through a state model that relies precisely on the hierarchical distinctions that social movements work to dissolve.

Popular insurrections play an especially important role in the dissolution these stark statist divisions amongst the capable and the incapable, for Zibechi, because “popular sectors only discover their internal power when it is unleashed.” (DP, 11) Or in other words, “the insurgency is a moment of rupture in which subjects display their capacities, their power as a capacity to do, and deploy them, revealing aspects hidden in moments of repose, when there is little collective activity.” (DP, 11) The capacity to reinterpret the world would, on this account, arise from the very moment of rupture when the collective power to enact such reinterpretations at a distance from the state becomes clear to those who possess it, and a dispersal of nodes of power begins to take place. While Vattimo and Zabala may be right to suspect that insurrectionary power is not in and of itself sufficient for overcoming the global neoliberal order, Zibechi’s emphasis on its ability to activate the capacities and organizational powers of ‘the weak’, which disrupt and weaken the ‘*arché*’ of state organization, makes it a decisive element in emancipatory processes.

The second prominent way of thinking the relationship between popular power and the state is elaborated by thinkers such as Enrique Dussel, Bruno Bosteels, and George Ciccariello-Maher, who see grassroots movements as engaged in a *dialectical* struggle with state power. Rather than the general rejection of the state in favor of the anarchic dispersal of power, this struggle seeks neither to avoid the state apparatus, nor to be assimilated into its existing structures, but to subject it to popular forces in such a way as to bring about a fundamental alteration of political power.

Consider the way that George Ciccariello-Maher’s *We Created Chavez: A People’s History of the Venezuelan Revolution* examines the tension between movements and states in the context of Venezuela and Hugo Chavez. As the title of the book suggests, one of its central arguments is that “Hugo Chavez is not a cause but

an effect, not Creator but creation.” (WCC, 21) He presents a history of recent Venezuelan politics ‘from below’, treating the history of the Bolivarian Revolution and the story of Chavez’s rule as “one driven by the struggles and the self-activity of the people themselves.” (WCC, 9) If his focus is power ‘from below’, however, Ciccariello-Maher does not share with Zibechi a vision of the state as quite so alien to progressive movements. For him, “the story of recent Venezuelan history is not the story of one side or the other, of how to seize the state as is or to avoid its sinister tentacles entirely.” (WCC, 16) Indeed, he warns of a *twin* fetish, the tendency either to fetishize states and leaders, or to fetishize horizontality, autonomism, and the renunciation of engagement with the state. In order to genuinely apprehend the political potential and novelty of Venezuela – and he argues that this is the case for other countries in Latin America as well – it is necessary to look at the dialectical interplay of constituent and constituted power, an interplay that carries the promise of radically altering the very nature of this distinction.

It is in an effort to avoid these twin fetishes that... [I] speak neither of power from above nor entirely from below, but instead of a “dual power” that exists in ongoing, tense, and antagonistic opposition to the state, straining insistently upward from the bases to generate a dialectical motion allowing the revolutionary transformation of the state and its institutions, with the ultimate goal of deconstructing, decentralizing, and rendering it a nonstate. (WCC 19)

Ciccariello-Maher’s evocation of the alteration of the state to the point of its becoming a ‘non-state’ is not, I would argue, fundamentally incongruous with some of the more anarchistic accounts of the transformations taking place in Latin American politics. What both approaches have in common is that they observe in Latin America a singular political process that is tenaciously seeking a transformation in social relations and governance, such that the very meaning of the division between constituent and constituted power is being progressively broken down.

What this admittedly brief discussion of the relationship between movements and states has sought to show, therefore, is that whether it is thought in terms of dispersal or dialectical transformation, the force of recent Latin American politics consists in large part in this effective challenge on the part of the so-called weak to the traditional statist interpretation of political power and democratic mediation. This is a fundamentally immanentist reinterpretation of political power, which seeks to do away with political authority as a transcendent, paternalistic structure. Moreover, one could argue that this movement toward the collapse of the division between power ‘from below’ and ‘power from above’ is an even stronger expression of the right of the ‘weak’ to interpret the world differently, as it is not their representations but rather *their own self-activity* that is carrying out these new interpretations. If, as Giorgio Agamben argues, “the concepts of sovereignty and of constituent power, which are at the core of our political tradition, have to be abandoned or, at least, to be thought all over again,” then it must be said that this rethinking is already unfolding in *barrios* and rural communities across Latin America.

Toward a Strong Theory of the Interpreter

Considering the centrality of popular struggle in both the dispersive and dialectical accounts, which, in spite of their differences, consider the 'weak' as the driving force of emancipatory social and political transformation in Latin America, it is worth asking *why* the conception of communism elaborated by Vattimo and Zabala leaves such struggles in relative obscurity. One answer, I surmise, might be the limitations of the attempt to develop a political philosophy from out of the postmodernism to which their project is wedded. One of the reasons postmodernism has attracted suspicion from both political philosophers and those involved in struggles for emancipation, is that it seems to weaken subjective practical agency to the point of rendering emancipation unintelligible. Thus, while the postmodern turn wins us the opening of the terrain of interpretation, as Vattimo and Zabala so rightly insist, it arguably has the effect of precluding a strong theory of the *interpreter*. Consider one of the passages from Nietzsche that they cite:

Against positivism, which halts at phenomena – 'There are only facts' – I would say: No, facts is precisely what there is not, only interpretations. We cannot establish any fact 'in itself': perhaps it is folly to want to do such a thing. 'Everything is subjective,' you say, but even this is interpretation. The 'subject' is not something given, it is something added and invented and projected behind what there is. – Finally, is it necessary to posit an interpreter behind the interpretation? Even this is invention, hypothesis.

This passage is not only important as an articulation of the shift from objective realism to interpretation, but also because it interlinks the weakening of 'truth' with the weakening and displacement of the subject (the interpreter). This displacement of the subject, aided by Freud and carried to its most radical limit by Foucault, Derrida, and others of their generation, is one of the central accomplishments of postmodern philosophy. It exploded the universalist pretenses of 'Man' – European, white, male, normalized, property owner – by exposing its thoroughly particular and historical nature, making it abundantly clear that there is no universal, neutral vantage. In doing so, however, it also subverted traditional conceptions of sovereign human agency and freedom. Far from being metaphysically substantial, self-present, voluntary agents engaged in self-conscious actions, these thinkers revealed our thorough entanglement in cultural, linguistic, social, and economic matrices.

Of course, it would be pointless and regressive to suggest returning to a modern, robust conception of subjectivity. But neglecting to *rethink* the political subject on post-metaphysical terms produces difficulties in properly accounting for democratic, people-driven expressions of collective capacities that drive revolutionary processes such as the ones unfolding in Latin America. The work of Jacques Rancière is perhaps helpful in this regard, insofar as it rethinks the nature of emancipation by elaborating just such a post-metaphysical theory of political *subjectification*. For Rancière, politics – which in his lexicon is equivalent to emancipation and democracy – "occurs through specific subjects or mechanisms of subjectification." (*D*, 35) Importantly, though, he does not attribute to political subjects a substantial identity, but rather argues that "these subjects do not have the consistency of

coherent social groups united by common property or a common birth, etc. *They exist entirely within the act.*" ("DW", 116) In keeping with the demands of Vattimo and Zabala's critique of Western metaphysics, subjectification is a *process*, an *event*, and a *becoming*, rather than a metaphysical, transhistorical being.

Similarly to Zibechi's claim that insurrections and social movements effectively activate capacities that the condition of domination suppresses, subjectification consists in the setting into operation of an *axiom of equality*, of the equality of capacities for action and thought. "By subjectification," Rancière writes, "I mean the production through a series of actions of a body and a capacity for enunciation not previously identifiable within a given field of experience, whose identification is thus part of the reconfiguration of the field of experience." (*D*, 35). In this way, subjectification consists of a collective assertion capacities on the part of those who, within a certain order of social perception and intelligibility, were not seen and heard as capable of participating in politics.

This (admittedly brief) look at Rancière's attempt to rethink political subjectivity suggests the possibility of adding a strong theory of the *interpreter* to Vattimo and Zabala's progressive recasting of interpretation. Indeed, one way to understand subjectification is to see it as the moment when oppressed people cease to be 'the weak', and begin to alter the 'field of experience' around them through a reinterpretation of their place in it. This is also to say that the true hermeneutic communists *are the weak themselves* in search of alternatives, rather than their defenders.

Conclusion

If it is true that, as Vattimo and Zabala maintain, "both Chavez's initiatives and Morales's nationalizations are paradigmatic examples of weak communism," (*HC*, 127) then this should perhaps be affirmed in a more limited sense. For such a communism must also – if not for the most part – be located in the new interpretations of the world being carried out *by* the weak. It is their recasting of social ties in non-capitalist and extra-statist (non-hierarchical) terms that is driving the transformation in the very nature of political power in Latin America, in such a way that the chasm separating constituent and constituted power is being challenged. My emphasis on the weakening of state power by the people's anarchic seizure of the right to interpret – whether thought in terms of dispersal or a dialectical relationship – has therefore sought foreground popular power and 'subjectification' in Latin America's projects of emancipation. I would argue that such an emphasis is not only enabled, but also necessitated by the important hermeneutical rethinking of 'communism' that Vattimo and Zabala provide us with, though my focus on the emancipatory capacities of the 'weak' is but one of the many avenues opened by the project of *Hermeneutic Communism*.

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Response to Glyn-Williams

Gianni Vattimo and Santiago Zabala

The essence of Glyn-Williams' insightful contribution is embodied in the beautiful epigraph ("Phases of a revolution are not decided in parliaments, they are only registered there") by C.L.R. James. In the spirit of this great historian and political activist, Glyn-Williams suggests that we have given too much significance to the role that Chavez, Morales and other leaders played in Latin American politics, leaving aside those grassroots movements which created them. The "absence of grassroots, constituent power from their consideration of a region in which such powers have reached an extraordinary level of intensity" has inevitably presented the "Latin American people as passive beneficiaries of benevolent rulers."

We agree. Chavez, Morales, and other leaders' weight is certainly exaggerated throughout the book. But referring to their policies is very different referring to those of other contemporary politicians as Angela Merkel or Matteo Renzi. The former embody their citizen's social and cultural identities to a much higher degree than the latter. This is not only evident in their indigenous origins, but also in the extent to which they remain faithful to the movements which created them, whereas the latter have betrayed their electorate numerous times, as Europeans have become accustomed to throughout Europe. This betrayal is manifest both in the coalitions they created as well as by ignoring their party's political identity, which, in the case of Renzi, cannot even be referred to as progressive or leftist anymore.

According to Glyn-Williams, in overstating the role of these Latin American politicians, or better, ignoring the "dynamics between constituent and constituted powers," we fail to overcome the "asymmetry of capacities" that our "anarchic and egalitarian theory of interpretation" was meant to achieve. This instead is in part achieved by Raul Zibechi and George Ciccariello-Maher who center their

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investigations precisely on the relationship between popular struggle and state power in Latin America. While the first believes social movements effectuate a “dispersal of power” through a “network of horizontal organizational structures” in order to reject the state, the latter instead claims that they engage in dialectical struggles to alter the political power of the state. Our preference for the latter’s interpretation does not simply rest in his central thesis (“Hugo Chavez is not a cause but an effect, not Creator but creation”), but also for trying to alter the state instead of rejecting it. Even though we were not able to use Ciccariello-Maher’s study as it was published after *Hermeneutic Communism*, his conclusions are not very different from those of Greg Grandin, Brian A. Nelson, and Richard Gott, to whose studies on Latin America we refer throughout the fourth chapter.

Glyn-Williams also questions whether our “anarchic” theory of interpretation and “weak” communism are appropriate to defend the weak, that is, those social movements Zibechi and Ciccariello-Maher stressed above. This is probably why towards the end of his contribution he refers to Giorgio Agamben’s call to abandon the concepts of sovereignty and constituent power and Jacques Rancière’s attempt to rethink a theory of emancipation through political subjectification. Although these are certainly noteworthy intuitions, we are afraid they do not overcome metaphysics because the first calls for the total abandonment of our political tradition’s central concepts, and the latter for the production of actions that were not previously identifiable within a given field of experience. But how are these operations possible and recognizable without falling back into another metaphysics against the weak? Our call to overcome metaphysics through an “anarchic hermeneutics” and a “weakened communism” is not meant to avoid the “dynamics between constituent and constituted powers” which Agamben and Rancière try to avoid, but rather to become further involved in the conflict they create.

The absence of this conflict in Europe is the sign of a political crisis that will not be resolved until social movements are capable of presenting charismatic leaders such as those in Latin America. Returning to James’ statement in the epigraph, it is important to remember that parliaments must themselves contain some innovative or progressive signs, otherwise these phases of revolution would not even be comprehended. In the case of Venezuela this is evident in the role Simon Bolivar played in the country’s (and region’s) history.

Nietzsche the Communist? A Genealogy of Interpretation

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Abstract This essay will examine the powerful influence of Nietzsche's philosophy on the "weak thought" of Vattimo and Zabala, and the degree to which this influence is developed and even challenged by a hermeneutic communism. If Nietzsche is the middle term in the sub-title's itinerary "From Heidegger to Marx," what gets lost along the way, and at what cost?

Christian and anarchist.—Anarchists are mouthpieces of a *declining* stratum of society; when they work themselves into a righteous state of indignation demanding 'rights', 'justice', 'equal rights', they are just acting under the pressure of their own lack of culture, which has no way of grasping *why* they really suffer,—*what* they lack in life... A powerful causal impulse is at work in them: it has to be someone's fault that they are not doing very well ... And even the righteous indignation does them good, all poor devils like to complain,—it gives them a little rush of power. Complaining and grumbling can even give life a charm that makes it bearable" there is a subtle dose of *revenge* in every complaint; people blame the fact that they are doing badly (and sometimes even their badness) on those who are different, as if that constituted a wrong, an *unauthorized* privilege. 'If I am just *canaille* then you should be too': out of this logic come revolutions.—Complaining never does any good: it comes from weakness. Whether you attribute your bad situation to other people or to *yourself* (socialists take the former strategy and Christians, for instance, take the latter), it does not really make any difference. What is common to both (we could also say what is *unworthy*) is that somebody is supposedly to *blame* for your suffering—basically, that sufferers are prescribing themselves the honey of revenge for their suffering. The objects of this need for revenge (as a need for *pleasure*) are occasional causes: sufferers find opportunities everywhere to quench their petty thirst for vengeance,—and to say it again: if they are Christians, they find these opportunities *in themselves* ... The Christian and the anarchist—both are decadents.—But when Christians condemn, libel, and denigrate the '*world*', they are motivated by the same instinct that moves the socialist worker to condemn, libel, and denigrate *society*: even the 'Last Judgment' is the sweet consolation of revenge—the revolution that the socialist worker is waiting for, only a bit further off ... Even the '*beyond*'—what is a beyond for, if not to denigrate the here and now? ... (*Twilight of the Idols*, 34).¹

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Would it be fair to consider *Hermeneutic Communism* a decadent work, a proposal written by a Christian and an anarchist (or two Christian anarchists) that in the end amounts to little more than a dose of philosophical *ressentiment* against capitalists and traditional communists alike? If there is a problematic (yet perhaps only seeming) contradiction at the core of the argument put forward by Gianni Vattimo and Santiago Zabala in *Hermeneutic Communism*, it centers upon the Christian-socialist principles of emancipation and community that motivate the authors' political and philosophical program, ones that appear to ignore the powerful critique of such principles put forward by one of their primary philosophical touchstones, Friedrich Nietzsche. Moreover, the authors' preference for an integral transformation/distortion/twisting (*Verwindung*) of late-capitalism and democracy rather than its simple overcoming (*Überwindung*) marks a potential distancing from Nietzsche's amply discussed anticipation of an *Übermensch*, an anti-Christ, an anti-nihilist, or anyone else who might restore strength and vitality to the human figure. In fact, it is in this moment, in the consideration of the human of modernity, the *bisheriger Mensch* ("the human so far") and that being's future, when the authors present the culminating and most philosophically problematic moment of the book.

The final section of *Hermeneutic Communism* ("Chávez: A Model for Obama") suggests two possible paths, two possible interpretations of this moment in the history of the West. They are not, however, presented as interpretative alternatives, but as an ambiguous and perhaps even dangerous set of possibilities that amount to something between a vague threat and wishful thinking. To summarize briefly: the model provided by South American democracies and economies that champions the weak and underprivileged offers an alternative to the armed and framed democracies of the North Atlantic; such models illustrate an updated reinterpretation of the inheritance of Marxism; such models arise in regions where colonial dominance has been resisted by "original communities" that challenge the disciplinary framing of metaphysics (Western hegemony, economic paternalism, democratic exceptionalism, etc.). The authors take this recent historical background as an opportunity to reflect on democracy, and in particular these democracies, as examples but not exemplars of the way that the future of hermeneutic communism might unfold. They tell us that "we should stop considering as scandalous the idea that a revolution can occur without a previous authorization by the citizens as expressed in a referendum; after all, no modern constitution was ever born 'democratically'..." (HC, 136). And while the South American governments in question "have not yet betrayed parliamentary democracy," they have a right to violate those rules because, citing Mao, "revolution is not a dinner party" but "an act of violence by which one class overthrows another" (HC, 136–7). Having now entertained (or even endorsed) the violence they spent the previous 130 pages condemning, the authors conclude with what many could (and I suspect will) view as four pages of hermeneutic equivocation. On the one hand, regarding the issue of whether or not hermeneutic communism justifies a violent revolution, the authors seem to suggest that this might be an unavoidable and unfortunate consequence of the violence that already permeates the order of framed democracies; on the other hand, the authors insist that mass movements of passive resistance offer the surest confirmation that a hermeneutic

communism does not take up the arms of its oppressors or fall back into Sartre's "practico-inert" (HC, 140). Everything depends, in the end, on how we interpret the world at this crucial moment—the very sort of emergency that the authors contend the world today lacks.

If my criticism appears overly harsh, it is so because the potentially violent consequences of revolution suggested at the end of *Hermeneutic Communism* test the theoretical claims of the authors in a very real way: logically, emotionally, and ultimately by the measure of human lives. I want to elucidate and consider seriously the authors' central refrain that "...the time has come, after the deconstruction of metaphysics, to rephrase Marx's statement in order to emphasize how 'the philosophers have only *described* the world in various ways; the moment now has arrived to *interpret* it'" (HC, 5). What do the authors have in mind when they invoke interpretation here? What guides their hermeneutic of the world at this moment? While Heidegger and Marx are the philosophical figures who garner the most print from Vattimo and Zabala, I want to suggest that Nietzsche remains the central (albeit problematic) figure behind the form of philosophical hermeneutics that drives the authors' political vision: central because the authors' program relies on a Nietzschean conception of interpretation that critiques the "will to truth"; and problematic because Nietzsche says so much that seems to run counter to the implicit principles operative in the emancipatory and communal vision of the world espoused by the authors. The authors' call to interpret the world, I argue, accomplishes (rather than overcomes) the history of nihilism by questioning the right that anyone has to claim its inheritance as its own.

Nietzsche's Path to Recovery

For the authors of *Hermeneutic Communism*, there are few moments in Nietzsche's *oeuvre* as emblematic and influential as the section of *Twilight of the Idols* entitled "How the 'True World' Finally Became a Fable." Here one finds in shorthand Nietzsche's rejection of truth and falsehood as the announcement of the "end of the longest error" and the "high point of humanity"—noontime as the "moment of the shortest shadow" in which the descriptive power of metaphysics and the violence of truth claims are finally dismissed. This moment is central to the position that Vattimo and Zabala take in the first part of *Hermeneutic Communism*, as it reveals their project to be one that is at odds not only with the metaphysics of description central to the power of "framed democracies," but also with the metaphysical naturalism at the core of traditional Marxism: "In sum, Nietzsche closes all the remaining metaphysical temptations that consider Being as something that is 'out there'" (HC, 90) and that can simply be described or applied as a founding principle for a political or economic program. Moreover, this moment is not merely a practical principle for the authors: the spirit and force of this moment, more than the critique of capital inherited from Marx, and more than the ontological turn inherited from Heidegger, provides the theoretical key to the authors' argument that it is now the time to

interpret rather than *describe* the world. But could one go so far as to claim that in this moment one also finds the grounds (however fluid and manifold) for the ideas of community and emancipation that the authors surely invoke as a rubric (if not a final end) for their project of hermeneutic communism? Do the authors avoid the “metaphysical temptations” that for Nietzsche must be scrubbed from every corner of human thought?

While Nietzsche’s influence is somewhat downplayed in *Hermeneutic Communism*, it would not be inaccurate to claim that the authors’ project is the product of a long and developing trajectory that stretches back to Vattimo’s earliest work. The origin of this particular reading of Nietzsche, one that proposes to read Marx and Heidegger in a Nietzschean key, begins with Vattimo’s first book: *Essere, storia e linguaggio in Heidegger* (1963). Here Vattimo first reveals his insight that a conceptual kinship links Marx, Nietzsche and Heidegger, and that taken together they can be interpreted as the basis for a project of liberation: “What for Marx is alienation, and for Heidegger was the forgetting of being, Nietzsche calls nihilism.”²

A decade later, Vattimo’s Nietzschean manifesto of liberation, *Il soggetto e la maschera* (1974), marks the height of this emancipatory interpretation, the hope of which was a radical transformation of the fabric of society in the strong (perhaps even metaphysical) sense of Nietzsche’s use of the prefix—*über* as a beyond toward which and through which liberation could be accomplished. As fate would have it, a series of political and personal events compel Vattimo to rethink this early interpretation such that it takes a decidedly pacifistic turn with the inception of “weak thought” in the late 1970s. Here, Vattimo’s political project exchanges the demand for liberation for an increasing focus on the reduction of violence. This interpretative shift—both in his reading of Nietzsche and in his assessment of the inheritance of metaphysics—admits a quantum of resignation into this theoretical re-orientation; yet, it retains the hope that nihilism can still be read positively, and in some way, accomplished. This time period marks the birth of “weak thought” and this project’s possibility for a “thinking of the weak” in both senses of the genitive.

If one takes up the position of the weak as Vattimo and Zabala propose, the violent thinking of metaphysics presents itself not as a hurdle to overcome—which would only lead to the championing of a new hurdle by the once weak—but rather a condition from which we must recover: in Heideggerian terms central to Vattimo’s thinking, a position that suggests a *Verwindung* rather than an *Überwindung* of metaphysics. The authors state rather clearly at the outset of *Hermeneutic Communism*: “only once we recognize how metaphysics cannot be overcome” (HC, 1) but must be *verwunden* can we dispense with “both the *ideal of development* and also the general call for revolution” (HC, 3). Such a position is not, as one might suspect, contrary to the spirit of interpretation in Nietzsche’s work; in fact, Nietzsche offers two compelling models for this interpretative reorientation. The first is the “historical malady” of the second *Untimely Meditation*, from which any metaphysical “recovery” is more likely a resignation to the fact that one cannot defeat such a malady (which would only repeat the violent thinking of metaphysics), but must

² Gianni Vattimo. *Essere storia e linguaggio in Heidegger* (Martinetti, 1963), 49 [my translation].

live with it and control it, lest it become a descriptive ideal that paints shared history and individual memory as *the* illnesses from which one must entirely break free. The *amor fati* is therefore not a metaphysical ultimatum issued as a last-ditch cure for what ails us in the final throes of nihilism. Yet, just such a prescription is all too often the solution that one finds in particular strains of Nietzsche scholarship. Nowhere is this more persistent than in certain readings of Nietzsche's *On the Genealogy of Morality* which idealize the vital force of the warrior and the freedom of the one who can will himself to forget. Thus we find in the *Genealogy* a second example of the interpretative reorientation toward weakness, one that I will here develop as an essential key to the understanding of interpretation offered by the authors of *Hermeneutic Communism*.

The importance of the *Genealogy* to weak thinking is established rather early in Vattimo's itinerary, and in fact reveals the transformation in his thinking away from the model of revolution and liberation to one of recovery and emancipation. In *Il soggetto e la maschera*, Vattimo argues that genealogy is not the critique and refutation of morality, but instead the history of its origin that is itself the product of an interpretation. Such a move is not only methodological, but illustrates the fact that only a genealogical thinking of the origin can highlight and bring under question the very condition of escaping or rejecting something. By the end of the 1970s Vattimo refines this understanding of Nietzsche's genealogical method so that it is understood less as a method for overcoming and more appropriately as a means to reconcile oneself to a situation that denies history as a fact for our immediate consumption or rejection: history is not a course of events simply to be described, but the product of an ever unfolding interpretation by humans in the present. Even though a full analysis of the *Genealogy* remains beyond the scope of this essay, a brief sketch of its key elements might suffice to highlight the challenges facing the authors' call to "interpret the world."

Recovering from *Ressentiment*

The polemic set forth in the *Genealogy* is one aimed at those "knowers" who, in a manner of speaking, claim to know better: scientists, technocrats, and above all else, philosophers. While Nietzsche spares no venom for Jews, Christians, mystics, British psychologists and moralists of every stripe, the purpose of the *Genealogy* is undeniably one that takes as its highest priority the crisis (or as Vattimo and Zabala might put it, the "emergency") of truth in the human world—one explained elsewhere (most notably in *Beyond Good and Evil*) as the domination of a Will to Truth. The crisis arises not merely because Judeo-Christian values have run their course (as the work is all too often understood) and require a transvaluation; rather, it arises because the seeming replacement and overcoming of those values in the name of scientific and analytic truth ultimately requires a critique of the value of value itself—in other terms, as we find out by the end of the work, it requires a critique of the human will as such. The history of metaphysics, and thus the history of its

dissolution as nihilism, illustrates that the human will is so strong that it wills (creates meaning) even when it means willing “nothing”—the ultimate (yet ineffective) *coup de grâce* of metaphysics. The act of willing value, of giving values to the world and then ultimately giving oneself over to those values, is the sickness which Nietzsche hopes we can manage and treat in the absence of a full recovery. The importance of the *Genealogy*, therefore, is that Nietzsche presents an alternative to radical transformation that rejects the destructive process of overcoming and revolution—one that should never be confused with the instinct of *ressentiment* that characterizes the values (moral, philosophical, scientific, etc.) of modernity and perpetuates the model of overcoming through a persistent belief in a beyond. In terms of the argument set forth in *Hermeneutic Communism*, this new model for change that is something other than an arbitrary (and thus violent) imposition of the will, on the one hand, and yet more than a passive description of the “natural” state of affairs on the other. The authors’ claim that the time is at hand to *interpret* the world relies on the possibility of an alternative, and the *Genealogy* offers a particular solution to this seeming dilemma, one that can be traced through Nietzsche’s treatment of the instinct of *ressentiment*.

The *First Treatise* of the *Genealogy* presents the reader with two competing instincts—the *pathos of distance* and *ressentiment*—each of which represents a particular way that the human will can be directed toward its world. The former is described as “active” and “life affirming” while the latter is “passive” and “life destroying.” These two instincts do not, however, represent an either/or option for the future of humanity. I will leave any further analysis of the *First Treatise*’s infamous passages aside; for my purposes, the *Second Treatise* is the key to unraveling how Nietzsche and thus the authors of *Hermeneutic Communism* take interpretation as essential to a recovery from the downward spiral of passive nihilism. This key is the figure of the “sovereign individual” detailed in the second and third sections of the treatise, a figure whose function in the text is no stranger to controversy.³ At first glance it might seem that this individual is the height (and thus the depths) of the instinct of *ressentiment*, the bred animal who has lost the ability to forget and is “permitted to promise”, is “calculable, regular, necessary,” and whose “privilege of responsibility” and “rare freedom” give rise to “conscience.” Presented as an individual possessed of life-denying rather than life-affirming properties, this figure could easily be misunderstood as a continuation of the critique of the slave morality and its origin in *ressentiment* that Nietzsche begins in the *First Treatise*. But later on in the treatise (GM, II: 16–18) we learn that the origin of guilt and bad conscience in fact do not have their origin in *ressentiment*, but in *the instinct for freedom* (will to power) turned inward: “I take bad conscience to be the deep sickness into which

³The debate over the role of the “sovereign individual” is captured nicely by the following essays: Christa Davis Acampora, “On Sovereignty and Overhumanity: Why It Matters How We Read Nietzsche’s *Genealogy* II:2” and Paul S. Loeb, “Finding the *Übermensch* in Nietzsche’s *Genealogy of Morality*”, both found in *Nietzsche’s On the Genealogy of Morals: Critical Essays*. Edited by Christa Davis Acampora (New York: Rowman and Littlefield Publishers Inc., 2006), 147–175.

man had to fall under the pressure of that most fundamental of all changes he ever experienced—the change of finding himself enclosed once and for all within the sway of society and peace” (GM, II:16). The sovereign individual, the refined product of this “sickness,” is presented as an *alternative* to the slavish morality of *ressentiment*, and not as its highest accomplishment. Yet, the sovereign individual is very clearly not a return to the active stance of the *pathos of distance*, or even the common (albeit distorted) image of the *Übermensch* as pure will to power. Just what this individual represents can be traced negatively through the *Third Treatise* of the *Genealogy*.

The *Third Treatise: What Do Ascetic Ideals Mean?* is properly understood as the culmination of the critique begun in the *Preface* and *First Treatise*, where one comes to find that even the scientist, the philosopher, and the nihilist are (still) embodiments of the ascetic ideal. They merely repeat and take to a logical conclusion, rather than overcome, the *ressentiment* at the root of the Judeo-Christian morality and the history of metaphysics, up to and including modern science. The will to truth—of religion and mysticism, but more importantly of science and philosophy—is the product of *ressentiment*, a reliance on a beyond, on a metaphysical or total truth that can ultimately be achieved, described, and put to use. If one considers the famous announcement that “God is dead” from *The Gay Science*, it is clear that its real force appears in the subsequent lines that demand we must continue the fight against God’s shadow, or in other words, against the forms of metaphysics that still persist in non-religious forms of human value. The death of God does not destroy the ascetic ideal: “from the moment belief in the god of the ascetic ideal is negated, *there is also a new problem*: that of the *value* of truth.—The will to truth is in need of a critique—let us thus define our own task—the value of truth is for once to be experimentally *called into question*...” (GM, III:24). Yet, it is futile to strike against shadows, for doing so would only be to mistake them for essences. The diligence and awareness Nietzsche demands of whomever might recover from nihilism is not captured by an ultimate and transformative death-blow to truth, but rather is found in the one who slowly digests and metabolizes the history of metaphysics into a new self so that the boundary between here and beyond, body and soul, self and other dissolve. This metabolic appropriation is just the sort of dietary regiment Nietzsche prescribes to control the decadent excesses of nihilism, one that replaces the desire to describe the world (and thus master it) with the need to interpret it.

A Genealogy of Capitalism

The shift from description to interpretation parallels the tension between a “beyond” and the “here and now” set at odds in the aphorism on the “Christian and Anarchist.” To consider these two figures in light of the “death of God” and in fact the entire polemic set forth in the *Genealogy* exposes how the structure of *ressentiment* entails a certain trust in causal relations, ones that continually defer to a beyond, place the blame on some other (society for anarchists, one’s own soul for Christians) and that

other's lack of authority. Out of this logic of revenge "come revolutions", and it is this mechanism that Nietzsche, and thus the authors of *Hermeneutic Communism*, seek to undermine and reform through a *Verwindung* of metaphysics. And although the entire history of metaphysics and its weakening form the theoretical backdrop for their critique, it is not altogether clear from their work if the essentialized structures of framed democracies and global capitalism will undergo the same sort of weakening such that they are neither overcome nor destroyed but rather metabolized and incorporated into a new awareness of our global responsibilities. This ambiguity is the focus of Ashley Woodward's powerful critique of Vattimo's more recent reflections on politics and global economy.⁴ Most notable is Woodward's suggestion that Vattimo should pursue a *Verwindung* of capital rather than merely claim that capitalism is a fundamentalism that relies on a metaphysical description of the world. As with the whole of metaphysics, the destabilizing possibilities of capital need to be followed through and weakened. Yet, even though Vattimo and Zabala suggest that we take South American governments as models for a new form of global capitalism and democracy, do they really represent a "coming to consciousness" as Nietzsche suggests in the *Genealogy*? Have leaders like Chavez accomplished or *verwunden* the nihilism of capital? Once again, Nietzsche's critique of the ascetic ideal sheds light on what such a recovery would entail.

At first glance, it would seem odd to consider a global capitalist or a Western head of state (in the most pejorative sense given them by Vattimo and Zabala) as embodiments of the ascetic ideal. But Nietzsche's point is not merely to show us the bankruptcy of a religious or a philosophical ideal at the end of the history of metaphysics; rather, the point is to highlight the insidious nature of such an ideal—how its "dishonest lie" (GM, III:19) perpetuates the prevalent mode of being in the modern world, one marked by domination, violence, and the will to truth. The ascetic ideal is not exclusively a guide for the those who remove themselves from life—the figure of the monk or the solitary thinker—but is more properly the principle guiding those one who engage life through a desire to rule over all things, to know them totally, and to correspond to an ultimate meaning (no matter if that meaning is religious, scientific, or even economic): "For an ascetic life is a self-contradiction: here a *ressentiment* without equal rules, that of an unsatiated instinct and power-will that would like to become lord not over something living but rather over life itself, over its deepest, strongest, most fundamental preconditions; an attempt is made here to use energy to stop up the source of the energy..." (GM, III:11). This depiction in the *Genealogy* is not entirely out of step with the image Nietzsche gives of the Western capitalism in *The Gay Science*: "One thinks with a watch in hand, as one eats lunch with an eye on the financial pages—one lives like someone who might always 'miss out on something.' 'Rather do anything than nothing'—even this principle is a cord to strangle all culture and higher taste" (GS IV: 329). In fact, if one were to ask what the rapacious capitalist and the ascetic have in common, it would not merely be the

⁴Woodward, Ashley. "The 'Verwindung' of Capital: On the Philosophy and Politics of Gianni Vattimo." *Symposium: Canadian Journal of Continental Philosophy* 13, no. 1 (03/01, 2009): 73–99.

motivating instinct of *ressentiment*, but more importantly, the unrelenting desire to will, even if it means willing (nothing/anything) just for the sake of willing. Moreover, Nietzsche's critique of the savagery of American industriousness is that it leaves no time for leisure, contemplation, or the life of culture and creativity—it is a life that is always led in deference to other factors, in response to external forces. It is life against the creative force of life itself, and as with the culturally bereft Christian and the Anarchist—the ascetic extremes of the will to nothing—all that remains of the will to truth for the capitalist is the desire to dominate willing as such through economic “science.” How else should we consider Benjamin Franklin's pithy aphorisms presented by Weber at the outset of his brilliant critique of the Protestant work ethic (which read like a breviary for the modern capitalist), or Schumpeter's notion of “creative destruction” (repeated like a mantra for fiscal growth), or the disproportionate influence of Alan Greenspan and the other high priests of the market on the economic fate of the planet, or the “truths” of economic forecasts, marketing, and the driven self-interest of *homo economicus*. What capitalism presents as a reflection of natural reality—the market's self-correction, consumer demand, etc.—is in fact the brutal imposition of will over a vast nothingness, a Ponzi scheme on a global scale. The capitalist, like the repentant Christian and the idealistic Anarchist, refuses to give up on the “dishonest lie”—and this is perhaps the most powerful aspect of global capitalism, the one that permeates from its high priests all the way down to the lower ranks where there is little difference between consumer and consumed. The power of capitalism's unrepentant fiction is that it has decontextualized the positive (and even moral) value of hard work, investment, consumerism and retail exchange and in so doing has essentialized them into secular absolutes. Can there be any rehabilitation or recovery from the depths of this economic *ressentiment*?

Let us once again consider the “sovereign individual” of the *Second Treatise*, who represents an alternative to the extremity of the ascetic ideal and, in the context of this argument, as a possible candidate for the rehabilitated capitalist. The ascetic is the one who turns *ressentiment* inward on the will itself. The ascetic's self-indictment—“*You alone are to blame for yourself!*” (GM, III:15)—echoes its contemporary forms in the moralizing capitalist's “bootstrap argument” and even in the liberal's abstract conception of individual freedom as something that is “immunized” from the freedom of others. In these cases responsibility to others is something an individual encounters in only a secondary manner, as a product or even residue of abstract freedom. If the ascetic in all its forms represents the extreme limit of *ressentiment* such that the individual will becomes its ultimate other and thus its ultimate object of domination, the sovereign individual represents a more measured path toward notions of freedom and community—ones that arise through the feelings of guilt and bad conscience that are not, as I noted above, derived from the instinct of *ressentiment*. By Nietzsche's account, such feelings arise on account of a powerful paradox in human nature that place the will at odds with the regularity and fixity of natural laws: “...with the appearance on earth of an animal soul turned against itself, taking sides against itself, something so new, deep, unheard of, enigmatic, contradictory, *and full of future* had come into being that the appearance

of the earth was essentially changed” (GM II:16). Kant identifies a similar paradox when he postulates the ideal moral law in his *Groundwork for the Metaphysics of Morals*, taking the irregularity of human will—compared to the fixity of natural laws—as a limitation to be overcome. But if the individual of “good will” in Kant’s system represents an extreme philosophical asceticism (is there any other way to understand Kant the individual?) whereby choices are submitted to an abstract and absolute ideal that cuts off possibilities for the future, the responsibilities and promises of the “sovereign individual” arise out of the real conditions of history and a set of memories that reflect the radical contingency of human affairs yet to be scrubbed clean by the ascetic’s desire for total domination.

As noted above, by Nietzsche’s account such feelings of guilt or “bad conscience”—the basis of the sovereign individual’s responsibility and permission to promise—first arise in humans as a “deep sickness” when humanity finds itself “enclosed once and for all within the sway of society and peace” (GM, II:16). Society is the condition for the sovereign individual, and as sections 4–15 of the *Second Treatise* illustrate, the human will, now turned inward because of its mutual obligations to others, can be traced in history through a variety of forms: from the shared cathartic vengeance of public punishments to the self-cancellation of justice in the act of mercy. This latter form, in particular, “remains the privilege of the most powerful” (GM, II:10)—only the wealthiest can allow the guilty to go unpunished. And although the sovereign as depicted by Agamben and others stands completely outside the law (beyond the reach of good citizens and criminals alike), what would it mean for Western societies—those that enjoy wealth, peace and the sway of society—to operate as a community of “sovereign individuals” of the sort depicted in the *Second Treatise*, such that the purpose of justice were not to punish, but to emancipate individuals and expand communities? Such mercy cannot, however, be granted by the isolated individuals and successful states of late capitalism who defend the “natural order” of the free market: “Those that preach that there ‘is’ an order of the world to which we must all conform are really its consumers, that is, its satisfied and therefore most rabid defenders” (HC, 94). It would instead have to flow from those who represent a mitigation of and recovery from these extreme effects of *ressentiment*, not their total overcoming into a new (and equally metaphysical) order.

The sovereign individual is “full of future” precisely because the “deep sickness” of bad conscience is not fueled by a *ressentiment* that cuts off conversation through an appeal to ultimate truth, but rather is sanctioned by a shared responsibility to engender the play between possible interpretations. Despite the brutal imagery of the “mnemonics of pain” and the “right of lords” that characterize the internalized history of this sovereign in the *Second Treatise*, this figure remains—somewhat ironically—the progenitor of the “good” capitalist: a historical embodiment of the economic justice of credits and debts rather than its perverted and abstract epigone. A similar patrimony can be traced in the Christian and the anarchist, whose *ressentiment* have transformed the positive ideals of liberation and community into the most abstract and totalizing terrors. In all three figures, the sovereign individual represents a possibility for economic justice, individual liberation, and shared community that

is not imposed from the outside, but that arises from within the history of nihilism, or in Nietzsche's terms, accomplishes nihilism. If there is an argument for the *Verwindung* of capitalism (and thus a resignation to the inevitability of capitalism in some form) that coincides with the recovery and distortion of Christianity and communism, it relies on the interpretations set forth in Nietzsche's analysis of the creditor-debtor relationship that, as he poignantly notes, are the basis for justice and moral value and not, as moral history would have it, the other way around. Perhaps, to re-become what one truly is (to steal a phrase from Vattimo's *Ecce Commu*) means once again making our economic and political selves "full of future" rather than subservient to the false truths of the ascetic high priests of finance and framed democracies—to ask, in the world of capital, what will be the basis for our promises and responsibilities to others and even ourselves?

The Risk and Responsibility of Interpretation

My intention in this essay, however, was not to read *Hermeneutic Communism* in an existential key, which might simply require one to consider how to enact the project of rethinking one's existence as a consumer and a citizen within the frame of late capitalism and the challenges of a truly global and inclusive form of democracy; rather, it was to explore the philosophical problem at the core of this issue, one that centers upon the authors' sustained critique of metaphysics and the symptoms of its influence that take the form of framed democracies. Do Vattimo and Zabala really *interpret* (rather than blindly accept or condemn) the patrimony of positive *and* negative guiding principles inherited from the history of Christianity, socialism, and capitalism—ones that cannot be completely overcome, and that for good reasons, should not be entirely tossed out? What in the end keeps the authors' interpretation of the world from being just another violent (and expedient) imposition upon it, just another symptom of *ressentiment*?

With Nietzsche as their guide, the authors understand that the absolute ideals of the past are not and cannot simply be overcome, but as with "All great things perish through themselves, through an act of self-cancellation..." (GM III:27). And yet, this history of nihilism—the historical and logical consequence of the will to truth left unchecked—entails more than just a passive resignation to a destiny we have inherited; accomplishing nihilism means taking up that history as a problem, even as an emergency that demands interpretation. The "sovereign individual," the "good European," the "free spirit," the moderate soul at noontime and the conscious dreamer who nonetheless continues to dream all represent in Nietzsche's work the figures of an accomplished nihilism, those who take up this problem and subject it to the effects of its own history, namely, those who interpret it in terms of its continually unfolding history so that its future is never cut off. For Nietzsche, the blind submission to an idea (Christian, anarchist, capitalist) and its blunt application "... is *over* now; that has conscience *against* it; every refined conscience considers it to be indecent, dishonest, a form of mendacity, effeminacy, weakness, cowardice. With

this severity, if with anything, we are simply *good* Europeans and heirs to Europe's longest and most courageous self-overcoming" (GS 357; GM III:27). What this inheritance demands is that we no longer "denigrate the here and now" in favor of some beyond, some metaphysical ideal; interpretation demands that we ask what it means in this moment to take up such an ideal and to consider seriously if one is sanctioned to deploy it.

In an age when there are no longer facts but only interpretations, what is at stake is not how effectively a guiding principle is applied (which still retains the criteria of right/wrong, true/false, etc.), but *by what right* such a principle can be taken up and utilized in the first place. The authors of *Hermeneutic Communism* argue, "Hermeneutics is a way of looking at Being as an inheritance that is never considered as ultimate data." In contrast, "Capitalism has always grown by considering, or forcing another to consider, as a 'natural' possession what is inherited" (HC, 93). The ideas and principles that guide the authors' "thought of the weak" belong to this very same inheritance, even though they are often trumped by principles considered to more natural, fundamental, or even beyond question. These principles—good and bad, popular or marginalized—shape the historical and cultural conditions of our shared existence. They are our contingent conditions of possibility, our historical *a priori*. The origin and ground of these principles is not simply a datum we can collect, and thus our possession (and subsequent use) of them cannot stand on a *de facto* rule of inheritance; such claims to possession are arguments *de jure* made when an absolute ground, an absolute origin, cannot be obtained.⁵

Vattimo and Zabala offer us an interpretation where so many others have merely presented polemics or solutions. Introduced on the first page as an antidote to political approaches framed within the tradition of metaphysics, the authors conclude by announcing that "the moment has now arrived to *interpret* the world." Rather than a revolution, or a return to origins, or a clean slate, everything is on the table and open for discussion, and more importantly, the call is for everyone to be at the table. The risk is real, and the future of such a program is not necessarily safe. This is challenge that arises with the "death of god" and the "fabling of the world:" one that can no longer appeal to a higher principle; one that assumes full responsibility for success and failure; one that transforms but does not obliterate the meaning of inheritance, possession, property, and ultimately, community. This demand to justify one's principles, and to maintain the environment where such dialogue is possible, is the great responsibility, and risk, of the interpreter, of the "sovereign individual" who is "permitted to promise." The principle or ground upon which an interpretation is made, its guiding criterion, is fluid and itself always in need of justification by a community that can sanction or challenge it. This community and its members are neither determined nor mastered, but always remain open so that the conflict of interpretations takes the form of a conversation rather than a *gigantomachia* over

⁵I have elsewhere called this process of justification a "hermeneutic deduction," based on the legal arguments Kant uses in the transcendental deduction of the *Critique of Pure Reason*. See my "La deduzione ermeneutica" in *Tropos. Rivista di ermeneutica e critica filosofica*, n. 1 (2009): 127–139.

the meaning of being. They are compelled to ask what it means to engage the problem of the forgetting of being, of nihilism, and of alienation as a fundamental condition, and even an *emergency*, that faces humanity today.

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Response to Valgenti

Gianni Vattimo and Santiago Zabala

Robert Valgenti introduced the great Italian philosopher Luigi Pareyson to the English speaking world. Pareyson, together with Hans-Georg Gadamer and Paul Ricoeur, is among the most original hermeneutic thinkers of the twentieth century. But Valgenti has not simply translated one of his most important works, *Truth and Interpretation* (1971), but also a number of books by Gianni, such as *Farewell to Truth* (2011) and *Of Reality* (2016), as well as many of his essays. Valgenti's expertise is not limited to Italian philosophy. His knowledge of German hermeneutics is also profound, as is evident in the "genealogy of interpretation" he delineates through Nietzsche's writings in his contribution. This genealogy serves our American friend not only to point out the centrality Nietzsche plays together with Marx and Heidegger in our project, but also to disclose a "contradiction" at the core of *Hermeneutic Communism*. What does this contradiction consist in and why is it important?

According to Valgenti we have been motivated by certain "Christian-socialist principles of emancipation and community" which have been powerfully criticized by Nietzsche. Ignoring the German thinker on this matter has led us to exaggerate our "preference for an integral transformation/distortion/twisting (*Verwindung*) of late-capitalism and democracy rather than its simple overcoming (*Überwindung*)."

The problem with this preference is that it further distances us from Nietzsche as it implies the figure of someone "who might restore strength and vitality to the human figure." This figure, according to Valgenti, is opposed to the original role of the "*Übermensch*". Together with other issues as the "justification of violence in case of a revolution" or "mass movements passive resistance," Valgenti believes our theoretical operation rests on a "hermeneutic equivocation" as "everything "depends, in

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the end, on how we interpret the world at this crucial moment—the very sort of emergency that the authors contend the world today lacks.”

Valgenti refers to his criticism as “overly harsh.” But we disagree. Hermeneutics, similarly to a revolution, is not a “dinner party,” and conflict should be welcome. His contribution is an example of the anarchic vein of hermeneutics we outlined in the third part and that we call on philosophers to practice. Before we respond to his “harsh” criticisms, we would like to stress that Valgenti is correct when he claims *Hermeneutic Communism* “is the product of a long and developing trajectory that stretches back to Vattimo’s earliest works.” In *Essere, storia e linguaggio in Heidegger* (1963) and *Il soggetto e la maschera* (1974), where Gianni examined the problem of “liberation,” one can find a conceptual kinship that links Marx, Nietzsche, and Heidegger together. Statements such as “What for Marx is alienation, and for Heidegger was the forgetting of being, Nietzsche calls nihilism,”¹ which Valgenti quotes from Gianni’s book on Heidegger, could also have been found in our text.

In order to respond to the charge that our project rests on a “hermeneutic equivocation” we would like to start by pointing out that “weak thought” was not simply a “pacifistic turn”, as Valgenti claims. The “series of political and personal events” at the origins of “weak thought” are not only a response to the violence of the Red Brigades, but also to overcome the dichotomy violence/pacifism in favor of the defense, rights, and liberation of the weak. Something Valgenti, as well as other contributors in this book overlook, is that weak thought is also a consequence of and a departure from Heidegger’s destruction and Derrida’s deconstruction of metaphysics. Reiner Schürmann was among the first to notice this, as indicated by the title of his 1984 essay “Deconstruction is not enough: On Gianni Vattimo’s call to ‘weak thinking’”.² In sum, the call to “reduce violence” comes after accepting the end of metaphysics, that is, the possibility of another metaphysics. This acceptance does not imply resignation, passivity and “pacifism,” but rather productive interpretations against the impositions and conservations propagated by the bearers of power.

Although Valgenti recognizes all this when he states that we have offered “an interpretation where so many others have merely presented polemics or solutions,” the problem is that for us everything depends “on how we interpret the world at this crucial moment.” But this “moment” is vital for us. Instead of a falling into nihilism or relativism, it denotes the “ontology of actuality” which is at the heart of weak thought. This ontology rests in the interpretation of the “events that have led us to constitute ourselves and to recognize ourselves as subjects of what we are doing, thinking, saying.” If this ontology, which has its origins in Foucault’s last courses at the Collège de France, was also meant to overcome metaphysical dichotomies, it is because these same dichotomies often ignore the histories that created them in the

¹ Gianni Vattimo. *Essere storia e linguaggio in Heidegger* (Martinetti, 1963), 49 [my translation].

² Reiner Schürmann, “Deconstruction Is Not Enough: On Gianni Vattimo’s Call for ‘Weak Thinking,’” *Graduate Faculty Philosophy Journal* 10:1 (1984), pp. 165–77. Also in *Weakening Philosophy: Festschrift in Honour of Gianni Vattimo*, ed. S. Zabala (Montreal: McGill-Queen’s University Press, 2007): 117–130.

first place. This is why the French master opposed to this ontology an “analytics of truth” where critical philosophy becomes a violent metaphysical analysis of truth, origins or realism. If we do not call for “a revolution, or a return to origins, or a clean slate,” as Valgenti points out, it is because “everything is on the table and open for discussion, and more importantly, the call is for everyone to be at the table.”

This table, which indirectly echoes the United Nations, is not meant for dialogues. As we repeated several times we prefer conversations where the outcome is not established in advance. This is why the response to Valgenti’s central question, “What guides their hermeneutic of the world at this moment?”, is the absence of conversations, that is, emergencies. If our hermeneutics apparently clashes with weak thought’s reduction of violence, it is only because the emergencies of the weak are now overlooked and must be addressed at any cost.

Hermeneutic Capitalism? Prologue- the Death and the Challenge

Mike Grimshaw

Abstract If as Vattimo notes, we are in the end-days of metaphysical capitalism, then just as metaphysical communism was able to collapse, so too can metaphysical capitalism. A new ‘Nietzschean’ announcement is therefore needed: capitalism -like communism - is dead. For in many ways, perversely, the left has continued its belief in capitalism long after it has lost its belief in communism. However if we are to re-engage with Marx, then capitalism is not the end but the state of transition. Secondly, in arguing versus Marx for Marx, the first stage is to interpret and then to change, for the old metaphysical arguments against capitalism- whether religious or communist - did not change it. Now however, after metaphysical capitalism, the task is to firstly interpret post-metaphysical capitalism and then to change it and to do so in tandem with another reworking of Marx whereby the criticism of capitalism is the premise of all criticism. The challenge is that this post-metaphysical capitalism, which I term hermeneutic capitalism is really the transition to hermeneutic communism because it will involve the only class capable of societal transformation in the west and north: the bourgeoisie.

If as Vattimo (2011, 2010) notes, we are in the end-days of metaphysical capitalism, then just as metaphysical communism was able to collapse, so too can metaphysical capitalism. In response, a new ‘Nietzschean’ *announcement* is therefore needed: *capitalism - like communism - is dead*. For in many ways, perversely, the left has continued its belief in capitalism long after it has lost its belief in communism. However if we are to re-engage with Marx, then capitalism is not the end but the state of transition. Secondly, in arguing versus Marx for Marx, the first stage is to interpret and then to change, for the old metaphysical arguments against capitalism- whether religious or communist - did not change it. Now however, after metaphysical capitalism, *the task is to firstly interpret post-metaphysical capitalism and then to change it* and to do so in tandem with another reworking of Marx whereby *the criticism of capitalism is the premise of all criticism*. The challenge is that this post-metaphysical capitalism, which I term *hermeneutic capitalism* is really the

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transition to hermeneutic communism because it will involve the only class capable of societal transformation in the west and north: the bourgeoisie.

Towards Hermeneutic Capitalism...

Vattimo and Zabala's *Hermeneutic Communism* (2011) [hereafter: HC] argues for the thought of the weak in search of alternatives to neo-liberalism, a politics arising out of interpretation, history and event[HC: 2]. This is a politics that wishes to change the world, not keep it as it is. Hermeneutics is therefore positioned as the alternative to what is taken to be. Weak hermeneutics, in speaking against the opponents of the weak who are not the strong but the powerful [HC:7], is also, I would argue, a responsibility of the intellectual in their central role of speaking truth to power.

If we remember therefore that the experience of the age of weak thought is where we respond *only* to appeals and announcements, we need to reconsider what such appeals and announcements may be. For weak thought to become weak politics it must be able to speak to and out of those who are in the position to effect change. This is a tension for hermeneutic communism- and in fact for what can be termed the communist re-turn of continental thought. A weak communism, to be effective in the west and north (let alone the west-north outposts in the south) needs to remember that communism as political critique was effective when it ventured outside the limits of the academy and became a means of educated left middle-class hermeneutics. It may not have resulted in communism as political state of governance in the north and west, but it did provide an example of weak communism in action that was- and is- I admit still part of western capitalism; but- and this is important- not part of neo-liberal capitalism. In combination with radical Christianity such thought also proved a valuable basis for the creation and continuation of the welfare state. If as Vattimo notes in his discussion of 'weak communism' [WC],¹ we are in the end-days of metaphysical capitalism [WC: 206] then just as metaphysical communism was able to collapse, so too can metaphysical capitalism. The tension of attempting to implement the alternative is that identified by Vattimo whereby the left, upon taking power "fatally loses its transformative energy" [WC: 206]. The first step is therefore to ensure the left when in power does not lose its transformative energy but does lose its metaphysics - and especially its sense of the inevitability of metaphysical capitalism. A new 'Nietzschean' *announcement* is therefore needed: capitalism - like communism - is dead. For in many ways, perversely, the left has continued its belief in capitalism long after it has lost its belief in communism. However if we are to re-engage with Marx, then capitalism is not the end but the state of transition. Secondly, in arguing versus Marx for Marx, the first stage is to interpret and then to change, for the old metaphysical arguments against capitalism- whether religious or

¹Vattimo, Gianni. "Weak Communism?" in *The Idea of Communism*. ed. Costas Douzinas and Slavoj Žižek. London & New York: Verso 2010.

communist - did not change it. Now however, after metaphysical capitalism, the task is to firstly interpret post-metaphysical capitalism and then to change it and to do so in tandem with another reworking of Marx whereby the criticism of capitalism is the premise of all criticism. Therefore a challenge is that this post-metaphysical capitalism, which I term hermeneutic capitalism is really the transition to hermeneutic communism because it will involve the only class capable of societal transformation in the west and north- that is the bourgeoisie. For a self-reflective, hermeneutic bourgeoisie is the only genuinely transformative, revolutionary class in the west and north. Yet this is perhaps the most truly alienated class as well - for they exist after politics and after institutional religion. This is the class that exists most truly in capitalist nihilism [the poor in spirit] - and so is the class most open to seeking a new hermeneutic. It is the class of those whose members are, in the universities, already engaged with reading, teaching and studying writers of the left including Vattimo, Zizek, Badiou, Negri and the like. For we need to self-assess and remember that for every celebrated survivor of the now almost mythical working class intellectual, the vast majority of those most open to the re-turn of communism are the self-critical bourgeois intellectuals, who find themselves a minority amongst the vast factory of capitalist industry academics.

So, what if we read the challenges of *Hermeneutic Communism* as if they are referring to capitalism? For the centrality of weakening, of hermeneutics as developed by Vattimo and Zabala enables a productive weakening of capitalism to occur.

We begin therefore noting that, while the offer has been made by Vattimo and Zabala to change the world from a Marxist perspective by firstly overcoming metaphysics, perhaps they are paradoxically too far along and yet not yet of the moment itself. For Marxism in and of itself, whether metaphysical or anti-foundationalist is increasingly a position expressed both from and into a type of academic void whereas, outside this academic abyss, capitalism continues its dominance as if it is a revealed, final truth for most. We academics, or rather, we intellectuals who take seriously the weak position of speaking truth to power, may talk of, write of, and express the hope of an outside to capitalism, especially in its neo-liberal final excesses. Yet such a thought, such a hope is easily dismissed because to weaken communism before we weaken capitalism is to work from a position that takes as self-evident what is not apparent to most. We must not fall into a gnosticism of weak thought, rather we must constantly strive to make it truly democratic. For we need to constantly remind ourselves, in a hermeneutic self-reflexivity, that while we, who work from weakness, can see the weakness inherent in capitalism, the reality is that this is a presupposition that few others can actually dream of, let alone experience. Our starting point is therefore that false consciousness in our age is the belief, both implicitly and explicitly, in metaphysical capitalism and the structures of life that result.

We begin therefore by expressing the need to weaken capitalism in favour of the weak, a weakening accomplished by hermeneutics that notes if we do not attempt to weaken capitalism and weaken it by argument, by hermeneutics, then we enable the continuation of the false consciousness of a metaphysical capitalism. We must also do this by acknowledging that we who may speak on the side of the weak must

never attempt to speak on behalf of the weak. For we are not weak in global terms. So an inherent tension arises. I who am strong, deliberately position myself on the side of the weak, but not in the position of vanguard who will seek to lead and control a revolution. Rather, in position of weakness, as critic, as one who undertakes hermeneutics of the alternative, a hermeneutics that positions itself also against the strong positions of violence and authoritarianism, against such strong positions of the left as much as of the right. I also do so from within capitalism. Hermeneutic communist in my head, I am capitalist in my daily life for I live, work and am employed within a capitalist system, structure and institution. From such a position, if communism is not to be more than just an indulgence from within capitalist privilege and a politically romanticized grand adventure, I must realise the weakening of capitalism and the established neo-liberal order is not to be accomplished by calls to acts of violence, often accompanied by metaphysical ideals of violence, the revolution and the vanguard. For in proclaiming a need for violence, revolution and vanguard, the left ascribes a power and truth to capitalism and further, in speaking of revolution, the proletariat and the vanguard, the left is merely guilty of the rhetoric of metaphysical false consciousness in a post-industrial world.

How to proceed? In the wake of Vattimo and Zabala, who themselves are in the wake of Heidegger, we begin with the reworking of Marx's *Theses on Feuerbach* whereby we state: *the task is to firstly interpret post-metaphysical capitalism and then to change it*. For in Vattimo and Zabala's reading of Heidegger, there occurs the realization that hermeneutics is expressed in change. (HC:4) Vattimo and Zabala themselves rephrase Marx to state "the philosophers have only *described* the world in various ways; the moment has now arrived to *interpret* it." (HC: 5). Their interpretation is via South American communism; my interpretation arises from within western Anglo-centric capitalism as a hermeneutic communism of the mind that is attempted to be expressed in and against everyday life. This is not to downplay what was, is and might be achieved in South American attempts. But I am not and can not be South American, nor is my context that of a society similar in structure, history or culture to South America. The weakened reality I find myself in is that communism, hard or weak, is only ever going to be a marginal choice and expression- revolutionary or hermeneutic. But in the choice I make I align myself as hermeneutic communist within capitalism, with the constant task of hermeneutics towards change, a democratic change. Central to such a position and such a re-reading in and yet against capitalism is the statement of Vattimo and Zabala that "we will treat hermeneutics as the whole existence of the human being...hermeneutics is not a conservative political position... but a progressive one, opposed to the objective state of affairs." (HC:6) Or, as I annotated my copy of *Hermeneutic Communism*: hermeneutics as alternative to what (is taken to be) 'is'.

I am also an intellectual, for that is my role, my job and I trust my vocation and where I find myself within a capitalist society. Yet with this position, with this self-designation, comes a responsibility that sits at the heart of hermeneutic communism. For if hermeneutics is on the side of the weak, on the side of "the discharge of capitalism, that is, of metaphysical realism" (HC:7) then I must also note that "the opponents of the weak are not the strong but the powerful." (HC:7). Furthermore, if

I remember that one of the tasks of the intellectual is to speak truth to power and if hermeneutics is on the side of the weak then the role of the hermeneutic intellectual is to speak to power- against the opponents of the weak.

How do we proceed in reference to the problem of metaphysical capitalism? To define: metaphysical capitalism is the capitalism of our everyday experience, a capitalism that exists as normative and, for most in the West, a capitalism that exists without any seeming alternative. It is capitalism however, that as metaphysical, "is an aspect and a consequence of domination and not its cause." (HC:12). What causes domination is the claim to and of truth and realism; against such domination is positioned hermeneutics. In short, capitalism exists as domination because we as humanity appear to wish it to and because we are not prepared to seriously entertain alternatives, especially in the West. And yet, there is nothing to stop us proclaiming our own Nietzschean announcement: *capitalism - like communism - is dead*. But, capitalism, like God, proves harder to bury than communism. So just as we live after the death of God yet with the return of God, so we may find ourselves living after the death of capitalism but with the return of capitalism. God as metaphysical claim survived the death of god because we wished to have god continue. We did not want to give up what we felt god offered- and more so, were not prepared to live within an alternative of the death of god where-upon the responsibility for life and its experiences and outcomes becomes situated and located with us. Likewise with capitalism, the injustice of capitalism occurs because we allow it to, because the benefits of capitalism to and for us are seen to out-balance the costs to others of it. The waste of the weak is what allows me to live as I do - and in response I can blame capitalism and so shift the problem into a metaphysical realm of truth and realism. But capitalism exists as metaphysics and seemingly therefore without an alternative because I allow it to. In the name of rational free markets and rational individuals participating in rational free markets which drives so much economic thinking we actually participate in metaphysical capitalism.

The opposition to metaphysical capitalism entails democracy. For democracy ends metaphysics because, as stated by Vattimo in *A Farewell to Truth* [FT], in proper democracy there is no class possessing a 'true truth' and who rule accordingly with direct power as philosopher kings or as sovereign dictate rules of conduct [FT:16]. In applying this to the continuation of metaphysical capitalism the task is clear. We must, by opposing and dismantling metaphysical capitalism, dethrone those who attempt to rule as philosopher kings or as sovereigns within capitalism. The aim is that of weak capitalism, a capitalism that is democratic, but also, a weak capitalism that, in the post-metaphysical vacuum, is not open to the technicians of social life to exert power to replace the power of the dethroned philosopher kings [FT: 17] In short, capitalism must be returned to the people, for the people, via hermeneutics. What does this involve? Applying Vattimo's reading of Heidegger via Reiner Schürmann, it involves nothing less than an exit from metaphysical capitalism "through struggle against the fixed objectivity of the existent thing" [FT:31]. In discussing Being and beings, Vattimo refers to the possibility for being in the aperture of the paradigm [FT: 34] whereby it can be stated our being is continuously ruptured by the aperture of Being- yet Being is itself only experienced via being. Yet

further, Being is that which reminds us of the beings who lose, “the continually silenced voices of history’s losers” [FT: 32–33], those who, in capitalism, are other to us, are the waste of neo-liberalism.

Reading, weakly out of this, the end of metaphysical capitalism is a rupture, an aperture that occurs via the ontology of actuality. What if capitalism is the paradigm into which we have been thrown, but, in weakening it to hermeneutics we suspend “its claim to definitive validity” [FT: 32] and therefore hermeneutic communism—the reminder of the beings who lose—is “that which remains unsaid” within capitalism after metaphysics.

That which remains unsaid, those who exist unspoken, exist outside “the politics of descriptions or, which is the same, framed democracy” [HE: 26]. So it is no surprise that in seeking to maintain a framed democracy, for our convenience we most often, implicitly or explicitly, claim a metaphysical capitalism wherein at most, we are granted the possibility of dialogue, but never the conversation that holds the possibility, even the intention, of collapsing the conserved political and capitalist order. Put that way of course we can understand why the conversation is withheld; yet such a withholding occurs because the metaphysical presupposition that has come to exist regarding capitalism is taken as self-evident truth, increasingly by the technicians of social life. The complexity of late-modern life, aided by the framed democracy of metaphysical capitalism, also means that we, with relief, increasingly give up the issues of decision and choice to the technician. Consider the 2007–2009 Global financial crisis and its on-going effects. The complexity of the shift to a word of finance that failed actually increased our belief in the metaphysics of capitalism, for the alternative of the failure of metaphysical capitalism was too much for most of us to consider; so we called in the high priests of the technicians to restore a sense of metaphysical calm. The technicians indulged in dialogue, but never in the conversation that would open the aperture, the rupture whereby capitalism could stop being a metaphysical claim and experience. For framed democracy relies on metaphysical capitalism and metaphysical capitalism relies on our fear to take up a conversational democracy wherein we are implicated in the choices made, their success and their failure. That is, a metaphysical capitalism always allows us, down to me as an individual, to claim that where and how we find ourselves exists as a final truth, in the sense there appears no viable, or desirable, out-side to the status quo. The technician, as the one claiming and granted the status of the metaphysician, claims to understand the true nature, a true nature that does not allow for any alternative. In such a situation, hermeneutic communism is for most too great a step. For what is needed is firstly an alternative within capitalism rather than an alternative against it. Such an alternative breaks the framed nature, breaks the state of emergency that extends the lack of emergency wherein everything is decided and capitalism continues as it was. To weaken capitalism is therefore the first step, not a weakening within a framed system of metaphysical capitalism, but a weakening that ends the metaphysics of capitalism itself.

Such a weakening also involves a weakening of my being, as does any weakening of any expression of metaphysics. Because to end a recourse to metaphysics in any area invites the question: if possible there, why not here, if possible for that,

why not for me? Therefore my being is, in late modernity in the West post-1989, increasingly tied to the persistence of metaphysical capitalism. This is why the global financial crisis has seen the persistence of capitalism, the persistence of metaphysical capitalism. The alternative would be a metaphysical crisis for all of us who, implicitly or explicitly stake our being to the maintenance of a capitalism that exists, we can claim, separate from us. It is not in the end that certain financial institutions are 'too big to fail' but rather, for us, capitalism itself, as metaphysics, is too big to fail; for if it fails then we fail - as beings. If it fails then we - that is us who still succeed - run the risk of becoming ontological losers, the ones who lose and would exist now in the realm of the unspoken.

Therefore the risks of the failure of capitalism are such that for most in the West it is near impossible to think the unthought of the outside of capitalism. The unthought outside is not the same as the opposition, for one can be opposed without being able to undertake the unthought that signals a coherent, viable, achievable alternative: the outside.

Communism for most stopped being the unthought outside somewhere between 1989 and 1991. Communism retreated, in the West, to the academy where the unthought outside was granted refugee status within institutions funded by capitalism. Here it was effectively domesticated because, as long as communism remained metaphysical it was undone by its dominant, hegemonic unthought outside: metaphysical capitalism. Yet to weaken metaphysical capitalism to the point of hermeneutics but to provide as the only unthought outside a return to metaphysics via metaphysical communism would be put us in the position of a metaphysical yo-yo: we may undergo the retreat from capitalist metaphysics but then undertake the return to metaphysics, even if this time it is communism-but still metaphysics.

This is why the retreat from metaphysics, the retreat from the dominant metaphysics of our age, that of metaphysical capitalism, can only be undertaken if there has already occurred the project of hermeneutic communism as expressed by Vattimo and Zabala. Only when the unthought outside is itself not metaphysical can the retreat from metaphysical capitalism occur; for we must never lose sight of the issues that metaphysics is itself at the root of the issue. For the project we are calling for is first and foremost the emancipatory project of interpretation whereupon freedom from metaphysical capitalism lays the ground of the possibility of the freedom for hermeneutic capitalism. But as long as capitalism is seen and experienced as metaphysical then the call for the further emancipatory project of hermeneutic communism stalls upon a metaphysical and ontological choice that allows me, within capitalism, to not run the risk of becoming an ontological loser.

To weaken metaphysical capitalism is therefore the first step on the road to the possibility of hermeneutic communism being more than the academy gazing fondly, nostalgically, to Latin America.

So to proceed.

If "hermeneutics has always been the latent backbone of cultural revolutions against bearers of power" [HC:78] then the cultural revolution of and in the west, today, is that undertaken firstly by hermeneutic capitalism. For this weakens the bearers of power from within, by providing what can be termed the unthought inside

that lays the ground for the unthought outside. The unthought inside, that is hermeneutic capitalism, is the alternative within what is. This is not the end in itself but is that which weakens the apparently hegemonic system. Let's be honest with ourselves. As long as capitalism is metaphysical there is little chance of the communist revolution in the west. To call for communism- metaphysical or otherwise- will make a fascinating conference, may result in many small press and university press books but will do little to result in change- or a desire for real change - by those who find their ontology within metaphysical capitalism. Only when we can undertake hermeneutics within capitalism can we then move toward the project of hermeneutic communism. For hermeneutics is what lays the ground for the conversational, engaged, unframed democracy that is central to hermeneutic communism.

So our starting point is the expression and undertaking of weak thought within capitalism - which is actually what many of us in the academy do. If in our thinking, teaching and writing we position ourselves at a critical position to that which is strong we are already engaged in a form of weak thought. If we question and critique capitalism, its structures and effects- and hold and teach and write that it can and should be questioned and challenged - we are laying the grounds for what could become hermeneutic capitalism. It is hermeneutic capitalism in effect - even if the intent is hermeneutic communism. What we undertake is, we must be clear, in the main, not yet communism, except in attitude and anticipation. It occurs as challenge and critique within capitalism, a capitalism that regularly proclaims its own end and resurrection, demise and re-imagination, collapse and return. Consider the type of resurgent capitalism proposed by Anatole Kaletsky, economist, journalist and Chairman of the Governing Board of the Institute for New Economic Thinking (<http://ineteconomics.org/>)

In his book *Capitalism 4.0* [C4] Kaletsky states we find ourselves, post 2007–2009, in a fourth period of re-imagined capitalism. In Kaletsky's schema, the first stage stretched from 1815 to World War One and was the age of classic laissez-faire capitalism whereby there was a separation of politics and economics. Stage Two capitalism encompassed the New Deal and the Welfare State and saw, in Kaletsky's view an "almost romantic faith in benign, all-knowing governments and instinctive distrust of markets, especially financial markets." [C4: 4]. This was followed by what I would term the self-inversion of capitalism under the Capitalism 3.0 which was the Thatcher- Reagan free market that, as Kaletsky observes, "romanticized markets and distrusted government" [C4: 4]. Now, post- 2007–2009 Kaletsky proclaims we find ourselves in Capitalism 4.0 whereby we realise that both markets and governments can be wrong. The result is not however the end of capitalism nor the end of government but rather a re-imagined capitalism realizing that markets and governments "are both imperfect mechanisms" and that in a world that is "complex and unpredictable" the option is "Experimentation and pragmatism" leading to a world of "ambiguity, unpredictability and fuzzy logic." [C4: 8–9]. This change occurs because capitalism is positioned as evolutionary capitalism, whereby out of its continual self-destruction "it is always recreating itself and, like a species evolving through natural selection, this protean creature emerges from each mutation stronger than it was before." [C4: 34]. There are unconscious and illuminating

echoes here of David Harvey's description in *The Condition of Postmodernity* of what can be termed the permanent revolution of capitalism whereby capitalism is defined as "a social system internalizing rules that ensure it will remain a permanent revolutionary and disruptive force in its own world history"[107]. The trouble is that we, that is the wider population of the West, respond as if this is natural cycle, a series of natural events, because we cannot or will not think the unthought outside of capitalism and by doing so allow such changes and restructurings of capitalism to be responded to as if it is indeed a metaphysics. Therefore before we seek the realization of a hermeneutic communism, we must, I would argue undertake the weakening of capitalism that is involved in the challenge from within of a hermeneutic capitalism; before the unthought outside can be successful, the way must be opened by the expression of the unthought inside that is hermeneutic capitalism. In this, I acknowledge, I am very close indeed to re-expressing the call for a Leninist vanguard, but a vanguard from within capitalism, not from outside it. For, even if our minds are outside, our bodies are lived inside capitalism. Unless I wish to undergo a body-mind split I must instead undergo a self-weakening of being within capitalism, a self-weakening that is also involved in the self-weakening of capitalism, of hermeneutic capitalism. For weak thought is an on-going project of weakening strong structures and weakening metaphysics; even proclaiming its end is never enough, for the project never stops. Rather, weak thought is central to a post-metaphysical ontology whereby "Hermeneutics is a way of looking at Being as an inheritance that is never considered as ultimate data." [HC: 93]. Here I wish to reference the interviews of Eric Hobsbawm with Giorgio Napolitano of the Italian Communist party published in 1977 as *The Italian Road to Socialism* [hereafter IRS]. Reading these debates raises the question of whether it is not actually capitalism as a stage *toward* communism but rather communism as a corrective *within* capitalism, especially within a western capitalist frame. As Hobsbawm commented in 1977, "In the past Communists frequently committed the error of maintaining that there is no way out besides socialism, that capitalism cannot overcome its crises. It was able to do so in the past, and it may be able to do so yet; the problem is one of choosing between differing solutions and not immediately one of the alternative between socialism and catastrophe." [IRS:51]. Reading this from our current post 2007–2009 crisis position Hobsbawm is sagely prescient. Only now, post 1989–1991, even now, socialism for most in the west is not considered an alternative to catastrophe. Rather the metaphysics of capitalism means capitalism is considered by many as both catastrophe and its own solution.

In tandem to Hobsbawm, Napolitano expressed the basic problem of the need to provide "a positive answer to the problems raised by the crisis of capitalism" [IRS: 45] and this is complex in advanced capitalist societies. The route to socialism for Napolitano lay "though a struggle with the democratic process, a broadening of the alliances of the working class and its affirmation of hegemony and, finally, a gradual modification of economic and social structures within the framework of a still further development of democracy." [IRS: 83].

Remember the centrality of democracy to weak thought; that weak thought is the expression of true and not framed democracy. Here therefore is part of the possibility

of hermeneutic capitalism that is also part of the possibility of a hermeneutic communism. This involves a weakened, unframed democracy that is conversational and not dialogic; that is in fact conversational within and between both hermeneutics, capitalism and communism. Communism may be our 'highest "weakness"' [HC:112] but to get there involves our lower weakness that is hermeneutic capitalism. Only when our Being is weakened within capitalism by enacting the proclamation of the death of metaphysical capitalism will we, in the west, be able to move, conversationally toward our highest weakness as an event in Being. In the west, in the north- and in its southern outposts, it is within capitalism, it is from within capitalism that weakening must first occur. This involves therefore my own weakening as capitalist before I can proclaim myself as communist. It also involves my own weakening as communist within capitalism. For as intellectual and bourgeois, as vanguard and privileged, within a capitalist society and thus also within a capitalist funded institution, I am always both capitalist and communist. If I am metaphysical, at best I find myself dialogical being, but a framed being. But, if I am hermeneutical, in a constant interplay of weakening, I am possibly that spectre of conversational being. Within the death of metaphysical capitalism I am a double spectre, self-haunted by the ghosts of metaphysics. Until I weaken capitalism, even if only at first for myself, I cannot weaken communism except as utopian dream, a haunting of the past as future. For hermeneutics is the end of all the spectres, of both spectres of what was capitalism and what was communism- and most importantly, the end of the spectre of metaphysical Being. Until I am a hermeneutic capitalist, I cannot become a hermeneutic communist- and until I am both, I am that spectre of metaphysical Being.

Response to Grimshaw

Gianni Vattimo and Santiago Zabala

The central argument of Mike Grimshaw's contribution is that we made "too great a step" and are "too far along" in history. We can't but interpret this as a compliment. One of the last things we wanted *Hermeneutic Communism* to be is simply another description of the world. Even though innovative concepts such as "politics of description" or "framed democracy" sought to better understand the present, they also involved a call to change the status quo. This change, however, does not imply an "alternative" to the "politics of descriptions" and "framed democracies," but rather an "alteration", as metaphysics cannot be overcome (*überwunden*) once and for all. We still consider this to be one of the most significant contributions of our book, because it invites other political theories to prevent falling back into metaphysics. Although the New Zealander sociologist does not explicitly reproach us for falling back into metaphysics, he claims that we overlook the transition to "hermeneutic communism," which he refers to as "hermeneutic capitalism." But why is this transition important and what does it consist in?

In order to explain this transition, Grimshaw does not only refer to our text, but also the talk Gianni delivered at the 2009 conference on "The Idea of Communism" in London. This conference, organized by Costas Douzinas and Slavoj Žižek, was meant to question if communism is still the "name to be used to designate radical emancipatory projects."¹ In this context Gianni presented a paper titled "Weak Communism", in which the crisis of capitalism is interpreted as a "second moment

¹C. Douzinas and S. Žižek, "Introduction," *The Idea of Communism*, eds. C. Douzinas and S. Žižek. London & New York: Verso, 2010: iii.

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which completes the fall of the Berlin wall. Real capitalism is becoming discredited in the same way that the realm of communism was in 1989.”²

Grimshaw uses this analogy between capitalism and communism to declare a new “Nietzschean” announcement: “capitalism – like communism – is dead.” “But, capitalism, like God, proves harder to bury than communism. So just as we live after the death of God yet with the return of God, so we may find ourselves living after the death of capitalism but with the return of capitalism.” As much as we welcome this formulation, we are concerned this return of capitalism is much stronger not only than the return of God, but also of those examples of “hermeneutic communism” we illustrated in the last part of our book. This is not only evident in all the financial bailouts and ongoing trade agreements that framed democracies have implemented during these recent years, but also in the economic sanctions (Venezuela) and coups (Brazil) taking place in South America right now. In twenty-first century, capitalism – rather than turning hermeneutic or weak – has intensified its frames. But who is resisting these frames?

If “hermeneutic capitalism,” as Grimshaw suggests, “is really the transition to “hermeneutic communism,” it is not simply for genealogical reasons. It is also because it involves “the only class capable of societal transformation in the west and north: the bourgeoisie.” As “self critical-bourgeois intellectuals,” open to the return of communism, this is the only genuinely transformative revolutionary class capable of creating an “alternative within capitalism.” These include, according to Grimshaw, academic members of the “left including Vattimo, Žižek, Badiou, Negri and the like.” As much as we like to be mentioned among these radical thinkers, one must wonder whether we are really a revolutionary class? The idea, hypothesis, or project of communism, which was discussed at the conference mentioned above, was not the name for an alternative or solution, but rather, as Žižek pointed out, of a number of problems that range from global pollution, inequality, and terrorism created by capitalism.

In order to respond to these vital issues, it is not necessary, as Grimshaw seems to imply, to be a “self critical-bourgeois intellectual” in the West, or wait for capitalism to weaken, but rather to learn to interpret signs from the future. After all, for many Marxist and leftist activists in the West, the South American alternative represents this future. In other words, it indicates that another world is possible. It is important to remember that what distinguishes hermeneutical philosophy from other theoretical stances is that it allows this interpretation to take place practically, that is, through involving ourselves in a project of transformation which concerns our lives. In order to assume this future as a model it is not necessary, as he claims, to be from a South American context, tradition, or society, but rather to learn to interpret their initiatives independently of how alien they might seem. If this requires taking “too great a step” and moving “too far along,” it is a risk worth taking.

²G. Vattimo, “Weak Communism?,” *The Idea of Communism*, eds, C. Douzinas and S. Žižek. London & New York: Verso, 2010, 206.

Potentiality of Life

William Egginton

Abstract The current legal attack on women's reproductive rights with its turn to neuroscience underscores an important aspect of what Gianni Vattimo and Santiago Zabala have called "framed democracy" and its reliance on an objectivist notion of truth and a foregrounding of rationalist science at the expense of any other potential modes or sources of knowledge. By permitting scientific data to replace thought, interpretation, and debate as the adjudicator of the legal limits of human life, fetal pain statutes seek to retrench age-old patriarchal models of gender inequality and subservience under the guise of objective knowledge. What is in fact a deployment of power by a metaphysically and theologically grounded ideology enters political discourse under the guise of scientific truth. Rights that have been wrested from entrenched power through generations of political struggle are represented as subordinate to scientific discovery, and as such subject to adjustment. But science has never determined personhood; the limits of human life have in all places and all cultures been determined by contested interpretations.

This summer, attorney Rick Hearn approached me to serve as an expert witness in an appellate case that could, some think, lead to the next Supreme Court test of *Roe v. Wade*.¹ Mr. Hearn is representing Jennie McCormack, an Idaho woman who was arrested for a self-induced abortion after she took RU-486, the so-called abortion pill. While the case against Ms. McCormack has been dropped, Mr. Hearn is pursuing a class action suit against an Idaho statute that prohibits abortions even prior to viability, currently held to be around 24 weeks, citing evidence that "pain receptors (nociceptors) are present throughout the unborn child's entire body by no later than sixteen (16) weeks after fertilization and nerves link these receptors to the brain's thalamus and subcortical plate by no later than twenty (20) weeks."² Since viability is, according to *Roe v. Wade*, the point at which the State's interest in protecting "the

¹ I published some thoughts on this case in much reduced form in the *New York Times*' Opinionator pages: <http://opinionator.blogs.nytimes.com/2012/10/28/can-neuroscience-challenge-roe-v-wade/>

² Idaho Code §§ 18–503.

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potentiality of human life”³ becomes compelling enough to override its interest in protecting the right of a woman to make decisions regarding her body and its reproductive organs, Idaho’s statute and others like it would either be found unconstitutional or, if upheld, entail overturning a fundamental aspect of *Roe v. Wade*.

The case for fetal pain at such early stages of pregnancy as claimed by the Idaho statute is shaky at best. As the authors of a 2005 review of clinical research in the *Journal of the American Medical Association* put it, “Evidence regarding the capacity for fetal pain is limited but indicates that fetal perception of pain is unlikely before the third trimester.”⁴ While it would seem that such evidence is enough to undermine the state’s claim to having a rational basis for its statute, it is my contention in the opinion I produced for the plaintiffs that scientific findings on their own, regardless of whether they support the State’s position or not, cannot supply such a rational basis. While the sciences should inform individuals’ and communities’ legal and ethical choices, they can never relieve us of the obligation to choose, to reason, and to make judgments in full awareness of the traditions and meanings that underlie our most basic and often controversial dilemmas.

The current legal attack on women’s reproductive rights with its turn to neuroscience, underscores an important aspect of what Gianni Vattimo and Santiago Zabala have called “framed democracy”⁵ and its reliance on an objectivist notion of truth and a foregrounding of rationalist science at the expense of any other potential modes or sources of knowledge. By permitting *scientific data* to replace *thought, interpretation, and debate* as the adjudicator of the legal limits of human life, such statutes seek to retrench age-old patriarchal models of gender inequality and subservience under the guise of objective knowledge. What is in fact a deployment of power by a metaphysically and theologically grounded ideology enters political discourse under the guise of scientific truth. Rights that have been wrested from entrenched power through generations of political struggle are represented as subordinate to scientific discovery, and as such subject to adjustment. But science has never determined personhood; the limits of human life have in all places and all cultures been determined by contested interpretations; this legal case presents yet another such example.

Science and Framed Truths

According to the authors of *Hermeneutic Communism*, far from purely descriptive, scientific rationalism and philosophical realism are complicit with and supportive of entrenched political and economic elites and their efforts to maintain their privileges. As Vattimo and Zabala write,

³ROE v. WADE, 410 U.S. 113 (1973), 162.

⁴Susan J. Lee et al., “Fetal Pain: A Systematic Multidisciplinary Review of the Evidence,” *Journal of the American Medical Association* 294.8 (2005): 947–54, 958.

⁵Gianni Vattimo and Santiago Zabala, *Hermeneutic Communism: from Heidegger to Marx* (New York: Columbia University Press, 2011), 16.

A politics of description does not impose power in order to dominate as a philosophy; rather, it is functional for the continued existence of a society of dominion, which pursues truth in the form of imposition (violence), conservation (realism), and triumph (history). These metaphysically framed political systems hold that society must direct itself according to truth (the existing paradigm), that is, in favor of the strong against the weak. Only the strong determine truth, because they are the only ones that have the tools to know, practice, and impose it. (12)

The political guise that the society of dominion has donned in the modern industrialized world is nothing other than liberal democracy. Elites who benefit from the status quo endeavor to ensure that existing democratic structures continue to support the wealth of privileges that accrue to them. This explains the transformation of democracies in the modern western world, where the majority of the world's multinational corporations are based, into thinly disguised oligarchies in which access to the higher reaches of political power is limited to a class defined by its outlandish and ever-increasing wealth. As the New Zealand Herald and other sources reported in July of 2012, the former chief economist at McKinsey, James Henry, produced a report alleging that as much as \$30 trillion from the world's richest may be squirreled away in tax havens, an amount equal to the combined GDPs of the USA and Japan. Alone the wealth that has escaped taxation in developing countries since the 1970's would be enough to pay off all the developing world's debts.⁶ The institutions and individuals who are complicit in this system play a leading role in assuring that democracy does not become any more democratic than its current manifestation; the acceptable framework defining adequately functioning formal democracy excludes any viable alternatives.

Any discourse that decides in advance what truth is and who has access to truth is by definition a threat to democracy. The unexamined nature of liberal democracy's own framing of truth claims is thus a threat to unframed democracy, or what Derrida called the "democracy to come."⁷ This is why "communism" in Vattimo and Zabala's view is both hermeneutic and limited to the status of a Kantian regulative idea. It is hermeneutic because, as the authors write, hermeneutics is the essence of politics, which "relies on a plurality of individual developments, that is, active interpretations. A philosophy that relies on a plurality of interpretations must avoid not only any metaphysical claims to universal values, which would restrict personal developments, but also that passive conservative nature that characterizes descriptive philosophies in favor of action (77)." Hermeneutics, the circulation and exchange of active interpretations, occurs prior to and outside of metaphysical framing, and must be excluded in order for metaphysics and framed democracy to establish their claims to exclusive validity.

Communism, in turn, is the name Vattimo and Zabala give to democracy unframed, unleashed from the bonds of such prior metaphysical assumptions. Their concept of communism is this unrelated to the totalitarian movements that assumed its title in the twentieth century, principally because the concept is inherently inimical to institutionalization. From the perspective of hermeneutic philosophy,

⁶Heather Stewart, "Trillions Disappear Off Shore to Tax Havens," NZ Herald online, July 23, 2012): http://www.nzherald.co.nz/economy/news/article.cfm?c_id=34&objectid=10821400

⁷Jacques Derrida, *The Last of the Rogue States: The 'Democracy to Come,' Opening in Two Turns*, *South Atlantic Quarterly* 103:2/3 (2004): 323–41.

communism can only ever be an incomplete and utopian project. Communism must be figured as the embodiment of hermeneutics in the political sphere, the struggle to hold open a space for the populations that framed democracies exclude, to allow in turn a basic level of ferment to undermine their unexamined truths. As the authors continue,

While we cannot imagine a world where communism is completed, neither can we renounce this ideal as a regulative and inspiring principle for our concrete decisions.... Kant's lesson of practical reason also has this meaning: the union between virtue and happiness is not only the end that gives meaning to moral actions but also something impossible to carry out in the world. Nevertheless, this impossibility does not remove the obligation toward the categorical imperative. In sum, communism is utopia or, as Benjamin would have it, a 'weak messianic power, a power on which the past has a claim.' (117)

For communists in the hermeneutic sense, in short, politics is not limited by *what is*, but is oriented always toward *what could be*.

When a legislature enacts statutes that claim a rational basis in science but whose purpose is the re-characterization of fundamental rights or notions of personhood, it seems to me that the theoretical perspective outlined by Vattimo and Zabala suddenly becomes very real. In such cases, attentiveness to the clandestine deployment of political power in the claims to scientific neutrality put forth by Idaho and other states that are currently aiming to restrict women's reproductive rights exemplifies the deployment of a politically engaged hermeneutic philosophy of the kind they advocate.

The Non-scientific Status of Basic Rights

In the opinion I produced for the Idaho case, I contended that neuroscience—or any other science, for that matter—can never serve as a sufficient legitimate basis for a society to expand or contract the rights of its citizens. This is consistent with my position in a debate I conducted with the naturalist philosopher Alex Rosenberg in *The New York Times*, where I argued that, “while neuroscience may well have very interesting things to say about how brains go about making decisions and producing different interpretations...it does not follow that the knowledge thus produced replaces humanistic knowledge.”⁸

The brain sciences, like all branches of the natural sciences, are immeasurably useful tools for individuals and communities to make use of—hopefully for the betterment of society and the improvement of our understanding of the natural world. The basic rights guaranteed by the Constitution, however, have nothing at all to do with the truths of science. They are, to use Karl Popper's terminology, non-falsifiable, like religious beliefs or statements about the immortality of the soul: our commitment to them is not a product of scientific evidence but a result of a complex history of political debate. Jefferson's description as self-evident truths the claims

⁸ William Egginton, “The Cosmic Imagination,” in “Bodies in Motion: An Exchange,” *The Stone*: <http://opinionator.blogs.nytimes.com/2011/11/06/bodies-in-motion-an-exchange/>

“that all men are created equal, that they are endowed by their Creator with certain unalienable Rights, that among these are Life, Liberty and the pursuit of Happiness,” was, as scholars such as J. Hillis Miller have pointed out, far from self-evident.⁹ It was a politically charged speech act that ignited a war of self-determination on the part of a fledgling nation. Like the equality of its citizens, in other words, the basic rights of Americans are not dependent on the changing opinions of science.

Science has been used in myriad instances in the past to justify political redefinitions of personhood, almost always with ghastly results. In the sixteenth century the Spanish Crown based its subjugation and ultimate decimation of native-American populations on the best science of the time: namely, contemporary interpretations of Aristotle’s claim that some peoples were less fully human than others and could be legitimately enslaved by others.¹⁰ In the twentieth century European fascists wholeheartedly adopted the scientific findings of Cesare Lombroso’s positivist criminology, which held that criminal tendencies were inborn and could be detected in physical traits on the body and skull. One of his intellectual descendents, Hans Günther, was a widely admired and decorated scientist who was appointed to the Chair of Racial Theory at the University of Jena in 1930, and whose theories were influential to the Third Reich’s racial policies.¹¹

While neuroscience may or may not be able to tell us something about the development of fetal nociceptive capacity, it has nothing to say about the fundamental question of what defines a full-fledged person deserving of the rights afforded by a society. Science can no more decide that question than it can determine the existence or non-existence of God. If the Idaho State Legislature would likely disapprove of using (the rather abundant) scientific evidence of the non-existence of God to write a law depriving citizens of the right to worship as they choose, they would be wise to avoid turning to neuroscience for evidence concerning the limits of personhood.

More than 200 years ago Immanuel Kant identified three questions about which science could have nothing to say. Moreover, he demonstrated that should it try to come to conclusions about these questions, it would necessarily fall into error. These questions were that of the existence of God, the immortality of the soul, and the origin of human freedom.¹² Not coincidentally, these are exactly the questions that are relevant for my testimony. For, “to believe that our empirical exploration of the world and of the human brain could ever eradicate human freedom” is a fundamental error we fall into when we project the concrete knowledge the sciences can

⁹J. Hillis Miller, *Speech Acts in Literature* (Stanford, CA: Stanford University Press, 2001), 126. Text of the Declaration can be found online at: <http://www.ushistory.org/declaration/document/>

¹⁰See William Egginton, “On Relativism, Rights and Differends, or, Ethics and the American Holocaust,” *Qui Parle* 9.1 (1995, appeared 1997): 33–70.

¹¹See Bernadette Wegenstein, *The Cosmetic Gaze: Body Modification and the Construction of Beauty* (Cambridge, MA: MIT Press, 2012), 29–49.

¹²Immanuel Kant, *Critique of Practical Reason*, trans. T. K. Abbott (Amherst, NY: Prometheus Books, 1996), 159.

give us about how our brain works into the domains of theology and ethics.¹³ Scientific evidence can no more be used to determine the limits of personhood and the rights that should accrue to it than it can be used to dictate how or what citizens may worship or—since according to some polemicists free will is illusory anyway—to justify limits to our freedoms of speech or assembly. Neuroscientific findings thus have no relevance for the constitutional issues at stake in legal debates around access to abortion.

As a scholar of the humanities, one way I could describe my work would be as the attempt to use the history of western literature and thought to arrive at a more precise understanding of concepts that are intrinsic to controversies in the present. As concepts always carry implicit meanings and associations that have accrued to them through their development in a given cultural and linguistic context, the clarification of concepts from a historical perspective has enormous relevance to our debates in the present. This is undoubtedly the case for those statutes currently attempting to push the time when the state may restrict access to abortion to points earlier than viability.

In 2010 the Nebraska state legislature passed a law that, in its own words, seeks to “assert a compelling state interest in protecting the lives of unborn children from the stage at which substantial medical evidence indicates that they are capable of feeling pain.”¹⁴ As the authors of a recent study of this statute in the *Journal of Law, Medicine, and Ethics* point out, there are two potentially plausible lines of reasoning for an attack on the principle of viability laid out by *Roe* in the statute. The first would be to claim that the state has some compelling interest in restricting pain per se. But such a restriction, while greatly to be desired by animal rights activists, would be far broader than intended by the Nebraska legislature and is unlikely to be supported by the population at large. The second is thus the only feasible line of argumentation: namely, as the authors summarize, that “while preserving fetal life is not a compelling state interest until the viability point, the state’s interest in preserving fetal life of a not-yet-viable fetus becomes compelling when we add the prevention of fetal pain to it, thus two state interests not compelling standing alone may be compelling when added together.”¹⁵

It is precisely at this point that a perspective informed by humanistic study becomes not only relevant, but essential. What connection exists between the capacity to feel pain, on the one hand, and the potentiality of human life that, according to Justice Blackmun’s opinion in *Roe v. Wade*, the State has a compelling interest in protecting as of viability? To answer this question, we must understand what is intended, explicitly and implicitly, in the concepts involved.

In *Roe v. Wade* Justice Blackmun demonstrated with great care and historical detail why the State’s interest must be in the *potentiality* of human life, as opposed

¹³Egginton, “The Limits of the Coded World,” *The Stone*, <http://opinionator.blogs.nytimes.com/2010/07/25/the-end-of-knowing/>

¹⁴Cited in Glenn Cohen et al., “Fetal Pain, Abortion, Viability, and the Constitution,” *Journal of Law, Medicine, & Ethics* 39 (2011): 235–41, 237.

¹⁵Cohen et al., 237.

to in the life that might be supposed to already exist in a human embryo or fetus. The problem is that neither the legal or the theological traditions, on the one hand, nor current scientific knowledge on the other, can establish what human life is or when, exactly, it can be said to begin. As Blackmun explores in some detail, the legal tradition has varied over time and between cultures from permitting abortion wholesale, to prohibiting it after the quickening of the fetus, to restricting it wholesale, as occurred in the U.S. in the twentieth century.

Theological notions of when human life begins and when it is worthy of being respected and protected are even less consistent. As Blackmun writes, “[t]here has always been strong support for the view that life does not begin until live birth. This was the belief of the Stoics. It appears to be the predominant, though not the unanimous, attitude of the Jewish faith.”¹⁶ From the Middle Ages until the nineteenth century, the Catholic Church’s position stemmed from the Aristotelian concept of “mediate animation,” which held that the human soul entered, or was “ensouled,” in the fetus sometime between fertilization and birth—according to canon law, curiously enough, this was held to happen at 40 days for males and 80 days for females. The Catholic Church’s current position that life begins at conception and that abortion at any stage is an excommunicable offense was inscribed in canon law only in 1917. As Blackmun pointed out in his opinion, even arguments claiming conception as the only logical starting point of life—because it marks a moment in time before which there is no life and after which there is—run afoul of “embryological data that purport to indicate that conception is a ‘process’ over time, rather than an event.”¹⁷ Even biologically, in other words, conception fails as a line in the sand.

For this reason, Blackmun in *Roe* used the language of potentiality. While “the unborn have never been recognized by the law as persons in the whole sense”¹⁸—and therefore deserving of protection over the legitimate interests of the State in preserving a woman’s right to make decisions regarding her own body and reproductive organs—we can all agree, he reasons, that a fetus is at a minimum a potential human life. That is, under the right conditions, it may develop into a human being deserving of full legal protection.

Those wishing to abolish abortion believe, with the appellee in *Roe v. Wade*, that “the fetus is a ‘person’ within the language and meaning of the Fourteenth Amendment.” If, Blackmun continues, “this suggestion of personhood is established, the appellant’s case, of course, collapses, for the fetus’ right to life would then be guaranteed specifically by the Amendment.”¹⁹ If a fetus is a person, in other words, then it is not a potential human life at all, but is a full human life deserving of full legal protection, and abortion must be murder and punishable as such. There cannot be, it should be clear, a mediating point between these positions. To say something is potential is to deny that it is actual; it is even to deny that it will be with certainty actualized, as potentiality carries with it the notion that something may

¹⁶ ROE, 160.

¹⁷ ROE, 161.

¹⁸ ROE, 162.

¹⁹ ROE, 156–7.

intervene at any time to contravene actualization. Potential human life can always fail to become a human life. Moreover, the opposing concepts of potentiality and actuality are not newcomers to philosophical attempts to deal with the essence of life. Aristotle's definition of a living thing's soul was the "first actuality of a natural body that is potentially alive."²⁰

The Nebraska statute, in other words, cannot seek to enhance the State's legitimate interest in potentiality of human life through combination with an interest in preventing pain, because the fetus is either a potential human life, in which case viability is a proper line for all the reasons *Roe* made clear; or the evidence of pain sensibility pushes the fetus past the tipping point of potentiality and makes it an actual human life, in which case viability is not the proper line.

The ultimate intent of those writing the statute is not merely to enhance the state's interest; rather, it is to replace it with another measure altogether. Ability to feel pain on the part of a human fetus, if it can be established by neuroscience, would have to be a claim for actual human life or full personhood. But ability to feel, or sentience, on its own is an attribute of most animate organisms, and no one has ever claimed that a fetus is not an animate organism. The claim of human life is a higher one: implicit in it is the idea of a unique self or soul. However, as the doctrine of the immortal soul entering the body at the moment of conception pertains to a specific religious tradition and its allies, and as institutionalization of a particular religious tradition in the law is prohibited by the establishment clause of the Constitution, *another justification* would need to be found. As Justin Blackmun wrote in his separate opinion in *Casey v. Planned Parenthood* in 1992, "a State's interest in protecting fetal life is not grounded in the Constitution. Nor, consistent with our *Establishment Clause*, can it be a theological or sectarian interest."²¹

This attempt at another justification is present in implicit form in the Nebraska statute, as well as in all other state statutes seeking to introduce fetal pain as relevant to abortion legislation, in the concept of consciousness. The Nebraska statute not only refers to "ability to feel pain"; it also characterizes the unborn child as "having the physical structures necessary to *experience* pain," and claims that the evidence shows that "unborn children *seek* to evade certain stimuli." It is clear from the terms *experience* and *seek* that the statute's implicit understanding of the ability to *feel* pain is that feeling refers not merely to what neuroscientists call the nociceptive capacity of an organism—the ability of its nervous system to detect and respond to potentially noxious stimuli—but to conscious awareness of the presence of such stimuli.

Current neuroscience distinguishes a spectrum of degrees of "consciousness" among organisms, ranging from basic perception of external stimuli to fully developed self-consciousness. Even the idea of self is subject to further differentiation. The neuroscientist Antonio Damasio, for instance, distinguishes conscious ability in terms of the kind of "self" wielding it: while non-human animals may exhibit the

²⁰ Aristotle, *On the Soul*, trans. J. A. Smith, book II, part 1: <http://classics.mit.edu/Aristotle/soul.2.ii.html>

²¹ *PLANNED PARENTHOOD v. CASEY*, 505 U.S. 833 (1992), 931.

levels he calls proto-self and core-self, both necessary for conscious experience, only the autobiographical self, which provides the foundations for identity, is considered to be an attribute largely limited to humans.²²

This more robust concept of consciousness that seems to distinguish human personhood from more basic forms of perception has a very specific history, which dates to the early seventeenth century and is most associated with the thought of the French philosopher René Descartes and the school of thinkers that followed him. While Descartes considered whether a neonate or even young children might have consciousness of this kind, in the end he and his followers rejected this posit, insisting on the “reflective” nature of consciousness: “In short, just as we make a distinction between direct and reflected vision, in that the first depends on the first reception of the light rays, and the other on the second; in the same way I call the first and simple thoughts of children, that come to them as, for example, they feel the pain caused when some gas enclosed in their intestines distends them, or the pleasure caused by the sweetness of the food that nourishes them...., I call these direct and not reflexive thoughts; but when the young man feels something new and at the same time perceives that he has not felt the same thing before, I call this second perception a *reflection*, and I relate it only to the understanding, insofar as it is so attached to sensation that the two cannot be distinguished.”²³ As Larry Jorgensen summarizes in his commentary on this exchange, “a conscious thought is a mental state that is somehow self-intimating. And all thoughts, according to Descartes, have this basic property.”²⁴

Consciousness, in other words, presents a much higher, and much harder-to-establish, standard than mere potentiality of life. Therefore, implicit recourse to the concept fails as a means of replacing viability as the line dividing the permissibility of abortion and its prohibition. For a fetus to be conscious in a sense that would establish it as a fully actualized human life, according both to current neuroscientific standards and to the philosophical tradition from which the concepts stem, it would have to be capable of self-intimation as well as simple perception of stimuli. And as philosophers of many stripes since Descartes have argued, self-intimation is a reflexive state involving a concept of self in contrast with that of others—concepts it would be hard to imagine being meaningful for a fetus, even if fetuses could be shown to have access to concepts in the first place. By turning to consciousness in an attempt to push Roe’s line-in-the-sand back toward conception, in other words, abortion proponents would in effect be pushing it forward, toward the sort of self-differentiation that only occurs well after birth and the emergence of what the phenomenological tradition has called “world.”

²² See Antonio Damasio, *Self Comes to Mind: Constructing the Conscious Brain* (New York: Random House, 2010), *passim*.

²³ René Descartes, *Correspondance avec Arnoud et Morus*, ed. Geneviève Lewis (Paris: Librairie Philosophique J. Vrin, 1953), 86–87, my translation.

²⁴ Larry M. Jorgensen, “Seventeenth-Century Theories of Consciousness,” *Stanford Encyclopedia of Philosophy*, <http://plato.stanford.edu/entries/consciousness-17th/>

The Dictates of Dialectic

This argument has some broader implication as regards the relevance of scientific research in general for the legislation of social conflicts. Among the pre-Socratic philosophers of ancient Greece, Zeno of Elea was renowned for his power in deploying what the Greeks called dialectic, or reasoned argument. In a legendary standoff, he demonstrated to the listeners in the forum that motion was impossible, since any motion between two points would have to first cross the half-point between those distances, and the half-point between that point and the starting point, and so on. As the distance can be divided infinitely, it would take an infinite time to move any distance, no matter how small. One of his listeners, Diogenes the Cynic, was said to have responded by standing up and moving.

While it is generally accepted that Zeno was deploying his paradoxes not as actual proof of the stated claims but as a *reductio ad absurdum* of opposing positions, the anecdote is illustrative of a form of argumentation and, specifically, of inference from scientific information, that is still prevalent today. In a recent pamphlet, the polemicist Sam Harris has, for example, summarized many of the recurrent arguments brought to bear by philosophers against the existence of free will, emphasizing those that emerge from advances in the neurosciences showing, for example, that computers attached to sensors can “read” test subjects’ decisions some 300 milliseconds before the subjects report being aware of them.²⁵ While he draws grand conclusions from such experiments, regarding the non-existence of free will and how we should organize and think about law and ethics, most reasonable peoples’ response will inevitably be similar to that of Diogenes: we will put down the book and go about making choices and accepting our responsibility for them (or shirking it and trying to blame someone else, in the case of my 17-year old).

The problem with such grand statements (made, it should be noted, almost exclusively by non-neuroscientists ostensibly on behalf of that field) is that the people making them apparently have little or no knowledge of the history of western thought. If they did they would know that already in 1791 Immanuel Kant dedicated the second half of his magnum opus, *The Critique of Pure Reason*, to showing how exactly such conclusions result from our failure to recognize and impose proper limits on the extent of our knowledge. Kant’s argument, as it turns out, is directly relevant both to Harris and to Zeno, and provides an early modern philosophical corollary for the political urgency of Vattimo and Zabala’s argument about how objective notions of truth can lead to tyranny.

At the heart of his critique Kant situates a series of apparently contradictory results that—as had been obvious to thinkers since antiquity—emerge when humans push reasonable conclusions to their logical extreme: On the one hand, the universe has a beginning in time, for anything that is must have begun; on the other hand, it can’t have a beginning, since any starting point would have a point before it. On the

²⁵ Sam Harris, *Free Will* (New York: Free Press, 2012), 8.

one hand, the universe is composed of substances that are infinitely divisible, since anytime you cut something down to a concrete particle, it has extension and thus must be further divisible; on the other hand, the universe must be composed of discrete simple substances that cannot be further decomposed, since anything that is divisible ad infinitum has no original substance to be composed of, and so on. Kant's explanation for all such paradoxes was that they emerged when human reason's natural and beneficent tendency to explain the world, that is, to give reasons for what we perceive, was allowed to reign free and explain not only the realm of science, that is, the realm of calculations and measurements, of *how things appear to us*, but also how the universe in its totality is *in itself*, regardless of how it is registered by our senses or the instruments we use to measure it.²⁶

While we can, therefore, assume infinite divisibility, it makes no sense to draw conclusions concerning how the world really is from that assumption, because we cannot in fact infinitely measure divisibility. Likewise, ideas such as the existence of God, the immortality of the human soul, and the causality of human freedom—that is, our ability to intervene in the world of appearances and make things happen—are postulates that can neither be proven or refuted, and when we try to do either we fall inevitably into error.

In his second *Critique*, in which he takes on the problem of human freedom, Kant has already rebutted every one of Harris' arguments more than 200 years before Harris wrote his book. Commenting on his own exploration of the above-described antinomy, he writes,

The antinomy of pure speculative reason exhibits a similar conflict between freedom and physical necessity in the causality of events in the world. It was solved by showing that there is no real contradiction when the events and even the world in which they occur are regarded (as they ought to be) *merely as appearance*; since one and the same acting being, *as an appearance* (even to his own inner sense), has a causality in the world of sense that always conforms to the mechanisms of nature, but with respect to the same events, so far as the acting person regards himself at the same time as a noumenon (a pure intelligence in an existence not dependent on the conditions of time), he can contain a principle by which that causality acting according to laws of nature is determined, but which is itself free from all laws of nature. (139)

Of course—we can almost hear Kant saying—of course a machine that is fast enough can register a human decision before the human declares awareness of it. All that proves is that a machine can process a specific piece of information faster than the human's brain can. But to infer from that fact that human are not free to make choices is to conclude something about the totality of the world as it is in itself from a perspectively-limited observation of one aspect of existence; it requires, in other words, projecting from one concrete measurement an infinity of such measurements—just as Zeno's argument requires projecting from the division of one step to the infinite division of steps—in order to construct a spectral, God-like knowledge of the human being. If Harris maintains his conclusion is correct despite its apparent

²⁶ For a particularly eloquent formulation see Immanuel Kant, *Critique of Pure Reason*, trans Paul Guyer and Allen W. Wood (Cambridge: Cambridge University Press, 1998), 523.

irrelevance for our daily lives, well, so did Zeno. The difference is, of course, that Zeno knew he was a sophist.

In a similar way, what statutes such as those in Idaho and Nebraska reveal is how complicit democracies can be in the objectification of their citizens if it serves the interests of established power for them to be so. Using the discourse of neuroscience to justify pushing back the protections afforded to sovereign citizens to exercise choice in matters concerning their most intimate bodily existence is a powerful example of what Foucault called biopower, in which modern states complicate the deployment of power from mere coercive and prohibitive forms of power focused on individual bodies to the cultivation of life forms at the species level.²⁷ Even more to the point is Giorgio Agamben's extrapolation of the Foucauldian notion in the concept of bare life. Neither natural life (*zoe*) or political life (*bios*), bare life is a modern political formation that occurs when the state of exception decreed by sovereign power become, in effect, the norm.²⁸ Citizens have freedom of control over their own bodies...except when the state determines that those bodies hold another life inside them. At that point, the woman's body becomes a *femina sacra*²⁹—to paraphrase the figure from Roman law, the *Homo Sacer* that became the formative concept for Agamben's eponymous book. For by placing women's legal personhood under the threat of the state of exception, by exposing her natural life to the possibility of state-sanctioned denial of liberty, that is exactly what the State in fact does: a woman who finds herself in an unintended pregnancy is reduced by the State to bare life; stripped of the essence of personhood and its legal protections she becomes an instance of pure biopower, a ward of a sovereign power that commandeers her body for the purpose of growing a potential citizen, and perhaps even a more fully endowed one from the perspective of the patriarchal tradition.

The State aims at asserting this power through the objectivist revelations of science; it turns to secular rationalism in order to institutionalize a power imbalance that was only ever theorized and justified on theological terms. And the reason it does this is because, as Vattimo and Zabala have so persuasively argued, the discourses of rationalistic science and objectivist truth are tailored to preserve existing power structures. Capitalism, the most successful form of economic subjectification ever developed, does not maintain power exclusively through the use of force (although as the authors also demonstrate, the capitalist-democratic west ensures its hegemony through the constant use and threat of deadly force against external state and non-state challengers)³⁰; it does so primarily by defining the rules of the game,

²⁷ Michel Foucault, *Society Must Be Defended: Lectures at the Collège de France 1975–1976*, trans. David Macey (New York: Picador, 2003), 243.

²⁸ “The sacredness of life, which is invoked today as an absolutely fundamental right in opposition to sovereign power, in fact originally expressed both precisely both life's subjection to a power over death and life's irreparable exposure in the relation of abandonment.” Giorgio Agamben, *Homo Sacer: Sovereign Power and Bare Life*, trans. Daniel Heller-Roazen (Stanford, CA: Stanford University Press, 1995), 83.

²⁹ Mark Levine theorized this notion in a column in *Al Jazeera* online, “Sacred Women in Israel and Palestine”: <http://www.aljazeera.com/indepth/opinion/2011/12/20111228131232259788.html>

³⁰ Vattimo and Zabala, 45–74.

by framing the terms of debate in such a way that alternate models are excluded before ever having a chance to enter into the “marketplace of ideas.” Thankfully, in the U.S., precedence, due process, and the Constitution itself still provide the substance for full-throated defense of basic rights. But it is vital to show how oppressive interests can make the case for their continued dominance within the very discourse of truth and science that we turn to for succor.

When science is converted into dialectic it ceases to be mankind’s most useful servant and threatens, instead, to become its dictator. Science does not and should not have the power to absolve individuals and communities of the responsibility to *choose*. This emphatically does not mean that science should be left out of such personal and political debates. The more we know about the world the better positioned we are to make the best possible choices. But when science is used to replace thinking instead of complement it, when we claim to see in its results the reduction of all the complexity that constitutes the emergence of a human life or the choices and responsibilities of the person it may develop into, we relinquish something that Kant knew more than 200 years ago was essential to our humanity: our freedom.

Response to Egginton

Gianni Vattimo and Santiago Zabala

We have been collaborating for many years with William Egginton, and it is not simply because he is a brilliant philosopher and literary theorist, but also because he is an admirer and disciple of the late American thinker Richard Rorty. Rorty was not only a close friend of ours, but also of “weak thought,” which he endorsed on several occasions. This week Rorty has returned to the pages of *The New York Times*, *The Guardian*, and other papers around the world, because in one of his last books, *Achieving Our Country: Leftist Thought in Twentieth-Century America* (1998), he predicted in the near future the election of a “strongman”, “someone willing to assure them that, once he is elected, the smug bureaucrats, tricky lawyers, overpaid bond salesmen, and postmodernist professors will no longer be calling the shots.”

This is Donald Trump. The 45th president. But Rorty did not simply predict a President with these characteristics, he also foresaw a very similar plan: “One thing that is very likely to happen, the author with whom we wrote *The Future of Religion*, is that the gains made in the past 40 years by black and brown Americans, and by homosexuals, will be wiped out. Jocular contempt for women will come back into fashion... All the resentment which badly educated Americans feel about having their manners dictated to them by college graduates will find an outlet.”¹ Gianni not only promoted the translation of this book in Italian but also wrote a foreword alerting leftist Europeans to listen to Rorty’s warnings concerning the choice of “cultural politics” over “real politics”, as it would also lead them “to prefer knowledge to

¹R. Rorty, *Achieving Our Country: Leftist Thought in Twentieth-Century America*. Cambridge Mass: Harvard University Press, 1998), 90. Note Vattimo has written the foreword to the Italian translation for Garzanti publishers in 1999.

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hope.”² The wave of technocratic governments the EU imposed upon Italy, Greece, and other countries these past years is a consequence of this preference.

While Rorty is still considered as one of the most important American philosopher’s since John Dewey, in his own country he is still seen as an outsider, ever since he published his 1979 *Philosophy and the Mirror of Nature*. This book did not simply claim that “conversation” should replace “truth”, but also that hermeneutics was the path to take in order to overcome those “mirrors of nature”, which limit philosophy’s horizons. These frames are not only central in *Hermeneutic Communism*, but also in Egginton’s contribution, which points out its consequences in the “current legal attack on women’s reproductive rights with its turn to neuroscience.” This legal attack, which is probably going to increase under the Trump administration, relies “on an objectivist notion of truth and a foregrounding of rationalist science at the expense of any other potential modes or sources of knowledge.”

As Egginton’s points out, in *Hermeneutic Communism* we took seriously Rorty’s warnings that any “discourse that decides in advance what truth is and who has access to truth is by definition a threat to democracy.” In order to avoid this threat, it is necessary to find “unframed” truths, that is, truths capable of relying on a plurality of interpretations. This truth for us is “communism.”

While Rorty would probably have been suspicious about this concept, he would have appreciated how Egginton defined our notion of communism as “the embodiment of hermeneutics in the political sphere, the struggle to hold open a space for the populations that framed democracies exclude, to allow in turn a basic level of ferment to undermine their unexamined truths.” The legislatures Egginton rightly criticizes are framed within these sort of unexamined truths. The problem with truths, once they are left unexamined, is that they enact “statutes that claim a rational basis in science but whose purpose is the re-characterization of fundamental rights or notions of personhood.”

If these basic rights, similarly to communism today, have little in common with the truths of science or the totalitarian states that assumed its title in the twentieth century, how can we characterize our commitment to them? As Egginton suggests, our “commitment to them is not a product of scientific evidence, but a result of a complex history of political debate.” This debate is absent today. The fact that access to abortion is curtailed, or communism dismissed as unnatural or wrong, is an indication that we must return to and engage in these debates without deciding “in advance what truth is.” Otherwise it would become, as Egginton says, a “threat to democracy.”

²R. Rorty, *Achieving Our Country*, 36. The Italian translation was published by Garzanti in 1999.

The Actuality of Philosophy: Critical Reflections on *Hermeneutic Communism*

Roberto Alejandro

[T]he end of truth is the beginning of democracy
(Gianni Vattimo and Santiago Zabala)

[Truth] requires greatness of soul: the service of truth is the hardest service
(Friedrich Nietzsche)

Philosophy is not an adventure in modesty. Most philosophers do not want to talk about this or that particular person, but about the whole concept of man or human beings. They are not interested in capturing the spirit of an epoch, but of humanity's entire history. Nor are they concerned about one particular way of reasoning, but about Reason. They like to write about the "most important questions" that, if left unanswered, will drive us toward catastrophes. Socrates' insistence to Thrasymachus that they should continue talking about the importance of the soul is a vintage example. Kant writes about the preconditions of knowledge; Nietzsche, about the turmoil of the entire Western civilization; Hegel about the whole of Western history until it found its highest echelon in the state; Marx about the same history but with his radar on the ground, close to the material reality of the producers. Heidegger writes about Being. Hermeneutic communism is a refreshing example of this expansive and capacious project. Its central concepts are Being, emancipation, event, contingency. The goal is to hasten the demise of metaphysics and to propose a conception of philosophy that seeks to deepen the conflicts of the present along with the necessary awareness of those conflicts.

In this essay, I propose to examine Gianni Vattimo and Santiago Zabala's philosophy of "hermeneutic communism" by first laying down what I consider their main arguments. Secondly, I will discuss some problems in the idea of philosophy put forward by Heidegger that serve as an important source for Vattimo and Zabala's reflections. Thirdly, I will address their view of pluralism and dialogue. I will conclude with some reflections on the "nature of philosophy" and its role in contemporary times. To avoid misunderstanding: Vattimo and Zabala's philosophy is a

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refreshing account of the current predicament, sensitive to important traditions of thought, and infused with a sensibility toward the plight of the weak. In the spirit of Alain Badiou and Jacques Ranciere, their philosophy gives impetus to reconceptualization of new philosophical questions. My arguments advanced here have been nourished by their critiques of the global capitalist order and have encouraged me to begin a reflection on philosophical patterns that may sabotage the radical character of a philosophy of instability. I beg the reader to take this into account in assessing the positions that I present below.

The Arguments

In *Farewell to Truth*, Vattimo defined the “principal question” that we need to answer today and articulated it thus: “What becomes of the philosophy-politics relation in a world in which, in consequence of the end of metaphysics and the spread of democracy, politics can no longer be thought in terms of truth?” His answer was that “philosophy becomes intrinsically political thought,” which he calls “the ontology of actuality.”¹

We need “to focus on the twofold significance of the ontology of actuality: making oneself aware of the paradigm into which one has been thrown yet suspending its clam to definitive validity and heeding Being as that which remains unsaid.”² Hermeneutic communism is the political project that responds to Vattimo’s question. This project is a Heideggerian reflection that invokes a particular tradition to diagnose the contemporary predicament and to offer ways out of the dead ends of the capitalist order. In mapping out its conceptual landscape, hermeneutic communism privileges Heideggerian categories—Being, event, authenticity—and joins them up to the Marxist critique of capitalist organization. Vattimo and Zabala insist that hermeneutic communism is “a dialectical theory,” but not “the bearer of metaphysical truths or a metaphysics of conflicts and clashes.” Yet, Being is the “truth” of hermeneutic communism³ and its hope is the “event.” “Heidegger’s thesis” that envisions life “as a thrown project” is the “only one [they] manage to suggest” against the “politics of descriptions.” “Authentic existence” is an important goal but cannot be limited to the “professional revolutionary figure” even though this figure is “interesting.”⁴ The adoption of Heidegger’s language is constant throughout their text: “In sum, we prefer the idea of Being as ‘event,’ since without it we could not ‘exist’ (as projects) for the simple purpose of living.”⁵ Metaphysics left out “the forgotten Being.”⁶ Still, alienation can be overcome but not without a new sensibility

¹ Gianni Vattimo [1]; p. 41. Hereafter cited as *Farewell*.

² *Farewell*, p. 32.

³ Gianni Vattimo and Santiago Zabala [2]; p. 110. Hereafter cited as *HC*.

⁴ *HC*, p. 139.

⁵ *HC*, p. 94.

⁶ *HC*, p. 16.

that acknowledges the pluralistic nature of postmodern societies. “The world will not cease to be alienated by finding its identity but rather by being open to the multiplicity of identities.”⁷

Hermeneutic communism is a “dialectical theory” but is also an “objective necessity” that we need to assume.⁸ It is “a theory capable of both updating classical Marxism and again rendering believable the effective possibility of communism.”⁹ It also “proposes an effective conception of existence for those who do not wish to be enslaved in and by a world of total organization.” As philosophy, “is not an assessment of tradition but most of all an ontology of the event, a philosophy of instability,” which “has the task of intensifying the consciousness of conflict.”¹⁰ Metaphysics, precisely, is the negation of conflict to the extent that it is “the idea that an objective order exists independently from us and to which we ought to conform to know (mirroring) and act (rights and ‘natural’ ethics)”¹¹ This metaphysical belief leads to “politics of description” which in turn displays “the violence of truth, the conservative nature of realism, and the winner’s history.” Politics of “descriptions” are descriptions that, seemingly, tend to be based on universalism.¹² In order to overturn the prevalence of this politics, hermeneutic communism locates itself in a tradition that privileges “a certain textual tradition”¹³ and brings together Marxism and communism with some of Heidegger’s concepts.

This is a politics of Being that aims at emancipation through the rejection of metaphysics and the recognition of our contingency and historicity. Hermeneutics “only has contingent historical motivations as its disposal to claim any reasonable validity.”¹⁴ “Being is history and nothing else.” Emancipation “means openness, transformation, and projected interpretation instead of what already is; this, after all, is probably why Rorty used to say, ‘If you take care of freedom, truth will take care of itself.’”¹⁵

Hermeneutic communism rejects truth claims to the extent that these require political power, which is a call for violence and the silencing of the other. We may well dispense from the “if” in the following citation:

If truth claims are also always claims of political power, that is, violence, and if this same violence is nothing else than the ‘silencing’ of other interlocutor[s] through an apparent dialogue, truth and violence become interchangeable.¹⁶

⁷ HC, p. 138.

⁸ HC; pp. 113, 111.

⁹ HC; p. 133.

¹⁰ HC; p. 139.

¹¹ HC; p. 94.

¹² HC; pp. 139–140.

¹³ Farewell, p. 43.

¹⁴ HC; p. 95.

¹⁵ HC; p. 94.

¹⁶ HC; p. 19.

Against “politics of descriptions” and their truth claims, they offer the “‘event of unconcealment’ [that] renounces the distinction not only between true and false assertions but also between good and evil actions.”¹⁷ Instead of relying on truth descriptions, philosophical hermeneutics “is involved in interpretive ‘events of unconcealment’”¹⁸

In sum: Hermeneutic communism finds its context in the “end of metaphysics,” the “dissolution of the politics of descriptions,”¹⁹ and the belief that “hermeneutics is the only philosophy that reflects the pluralism of postmodern societies.”²⁰ Hermeneutic communism sees interpretation as “part of existence,”²¹ but it is much more than a “part” of existence. Hermeneutics is an “ontology” that should also be understood as “the constitutive dimension of Being.” This centrality demands that Being be understood “as an event and not an object.”²²

The main emphasis in Vattimo and Zabala’s philosophy of hermeneutic communism is the rejection of “politics of descriptions” whose view of truth requires violence. But they do allow both for the existence of “facts” and for the need to make choices between true and false options. In hermeneutics, they write, “it is always possible to establish whether an interpretation or a proposition is true or false but only within a historical condition, a certain scientific discipline, or a political epoch.”²³ They propose a transition from metaphysics to hermeneutics and from dialogue to conversation.²⁴

Concepts and Universality

Concepts should come with glass windows. They should allow us to see the vicissitudes that were needed and through which competing ideas were vanquished in favor of the triumphant ones. We would be able to see the scaffolds, the twisted, bloated, and bloody corpses, and the desolate landscapes that served as nourishing and constitutive grounds for concepts. This dark vision is what concepts such as rights, democracy, consent, equality, and liberty enclose and hide. Language reveals and conceals. As cold traces over pieces of paper or even as spoken words that carry spiritual forces, their sinister history is dimmed. There may be some resonances, but most echoes are muffled. The shell and its sound: this is, I think, the best metaphor for concepts. There is thunderous silence of invisible waves that we can still hear. Or can we?

¹⁷ HC; p. 22.

¹⁸ HC; p. 23.

¹⁹ HC; p. 78.

²⁰ HC; p. 79.

²¹ HC; p. 81.

²² HC; p. 89.

²³ HC; pp. 106–107.

²⁴ HC; p. 26.

Hermeneutics came into the North American academic world with force after the publication of Hans-Georg Gadamer's *Truth and Method* in 1960. The whole Gadamerian project had an eerie majesty. It spoke of tradition as an encompassing spiritual and cultural reality that led human beings to think in particular ways well before they were in a position to make choices or to invoke reason as the tribunal of validity. But *Truth and Method* also carried more than one grain of perversity. Fifteen years after the official cessation of the cataclysmic events of the Second World War and forty-two years after the first global war, not taking into account the anti-colonial movements in the 1940s and 1950s, a German philosopher was telling his readers, with all the solemnity that German philosophers can muster, that tradition and its intrinsic agreements were our salvation. In Gadamer's hermeneutics, we are a conversation, which in turns means that we have a hidden linguistic agreement before the conversation. The conversation succeeds when this prior, ontological agreement comes into the open and is consciously acknowledged by its participants.

There was no mention of the disfiguring atrocities that the same tradition so dear to Gadamer was capable of unleashing on European citizens, not to mention Africans. It is a pity that hermeneutics, as a philosophical sensibility ensconced in concepts (interpretation, tradition, contingency), lacks glass windows.

When Gadamer warmed up to his philosophy, hermeneutics turned into judge and tribunal of the most important actions and questions of our humanity: "The claim to universality on the part of hermeneutics rests on being able to integrate all the sciences into it, of perceiving the opportunities for knowledge on the part of every scientific method wherever it may be applicable to given objects, and of deploying it in all its possibilities."²⁵

In this ethos toward universality, no area is left untouched. Hermeneutics, Gadamer argues, should guide all sciences to the extent that it poses to "all human beings" "the greatest of questions."

Hermeneutics [as philosophy] not only accounts for the procedures applied by sciences, but also gives an account of the questions that are prior to the application of every science.... These are the questions that are determinative for all human knowing and doing, the greatest of questions, questions that are decisive for all human beings and their choice of the good.²⁶

This impulse to establish the authority of philosophy in advance is a sign of all philosophical endeavors in the West. In Heidegger, for instance, the sciences need philosophy in order to understand what they are doing. They do not grasp the inner structures of the areas they investigate. This structure is only made possible through a philosophical inquiry into the nature of Being.

²⁵ Hans-Georg Gadamer, "Hermeneutics as a Theoretical and Practical Task" in *The Gadamer Reader. A Bouquet of the Later Writings*. Edited by Richard E. Palmer. Evanston, Illinois: Northwestern University Press, 2007; p. 264. Emphasis added.

²⁶ Hans-Georg Gadamer, "Hermeneutics as a Theoretical and Practical Task;" 264–265. Emphasis added.

Laying the foundations for the sciences ...is a productive logic—in the sense that ... it discloses [Being] for the first time in the constitution of its Being, and, after thus arriving at the structure within it, makes these available to the positive sciences as transparent assignments for their inquiry.²⁷

The philosopher even feels entitled to tell the sciences how “real progress” is achieved in their particular ambit. “Real progress” in research in the sciences “comes not so much from collecting results and storing them away in ‘manuals’ as from inquiring into the ways in which each particular area is basically constituted.”²⁸ Vattimo and Zabala tread on the same path when they invoke Dilthey and argue that he “saw in the vitalist essence of hermeneutics the priority of interpretation over scientific inquiry, theoretical criticism, and literary constructions.”²⁹

In Farewell to Truth, Vattimo is explicit in the universality that philosophy propounds. In submitting the German term Verwindung as a description of the current times, he argues: “Philosophy’s claim to universality is not surrendered in the least; that would be to betray its task.” To this universality, he added that philosophy is not any kind of knowledge: “It would make no sense to propose Verwindung as a way of escape from metaphysics if we were to conceive philosophy as just a special form of knowledge, one science among others, an academic discipline.”³⁰

Though hermeneutic communism as philosophy still endows universality to its claims, it also addresses a landscape occupied by “politics of descriptions” and their “violence of truth.” In clearing a new landscape from metaphysical occupiers, hermeneutic communism does not repudiate the Western philosophical tradition. Rather, it chooses its own heroes. It privileges certain texts and even builds its own genealogy. Thus Marx, Nietzsche, Benjamin, and above all, Heidegger, are among its predecessors. Hermeneutic communism takes insights from the Frankfurt School but claims to be “more radical.” Lyotard is transformed into another predecessor of hermeneutics and weak thought: “Lyotard indirectly outlines the condition of weak thought.”³¹ “Rorty is among the first supporters of hermeneutic weak thought.”³² Hermeneutic communism assumes that its inventory of history and philosophy allows it to recover insights that were uttered in the past but were left unrecognized. Thus, In Farewell, Vattimo claims that Heidegger had a “political project” that now can be recognized with “clarity.”³³

Heidegger’s talk about Being invites the following question: Do certain concepts tie us inexorably to a metaphysical way of thinking—Being, forgetfulness of being, etc., universality, alienation?

²⁷ Martin Heidegger, Being and Time. Translated by John Macquarrie & Edward Robinson. New York: HarperPerennial, 2008; p. 31. Emphasis added.

²⁸ Martin Heidegger, Being and Time, 29.

²⁹ HC, p. 80.

³⁰ Farewell, pp. 128–129.

³¹ HC, p. 100.

³² HC, p. 104.

³³ Farewell, p. 31.

When we talk about Being as a totality, we are saying that philosophy, not science, holds the key to opening and reading, that is, deciphering that totality. It is the old Heideggerian claim that philosophy purifies and chooses the relevant questions and then delivers them up to the sciences for further scrutiny. The sciences, by themselves, are not equipped to identify fruitful questions. Gadamer goes a step further and alleges that scientists do not even know how to ask relevant questions. These may strike some readers as strange attempts to prop up the dwindling influence of philosophy. Still, both Heidegger and Gadamer's arguments do say something about how philosophy was considered by them as the best conceptual framework to provide ethical guidance.

In Heidegger's version, Being, in its pre-socratic incarnation, was harmony and apprehension of something original accomplished not by philosophers, but by the "greater thinkers." "Heraclitus and Parmenides were 'greater' in the sense that they were still in harmony with the Logos, that is, with the 'One (is) all.'"³⁴ Philosophy is a fallen condition. It is the leaving behind of thinking in favor of "philosophy," in which philosophy is a striving toward something (Being) that was lost.

The following passages from Heidegger warrant attention:

For, to be sure, although we do remain always and everywhere in correspondence to the Being of being, we, nevertheless, rarely pay attention to the appeal of Being. The correspondence to the Being of being does, to be sure, always remain our abode. But only at times does it become an unfolding attitude specifically adopted by us." "Philosophy is the correspondence to the Being of being, not until, and only when, the correspondence is actually fulfilled and thereby unfolds itself and expands this unfoldment. This correspondence occurs in different ways according to how the appeal of Being speaks, according to whether it is heard or not heard, and according to whether what is heard is said or kept silent."³⁵

Here we have a philosophical and historical sequence in which a first and essential moment was lost through, precisely, the sophists and Socratic philosophy. And we have a view in which philosophy is required to fulfill certain conditions in order to be relevant. First, it needs to identify and to think about this totality that is called Being. Second, it must develop a special sensibility to know that this totality speaks. Third, philosophy should know the language that Being speaks and, finally, it should listen to it. Philosophical action in Heidegger lies in listening. Presumably, this listening will reveal to us the correspondence (the attunement?) in which we remain "always and everywhere." Philosophy is the little nudge that makes us aware of that correspondence. If we pay some attention to Nietzsche's suspicions, this philosophy may also be the spectacle of ventriloquism. It is not Being that is talking through the philosopher but the other way around.

Like Nietzsche before him, Heidegger sees Socrates as a disturbing figure. For Nietzsche, the "fall" was the eclipse and eventual obliteration of the aristocratic values of the warriors extolled in Homer by Socrates' dialectics. For Heidegger, the "fall" is the move away from the "harmony" with the Logos and the One enjoyed by

³⁴ Martin Heidegger, *What is Philosophy?* Translated with an Introduction by Jean T. Wilde and William Kluback. New Haven, Connecticut: College and University Press Publishers, 1956.

³⁵ *What is Philosophy?*, p. 75. Emphasis added.

Heraclitus and Parmenides to the priorities and language of the sophists, Socrates, and Plato. This is crucial. Here are his words: "However, even the Greeks had to rescue and protect the astonishingness of this most astonishing thing against the attack of Sophist reasoning which always had ready for everything an answer which was comprehensible to everyone and which they put on the market."³⁶

His argument is a rejection of the sensibilities of the democratic polis in which words had to be comprehensible in the assembly and the agora. The sophists designed speeches to persuade and convince the polis, and Socrates attempted the same through his quest for clarity in definitions. Both represented experiences of education within a democratic context. This connection with the polis is something that Heidegger avoids. In his reading of the Greek past, the polis is invisible. Yet, it was the polis that provided the spiritual vigor, sensibility, and education for the development and impetus of philosophy. What does this Heideggerian silence about the Greek democratic polis say?

After his experience with the Third Reich, Heidegger was not a politically engaged philosopher. Contrary to Sartre who founded a newspaper and lent his voice to the cause of anti-colonial and ante-imperialistic policies, Heidegger kept silent about the pressing political issues of his days. His talk was about "Being," the forgetfulness of Being, and his apocalyptic views about technology, his struggle with language. Language may be the "house of Being," but, in Heidegger, it may also hinder access to that Being that he believed was apprehended by Parmenides and Heraclitus. Vattimo-Zabala are doing us a great favor: they are translating to the twenty-first century the Delphic-like statements about Being that come to us as spectral voices from the Black Forest.

Heidegger claims that we have inherited a metaphysical language.³⁷ The question is whether one can use the conceptual apparatus of metaphysics and still being able to overcome it. I suspect that it is not possible. Philosophy as a linguistic capacity to apprehend a totality (Being), to decipher it, and to see that its "essential" features are metaphysical hopes. This is present in the universality of hermeneutic communism as well as in Vattimo and Zabala's belief that alienation can be overcome. Alienation is not possible without a referential point, a central one in the constitution of what we are, from what we have strayed. The alienation may take the form of a lost site of pristine wholeness (Rousseau), a world of transparent social relations (Marx, Lukács), and the oblivion of Being (Heidegger). In all cases, the loss is deemed essential and the consequences apocalyptic. There is no way back to the original state of nature envisioned by Rousseau, but there is the conviction in Marx that new transparent social relations will be achieved under a communist society, and that the recapturing of Being is possible (Heidegger).

Both Gadamer and Vattimo are explicit in rejecting the Heideggerian view about an unspoiled apprehension of Being in ancient Greece. Heidegger, according to

³⁶ *What is Philosophy?*, p. 51.

³⁷ "The Onto-Theological Constitution of Metaphysics." In Martin Heidegger, *Identity and Difference*. Translated by Joan Stambaugh. Chicago: The University of Chicago Press, 2002; p. 73.

Vattimo, “deluded” himself into thinking that “Hitler’s Germany could become a revival of pre-classical Greece, mythically imagined as a land where Being was still present.”³⁸

Yet, Vattimo and Zabala cling to the notion of the “forgetfulness of Being.” When was Being present in humanity’s memory? When was it forgotten? What is the event they want to “unconceal”? A necessary question: Do they share Heidegger’s belief that Socrates and Plato represented a fundamental distortion of that “original” apprehension that Heraclitus and Parmenides as thinkers, not philosophers, obtained? Hermeneutic communism does not offer any hint to answer these questions. What it deploys is an hostility against the Platonic dialogue that is the best tradition of what Heidegger calls “destruction.”

They describe dialogue as “the best way ... to conserve framed democracy’s interests.”³⁹ The dialogue form entails the “politics of descriptions or, which is the same, framed democracy.”⁴⁰ “The same laws and dialogues ... depend on the metaphysical justification of objective descriptions, that is, of truth.”⁴¹ Their project is one that goes from dialogue to conversation and from metaphysics to Hermeneutic communism.⁴² One suspects that the outright rejection of dialogue is Vattimo and Zabala’s way of distancing Hermeneutic communism from the Gadamerian insistence on the preeminence of the Platonic form of dialogue. Regardless of whether this is the intention, their claim is a philosophical indictment of the dialogical form on the grounds that they are contrived to reach a particular goal. “Plato’s exemplary dialogues,” they aver, “aimed to conduct one of the two interlocutors (often a slave) to recognize the truth that the other already knew from the beginning.”⁴³ Now, on getting close to the textual evidence, this charge disintegrates. In all the early dialogues, Socrates is having conversations with Athenian citizens, some of them prominent members of the polis, and, with the exception of the *Laches*, Socrates needs to fight his way to get his point across. Thrasymachus insults him and Callicles does the same. In the *Euthydemus*, the character Socrates is even confused and dizzy in front of his interlocutors’ onslaught. The claim in Hermeneutic communism invites wondering whether this is an echo of the Heideggerian proclivity to invent translations and etymologies of Greek words to justify peculiar interpretations. In both cases, interpretation is reduced to what Nietzsche may have alerted us against: interpretation not only as slicing and selecting, but also an imposing of a particular will to power.

Furthermore, they add, “Plato does not want the established order to be disrupted, altered, or shocked by either those artists that he banned from the Republic or by the philosopher, who could also act this way.”⁴⁴ This is true for the ideal city,

³⁸ Farewell, p. 111.

³⁹ HC, p. 23.

⁴⁰ HC, p. 26.

⁴¹ HC, p. 23.

⁴² HC, p. 26.

⁴³ HC, p. 19.

⁴⁴ HC, p. 25.

but something should be said about a philosopher who, in imagining the kallipolis, abolished private property and defended a communist society with a community of women for the guardians, and who articulated reasons in favor of a philosophical vanguard. When we compare this Platonic radicalness with the conservative musings of Aristotle, we need to accept Vattimo's position: Dasein chooses its heroes.

Contingency

Hermeneutic communism is committed to the recognition of contingency and historicity in constituting our identity. In Vattimo and Zabala's view, contingency is not only faithful to the plurality of "postmodern" societies, but also to the opposite—to the "violence of truth" that they see in the "politics of description." The assumption of contingency as a new cornerstone should be accompanied by charity and freedom. Their view of contingency is similar to Rorty's, and they quote him approvingly: if we take care of freedom, truth will take care of itself.

We may pose, as a first step, that our humanity is contingent through and through. But we need to add that we never stay in the contingent flow. We build shelters—physical and symbolic ones. Our concepts are the highest expression of contingent utterances that, though based on some particular historical conditions, are transformed into rules of conduct. This presupposition can also lead to our all too human predicament, which is our capacity to stand back from the contingent flow, assess it, and seek to inscribe in it our own signature. This is Rousseau's idea of freedom: a law that one gives to oneself.

Freedom operates in existing agreements, that is, in an existing configuration of powers sustained by the sedimented weight of concepts, practices, and institutions. This triad always privileges some truths or even one truth. But power has a sinister nature not only in its invisibility but in its circularity. The invisibility follows a Heideggerian insight: we tend to miss what is near. Powers need foundations of symbolic underpinnings—ideas—that through the force of their own propaganda, acquire a naturalness that excludes power from critical inquiry. The circularity is more insidious, especially in the era of savage capitalism. Power has some values that in turn are translated into public policies. When these public policies bring about the havoc that European and American humanity is now suffering, the instinctive reaction of power is not to challenge the values, the originary principles that explained the policies in the first place, but to leave those values intact and to provide new means for their preservation. This is a dramatic manifestation of irrationality. It is the policy behind the bailout of the financial system carried out by the Bush administration in 2008. Power is anything but suicidal.

In the public sphere, crises put an end to power's invisibility, but power's circularity halts and preserves its legitimacy. The Jeffersonian idea that only errors need public support on the ground that truth can stand by itself is consistently crushed. Truth needs values, people who defend them, and institutions, even if they are

embryonic. No. Human truth cannot stand by itself. It needs its own Joseph of Arimathea.

In giving ourselves a law, we still the flow and show that contingency is a beginning that never has the final word. Achilles is one of the most eloquent examples in the Western tradition. He invited his fate to the extent that he “chose” it. His sense of honor was a contingent construction but, once accepted, the contingent origin gave way to forms of conduct that were necessary consequences of honor as defined by his culture. In early modern Europe, we find a similar situation. The aristocratic warriors who lived by the code of knighthood accepted for themselves a way of talking and acting that were necessary outcomes of the symbolic realm that was both received and crafted through their actions.

These examples suggest that contingency is not immune to universality or to the violence of its own truth. Hermeneutic communism may accept this offspring but then, by necessity, will have to tell people who give themselves a particular code of action that they need to see that code with some distance (Vattimo and Zabala). Rorty will say that they have to look at their code with irony (Rorty). Still, something about a necessity born from contingency remains: the willingness to separate, to distance oneself from the law that one has adopted does not change the actions emerging from the values. The knight may display a sense of irony or fragility in killing the adversary who tarnished his honor, but the killing must be done. It would be a necessary inference from the contingent value of honor.

The possible reply that we should go with the flow, with distance from values that we accept for ourselves (Rousseau’s definition of liberty), enveloped in the facile tolerance of postmodern pluralism will not do. Dionysian creatures do not exist.

In underestimating the necessity that is also inscribed even in a contingent construction of our identity, hermeneutic communism departs from what, up to this moment, is part and parcel of our humanity: the capacity to give rules to ourselves and to live by them. Alas, with necessity, dogmatic assertions and violence seem to be woven into the same tapestry.

Pluralism

We may throw in our lot with the pluralism of liberal democracy. This is a marketplace of shoppers and talkers. It cannot be a realm where some will impose their conception of truth since that would be violence. Habermasian officials on the lookout for evidence of manipulation and falsehood that are seeds for distorted communication need to have their conception of truth. These “mandarins,” Vattimo rightly asserts, should not be allowed free rein.⁴⁵ True: the voices of the weak will be heard. And then? The concepts and reasoning of the weak are, in themselves an incipient power that needs to vanquish the mummified configuration of powers that make

⁴⁵ Farewell, pp. 40–41.

them weak. If the weak erect their own concept as a new truth to replace the existing one, this would be an imitative behavior: it would be another version of the politics of description. If the weak keep talking, this would be the politics of liberal pluralism. At this juncture, it seems that the conversation will continue. This is where hermeneutic communism meets both Rorty in his desire to continue the conversation of the West and Gadamer in his faith in the power of the ontological agreement that precedes any conversation and ought to be fulfilled through dialogue.⁴⁶

To insist on the previous argument, philosophy proposes a political project that demands that the weak be heard. This entrance into the conversation, into the public sphere and the center of decision making should create a new sensibility among the power holders. Most important, this entrance makes the weak aware of their own voice, that is, of their own power. What are the goals of this expanded conversation and awareness? Reaching an agreement that acknowledges the weak? Or continuing the conversation?

These unanswered questions may be one reason why Alain Badiou claims that hermeneutics along with analytic philosophy and postmodern philosophy are too close to the status quo. "There is something in them that goes too far in reflecting the physiognomy of the world itself. They are too compatible with our world to be able to sustain the rupture or distance that philosophy requires."⁴⁷

The pluralism of postmodern societies is bereft of truth. Vattimo cites the Nietzschean view, taken from a work that he did not intend for publication, that there are no facts but only interpretations. Nietzsche also depicted truth as a hard fought condition: "We have had to wring the truth out of ourselves every step of the way, we have had to give up almost everything that our heart, our love, our trust in life relied on. It requires greatness of soul: the service of truth is the hardest service."⁴⁸ Which claim is more relevant? Most important, how do we choose between them? This could not be a mere declaration of personal preferences to the extent that our preferences can be traced to a will to power. Vattimo eschews this possibility.

⁴⁶For a discussion of the possibility of critique through hermeneutic conversations and interpretation see Lawrence K. Schmidt, "Critique: The Heart of Philosophical Hermeneutics;" and Pol Vandavelde, "What is the Ethics of Interpretation." In *Consequences of Hermeneutics. Fifty Years After Gadamer's Truth and Method*. Edited by Jeff Malpas and Santiago Zabala. Evanston, Illinois: Northwestern University Press, 2010; pp. 202–217; pp. 288–305.

⁴⁷Alain Badiou, *Infinite Thought*. London: Continuum, 2010; p. 37.

⁴⁸Friedrich Nietzsche, *The Anti-Christ, Ecce Homo, Twilight of the Idols. And Other Writings*. Edited by Aaron Ridley and Judith Norman. Cambridge, United Kingdom: Cambridge University Press, 2005. Citation is from *The Anti-Christ*, section 50.

A Strategic Blunder?

A philosophical argument that rejects truth is lethal and its timing could not have been more disturbing. When the lie that capitalism is came to the surface with its austerity policies, impoverishment, and the contradiction between freedom and the non-existent choices left by unemployment—namely, when the savagery and the structural lies lodged at the heart of the capitalist order and its values became transparent, and capitalist legitimacy reached one of its weakest moment in recent history—hermeneutic communism was advocating for interpretations, pluralism, diversity, and contingency. The intrinsic evils in the capitalist organization could not be denounced because the theory had precluded in advance arguments about good and evils options. The “‘event of unconcealment’” renounces the distinction not only between true and false assertions “but also between good and evil actions.”⁴⁹ This was the wrong language for the right conditions.

Even if truth is not an ethical value, it still carries a huge weight in political deliberation—hence, the importance of showing to those who adhere to the tender “fairness” of the market the evil consequences of their views. But hermeneutic communism had closed this road in advance. This is what Vattimo proposed in Farewell to Truth:

As good pragmatists, ... all we affirm is that this is what sounds true ‘to us,’ what is able to set us free. ... We can only acknowledge that we see things on the basis of certain prejudices, certain interests, and if truth is possible at all, it is the result of an accord that is not necessitated by any definitive evidence, only by loving charity, solidarity, the human (all-too-human?) need to live in harmony with others.⁵⁰

In the same text, Vattimo expresses a dismal assessment for radical changes. Revolutions are no longer possible. In Hermeneutic Communism, Vattimo and Zabala anticipate resistances emerging from the poor in the slums. The Arab Spring, which has encompassed vast majorities, rewarded abundantly the anticipations contained in Vattimo and Zabala’s philosophy. At the same time, the recession in Europe, which has sent working class families and the middle sectors into the miseries of unemployment and austerities, has shown that the savagery of the capitalist order can impoverish the majority of a whole society well beyond the slums.

Why the Apocalypse?

Vattimo and Zabala’s philosophy calls for a new awareness of dangers embedded in and entailed by metaphysics, and for a new sensibility to address the pressing political problems of the present. Yet, their characterization of some of these problems invites skepticism. They are insistent that in the United States and Europe the

⁴⁹ HC; p. 22.

⁵⁰ Farewell, p. 36.

ideology of free markets and the idea of exporting democracy are reflections of a politics of truth. These arguments are important not only for what they communicate but for what they miss. The preaching of the free market ideology has never been unchallenged. Its “truth” has been resisted by vast swaths of the population in Europe. In the United States, the New Deal of Franklin Delano Roosevelt is just one example of the struggle against the unfettered free markets. The Reagan administration’s anti-regulatory policies have always been the subject of a rather robust debate between Democrats and Republicans. In the past 2 years, the free market economy has been discredited in the United States, England, Spain, and Greece. The claim that free market policies were “truth claims” went up in flames in Spain and Athens. Here we need to distinguish the rhetorical flourishes of the rabid right wingers who always invoke their “truth” to support their violence.

The claim about bringing the “blessing” of democracy to Iraq is weaker. The Bush administration was never able to articulate convincing justifications for the invasion. It went from alleging connection between the September 11 terrorist attack and the Iraqi government, to the so-called weapons of mass destruction, to the possibility of democratizing Iraq. The first two claims were false and the last one was a bad joke. The American press, ever so pliable in moments of war, went along, but not all voices were muffled. Already in 2003 and 2004, during the primary season to choose the Democratic presidential candidate, some mainstream politicians rejected the administration’s narrative about the Iraq invasion. Vattimo and Zabala’s claim that this was a dominant discourse does not correspond to the factual reality. They cite declarations by both the Bush and the Obama administration about the military intervention in Afghanistan and Iraq, and conclude that “[b]oth follow the logic of liberal individualism, where self-certainty becomes the measure for action.”⁵¹ They miss the reality that these types of declarations were and are part of a rather debunked political rhetoric. Of course, the language of the state apparatus will always invoke some values that are in obverse relation to what it really intends. With the historical record of Washington in support of dictatorships around the world, rhetoric about rights rings hollow. And the fact is that the Obama administration was looking for a way out of Iraq and Afghanistan, which we are now seeing.

The “culture” of military intervention in the United States warrants some comments. This is a society in which a significant majority accepts manipulation by power holders and dutifully plays the role of cheerleaders for wars that must be short, sanitized, and safe for American soldiers. The imagery of body bags is repellent and the traumas of scarred veterans should not be part of a “triumphant” narrative. Somehow the “unsanitized” events seep into the larger public sphere. And then the whining and second thoughts begin. After all, the United States is an empire that built a monument to a defeat: the Vietnam Memorial. The talk about bringing democracy to Iraq was punctured from the beginning, and it is surprising that Vattimo and Zabala buy into that rhetorical varnish to ruminate about the “I” of liberalism. With their positions about the liberal tendency to impose truth, their theory cannot explain why American troops are leaving Iraq and Afghanistan in a

⁵¹ HC; p. 57.

rather crestfallen mood, which is a sobering corrective to the “self-certainty” that they see in presidential declarations.

Contingency Has Been Here

The idea that we have reached a point in history where contingency must be a crucial acknowledgment in our political outlook faces an important indictment: contingency has been with us. The second American Founding represented by the deliberations about the constitution was a thoroughly contingent project tinged with a high dose of fragility. The deliberations assumed that human nature was a striving toward power, which is why guardrails and controls are indispensable. But these controls are not ironclad warranties. The Federalists and the Anti-Federalists understood the people as the supreme authority of a representative government but, at the same time, they saw the people as naïve, ignorant, passionate, and prone to following potential tyrants. Madison even spoke of the fragility involved in dealing with linguistic constructions.

In attempting to demarcate the boundaries of the different branches of government, Madison argues in *Federalist* 37 that the science of government was not able yet to make that kind of discrimination. The grounds for that inability are revealing: these grounds are the particular object, the imperfection of the human mind, and the opaque nature of language. “When the Almighty himself condescends to address mankind in their own language, his meaning, luminous as it must be, is rendered dim and doubtful by the cloudy medium through which it is communicated.”

Both James Madison and Alexander Hamilton invoked the authority of history, which they did not see it as a rational process but as a sequence of inveterate conflicts.

The history of almost all the great councils and consultations held among mankind for reconciling their discordant opinions, assuaging their mutual jealousies, and adjusting their respective interests, is a history of factions, contentions, and disappointments, and may be classed among the most dark and degraded pictures which display the infirmities and depravities of the human character.⁵²

All civilized societies would be divided into different Sects, Factions, and interests, as they happened to consist of rich and poor, debtors and creditors, the landed, the manufacturing and the commercial interests, the inhabitants of this district or that district, the followers of this political leader or that political leader, the disciples of this religious Sect or that religious Sect.

The Federalist view of human nature did not emerge from a metaphysical system but from its proponents’ reading of history. “Men are ambitious, vindictive, and rapacious. To look for a continuation of harmony between a number of independent, unconnected sovereignties in the same neighborhood, would be to disregard the

⁵² *Federalist Papers* 37.

uniform course of human events, and to set at defiance the accumulated experience of ages.”⁵³ Governments are needed “[b]ecause the passions of men will not conform to the dictates of reason and justice, without constraint.”⁵⁴

Needless to say, these positions made them aware of the fragility of a constitutional arrangement, which in turn explained the need for institutional vigilance through a system of balance. Dogmatic truths were not part of their deliberation. Half a century later, the idea of avoiding the dogmas of immovable truth was articulated by Daniel Webster and John Calhoun.

Daniel Webster attacked the dogmatic spirit and its claim to embody truth in all disputes. He even invoked the same value that Vattimo and Zabala advocate: charity.

In all such disputes, there will sometimes be found men with whom everything is absolute; absolutely right, or absolutely wrong. They deal with morals as with mathematics; and they think what is right may be distinguished from what is wrong with the precision of an algebraic equation. They have, therefore, none too much charity towards others who differ from them. They are apt, too, that nothing is good but what is perfect, and that there are no compromises or modifications to be made in consideration of difference of opinion or in deference to other men’s judgment.⁵⁵

John Calhoun followed the Federalist view that conflicts are intrinsic to the political order and called forth for a politics of compromise that ought to be enacted into law.

There is, ... but one mode in which this can be effected; and that is, by taking the sense of each interest or portion of the community, which may be unequally and injuriously affected by the action of the government, separately, through its own majority, or in some other way by which its voice may be fairly expressed; and to require the consent of each interest, either to put or to keep the government in action.⁵⁶

But there is a gloomy surprise here: Both Webster and, above all, Calhoun were advocating for flexibility and compromise on behalf of slavery. And yes, Southern slaveholders thought that they were being “charitable” toward their “property.”

This contingency found its highest and most tragic version in the Civil War. At Gettysburg, Abraham Lincoln spoke of “propositions,” not “inalienable truths.”

I call the reader’s attention to this factual evidence to show that contingency has been and is a salient factor of all democratic politics; that it has been tried before; and that the consequences have not been radically different from the politics of truth. Are we trapped within “essential urges” of the human condition?

⁵³ Federalist Paper 6. <http://www.constitution.org/fed/federa00.htm>

⁵⁴ Federalist Papers 15.

⁵⁵ Daniel Webster, March 7, 1850 Speech. Available online: Classic Senate Speeches. http://www.senate.gov/artandhistory/history/common/generic/Speeches_Webster_7March.htm

⁵⁶ John C. Calhoun, Disquisition on Government. Online text: http://www.constitution.org/jcc/disq_gov.htm

Why the Universality?

In *Farewell to Truth*, Vattimo spoke of an “ontology of actuality” and specified that “cognizance of the paradigm and suspension of its validity through heeding the unsaid” are its two preconditions, which he in turn defined thus:

The comprehension of the paradigm is nothing, fundamentally, other than the effort to comprehend dialectically the social totality which one is thrown...And the heeding of Being as the unsaid is attention to the continually silenced voice of history’s losers...⁵⁷

Marx’s “historical materialism is a prime example” of the first. Benjamin is an example of the second.

Hermeneutic communism inscribes itself in a certain philosophical tradition that assumes that thought can design a concept—Being, will to power, class struggles, etc.—that can unify the totality of an epoch or of nature or of everything. This is a linguistic impulse that appears as part and parcel of the very nature of philosophy. But it is an impulse that should be resisted. Totalizing concepts emerge as the first steps before legislation is issued. The concept is not presented as a space of contestation but as a site of epistemological and ethical authority. In hermeneutic communism, Being, interpretation, and event are authorities before, during, and after the conversation. They are signposts for possible agreements. And these are not mere reflections of their “interests”: they are concepts that claim to grasp a total reality, which is by now a dubious claim. Hermeneutics itself emerges as a totalizing vision: “hermeneutics is the only philosophy that reflects the pluralism of postmodern societies...”⁵⁸; “hermeneutic ontology alone opens the horizon of emancipation...”⁵⁹

In the fissures and fractures that mark modernity or what some call “postmodernity,” the totality is what is at stake. Theodor Adorno, who also characterized an entire epoch, showed some sensitivity to the reality of a fragmented social reality that is no longer accessible to categories crafted by thought. With “the erosion of the constitutive character of mind that used to find expression in philosophical systems,” he argues, “the more insistent becomes the need not just to register existing reality, but to reflect upon it and understand it. And it is this that refers us in our search for a philosophical knowledge of individual things to the only source of knowledge that remains, given the present trend towards dispersion and fragmentation, namely, towards interpretation, the art of deciphering.”⁶⁰

Philosophies that define their horizon as a contest between totalizing entities and finitude—that is, between Reason, or History, or Being and the specificity of this or that thinker, group or person—are suspicious theoretical and ethical enterprises. In the totalizing entity, the other is not subsumed; it is erased. The philosopher then communes with Universals, which is another way of saying that he communes with his own proclivities. It is an old Platonic habit.

⁵⁷ *Farewell*, pp. 32–33.

⁵⁸ *HC*; p. 79. Emphasis added.

⁵⁹ *HC*; p. 93. Emphasis added.

⁶⁰ Theodor W. Adorno [3]; p. 127.

From the totalizing concept, philosophy assumes the garb of a redemptive project. All people or most of them are in need of “emancipation,” “liberation,” and “authenticity.” When people do not accept these diagnoses, the philosopher resorts to “alienation” or “total organization” as conceptual explanations for why he is not being paid enough attention. These explanations tend to use magnifying glasses always too ready to see the apocalyptic cliff ahead. This is the case with Nietzsche, Heidegger, and Adorno.

Why the redemption and the apocalypses? Why the totalizing categories where the suffering of historical human beings is displaced in favor of the redemptive notion of Being, which has been “forgotten” but can be, presumably, recovered in the “event”—the “event”—a term that is reminiscent and redolent of the Christian parousia?

I suggest that we should be suspicious of philosophies that deploy the pattern of the pristine origin followed by the fall, and then the perpetual nostos, the return home or the attempt at recovery of something original that was lost. Variations of this pattern are found in Plato, Rousseau, Nietzsche, and Heidegger. When Vattimo and Zabala invoke Being and add that it has been “forgotten,” they show their affinity to the previous pattern. This is a form of reasoning that may be primal: it is found in Greek myths and, above all, it is the pattern of the Judeo-Christian tradition. But unless we pose the mythical and primal place from which we fell as a constitutive element of our historicity, the pattern is metaphysical with all its rich and disconcerting implications.

The pattern enlists dialectics to its cause; it inserts this “method” into reality or history or reason and redeems it. Human history carries the seed of its own culmination in the state (Hegel), communism (Marx), or Being (Heidegger). A pattern that plunges into a mimetic “appropriation” of the Judeo-Christian tradition is suggestive, but presupposes a transcendent truth unless it is shown that history, in its nature, is cut and woven according to the Pattern. And this would be another metaphysical claim.

Conclusion

More than 50 years ago, Maurice Merleau-Ponty called attention to the limits of philosophy in late modernity. Philosophy, he declared, should renounce the belief that it possesses the key to deciphering nature or history.

As difficult as it is under these conditions to imagine the future of philosophy, two things seem certain: it will never regain the conviction of holding the keys to nature or history in its concepts, and it will not renounce its radicalism, that search for presuppositions and foundations which has produced the great philosophies.⁶¹

⁶¹ Maurice Merleau-Ponty, “Everywhere and Nowhere” in *Signs*. Translated and with an Introduction by Richard C. McCleary. Illinois: Northwestern University Press, 1964; p. 157.

Even earlier, in 1931, in his *Inaugural Address*, Theodor Adorno was even more pessimistic about the future of philosophy. Philosophy, he argued, is trapped in an “everlasting paradox.” It “must proceed interpretively without ever possessing a sure key to interpretation; nothing more is given to it than fleeting, disappearing traces within the riddles figures of that which exists and their astonishing entwinings.”⁶² Better still, Adorno detached interpretation from meaning and claimed that it was not within philosophy’s purview to provide a “meaningful” assessment of reality in order to justify it. “Every such justification of that which exists is prohibited by the fragmentation in being itself.”⁶³

Hermeneutic communism seems to accept Merleau-Ponty’s position that philosophy does not hold the key to the decipherment of history or nature, but in posing the Heideggerian category of Being returns to the belief that it negates. It further affirms the idea of a totality encompassed in Being that hermeneutic communism can apprehend.

Merleau-Ponty, Adorno, and my discussion above warrant the following question: Why do certain philosophies partake of the same pattern: the privileged origin, the fall, the striving toward recovery, the need to invent their own heroic genealogy and soil?

Vattimo and Zabala project a genealogy into the past and make hermeneutic communist heroic. Hermeneutics “has always been the latent backbone of cultural revolutions against bearers of power, that is, the most productive movements against imposed truth.”⁶⁴ In the effort to provide “concrete elaborations” for the political domain, the “ontology of actuality” presented in *Farewell to Truth* and also defended in hermeneutic communism “doesn’t have an easier time ... than the foundational philosophies.” Its works “turns out to be more arduous” because, among other things, it lacks the “supplementary social support” meaning the support once provided by political parties (in Europe) to their “organic intellectuals.”⁶⁵

Perhaps we need another style of philosophizing along with new categories outside the nostos. On this path, I assume that the time is ripe for new truths. Nietzsche was right: Truth is a hard fought condition.

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⁶²Theodor Adorno, “The Actuality of Philosophy” in *The Adorno Reader*. Edited by Brian O’Connor. Malden, Massachusetts: Blackwell Publishing, 2000; p. 31.

⁶³Theodor Adorno, “The Actuality of Philosophy;” p. 31.

⁶⁴*HC*; p. 78.

⁶⁵*Farewell*; p. 44.

Response to Alejandro

Gianni Vattimo and Santiago Zabala

In 1993, Alejandro published *Hermeneutics, Citizenship, and the Public Sphere*, which is one of the first studies in English that questioned the common interpretation that Hans-Georg Gadamer's hermeneutics is the expression of a conservative political project. This is a book we read with great enthusiasm and used considerably while working on *Hermeneutic Communism*. It is rare to find a political theorist interested in hermeneutics, but as his other books indicate (*Nietzsche and the Drama of Historiobiography* and *The Limits of Rawlsian Justice*), he always maintained a direct interest in hermeneutic thinkers and problems. This is also evident in his contribution, which critically questions a number of arguments, problems, and views we develop. In the limited space we have, our response will focus on the political consequences of hermeneutics as they seem to be the central issues which Alejandro questions.

One of the greatest achievements of *Hermeneutic Communism*, according to Alejandro, is to translate “to the Twenty-First century the Delphic like statements about Being that come to us as spectral voices from the Black Forest.” The problem for the Puerto Rican thinker does not rest in this “translation” as a philosophical operation, but rather in the saving power we attribute to its “spectral voices.” The fact that these voices come from the “Black Forest,” that is, from the author of the *Black Notebooks*, also seems to worry Alejandro. It is curious to notice how these references to Heidegger's Nazism also spreads suspicions over Gadamer, who continued to believe in “tradition” and “conversation” as realms of salvation after “the first global war,” the “cataclysmic events of the Second World War”, and after the “anti-colonial movements in the 1940s and 1950s.” It seems that for Alejandro after these events philosophy should have been done in a different manner.

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Together with Habermas, who also expresses perplexities over the stir Heidegger's published notes have created,¹ we believe the conservative political stance of these philosophers should not prevent readers from developing their thought in different directions. After all, these different directions do not rest, as Alejandro seems to suggest referring to the "conversation," in a "hidden linguistic agreement," but rather in the possibility of disclosing something different. It is through this difference that one can also understand why his ontology was interpreted by so many leftist thinkers in France, the US, or Mexico.

Alejandro is also doubtful that one can use "the conceptual apparatus of metaphysics and still [be] able to overcome it" as we attempt to do with a number of concepts as "communism," "truth," or "alienation." "Alienation," he explains, "is not possible without a referential point, a central one in the constitution of what we are, from what we have strayed. The alienation may take the form of a lost site of pristine wholeness (Rousseau), a world of transparent social relations (Marx, Lukács), and the oblivion of Being (Heidegger). In all cases, the loss is deemed essential and the consequences apocalyptic." We agree that there will always be a referential point, as metaphysics cannot be overcome ("überwunden") but rather only surpassed ("verwinden"). However, we disagree that it's a loss with such significant and terrifying consequences. On the contrary, it is just these 'losses' which allow the origin to cease oppressing or imposing its authority upon us. After all, as Nietzsche explained in an aphorism from *Origin and Meaning*, "the progressive knowledge of the origin increases the insignificance of the origin." Hermeneutics is a "progressive knowledge" meant to weaken origins, authorities, and violence.

As we can see, *Hermeneutic Communism*, as well as hermeneutics more broadly understood as a philosophical position, does not aim to return to an "original state of nature" envisioned by Rousseau, to engender "new social relations" sought by Marx, or to Being's inception as Heidegger would say, but rather in the realms which disclose these possibilities. These, as we explained with the help of such philosophers as Jacques Derrida and urban theorists such as Mike Davis, do not take place through revolutions or radical changes, but rather at the "margins," that is, in those "slums" which today have become the battleground for political emancipation. As Alejandro notices, we have anticipate(d) resistances emerging from the poor in the slums. The Arab Spring, which has encompassed vast majorities,

¹It seems to me completely absurd that today the *Black Notebooks* are treated like something new – and that some colleagues even attempt to sublimate Heidegger's anti-Semitism and the rest of his dull resentments into the history of being! On the other hand, I'm still convinced that the arguments of *Being and Time*, if read with the eyes of Kant and Kierkegaard, retain an important place in the history of philosophy. In spite of the political ambivalence of the style, I regard this work as a result of the long history of detranscendentalizing the Kantian subject: by appropriating the methods of Husserlian phenomenology in his own way, *Being and Time* also digests an important legacy of American pragmatism, German historicism and the kind of philosophy of language that originates from Wilhelm von Humboldt. (Michaël Fössel, "Critique and communication: Philosophy's missions: A conversation with Jürgen Habermas," in *Esprit* 8-9/2015. Also in *Eurozine*: <http://www.eurozine.com/articles/2015-10-16-habermas-en.html>).

rewarded abundantly the anticipations contained in Vattimo and Zabala's philosophy.

We are not surprised to find towards the end of Alejandro's excellent contribution a reference to Badiou's antipathies for hermeneutics as "too compatible with our world to be able to sustain the rupture or distance that philosophy requires." The problem is not whether one is compatible or not, but rather pretending it is possible to create a rupture or distance from the world. Assuming this rupture is possible, hermeneutics will be necessary to comprehend and act upon what occurred. As Žizek says, the biggest problem with a revolution is not the event in itself, but rather the morning after.